Hell

A Jewish Perspective on a Christian Doctrine

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Contents

Epigraph

Introduction

- The Modern Reader's Challenges
- Book's Goal

Part I

Historical Background: How Did We Get Here?

- Introduction
- 1. The Philology of "Hell"
- 2. Pagan Views on Hell
- 3. Repentance, Salvation, and Hell from a Jewish Perspective
- 4. Hell in Early Christianity
- 5. Hell in Late Christianity
- 6. Hell in Modern Christianity

Part II

The Theology of Hellfire

- Introduction
- 7. Jesus Died to Save Us from What? (Models of Atonement)
- 8. Jewish Model of Atonement

The Doctrines Behind the ECT Theology

9. Original Sin Theology

10. The "God Can't Stand You" Theology

11. Why God Allowed Sin in the First Place?

12. Does a Sin Against an Infinite God Merit Infinite Punishment?

Part III

Hell in the Bible

Introduction

13. Hell in the Torah

14. Hell in the Prophets

15. Gehenna: Jesus' "Hell"

16. "Eternal" Punishment

17. The Sheep and Goats (Matthew 25:31-46)

18. Outer Darkness, Weeping and Gnashing of Teeth

19. Lazarus and the Rich Man (Luke 16)

20. "Unquenchable Fire" (Matthew 3:10-12)

21. Aren't we "Born Again" to Avoid Hellfire?

22. "Away from me, you evildoers!"

23. "Narrow Gates" That Lead Where?

24. The "Gates of Hell" (Matthew 16:18)

25. Fear Whom?

26. Hell in Book of Acts

27. Racing for What?

28. Everlasting Destruction (2 Thessalonians 1:8-9)

29. Tartarus (2 Peter 2:4-6)

30. Jude

31. The Book of Life

32. The Lake of Fire, Sulfur and Smoke (Revelation)

33. Conclusion

Part IV

Hell: An Alternative View

Introduction

34. No Fear In Love (1 John 4:18)

35. Biblical Justice

36. Hellfire's Justice

37. God's Wrath and Vengeance

38. What's Life's Meaning?

39. Every Knee, Every Tongue

A Final Word

Also by Eitan Bar

Endnotes

When discussing a serious topic such as Hell, starting with a joke is only appropriate!

"Knock, knock."

"Who's there?"

"My name is Jesus. You must open up and let me in!"

"Why should I let you in?"

"So I can save you."

"Save me? Save me from what?!"

"Save you from what I am going to do to you if you don't open!"

The "Good News," according to some.

Did it shock you? Excellent. I trust the book will have the opposite effect!

Hell vs. Hellfire

In modern language, the term "**Hell**" encompasses a broad doctrine with diverse interpretations, ranging from a literal place of fire to a purely symbolic metaphor and with varying views, such as a place of eternal damnation or a temporary process of purification.

Therefore, I will use the term "**Hellfire**" when specifically describing the Augustinian-Calvinist depiction of a literal place of endless torture in the fire, known by theologians as the ECT (Eternal Conscious Torment) Hellfire view.

Lastly, since the book has a logical flow, I advise you to read the chapters sequentially rather than randomly.

Introduction

> The proper context for interpreting the Bible is not Augustine or any other church father. It is not the Catholic Church. It is not the rabbinic movements of late antiquity and the Middle Ages. It is not the Reformation or the Puritans. It is not evangelicalism in any of its flavors. It is not the modern world at all or any period of its history. The proper context for interpreting the Bible is the context of the biblical writers— the context that produced the Bible. Every other context is alien to the biblical writers and, therefore, to the Bible. Yet there is a pervasive tendency in the believing Church to filter the Bible through creeds, confessions, and denominational preferences. [1]
>
> Dr. Michael S. Heiser

As a Jewish individual, ever since I became a believer in Jesus, I've noticed significant differences in the interpretation of the biblical text between Jews and Christians. One example is the concept of hell, but there are many other examples as well, such as 'sin,' 'atonement,' 'salvation,' and 'divorce.' [2]

Numerous interpretations of the concept of *hell* have been proposed throughout the generations in most religions. Still, one particularly striking interpretation has captivated the minds of some Conservative Protestant denominations. Among them are the Baptist, Calvinist, Lutheran, Pentecostal, Evangelical, and other

fundamentalist groups holding to what is known as the Hellfire view—a place where God, directly or indirectly, punishes most of humanity, eternally tormenting billions of people through excruciating and abusive methods, which according to some depictions, include burning them in flames. These sadistic tortures allegedly would persist every minute of every day for eternity.

I have also observed that varying interpretations of biblical texts can greatly affect one's mental and emotional health. The manner in which we understand certain doctrines, especially concepts such as hell, can profoundly influence our faith-life perspective. Misinterpretations or overly strict views may result in adverse emotions and actions, such as anxiety, depression, fear, and a tendency to judge others harshly.

This is one reason why theologians who critique the "Hellfire view" often argue that it is both illogical and misrepresents God's nature as depicted in the Scriptures, emphasizing love, mercy, and corrective justice. A more compassionate and logical understanding of the doctrine of hell can possibly foster a healthier mental, emotional, and spiritual life, free from the burdens of existential fear and religious legalism.

The Modern Reader's Challenges

Modern Christianity has significantly diverged from its origins within the early Jewish movement, undergoing a two-thousand-year evolution shaped by church history and cultural shifts. This transformation started with the adaptation of the Gospel to fit the anti-Jewish sentiments of the Roman Empire and the philosophies of Greece, proceeded with its recontextualization for the converted European pagans, was further altered during the Reformation wars, and ultimately adapted to the distinct context of America's settlement. Consequently, while traces of the original Gospel remain, they are now interwoven with diverse interpretations, traditions, religious biases, erroneous translations, and cultural accretions, which many contemporary Christians might not fully acknowledge. Considering this long history of adaptation and transformation, it is conceivable that numerous obstacles to understanding Christianity from a Jewish perspective have become entrenched in its foundational beliefs.

The Bible, a collection of ancient Jewish documents, is rich with metaphors, symbolism, figures of speech, allusions, parables, and allegories. These literary devices permeate the text, posing significant challenges for those not versed in the original languages, cultures, and historical contexts. This often leads to questionable interpretations and confusion among modern readers, especially Westerners unfamiliar with the Ancient Near East, Judaism, and the Hebrew and Greek languages.

Moreover, language is dynamic; it evolves, and the meanings of many words and phrases change over time. Also, most Hebrew and Greek words have a spectrum of meanings, which context alone can clarify. Additionally, Hebrew operates on a fundamentally different linguistic structure than Germanic / Indo-European languages such as English. Its Semitic roots make it particularly resistant to full translation, as nuances and layers of meaning often elude capture. For example, Semitic languages such as Hebrew and Aramaic are unique compared to English because they primarily use root-based morphology, where most words are formed from three-consonant roots that convey core meanings. This allows for a rich and flexible derivation of related words, unlike English, which relies more on fixed prefixes and suffixes.

For instance, the "Serpent" in Genesis 3 is commonly perceived by English readers as a literal snake. Still, in Jewish tradition, it is often understood as a shining being or an angel of light who later lost his ability to fly or walk as punishment (Bereshit Rabbah 20:5). This interpretation arises from the Hebrew word "*NACHASH*," which is typically translated as "serpent" in English. However, "*Nachash*" is a three-letter Hebrew word that can also mean "copper," "shining," or "bronze," suggesting a luminescent and perhaps divine figure symbolizing the supernatural world rather than a talking reptile. Paul, a Jew, likely shared this perspective, as evident in his description of Satan as *"an angel of light"* (2 Corinthians 11:14). I provide numerous examples in another book, *"Lost in Translation"*; however, this one suffices to demonstrate that the content you read or comprehend in your English Bibles may not be exactly what I read or understand in my Hebrew Bible.

Evidently, translation choices can have far-reaching repercussions that stem partly from inaccurate Bible translations and a failure to appreciate the nuances of language, culture, and context in which pivotal figures like Moses, Jesus, and Paul delivered their teachings.

Additionally, some Semitic languages utilize patterns of vowel changes within these roots to convey grammatical nuances, making their structure markedly different from the more linear construction of English. In any event, the complexity of the biblical text requires meticulous translation decisions, which are undeniably shaped by the translators' pre-existing theological and religious views. This fact likely accounts for the existence of over 900 different translations of the Bible in English alone.[3]

I'll now share one example of what I mean by *"the translators' pre-existing theological and religious views."*

Matthew 10:29

- New American Bible:

> Are not two sparrows sold for a small coin? Yet not one of them falls to the ground without your Father's **knowledge**.
>
> Matthew 10:29, NAB

According to the NAB English translation, God knows or is aware of every sparrow's fall, implying divine knowledge rather than will.

In the original Greek, however, no specific word indicates the meaning, so many English translations interpret it as "knowing." At the same time, some, like the King James Version, translated the text as is (only from context it clear the verse speaks of God's knowledge):

> Are not two sparrows sold for a farthing? and one of them shall not fall on the ground without your Father.
>
> Matthew 10:29, KJV

Now, see how the NET translation, a popular translation in the US made by a Calvinist group, inserted a different word:

> Aren't two sparrows sold for a penny? Yet not one of them falls to the ground apart from your Father's **will**.
>
> Matthew 10:29, NET

Adding the word “will" into the text implies that nothing, including death, occurs without God’s explicit intent. This perfectly aligns with the Calvinist-TULIP doctrine of predestination, where everything that happens happens because God wills it, thus negating true human free will.

For me, as a Jewish reader who has lost family members in the Holocaust, this Calvinist addition is troubling. This translation doesn’t just imply that God was aware of such atrocities—it suggests that Jesus taught God actively willed them to happen! Such a portrayal risks making Jesus appear indifferent to human suffering, even endorsing evil events as divinely ordained. For Jewish readers with a history of suffering and loss, this interpretation is not only theologically revolting but also alienates them from Jesus' teachings altogether. Moreover, Free Will is a tenet doctrine in Judaism, as are God’s mercy and compassion, contrasting the depiction of God by many Calvinists.[4]

But juggling between translations is not the only challenge to the modern English reader. Another challenge is understanding the authors' original context and culture. Therefore, one of the most significant challenges and a popular fallacy in modern-day Bible interpretation is the Anachronism Fallacy. This fallacy occurs when an interpretation places ideas, theological concepts, events, customs, etc., in a historical period where they do not belong, leading to distorted conclusions. This involves projecting contemporary ideas, knowledge, or concepts onto past texts, events, or figures.[5]

For instance, the term "gay" had a completely different meaning a century ago than it does today. Reading the word in a book written a hundred years ago and applying the modern meaning would be an example of the Anachronism Fallacy. It will soon become evident that the Anachronism Fallacy is frequently employed in modern Christian teachings about the "hell" verses.

To complicate things even further, 45,000 different Christian groups—holding to varying interpretations of the Bible—uphold the Bible as the ultimate expression

of God's will, each believing they—not others—have interpreted it all correctly. Can you imagine? Every denomination and group is convinced that all other groups and denominations, except their own, of course, are partially or fully mistaken. This conviction has led to violent religious conflicts throughout Christian history, including disputes over numerous theological doctrines, especially salvation, faith, and hell.

Book's Goal

Our goal, therefore, is to transcend more than 2,000 years of predominantly Western, non-Jewish interpretations and strive to comprehend these complex Jewish texts in a manner as close as possible to how their original —also mostly Jewish—audience would have perceived them without permitting our contemporary theological biases to influence our understanding. This task involves a deep dive into historical contexts, examining how ancient words were used and understood in their original settings, and being mindful of the interpretative choices made during later translations.

It is not my intention to write a scholarly technical book but to try and summarize the theological "must know" in simple language as best as possible while doing so in a language not native to me (I was born and raised in Israel, and my native tongue is Hebrew. I later took Greek in seminary. Thus, I will sincerely appreciate your understanding when you find faults in my English).

I have no horse in this race other than to offer my understanding—as a native Hebrew-speaking Jew—of this complex and often misunderstood subject. Personally, as a theologian, I value the diversity of opinions and, for the most part, avoid emotionally attaching myself to any particular doctrine.[6] Therefore, you will not get conclusive "yes" and "no" answers. I will not be spoon-feeding you with answers—as though I possess all the correct knowledge—but aim to challenge preconceived notions you may have considered sacrosanct and seek to enrich you with new perspectives on a very controversial doctrine.

This book is organized into four primary sections:

Part I: Important Background - This section surveys the evolution of the concept of hell.

Part II: The Theology of Hellfire - This section delves into the fundamental doctrines that underpin the Augustinian-Calvinist Hellfire.

Part III: Hell in the Bible - This section scrutinizes the key passages and terms commonly associated with hell.

Part IV: An Alternative View of Hell - In this section, I present my reflections on God's justice, salvation, and hell.

Throughout this exploration, I will frequently provide a Jewish perspective, which I believe is crucial and often illuminates the deviations in some Christian teachings. I pray you will enjoy my book!

Part I

Historical Background: How Did We Get Here?

Introduction

In the first part of this book, we will delve into the linguistic roots and historical context of the concept of "hell," drawing on insights from both early and later Christian traditions as well as Jewish interpretations. The exploration will delve into the etymology of "hell" and scrutinize the varying perceptions of hell through Pagan, Jewish, and Christian lenses. The goal is to survey its historical development and its significance across various cultures, eras, and religious frameworks.

The Philology of "Hell"

The English word "hell" originates from the Old English "Hel" or "Helle," [7] which was derived from the Proto-Germanic term "haljō." This term generally referred to an underworld or a hidden place. "Haljō" is also related to the Old Norse word "Hel," which referred both to the underworld—a realm of the dead—and the goddess who ruled over it in Norse mythology. In Norse belief, this underworld was where souls who did not die in battle would go. As Christianity spread through Europe, the term was adopted and adapted within Christian theology to describe a place of punishment for the wicked, shifting its meaning from a general concept of the afterlife to the more specific notion of a place of torment.

- **Proto-Germanic:** "haljō" first referred to a concealed or hidden place and was used to describe the underworld.

- - **Old Norse:** "Hel" was both the name of the underworld and the deity presiding over it.

- - - **Old English:** "hel" or "helle" referred to a place of punishment after death.

- - - - **Modern English:** "hell" refers to a place of punishment after death, often torturous and eternal.

Four Words Translated "Hell"

English translations frequently employ the term "Hell" as a replacement for four distinct Hebrew/Greek words: "Géenna," "Sheol," "Tartarus," and "Hades." These words

are not interchangeable synonyms, and each carries its unique connotations and meanings. Let's see some examples:

Sheol:

> For thou wilt not leave my soul in ***hell*** *[sheol]*; neither wilt thou suffer thine Holy One to see corruption.
>
> (Psalm 16:10, KJV)

Hades:

> And death and ***hell*** *[hades]* were cast into the lake of fire. This is the second death.
>
> (Revelation 20:14, KJV)

Géenna:

> And if thy right eye offend thee, pluck it out, and cast it from thee: for it is profitable for thee that one of thy members should perish, and not that thy whole body should be cast into ***hell*** *[Géenna]*.
>
> (Matthew 5:29, KJV)

Tartarus:

> For if God spared not the angels that sinned, but cast them down to ***hell*** *[tartarus]*, and delivered them into chains of darkness, to be reserved unto judgment.
>
> (2 Peter 2:4, KJV)

Clearly, the English translations of these four different concepts do not do justice to their original meanings. In fact, none of these terms suggest a place where people are allegedly being tortured by fire forever.

Sheol, Hades, Géenna, Tartarus

Sheol is a Hebrew word used in the Old Testament to describe the realm of the dead, often translated as "the grave" or "the pit." It is portrayed as a shadowy place where the dead are asleep, regardless of their belief or moral choices during life. Sheol is not associated with punishment or reward but is simply the state of being dead and hidden from the living.[8] In English translations of the Bible, the term is frequently rendered as "Hell."

Hades is the Greek word equivalent of Sheol,[9] representing the underworld or the realm of the dead. In Greek mythology, Hades is both the name of the god ruling this domain and the place itself. In the New Testament, Hades similarly denotes the unseen place where souls go after death, awaiting resurrection. Like Sheol, Hades is not inherently a place of torment or bliss but a temporary holding place for the dead.[10] In English translations of the Bible, the term is frequently rendered as "Hell."

Géenna (or Gehenna) originates from the Hebrew word "Gehinnom," meaning *the Valley of Hinnom*, which is located outside Jerusalem. Historically, it was associated with the worship of Moloch, where children were sacrificed by fire and possibly with the city's garbage dump. In the New Testament, Jesus uses Gehenna as a symbol of great shame, guilt, humiliation, embarrassment, divine punishment (on earth), and dishonor. For instance, it can symbolize the destruction of a city or an individual being ostracized and becoming an outcast. In some later rabbinic literature, "Gehinnom" became associated with an afterlife disciplinary process, a destination for the wicked where they get to atone for their sins.[11] In English translations of the Bible, the term is frequently rendered as "Hell."

Tartarus, in Greek mythology, is a deep abyss used to imprison the Titans far beneath Hades. It signifies the lowest part of the underworld, a jail-like place. In the New Testament, particularly in 2 Peter 2:4, Tartarus is used metaphorically to describe the gloomy, dark place where rebellious angels are held, awaiting judgment. Tartarus

appears in the Septuagint translation of Job (40:20 and 41:24) and in Hellenistic Jewish literature, such as the Greek text of the ancient Book of Enoch. In Enoch, God places the archangel Uriel "*in charge of the world and of Tartarus*" (20:2). Tartarus is understood as the prison for 200 fallen Watchers (angels). [12] In English translations of the Bible, the term is frequently rendered as "Hell."

As evident, none of these terms imply a place of eternal torture and abuse, such as Hellfire. Consequently, "hell" appears to be a term causing much confusion and mistranslation.

In the Concordant Expositions, biblical scholar James Coram explains:

> The Old English "hell," denoted that which is covered (hidden or unseen). Consequently, it once served as a suitable translation of the Greek hades, which means "imperceptible" or "unseen." In modern English, however, due to the corrupting influence of human tradition, "hell" has come to mean "the abode of the dead; the place of punishment after death [in which the dead are alive]." Consequently, since in modern English the notion represented by the term "hell" constitutes, to say the least, interpretation, not translation, it is unconscionable for modern translators to render either the Hebrew sheol or the Greek hades by this expression.
>
> Yet it is worse still, whether in old English or modern English, to render the Greek tartarosas and especially the Greek geenna, also as "hell." Such "translations" are not translations at all; they are but the product of circular reasoning and hoary tradition. Whatever one's understanding may be concerning the matters to which these words make reference, as a translation of the Original, the rendering "hell," in all cases, is wholly unjustifiable. Yet it is this very rendering, the single term, "hell," for all these distinct words in the Original, which has spawned all the familiar talk concerning "hell" which prevails among "Bible-believing Christians" today. [13]
>
> James Coram

Pagan Views on Hell

Throughout human history, various ancient cultures and religions have developed distinct concepts of the afterlife, particularly regarding realms of punishment. These beliefs reflect each culture's moral and theological values, offering a glimpse into how ancient and modern societies understand their gods' characters and the soul's fate after death. This chapter provides a concise overview of the concept of "hell" in various major ancient civilizations before the advent of Christianity.

The Mesopotamian Hell

In ancient Mesopotamian mythology, the underworld is known as *Kur* or *Irkalla*. This realm is depicted as a dark, dreary place where all souls go after death, regardless of their actions in life. It is believed to be ruled by the goddess Ereshkigal, who governs this shadowy domain. The dead exist in a state of limbo, as shades with little awareness or activity. They subsist on dust and the scant offerings left by the living. Unlike many other cultural depictions of the afterlife, there is no strong concept of moral judgment or punishment in Kur/Irkalla. The afterlife is uniformly bleak and joyless, emphasizing the Mesopotamian view of death as an inevitable, somber fate for all.

The Egyptian Hell

In Egyptian mythology, the afterlife is a complex and multifaceted realm with the potential for both reward and punishment. The journey of the soul through the afterlife begins with its passage through the *Duat*, the realm of the dead, which is fraught with trials and judgments. Central to this journey is the *Weighing of the Heart* ceremony, overseen by the god Osiris. In this ceremony, the heart of the deceased is weighed against the feather of Ma'at, the symbol of truth and justice. If the heart is heavier than the feather, indicating a life of sin and imbalance, it is devoured by the monstrous Ammit, condemning the soul to oblivion. However, if the heart is lighter, the soul is granted passage to the *Field of Reeds*, a paradisiacal version of one's earthly life where one can live in eternal peace and happiness. This dualistic view of the afterlife underscores the Egyptian belief in moral retribution and the possibility of eternal reward.

Hell in Dharmic Religions

In **Buddhism**, hell is known as *Naraka*, one of the six realms of samsara (the cycle of birth and rebirth). Naraka is a place of intense suffering and punishment for those who have accumulated bad karma. Unlike eternal damnation, Naraka is not permanent; souls endure their punishment until their negative karma is exhausted, after which they can be reborn into other realms.

In **Hinduism**, hell is also referred to as *Naraka*. It serves as a temporary realm where souls are punished for their sins before being reincarnated. The god Yama presides over this process, ensuring that souls undergo appropriate retribution to cleanse their karma. Naraka functions as a means for the soul to purify itself and prepare for a better rebirth.

In **Zoroastrianism**, the *Chinvat Bridge* is a concept of judgment that souls encounter after death. The righteous cross the bridge easily and enter paradise, while the wicked

fall into a hellish abyss. Hell in Zoroastrianism is a place of punishment for the wicked, but it is not eternal. Over time, souls can be purified and eventually join the righteous in paradise, reflecting the Zoroastrian belief in ultimate redemption and the triumph of good over evil.

Hell in Greek Mythology

In **Greek mythology**, the underworld, known as *Hades*, is ruled by the god Hades. It consists of various regions, including the Elysian Fields for the virtuous and Tartarus for the wicked. Tartarus is seen as a place of severe punishment reserved for those who committed heinous crimes. Souls in Tartarus endure endless torment, reflecting the Greek belief in moral retribution in the afterlife.

There is evidence suggesting that a few early Christian theologians adopted some of the concept of hell from Greek mythology, which portrayed it as a dungeon-like place of eternal torment for the wicked and a prison for the Titans. This concept, found in early Greek texts like Hesiod's "Theogony" and Plato's "Gorgias," described it as a realm of severe torturous punishment and divine retribution. Some early Christian depictions of hell share striking similarities with these ancient Greek portrayals, often employing identical Greek terminology.

Early Christian writings demonstrate a pronounced integration of Greek concepts, including that of hell, into Christian eschatology, underscoring the profound impact of Greek literature and mythology on the formation of early Christian thought. Church Fathers and early Christian scholars like Clement of Alexandria, Origen, and Augustine actively engaged with Neoplatonism and other Greek philosophical frameworks, weaving these ideas into their theological constructs. This fusion highlights a complex dialogue between Greek pagan traditions and the developing Christian doctrines in its early stages. [14]

Etruscan, and Roman Hells

The **Etruscan** underworld shares many similarities with the Greek concept, where demons guide the dead to their final destinations. It is depicted as a dark and shadowy realm where souls are judged. The Etruscan belief system also emphasizes moral judgment, with the righteous rewarded and the wicked punished.

The **Roman** afterlife, heavily influenced by Greek mythology, includes the underworld known as *Hades* or *Inferi*. This realm features the Elysian Fields for the blessed and Tartarus for the damned. The Romans believed in a system of moral retribution, where souls face rewards or punishments based on their earthly deeds. The afterlife is a continuation of one's moral journey, with justice served in the form of eternal reward or punishment.

Islam

In Islam, hell is referred to as *Jahannam*. It is a place of severe punishment for those who reject faith or commit grave sins. Jahannam is vividly described in the Quran, with multiple levels and forms of torment tailored to the sins of its inhabitants. Similar to some Christian "Hellfire" traditions, the fire of Jahannam in Islam is said to be 70 times hotter than any earthly fire, causing immense pain and suffering. The executioners of punishment are the 19 'zabaniyya,' created from the fires of hell.[15] The righteous, in contrast, are rewarded with entry into *Jannah* (paradise), a place of eternal bliss and closeness to God. Jannah is described as a beautiful, verdant garden where believers enjoy eternal peace, joy, and the presence of the divine.

Repentance, Salvation, and Hell from a Jewish Perspective

This chapter will explore the concepts of 'repentance,' 'salvation,' and 'hell,' examining their interconnections from the perspective of the Hebrew Scriptures and Jewish thought.

Repentance

In certain conservative Christian traditions, such as Calvinism, Evangelicalism, Pentecostalism, Messianic Judaism (a small Evangelical Fundamentalist group I used to be associated with), and several others, a direct link is established between the concepts of hell and repentance. For example:

> God offered us the choice between an unbreakable love, or wrath that will bring upon those who reject the gospel, hell—and not just hell for five months. That will just be a get-acquainted time for unbelievers and demons to meet each other, because they'll be spending forever together...Embrace Christ while it is day, while the opportunity and the invitation is there, before the hard heart takes over and even the person who sees the power of God and sees the wrath of God doesn't repent, but blasphemes. [16]
>
> John MacArthur

In Jewish thought, however, T'shuva (or Teshuva), usually translated as "repentance," holds significant weight but serves a different purpose than how some Christians often see it. While Jewish repentance is seen as crucial, it is not directly linked to the notion of salvation or hellfire, as understood in several Christian denominations. Instead, T'shuva is more about restoring and enhancing.

The emphasis on repentance in Judaism is more about strengthening the quality of one's relationship with God and improving one's spiritual and earthly well-being rather than seeing it as a mechanism to evade eternal damnation or evaluate someone's salvation, which ultimately leads to a legalistic worldview and judgmentalism. The Jewish perspective aligns with the idea that a genuine relationship is built on love, trust, and mutual respect rather than fear of punishment and retribution when failing a moral standard. But to fully understand the Jewish doctrine of repentance, it's essential to first delve into the Hebrew Scriptures.

Repentance in the Old Testament

In biblical terms, repentance is not a one-time mystical event but involves changing one's view of God, often in relation to idol worship:

> Therefore say to the people of Israel, "This is what the Sovereign Lord says: Repent! Turn from your idols and renounce all your detestable practices!"
>
> Ezekiel 14:6

For Israel, it also pertained to the administration of justice: *"Learn to do right; seek justice. Defend the oppressed. Take up the cause of the fatherless; plead the case of the widow."* (Isaiah 1:17)

For the Israelites, the concept of repentance had an immediate, tangible, and practical application in daily life. The Mosaic Law provided a comprehensive framework that went beyond mere ritualistic practices; it was a guide to living a balanced, ethical life that honored God and respected fellow human beings.

Sin, in the Torah's context, threatened social harmony within the community. Repentance often involved restorative actions—like returning stolen property or making amends for false testimony—which had immediate, earthly implications. This is similar to Western culture today, where a thief's punishment often includes restitution to the victim, imprisonment, or community service aimed at repairing the fabric of society.

For Israel's prophets, repentance never focused on the existential or metaphysical implications but on tangible, real-world consequences and remedies. In both ancient and modern contexts, sin and repentance are seen first and foremost as having social dimensions, impacting community well-being and social cohesion. Thus, sin and repentance are not just vertical relationships between an individual and God but mainly horizontal relationships affecting the community. For this very reason, we are instructed to love our neighbors, which stems from our love for God, as stated in Matthew 22:37-40.

Biblical Repentance is Communal/Collective

Today, we live in an individualistic world, which has significantly influenced Christianity. However, in the context of the Torah, an individual was always viewed as an integral part of their community, not as an isolated entity. This poses a significant challenge in English translations of the Bible, as most fail to distinguish whether 'you' is intended as plural or singular. However, this distinction is obvious in the original Hebrew (and Greek) text. To simplify things, I will substitute '*you*' with '*y'all*' if it is originally written as plural.

The Hebrew word for "repent" or "repentance" literally means "return" or "turn," let's examine a few instances:

> Repent! [plural] Turn away from all your offenses; then sin will not be your downfall. Rid yourselves of all the offenses y'all have committed, and get a new heart and a new spirit.
>
> Ezekiel 18:30-31

Though it may sound like an individual call, this comes within a larger passage discussing Israel's accountability and the need for collective transformation.

> They said, "Turn now, each of y'all, from your evil ways and your evil practices, and y'all can stay in the land the Lord gave to y'all and your ancestors for ever and ever."
>
> Jeremiah 25:5

The emphasis is on remaining in the land given to the ancestors, a collective physical redemption, rather than the individual's eternal salvation.

> "Even now," declares the Lord, "return to me [plural] with all your heart, with fasting and weeping and mourning."
>
> Joel 2:12-13

This is part of a larger prophetic call for national repentance to avert physical disaster. The collective aspect is evident.

> If my people, who are called by my name, will humble themselves and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven, and I will forgive their sin and will heal their land.
>
> 2 Chronicles 7:14

This is clearly a collective call to the people of Israel for national repentance and healing rather than individual salvation.

> Therefore tell the people: This is what the Lord Almighty says: "Return to me," declares the Lord Almighty, "and I will return to y'all," says the Lord Almighty.

Zechariah 1:3

This passage reflects Zechariah's appeal to the nation of Israel after the exile, a period marked by the nation's physical reconstruction. Thus, it is a collective summons rather than an individual plea for salvation from damnation.

> Return, Israel, to the Lord your God. Y'alls sins have been your downfall! Take words with y'all and return to the Lord.
>
> Hosea 14:1-2

Hosea's entire book is an exposition of Israel's unfaithfulness and the need for national repentance.

To conclude, the Hebrew Scriptures present "repentance" as a collective concept rather than an individual appeal, and the outcome of repentance was the restoration of communal unity, peace, prosperity, and blessings on Israel's land and offspring. The focus was on maintaining a healthy, respectful, and loving relationship as a nation under God, which in turn influenced the quality of the Israelites' lives here and now.

T'shuva

The Jewish perspective of T'shuva likewise focuses on the restorative and relational aspects of repentance rather than a fear-driven avoidance of eternal torment. Much like a good father would never threaten to kill his children if they don't behave or fail to repent, God never issued such threats to the nation of Israel. However, there were severe consequences and repercussions when Israel sinned and failed to repent.

In Deuteronomy 28, Moses outlines the blessings for obedience and the curses for disobedience. When Israel repented and returned to God, they were promised blessings such as abundant prosperity, fertility, and protection from enemies (Deuteronomy 28:1-14). Conversely, failure to repent brought severe consequences, including famine, disease, and defeat by enemies (Deuteronomy 28:15-68). This demonstrates that the focus was on immediate earthly consequences, restoring a

proper relationship with God, and receiving His blessings rather than on the fear of eternal punishment in the afterlife.

In the Bible Knowledge Commentary, Charles Dyer, a conservative Christian theologian, comments:

> God was not saying that a saved Israelite would lose his [eternal] salvation if he fell into sin. Both the blessing and the judgment in view here are temporal, not eternal. The [most severe] judgment was physical death, not eternal damnation. [17]
>
> Charles H Dyer, Ph.D in Theology

In summary, the Hebrew Scriptures did not threaten eternal damnation but highlighted the immediate, tangible consequences of actions. Therefore, the concept of T'shuva in Judaism is centered on restoration and relationship, not the fear of hellfire. Any "*repent or burn*" warning was understood metaphorically as a temporal, earthly consequence rather than a threat of everlasting punishment.

New Testament Repentance

Nothing has changed in Israel's theology during the New Testament. Repentance's primary usage was in the context of calling the nation of Israel to change its ways. A Second Temple-era Jew would have understood "repentance" as the return of God's blessings and protection or the end of an exile and the restoration of the kingdom of Israel.

The Greek word for repentance, '*Metanoeō*,' much like its Hebrew equivalent, *T'shuva*, should be understood, at least according to Strong's Greek lexicon, in its basic sense as a "*To change one's mind.*" Charles Bing, a conservative Christian theologian, explains:

> Metanoeō should be understood as "Change the mind." [18]

Charles C. Bing, Ph.D in Theology

For instance, if I walk into an ice cream shop planning to get vanilla but then 'metanoeō' and opt for chocolate, I've essentially repented—changed my mind.

Given that the New Testament's Gospels are Jewish documents that concern Jewish matters with the Jewish Messiah at their core, it is only logical to extend our study of "repentance" within this context of the teachings of Jesus, who also was a Jewish prophet.

In essence, for first-century Israel, the call to repentance meant adopting Jesus's Way—such as loving your enemy, showing compassion, being generous, maintaining justice, and caring for the poor and needy, rather than following false traditions such as those of the Scribes and Pharisees. For the Nations, repentance involves shifting from worshipping their pagan idols to embracing the God of Israel.

Once more, the call for repentance in the New Testament, akin to that in the Hebrew Scriptures, served as a collective summons for Israel. The gospels' primary concern wasn't individuals but Israel's collective identity, role, and destiny.

> Repent [plural], for the kingdom of heaven has come near.
>
> John the Baptist (Matthew 3:2)

Christians who interpret John the Baptist's call for repentance as an invitation to accept Christ as Lord and Savior is an example of the Anachronism Fallacy. During that period, Jesus had not emerged as a figure, let alone been crucified. John's message was directed at a Jewish audience and aligned with the Old Testament's calls for national repentance, which is why it found resonance. The call for Israel to repent was simply a call for Israel to change its ways.

A failure to repent—which later meant accepting Christ as Israel's Prophet and acknowledging Him as Messiah—would result in national calamity—The destruction of the Second Temple and Jerusalem.

> From that time on Jesus began to preach, "Repent [plural], for the kingdom of heaven has come near."

Matthew 4:17

Jesus takes up John's message after John's imprisonment. Aimed again at the nation of Israel, this too should be considered a call for national repentance of Israel.

> I tell ya'll, no! But unless y'all repent, y'all too will all perish.
>
> Luke 13:3, 5

This is yet another warning to the nation of Israel to change its ways, or it will perish. Perish should not be understood as "burn in hell" but as the destruction of Jerusalem, which indeed happened in years 70-135 with the destruction of the temple, Jerusalem, and the exile of the few who were left alive.

In the Gospels, even when Jesus called individuals to repentance, it was not about accepting Him as an atonement for their sins since His death had not yet occurred and was not yet contemplated by anyone. Instead, it was a matter of interpersonal relationships. For example:

> If your brother or sister sins against you, rebuke them; and if they repent, forgive them.
>
> Luke 17:3

This deals with interpersonal relationships. It does not suggest that otherwise, they will lose their salvation and burn forever.

> There will be more rejoicing in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who do not need to repent.
>
> Luke 15:7, 10

In this context, Luke 15's parables (The Lost Sheep, The Lost Coin, The Prodigal Son) illustrate the restoration of a strained relationship. The son's return to his father is a

prime example of reconciling after a dispute. It would be unlikely for listeners of this parable to interpret it as being saved from eternal punishment for rejecting Christ, who had not even died yet.

Salvation

You likely heard the phrase "*Salvation (or Justification) is by faith alone*," as it is frequently cited within Protestantism. However, its interpretation varies significantly between the two main Protestant theological camps (Arminianism vs. Calvinism). In fact, I would say that "*by faith alone*" is nothing more than an illusion—a placebo in most Western Christian theology. What do I mean?

On the one hand, **Protestant Arminianist denominations**[19] teach that you are justified by faith alone. However, it is also believed that if you fail to live holy, keep all the rules, produce abundant fruit, successfully avoid sin, and endure until the end, you lose your salvation—resulting in endless torment in God's torturous cosmic fire chamber.

Conversely, **Protestant Calvinistic denominations**[20] (aka 'Reformed') advocate for justification/salvation by faith alone as well, embracing the concept of "once saved, always saved." Yet, Calvinists assert that failing to live a holy life, keep all the rules, produce fruit, successfully avoid sin, and persevere until the end suggests that you were never truly saved, to begin with; your faith was fake all along—also resulting in endless torment in God's torturous cosmic fire chamber.

Thus, despite the shared mantra of "by faith alone," most Protestant theology, much like some Catholic theology, ultimately ties salvation (from hellfire) to works. Arminianism incorporates works at the outset, aligning them with Christ's finished work, whereas Calvinism integrates them retrospectively. Both perspectives subtly blend salvation with works rather than embracing a pure doctrine of salvation/justification by faith alone. This implies a correlation between one's actions and one's salvation, suggesting that salvation isn't truly a free gift of grace but something earned or sustained through one's hard work and deeds. In essence, most Protestant theology (which, for the most part, is Catholic theology with just a few tweaks) involves a combination of faith and works in one way or another.

Don't get me wrong, I believe our works and deeds are of utmost importance! They are crucial for the quality of our lives and those of others around us. They are also essential for the individual's rewards and roles in the afterlife. However, as a Jew, Paul knew exactly where the line between faith and works was drawn, a line which later became blurry. Paul himself acknowledged the importance of his works as he knew the rewards he may or may not receive in the afterlife were in accordance with how he lived his life in the present world (1 Corinthians 9:27). It makes perfect sense rewards and roles in the afterlife can be earned and lost, but if getting saved from a cosmic incinerator is also something that must be earned or sustained, then I'm not sure how anyone can ever have peace of mind or sleep at night. As a Jewish person who believes in Jesus and obtained all my seminary degrees from conservative Christian institutions, the Western Christian interpretation of salvation was never something I was able to wrap my mind around fully. Allow me to illustrate…

What if our Father was a Calvinist or Arminianist?

Through His teachings, parables, and prayers, Jesus spent significant time and effort encouraging us to see God as our Father who loves us unconditionally. Hence, we should examine every theology from the perspective of divine fatherhood.

When your child sins against you, it no doubt damages the *quality* of your relationship (at least temporarily). If they repent, your relationship could heal instantly. But if they don't repent, will they cease being your child? Will you forever stop communicating with them? Will you burn them in the fire? Of course not! You will always seek to forgive, restore, and mend what is broken.

But wait, what if they repeatedly continue to sin and never seem to change their ways? Let's say they are a university student and keep getting drunk, sleeping around, getting into trouble, and never going to church. Will you ever think, *"That's it! There's no repentance nor fruit in their life. I must kill them!"* (Arminianism)? Or perhaps you would think, "*Look at their behavior! This is not how I raised them! This proves they never were my child to begin with!*" (Calvinism)? Of course not! They might disappoint you, and you may feel reluctant to buy them gifts, but these thoughts will never cross your mind! And yet, this is precisely how many Christians—always anxious and walking on eggshells—believe their Father in heaven views them.

Whether one accepts it or not, the children of God are as susceptible to sin as any other person in the world, and the inclusion of the Corinthians in the Bible canon—twice—serves to illustrate this point. Paul described the Corinthian church members as "sanctified" (1 Corinthians 1:2) while also confronting and condemning their sins, urging them to cease (1 Corinthians 15:34). They were paradoxically both "sinners" and "sanctified." No one doubts that their transgressions led to numerous issues. Yet, Paul's motivation for them to get their act together was the fact that God was their loving Father, never the fear or threat of Him torturing them forever. God is love, not a narcissistic, sadistic psychopath.

From that perspective, the endless, relentless, and fervent debates about the doctrine of salvation in many Christian circles could indicate a significant absence of inner peace and faith resulting from a flawed theology. It appears to suggest an internal struggle driven by fear of God rather than assurance in His love.

A fixation on salvation's theoretical mechanics and details could point to a profound insecurity regarding one's spiritual condition, as shown by the excessive time some spent on these arguments. Such an obsession implies that for many Christians, faith is often associated more with anxiety and fear than peace and confidence. Rather than perceiving God as a benevolent Parent, there's often a tendency in some Christian circles to view Him as an oppressive tyrant figure to be feared.

In Judaism, on the other hand, the concept of salvation is distinctively different. For a Jew, deeds are significant as they influence the quality of life, divine rewards, and one's status in the hereafter. Yet, these deeds are almost never connected to one's eternal fate. I believe the theology of Paul, a Jewish rabbi, was rooted in the Hebrew Scriptures and Jewish thought—rather than Protestant, Catholic, or Orthodox, which did not exist in his time.

Jewish Salvation

Contrary to certain Western notions of 'salvation,' for Jewish individuals, salvation is less about evading an infernal afterlife in God's cosmic fire chamber and more about receiving God's blessings and redemption in the present life. Just as in ancient times, today's Jewish community applies the term "salvation" to mean blessings, success,

and deliverance from adverse circumstances. The joy of conceiving a child after difficulty or finding business success following a period of hardship, as well as victory in conflict, are all seen as forms of 'salvation.' This usage was also common in biblical times. Below are several examples from the Hebrew Scriptures:

> Fear not, stand firm, and see the ***salvation*** of the Lord, which he will work for you today. For the Egyptians whom you see today, you shall never see again. The Lord will fight for you, and you have only to be silent.
>
> Exodus 14:13-14

This passage reflects God's salvation as deliverance from physical danger and oppression.

> The Lord is my light and my ***salvation***—whom shall I fear? The Lord is the stronghold of my life—of whom shall I be afraid?
>
> Psalm 27:1

Here, 'salvation' is linked with earthly protection and a sense of security in God.

> The ***salvation*** of the righteous comes from the Lord; he is their stronghold in time of trouble. The Lord helps them and delivers them; he delivers them from the wicked and saves them, because they take refuge in him.
>
> Psalm 37:39-40

This passage speaks of salvation in terms of rescue from adversaries.

> Surely God is my ***salvation***; I will trust and not be afraid. The Lord, the Lord himself, is my strength and my defense; he has become my ***salvation***.
>
> Isaiah 12:2-3

In this context, salvation is associated with strength, defense, and confidence in God's providential care in earthly terms.

> "So do not fear, Jacob my servant; do not be dismayed, Israel," declares the Lord. "I will surely ***save you*** out of a distant place, your descendants from the land of their exile. Jacob will again have peace and security, and no one will make him afraid."
>
> Jeremiah 30:10-11

Salvation here includes the promise of return from exile and restoring social peace and security.

Similar to the concept of "salvation" in the Hebrew Scriptures, the Jewish perspective on salvation focuses on earthly realities instead of deliverance from a torturous afterlife.

Hell in Judaism

The concept of the afterlife in Judaism is varied and complex, and it is not as explicitly laid out as it is in other religions. The traditional Jewish belief does include concepts of Heaven (Gan Eden) and Hell (Gehinnom), but these are not identical to the Christian concepts of Heaven and Hell. For example, the ancient writings of 2 Maccabees underscore a belief in posthumous rewards and punishments, laying the groundwork for later, more developed concepts of hell and divine judgment.

However, hell is not seen solely as an afterlife destination but mostly as a reality that occurs in people's lives on Earth.

The Jewish view of hell as a present reality can be profoundly illustrated by historical and contemporary tragedies such as the Holocaust. In Jewish thought, hell is often understood not as a distant, post-mortem realm of punishment but as an experience of immense suffering and evil that can occur within our lifetimes. The Holocaust, where six million Jews were systematically exterminated, represents a period where hell was palpably present on earth, manifesting through the extreme cruelty, dehumanization, and relentless torment inflicted by the Nazis.

Similarly, the horrific events of October 7th, 2023, where acts of terror brought profound loss and devastation, including teenage boys and girls being raped and babies being burned alive by Hamas, serve as a stark reminder that hellish realities can and do unfold in the here and now. As I write these lines, there are thousands of signs and billboards all over Israel with photos of the abductees and the writing, "*Release them from Hell now!*" These examples underscore the Jewish perspective that hell is a tangible, brutal experience of evil and suffering that permeates our world, demanding a moral and communal response to combat and overcome such darkness. The events of October 7 resulted in "hell" for many individuals on both sides.

In terms of the afterlife, Judaism offers a pluralism of theological and religious views. However, the most prevalent Jewish concept of Gehinnom, often translated as "Hell," is seen more as a place of purification rather than eternal damnation. In rabbinic literature, Gehinnom is usually described as a temporary abode where souls undergo purification before entering Gan Eden (Paradise).

The Talmud, the most pivotal text in Rabbinic Judaism, presents the perspectives of various rabbis and endorses this viewpoint in numerous passages. For instance, in Rosh Hashanah 17a, it is stated that the maximum duration of punishment in Gehinnom is one year, after which the soul is cleansed of its sins and ascends to its rightful place in paradise, highlighting that Gehinnom serves as a place where souls are purified before they can enter Gan Eden.

However, the Talmud (Berachot 5a) also introduces the idea that suffering in this world can serve as atonement for sins, essentially serving as a type of "Hell" on Earth. This is often interpreted to mean that hardships in life can cleanse the soul and bring spiritual growth. Judaism's perspective underscores the Jewish belief in ultimate

redemption and the merciful nature of divine judgment, distinguishing Gehinnom from the concept of eternal damnation found in some other religious traditions.

At the same time, the Mishnah (the first major work of rabbinic literature compiled around 200 CE) in Eduyot 2:10 mentions that after this sanctification period, the souls of the righteous are purified and move on to Gan Eden, while only those who became truly wicked are annihilated.

The Jewish perspective on hell as a place for correction and rehabilitation is quite pronounced and distinctively unique. I believe Rabbi Manis Friedman, a Jewish theologian, philosopher, and the dean of the Bais Chana Institute of Jewish Studies, summarizes the prevalent Jewish view quite well:

> Is Hitler going through hell? He put the world through hell, but I don't know if he's going through hell. You see, the concept of hell is "the repair of damage." Hell is not simply revenge on God's part. It's repair. It's salvaging the good that got lost in the bad, so you burn off the bad, and then you're left with the good. I'm not sure there's any good to Hitler that needs to be salvaged. Hell means the transition—the painful transition—between a soul in a body and a soul without a body. So, a soul returning to the world of souls goes through a painful transition—a painful readjustment. It's inevitable; the soul gets used to being in a body, and all of a sudden, it's not in a body. So, actually, the only people who go through hell are those who are on their way to heaven. Getting to Heaven you have to go through the adjustment, the cleansing process, the rethinking. If you're not going to heaven, then there is no point in going through hell.
>
> You might say very simply, "Getting to Heaven is Hell." But if you're not going to heaven, then there's no reason to go to hell. So Hitler is not on his way to heaven; he's probably not in hell. So what happens is that a soul that can be salvaged retains its identity, not just its existence. You retain your memories and your relationships; you're still you—not a generic angel; you are you. But that's if you're on your way to heaven. What happens to a person who doesn't deserve to go to heaven and doesn't even deserve to go to hell?

> What happens to them is they lose their identity, and they become generic energy. So, Hitler is not Hitler anymore. He's gone. You have to deserve to go through hell. [21]
>
> Rabbi Manis Friedman

Other rabbis hold the view that even in an individual such as Hitler, a trace of God's image might be present and thus could result in him occupying the lowest echelon of heaven.

On the other end of the spectrum, just as Christianity has its fringe radical elements, like the notorious Westboro Baptist Church, Judaism also has a handful of marginalized rabbis who espouse radical views, believing that almost everyone except themselves is destined for eternal torment in hellfire. Almost always, these are Sephardic rabbis with backgrounds from Muslim countries who have incorporated concepts of hellfire influenced by Islamic teachings. However, these individuals do not represent the mainstream beliefs of Judaism.

In short, the concept of hell in Judaism differs from that in Christianity, likely due in part to differing theological views on the proximate doctrines of 'sin,' 'atonement,' 'salvation,' and 'repentance.' For instance, often, when some Christians consider 'salvation,' they perceive it as being saved from eternal torment. However, as we saw earlier, the concept of 'salvation' has an essentially different meaning in Judaism.

Hell in Early Christianity

The understanding of hell has varied significantly throughout Christian history, reflecting differing theological frameworks across the early church. While views on the afterlife, especially hell, appear to have been underdeveloped during the early days of the church, below are some noteworthy statements from key figures in early Christianity that merit consideration. But first, it is essential to recognize that different modern schools of thought often dispute which Church Father held to what specific view. These debates reflect the challenges of translating and interpreting ancient texts and the diversity and complexity within early Christian theology regarding the nature of hell.

Church Fathers

Naturally, the authenticity of certain ancient quotes is often contested, so it's wise to approach them with a healthy dose of skepticism.

Clement of Rome (35-99 AD)

Also known as Pope Clement I, was a bishop of Rome in the first century. He is regarded as the foremost among the Apostolic Fathers of the Church. He authored a Greek letter to the Corinthians, which, having been lost for centuries and only known

in fragments through quotations by later authors, was eventually discovered in its entirety and attached to the Alexandrian codex. His letter was known to be recited in churches along with the writings of the New Testament.[22] In it, Clement of Rome wrote:

> Let us reflect how free from wrath he is towards **all** his creatures. God does good to all, but most abundantly to us who have fled for refuge to his compassions. God is the all-merciful and beneficent Father.[23]
>
> Clement of Rome

Hosea Ballou, an American theologian from the 18th century, commented, *"He [Clement of Rome] probably believed in the salvation of all mankind."*[24] Likewise, Thomas Allin, an Anglo-Irish priest and theologian from the 19th century, commented, *"From which we may, I think, infer that Clement, with other fathers, was a believer in the larger hope."*[25]

However, there is the issue of 2 Clement 6:7, in which he allegedly wrote the contrary.

2 Clement was once believed to have been written (to the Corinthians) by Clement of Rome sometime in the late 1st century.[26] However, 4th-century bishop Eusebius, in his historical work, says there was only one recognized epistle of Clement (namely the so-called First Epistle of Clement),[27] challenging the authenticity of a second epistle. Similar doubts were also expressed by Jerome in the 5th century.[28] Today, modern scholars believe that Second Clement is actually a sermon written much later, long after Clement of Rome died, by an anonymous preacher, one who was not Clement of Rome.[29]

Nonetheless, historians refer to the work by its known name, "Second Clement." Still, in it, the anonymous author used the word αἰωνίου (aionios) to describe his beliefs regarding hell. First, it is important to note that much like the New Testament, many of the writings of the Church Fathers were composed in Koine Greek and are often misunderstood or mistranslated. For instance, the Greek word αἰωνίου (aionios) found in 2 Clement 6:7 is translated by some as "*eternal*" and "*everlasting*," whereas a more accurate translation would be "*age-long*," "*for an age*," or "*pertaining to an age*."

The term "ἀΐδιος" (aïdios), on the other hand, which more definitively means "eternal," is used in the New Testament to describe God's power (Romans 1:20) but is not applied to hell or punishment. This distinction is crucial for understanding the New Testament writings and early Christian eschatology and theology. Further exploration of this topic will be detailed in subsequent sections of the book.

Ignatius of Antioch (Died 108 AD)

Also known as Ignatius Theophorus, was an early Christian theologian and Patriarch of Antioch. While en route to Rome, where he met his martyrdom, Ignatius, who some believe was a disciple of the Apostle John and/or Simon Peter, wrote a series of letters. This correspondence forms a central part of a later collection of works by the Apostolic Fathers. He is considered one of the three most important of these, together with Clement of Rome and Polycarp. Different camps often quote Ignatius. Interestingly, in his letter to the Magnesians, Ignatius wrote:

> For as one who has been thought worthy of a divine and desirable name, in those bonds which I bear about, I commend the Churches, in which I pray for a union both of the flesh and spirit of **Jesus Christ, who is the Saviour of all men, but specially of them that believe**; by whose blood ye were redeemed; by whom ye have known God, or rather have been known by Him. [30]
>
> Ignatius of Antioch

Polycarp of Smyrna (c. 69-155 AD)

Polycarp, a prominent early Christian bishop and martyr, is often cited in discussions on early Christian beliefs about the afterlife. However, there is no clear evidence from his own writings that he explicitly believed in a temporary hell, eternal hell, annihilation, or something else altogether. The famous quote attributed to him about the afterlife comes from the *Martyrdom of Polycarp*, a letter written to the church at

Smyrna around 150 AD. In Chapter 11 of this letter, Polycarp reportedly says to his torturers:

> You threaten me with the fire which burns for an hour and after a little is extinguished, but you are ignorant of the fire of the coming judgment and of *aiónios* [age-long] fire.[31]
>
> Polycarp of Smyrna

While this account clearly suggests a belief in some form of judgment, the Greek term used here (and in other early Christian texts), "aiónios," more accurately translates to "age-long" rather than implying undefined long duration (aïdios), suggesting that their judgment will be much more severe, but not necessarily eternal.

Justin Martyr (c. 100-165 AD)

Justin was an early apologist and philosopher known for his robust defense of Christianity. Though many of his works are lost, two apologies and a dialogue have survived. His most well-known text, the "*First Apology*," passionately defends the morality of the Christian life and provides various ethical, moral, and philosophical arguments to convince the Roman emperor, Antoninus Pius, to abandon the persecution of Christians. In it, Justin wrote:

> Then shall they be punished with *aiōnian* [age-long] punishment and not, as Plato says, for a period only of a thousand years.[32]
>
> Justin Martyr

Justin Martyr rejected Plato's idea of a thousand years' punishment for all unrighteous regardless of the severity of their sins, advocating instead for the notion of a time he describes as "αἰωνίαν" (aiónios), which has no predefined time. It remains ambiguous whether Justin's opposition to Plato's doctrine of hell was general or

specifically targeted at the concept of 1000 years, given that Plato was a Greek philosopher and not a Christian. Nonetheless, by contesting the fixed period of 1000 years and proposing an indefinite duration, Justin appears to emphasize the gravity of divine justice, suggesting variable, undefined periods of time proportionate to the gravity of the sin committed, as inferred from the context of their debate on morality and ethics.

Theophilus of Antioch (c. 120-183 AD)

Theophilus of Antioch was an early Christian apologist and Patriarch of Antioch. He is best known for his work "To Autolycus," a defense of Christianity addressed to a pagan friend. Theophilus contributed significantly to the development of Christian thought in the second century:

> And God showed great kindness to man, in this, that He did not suffer him to continue being in sin forever; but as it were, by a kind of banishment, cast him out of paradise in order that, having punishment expiated within an appointed time, and having been disciplined, he should afterwards be recalled... just as a vessel, when one being fashioned it has some flaw, is remoulded or remade that it may become new and entire; so also it happens to man by death. For he is broken up by force, that in the resurrection he may be found whole; I mean spotless, righteous and immortal. [33]
>
> Theophilus of Antioch

Irenaeus of Lyons (c. 130-202 AD)

Irenaeus, a Greek bishop, was a pivotal early Christian theologian. His influential work, "Against Heresies," targeted Gnosticism and played a crucial role in shaping orthodoxy for the early church. The exact stance Irenaeus held regarding hell remains a topic of

debate as more than one camp claims Irenaeus represents their view. In his writings, he stated the following:

> The judge…will send into αἰώνιος fire those who alter the truth, and despise his Father and his coming. [34]
>
> Irenaeus of Lyons

The main argument concerns Irenaeus' use of the words "αἰώνιος" (an age vs. eternity) and "fire" (literally vs. metaphorically), which is challenging to determine due to the various uses of these words in different contexts and Irenaeus' use of these words elsewhere.

Clement of Alexandria (c. 150-215 AD)

Clement of Alexandria was an early Christian theologian and philosopher. He founded the Catechetical School of Alexandria and was instrumental in the development of Christian education and apologetics. He wrote:

> We can set no limits to the agency of the Redeemer to redeem, to rescue, to discipline in his work, and so will he continue to operate after this life. [35] …All men are Christ's, some by knowing Him, the rest not yet. He is the Savior not of some and the rest not. For how is He savior and Lord, if not the Savior and Lord of all? [36]
>
> Clement of Alexandria

Origen of Alexandria (c. 185-254 AD)

Origen was the most important biblical scholar of the early Greek church and one of the most influential early theologians. He founded a school in Caesarea and is known

for his extensive writings, including the "Hexapla" and "On First Principles," which laid the groundwork for much of Christian theology and biblical exegesis. Origen proposed the concept of ***apokatastasis*** (the restoration of all creation to a condition of perfection), suggesting that all souls, including the devil and his demons, would ultimately be reconciled with God. Origen believed that God's love and mercy would lead to the restoration of all creation. This Jewish-resembling view reflected the early Christian inclination towards universal reconciliation. Origen's belief was that the fires of hell served a corrective, purifying purpose rather than being a place of eternal punishment:

> There is a resurrection of the dead, and there is punishment, but not everlasting. For when the body is punished the soul is gradually purified, and so is restored to its ancient rank. For all wicked men, and for daemons, too, shall be restored to their former rank. [37]

> So then, when the end has been restored to the beginning, and the termination of things compared with their commencement, that condition of things will be re-established in which rational nature was placed, when it had no need to eat of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil; so that when all feeling of wickedness has been removed, and the individual has been purified and cleansed, He who alone is the one good God becomes to him 'all,' and that not in the case of a few individuals, or of a considerable number, but He Himself is 'all in all.' And when death shall no longer anywhere exist, nor the sting of death, nor any evil at all, then verily God will be 'all in all.' [38]
>
> Origen of Alexandria

Arnobius of Sicca (c. 255-330 AD)

Also known as Arnobius the Elder, was an early Christian apologist of Berber origin

during the reign of Diocletian. While some argue that hints of annihilationism[39] are found in the writings of Ignatius of Antioch,[40] Justin Martyr,[41] and Irenaeus,[42] it is the teachings of Arnobius that are most often interpreted as the first to defend annihilationism explicitly:

> For they are cast in, and being annihilated, pass away vainly in everlasting destruction. For theirs is an intermediate state, as has been learned from Christ's teaching; and they are such that they may on the one hand perish if they have not known God, and on the other be delivered from death if they have given heed to His threats and proffered favours. And to make manifest what is unknown, this is man's real death, this which leaves nothing behind. For that which is seen by the eyes is only a separation of soul from body, not the last end— annihilation.[43]
>
> Arnobius of Sicca

Eusebius of Caesarea (c. 260-340 AD)

Also known as Eusebius Pamphili, was a historian, exegete, and Christian polemicist. He became the Bishop of Caesarea Maritima about 314 AD. He was a scholar of the Biblical canon and is regarded as an extremely learned Christian of his time:

> The Son "breaking in pieces" His enemies is for the sake of remolding them, as a potter his own work; as Jeremiah 18:6 says: i.e., to restore them once again to their former state."[44]
>
> Eusebius of Caesarea

Hilary of Poitiers (c. 310–367 AD)

Hilary of Poitiers was a significant early Christian bishop and theologian known for his staunch defense of the doctrine of the Trinity against Arianism. He is often referred to as the "Athanasius of the West" and as the first theologian of the Trinity. Hilary believed "*that Christ assumes all humanity physically into his body at the incarnation.*"[45] In other words, Hilary's understanding of salvation was that Christ's atonement was universal in scope:

> Christ has become the body of the whole of humanity, that, through the body that he was kind enough to assume, the whole of humanity might be hidden in him.[46]
>
> Hilary of Poitiers

Athanasius of Alexandria (c. 296-373 AD)

Athanasius was a significant theologian, Church Father, and the twentieth bishop of Alexandria. His defense of Trinitarianism against Arianism and his works, including "On the Incarnation," has made him a pivotal figure in the development of Christian orthodoxy. He wrote:

> While the devil thought to kill One [Christ], he is deprived of all those cast out of hades, and he [the devil], sitting by the gates, sees all fettered beings led forth by the courage of the Savior.[47]... Flesh was taken up by the Logos to liberate all humans and resurrect all of them from the dead and ransom all of them from sin.[48]
>
> Athanasius of Alexandria

St. Basil the Great (c. 330-379 AD)

Also known as Basil of Caesarea, was the Bishop of Caesarea Mazaca in Cappadocia, Asia Minor. Basil was an early Church Father who defended the orthodox faith against the Arian heresy. As bishop of Caesarea, he wrote several works on monasticism, theology, and canon law. He was declared a saint soon after his death. Basil wrote of the common belief regarding afterlife punishment:

> The mass of men [Christians] say there is to be an end to punishment and to those who are punished.[49]
>
> St. Basil the Great

St. Macrina the Younger (c. 327-379 AD)

Also known as St. Macrina the Blessed, the sister of St. Basil the Great and St. Gregory of Nyssa, was a prominent early Christian nun and theologian. Her teachings and piety greatly influenced her brothers and the development of early monasticism in the Eastern Church. Macrina wrote:

> The Word seems to me to lay down the doctrine of the perfect obliteration of wickedness, for if God shall be in all things that are, obviously wickedness shall not be in them. For it is necessary that at some time evil should be removed utterly and entirely from the realm of being.[50]
>
> St. Macrina the Younger

Gregory of Nazianzus (329-390 AD)

Also known as Gregory the Theologian, was a 4th-century Archbishop of Constantinople and one of the Cappadocian Fathers. He wrote:

> These, if they will, may go Christ's way, but if not let them go their way. In another place perhaps they shall be baptized with fire, that last baptism, which is not only painful, but enduring also; which eats up, as if it were hay, all defiled matter, and consumes all vanity and vice. [51]
>
> Gregory of Nazianzus

Diodore of Tarsus (c. 320-394 AD)

Diodore of Tarsus was a prominent early Christian bishop and theologian known for his exegetical works and his influence on the Antiochene school of theology. His teachings emphasized a literal and historical interpretation of the Bible, and he was a mentor to notable figures like John Chrysostom and Theodore of Mopsuestia. Diodore wrote:

> For the wicked there are punishments, not perpetual, however, lest the immortality prepared for them should be a disadvantage, but they are to be purified for a brief period according to the amount of malice in their works. They shall therefore suffer punishment for a short space, but immortal blessedness having no end awaits them...the penalties to be inflicted for their many and grave sins are very far surpassed by the magnitude of the mercy to be showed to them. [52]

Diodore of Tarsus

Gregory of Nyssa (c. 335-395 AD)

Also known as Gregory Nyssen, revered as one of the Cappadocian Fathers, was the Bishop of Nyssa in Cappadocia. He contributed significantly to the doctrine of the Trinity and the Nicene Creed. He is venerated as a saint in Eastern Orthodoxy, Catholicism, Oriental Orthodoxy, Anglicanism, and Lutheranism. Gregory posited that God's love would eventually compel all creation to return to Him. Gregory's vision of hell was not one of eternal damnation but of a forging process through which souls are purified and ultimately restored to a right relationship with God:

> For it is evident that God will in truth be 'in all' when there shall be no evil in existence, when every created being is at harmony with itself, and every tongue shall confess that Jesus Christ is Lord; when every creature shall have been made one body. Now the body of Christ, as I have often said, is the whole of humanity.[53]
>
> Gregory of Nyssa

Ambrose of Milan (340-397 AD)

Ambrose was a bishop of Milan who became one of the most influential ecclesiastical figures of the 4th century. He played a significant role in the conversion of St. Augustine and was known for his theological writings and hymns. Ambrose wrote:

> Our Savior has appointed two kinds of resurrection in the Apocalypse. "Blessed is he that hath part in the first resurrection," for such come to grace without the judgment. As for those who do

> not come to the first, but are reserved unto the second resurrection, these shall be disciplined until their appointed times, between the first and the second resurrection.[54]
>
> Ambrose of Milan

Didymus the Blind (313-398 AD)

Didymus the Blind was a prominent theologian and head of the Catechetical School of Alexandria. Despite losing his eyesight, he contributed significantly to Christian theology and was highly respected for his deep understanding of Scripture. Didymus wrote:

> Mankind, being reclaimed from their sins, are to be subjected to Christ in the fullness of the dispensation instituted for the salvation of all.[55]
>
> Didymus the Blind

St. Chrysostom (c. 347-407 AD)

John Chrysostom, known for his eloquent preaching and public speaking, was an early Church Father who served as Archbishop of Constantinople. His sermons, theological treatises, and letters have had a lasting impact on Christian liturgy and theology. John Chrysostom described Hell as a place of *"various kinds of torments and torrents of punishment."*[56] On the other hand, he also concluded that…

> While the devil imagined that he got a hold of Christ, he really lost all of those he was keeping.[57]
>
> St. Chrysostom

St. Jerome (347-420 AD)

St. Jerome was a Christian priest, confessor, theologian, and historian. He is best known for his translation of the Bible into Latin (the Vulgate) and his commentaries on the Gospels. Jerome's scholarly work laid the foundations for much of the Western Church's biblical interpretation:

> In the end and consummation of the Universe all are to be restored into their original harmonious state, and we all shall be made one body and be united once more into a perfect man and the prayer of our Savior shall be fulfilled that all may be one. [58]
>
> St. Jerome

Theodore of Mopsuestia (350-428 AD)

Theodore of Mopsuestia was a theologian and bishop known for his exegetical works and his influence on the Antiochene school of thought. He emphasized the historical and literal interpretation of Scripture and significantly impacted the development of Nestorianism.

> The wicked who have committed evil the whole period of their lives shall be punished till they learn that, by continuing in sin, they only continue in misery. And when, by this means, they shall have been brought to fear God, and to regard Him with good will, they shall obtain the enjoyment of His grace. [59]
>
> Theodore of Mopsuestia

Augustine of Hippo (354-430 AD)

Augustine of Hippo was a pivotal figure in Western Christian theology and philosophy and a controversial figure to date. His seminal works, "Confessions" and "City of God," have profoundly influenced Western Christian thought. Augustine originated the doctrines of Original Sin, Total Depravity, Total Inability, and Predestination, which were crucial to medieval and Reformation theology, highly influencing Calvin and Luther's Reformation in the Catholic church. Augustine was among the first to challenge various doctrines of the Church Fathers, particularly their views on hell, advocating for the concept of "endless torment in hell." Despite being a prominent proponent of this perspective, he recognized it as a minority opinion:

> There are very many in our day, who though not denying the Holy Scriptures, do not believe in endless torments. [60]
>
> Augustine of Hippo

The doctrine of eternal conscious torment (ECT), as popularized by Augustine, presented hell as a place of unending physical suffering and torture. His view was and is often criticized for portraying God as a narcissistic, sadistic psychopath who derives pleasure from perpetual pain, a concept that conflicts with the scriptural portrayal of a loving and merciful deity. The idea of eternal torture with no possibility of redemption appears to many as more sadistic than just, suggesting a God who delights in suffering for its own sake. Despite this, Augustine's perspectives, who lived far away from most of the Church Fathers, gained significant influence within the Western Church (Roman Catholic and Protestant), where his teachings became the prevailing doctrine across many contemporary conservative Protestant denominations today.

Peter Chrysologus (c. 380-450 AD)

Peter Chrysologus, known as the "Golden-Worded," was a bishop of Ravenna. He is recognized for his concise and impactful homilies, which addressed various theological and moral topics, earning him the title of Doctor of the Church. He wrote...

> That in the world to come, those who have done evil all their life long, will be made worthy of the sweetness of the Divine bounty. For never would Christ have said, "You will never get out until you have paid the last penny" unless it were possible for us to get cleansed when we paid the debt.[61]
>
> Peter Chrysologus

Theodoret the Blessed (387-458 AD)

Also known as Theodoret of Cyrus, was a prominent theologian and bishop of Cyrrhus in Syria. He was a prolific writer and a key figure in the theological debates of his time, particularly those concerning Christology. His works contributed to the development of Christian doctrine in the Eastern Church:

> In the present life God is in all, for His nature is without limits, but he is not all in all. But in the coming life, when mortality is at an end and immortality granted, and sin has no longer any place, God will be all in all. For the Lord, who loves man, punishes medicinally, that He may check the course of impiety.[62]
>
> Theodoret the Blessed

Olympiodorus (495-550 AD)

Olympiodorus was a Christian philosopher and commentator known for his works on Neoplatonism and his efforts to reconcile Christian theology with classical philosophy. His writings contributed to the intellectual tradition of the early Byzantine Church. Olympiodorus wrote:

> Do not suppose that the soul is punished for endless eons (apeirou aionas) in Tartarus. Very properly, the soul is not punished to gratify the revenge of the divinity, but for the sake of healing. But we say that the soul is punished for an aionion period (aionios) calling its life and its allotted period of punishment, its aeon.[63]
>
> Olympiodorus

In summary, aside from Augustine of Hippo, the majority of the Church Fathers held the belief in a temporary judgment in the afterlife, as opposed to an eternal one, a concept likely first advocated by Augustine of Hippo.

Hell in Early Christian Schools

In the first few centuries of the church, six catechetical schools taught theology, and their teachings on hell varied widely. These schools—much like modern seminaries—were the primary centers of Christian education and theological development during their time.

1. **Antioch:** The School of Antioch was known for its emphasis on the literal and historical interpretation of Scripture. This school taught that hell was a temporary state designed to purify and ultimately restore all souls to

God. This approach emphasized God's ultimate plan for the reconciliation and salvation of all creation.

2. **Alexandria:** The Catechetical School of Alexandria was one of the most influential theological centers in early Christianity. It was known for its allegorical interpretation of Scripture and philosophical approach to theology. Alexandria's teachings proposed that hell served as a corrective and purifying phase, ultimately leading all souls to salvation through God's love and mercy.
3. **Cesarea:** The theological school in Caesarea, influenced by Origen and other prominent theologians, also believed and taught that God's judgment was not endless but rather a process through which souls would be purified and eventually restored to their original, sinless state.
4. **Eastern Syria:** The Eastern Syrian school, part of the broader Syriac Christian tradition, taught that divine punishment was temporary and aimed at bringing about repentance and healing, emphasizing the compassionate nature of God.
5. **Asia Minor (Turkey):** The theological school in Asia Minor took a different approach, teaching annihilationism. This view held that the wicked would ultimately be eliminated—cease to exist—rather than being subjected to eternal torment.
6. **Hippo:** The school in Hippo, named after Augustine of Hippo, was located in North Western Africa and was the only one that taught eternal conscious torment. This school viewed afterlife punishment as "hellfire"—a place of never-ending torturous punishment and suffering for the unrepentant. It emphasized the severity of sin and the absolute nature of divine wrath and judgment.

The majority of these schools, including the most esteemed centers of Alexandria and Antioch, taught complete and total reconciliation. They viewed eschatological punishments as corrective, temporary, and remedial, aimed at the restoration of the sinner. Their understanding of hell reflect a more hopeful and compassionate view of God's justice and mercy, likened to that of the Jews, contrasting sharply with the later, more punitive doctrines of eternal conscious torment of hellfire.

Hell in Late Christianity

On July 16, 1054, Michael Cerularius, the Patriarch of Constantinople, was excommunicated from the Christian church based in Rome, Italy. This excommunication marked a critical juncture in the escalating tensions between the Western Roman church (in Rome) and the Eastern Byzantine church (in Constantinople). This division is referred to as the Great Schism, also known as the "East-West Schism" or the "Schism of 1054." The ensuing division cleaved the European Christian church into two principal branches: the Western Roman Catholic Church, which later included Protestantism, both largely influenced by Augustine's theology, and the Eastern Orthodox Church, shaped by theologians like Origen of Alexandria. Subsequently, the notion of hell became a pivotal element in Western Christian theological discourse.

The Harrowing of Hell

In Christian theology, the Harrowing of Hell (Latin: Descensus Christi ad Inferos) is the period of time between the Crucifixion of Jesus and his resurrection. The Harrowing of Hell was depicted differently in Western and Eastern Christian traditions. In Western Christianity, the focus often lies on judgment, portraying Jesus as a judge who casts the damned into hell. This perspective is reflected in sources such as the Catechism of the Catholic Church and Dante's *"Divine Comedy,"* which highlight Christ's triumph and the finality of divine retribution. In contrast, Eastern Christianity emphasized Christ's victory over death and His role in liberating souls, often depicting

Him breaking the gates of hell and rescuing the damned, symbolizing His boundless mercy and the redemptive aspect of His mission. This approach is evident in Eastern Orthodox iconography and St. John Chrysostom's Paschal Homily, which celebrates Christ's universal redemption and liberation through His resurrection. These differing portrayals reflect broader theological differences between Western and Eastern traditions on hell, with the West (Catholic) focusing on judgment, while the East highlights victory and salvation.

Orthodox Christianity

The Eastern Orthodox Church, which first shared some similarities with Catholicism in viewing hell, sees Hell as a state of self-exclusion from the love and presence of God, chosen by the individual through persistent sin and rejection of God's grace. Some Orthodox theologians emphasize the transformative nature of God's love, even in the context of judgment in Hell, which is seen less as a place of active torturous punishment and more as a state of being that results from one's own choices and refusal to accept divine love—much like the life of the Prodigal Son.

Catholic Christianity

In Catholic theology, hell was acknowledged as a state of eternal separation from God for those who die in a state of mortal sin. However, Catholic doctrine also introduces the concept of Purgatory, a temporary state of purification for souls destined for heaven but needing to be cleansed of venial sins or temporal punishment due to sin. Purgatory is a place of purification, where suffering serves a redemptive purpose, ultimately preparing souls for the beatific vision of God. This is a temporary state where souls who have died in a state of grace but still need purification from venial sins or the temporal effects of sins undergo cleansing before entering heaven. The idea is that these souls are assured of their eventual entrance into heaven but need to be purified to achieve the holiness necessary to enter the presence of God.

Although its roots lie in the Church Fathers' teachings, the concept of Purgatory as a distinct place or state where souls undergo purification before entering heaven was

developed gradually in later centuries, mostly taking shape in the early Middle Ages with Pope Gregory the Great (c. 540-604), who played a significant role in developing the concept of Purgatory. In his "*Dialogues*," he spoke about fire being purgatorial and the need for purification after death for certain souls, helping to establish the idea within the Church.

Late Medieval Era (10th-15th Centuries)

The Second Council of Lyons (1274) provided one of the first official articulations of the doctrine of Purgatory. The council defined Purgatory as a place where souls are purified and emphasized the importance of prayers and masses for the loved ones who are dead. The Council of Florence (1438-1445) further clarified the doctrine of Purgatory, affirming the existence of a purgatorial state and the efficacy of prayers, masses, and almsgiving for the souls undergoing purification. The Council of Trent (1545-1563) solidified the doctrine of Purgatory in response to the Protestant Reformation, which rejected it and held to the "eternal torture" (ECT) view of hellfire. The council reaffirmed the existence of Purgatory and the practice of offering prayers and masses for the dead, making it an essential part of Catholic teaching.

Hellfire

As Augustine's perspectives gradually prevailed and became entrenched in the Western Church, depictions of hellfire were often graphic and grotesque, designed to invoke fear and terror. Below are several well-known, vivid illustrations of hellfire from the Middle Ages that profoundly influenced the minds of countless individuals:

- **"The Last Judgment" by Gislebertus** - Gislebertus, a Romanesque sculptor, created a tympanum on the west portal of Saint-Lazare Cathedral in Autun, France. This relief sculpture allegorically yet vividly portrays the damned being led to torture. Gislebertus' depiction of hellfire is particularly

gruesome, with grotesque demons torturing the damned. Distorted figures and horrific scenes illustrate the eternal torment awaiting sinners. The Archangel Michael is shown weighing souls while demons try to tip the scales, adding to the sense of impending doom and horror. Hellfire itself is depicted as a chaotic, terrifying place, filled with suffering and demonic figures reveling in the torment of the damned.

- **"L'Inferno" illustrated by Sandro Botticelli** - Sandro Botticelli, one of the most renowned artists of the Italian Renaissance, created a series of drawings depicting scenes from Dante Alighieri's *"Divine Comedy."* Among these, his illustration for Canto XVII of the "Inferno" stands out as a vivid portrayal of the poet's journey through hell. His work vividly brings to life the terrifying and grotesque aspects of what he believed hellfire was like, blending his artistic mastery with Dante's literary genius. The central figure in Botticelli's drawing is Geryon, depicted as a fearsome creature with a human face, the body of a serpent, and the paws of a lion. Around Geryon, Botticelli illustrates the tormented souls of the usurers. These figures are portrayed as crouching in the burning sand, with purses hanging from their necks, each bearing their family's coat of arms.
- **"The Inferno" from the Holkham Bible** - This English illuminated manuscript contains a depiction of hellfire that is chaotic and crowded with damned souls and monstrous demons. The demons are illustrated as torturing the damned in a fiery landscape, with various forms of grotesque punishments that match the sins committed during their lifetime.
- **"Apocalypse Tapestries" by Jean Bondol** - Commissioned by the Duke of Berry, these tapestries depict scenes from the Apocalypse, including vivid representations of hell. The images are filled with monstrous beasts and dragons torturing the damned, reflecting the fears and religious beliefs of the time. These illustrations and artworks serve not only as religious teaching tools but also as reflections of the societal values and fears of their times, portraying hellfire in ways that were meant to be profoundly terrifying.
- **"The Garden of Earthly Delights" by Hieronymus Bosch** - Though at the very end of the medieval period and beginning of the Renaissance, Bosch's

work encapsulates the medieval imagination with its nightmarish detail. The right panel of this triptych, depicting hellfire, is filled with bizarre and disturbing images: humans are tormented by demons, creatures eat sinners, and others are subjected to endless, bizarre tortures involving various medieval instruments and creatures.

Medieval depictions of hellfire, originating from Western Europe, have undeniably impacted subsequent generations, greatly shaping the Catholic and Protestant theologies that prevailed in the area and, in modern times, becoming even more popularized through mass media depictions. These portrayals emphasize hellfire as a realm of perpetual agony, influencing theological views and societal attitudes towards sin and retribution for centuries. The stark and dreadful images of ceaseless torture and demonic entities presented a graphic and frightful vision of Augustine's hellfire that made a deep and alarming impact on Christian followers, instilling them with fear and dread, which was then mirrored in the works of Western Christian writers, including clergy and theologians.

In summary, the most vivid descriptions of hellfire, including those in modern times, originate from early Roman Catholic authors and later artists like the Italian poet Dante Alighieri (1265-1321), who is famous for "Dante's Inferno." These depictions continued to influence literature, as seen in the works of the English poet John Milton (1608-1674), author of "Paradise Lost." In later years, the concept of hell was further developed by Protestant theologians such as Martin Luther, John Calvin, and Jonathan Edwards (known as *"the Theologian of Fire and Brimstone"*), who brought the theology of Calvin and Luther to the United States and significantly shaped what would later become American Evangelicalism.[64] This influence extended to the theology of other American denominations, such as Baptist, Southern Baptist, and Calvery Chapel.

While Protestant theologians generally rejected the concept of Purgatory, maintaining the Augustinian-Calvinist belief in eternal torture, Catholic theologians developed and codified the formal doctrine of Purgatory. This divergence led to differing views: Many traditional churches entertain a temporary, corrective view of hell (as a form of post-mortem purification), while conservative Protestant denominations typically adhere to the belief in eternal hellfire.

The Protestant Reformation (16th Century)

Protestant perspectives on hell, encompassing Reformed (Calvinist), Arminian, Evangelical, Pentecostal, Baptist, and other fundamentalist denominations, differ markedly from Jewish, Catholic, and Orthodox interpretations, which sometimes view hell as a corrective and temporary state. The Protestant "hellfire," frequently depicted as a place of eternal conscious torment, is characterized by unending physical, mental, and emotional suffering through means of torture such as fire. This view, like much of the other Protestant theology, is heavily influenced by Augustine of Hippo and is based on a literal interpretation and imaginative elaboration of biblical metaphors.

In the Protestant framework, hellfire is primarily a place of everlasting revengeful retribution, where God's justice is seen in the eternal abusive punishment of sinners. This portrayal lacks the rehabilitative or corrective elements found in other theological views. Instead, it presents a vision of hellfire that emphasizes the severity of sin and the supposed unforgiving and absolute nature of divine justice. However, problematically, it also suggests a sadistic aspect to God's character. The concept that God could find any pleasure or gratification in the endless suffering of His creations without any chance for redemption or cessation of their pain presents deep ethical and theological dilemmas.

Please don't understand my words as labeling the Protestant Reformation entirely bad and evil (as a Jew, it was through them that I first got introduced to Jesus!); however, we cannot overlook the negative aspects and doctrines that emerged from it.

Martin Luther and John Calvin, the two central figures behind the Protestant Reformation, profoundly influenced the various branches of Protestant Christianity. While they aimed to reform Catholic Christianity, their theological foundations remained deeply rooted in Catholic doctrine, especially that of Augustine of Hippo. Both Luther and Calvin believed and promoted a literal view of hellfire, where eternal torture awaits those who reject their theological perspectives, such as their doctrine of soteriology (how to "get saved").

Martin Luther (1483-1546)

Martin Luther, the seminal figure of the Protestant Reformation, is celebrated for his role in challenging the Catholic Church and initiating religious reform with his Ninety-Five Theses. Nonetheless, Luther's legacy is significantly tarnished by his vehement antisemitism. His later writings, such as "*On the Jews and Their Lies,*" are filled with vitriolic language and hateful rhetoric against Jews,[65] which included incitements to burn Jewish synagogues and the homes of Jews and ultimately advocating for the elimination of the Jewish race.[66] These writings have been condemned for their contribution to centuries of antisemitic sentiment and violence, with its climax in the murdering of six million Jews during the Holocaust orchestrated by Adolf Hitler, a figure who repeatedly quoted Martin Luther in his speeches and writings. Hitler praised Martin Luther as "*a great warrior, a true statesman, and a great reformer.*"[67] Hitler also admitted, "*Martin Luther has been the greatest encouragement of my life.*"[68]

John Calvin (1509-1564)

John Calvin was a lawyer and the other principal figure in the Protestant Reformation due to his influential works in theology, including *"Institutes of the Christian Religion."* However, his legacy is marred by his role in the execution of Michael Servetus, a physician and theologian who challenged Calvin's views. In 1553, after several attempts by Calvin, Servetus was finally arrested, tortured, and burned at the stake in Geneva for alleged heresy, highlighting Calvin's severe and uncompromising approach. This notable event also illuminates Calvin's thought process and perception of God. Calvin, renowned for his theological affinity for Augustine, discussed the concept of hellfire:

> Language cannot describe the severity of the divine vengeance on the reprobate, their pains and torments are figured to us by corporeal things, such as darkness, wailing and gnashing of teeth, inextinguishable fire, the ever-gnawing worm.[69]

The Protestant Confession (1647)

According to the 1647 Protestant confession, non-Protestants will be "*punished with unspeakable torments, both of body and soul.*"[70]

In December 1643, a committee was formed to write the Catechism, which was completed by the Westminster Assembly in 1647. It was then adopted by the General Assembly of the Church of Scotland in 1648. Although with some modifications, it was later adopted by the Presbyterian Synod of New York and Philadelphia and by the Presbyterian Church in the U.S.A. The Catechism was later dropped by some groups while embraced by the successor conservative denominations, including the Presbyterian, Orthodox Presbyterian, and Evangelical Presbyterian churches.

The Wars of Religion (16th-18th Centuries)

The Wars of Religion, a series of violent conflicts that ravaged Europe during the 16th, 17th, and early 18th centuries, were primarily fueled by deep-seated theological disagreements between Catholics and Reformed Protestants. These wars, including the French Wars of Religion, the Thirty Years' War, and the Eighty Years' War, resulted in immense human suffering. It is estimated that up to 20 million Christians were killed, and many more were affected, with the Thirty Years' War alone causing the deaths of about 8 million people and injuring countless more. These brutal conflicts, ostensibly over interpretations of Christian doctrine, highlight the devastating consequences of religious intolerance and the tragic cost of loveless doctrinal disputes.

The French Wars of Religion (1562-1598) saw brutal massacres and widespread violence between Catholic and Reformed Protestant factions, deeply fracturing French society. The Eighty Years' War (1568-1648) was a prolonged struggle in the Low Countries, where Protestant Dutch forces fought against the Catholic Habsburg monarchy for independence, resulting in significant destruction and loss of life for both sides. The Thirty Years' War (1618-1648) devastated large parts of Europe, with battles causing famine and disease, taking a further heavy toll on the general population.

"What Would Jesus do"

When Jesus initially dispatched His Jewish disciples, it was not to persuade atheists of God's existence. Instead, it was to demonstrate to religious fundamentalists that God embodies love and, as such, they, too, should love others. Moreover, when Jesus cautioned His disciples about persecution, He was not alluding to hostility from a secular society but rather from a world ruled by religious factions prepared to commit violence for their beliefs, claiming divine sanction.

The Wars of Religion exemplify how theological disputes often escalate into extensive and destructive conflicts, revealing the dire consequences of religious extremism and intolerance. When Jesus advised, "*By their fruit, you will recognize them...every good tree bears good fruit, but a bad tree bears bad fruit*" (Matthew 7:16-17), He likely warned against such devastating outcomes, underscoring the importance of genuine spiritual fruit over divisive dogma. This period—which may have positioned Catholic and Protestant Christianity as the most bloodshed religions in history— serves as a somber reminder of the human cost of doctrinal rigidity and the profound physical, spiritual, and emotional impact of religious conflict on the general society, believing and unbelieving alike. Ironically, it is often those same Christians teaching that God will eternally torture those who oppose their theology who killed so many—attempting to force their theology on the world. This unfortunate era serves as sad proof that our beliefs about God and His character profoundly influence our behavior in real life—theology matters!

Jonathan Edwards (1703-1758)

Four main characters brought Protestantism to American Christianity: George Whitefield, John and Charles Wesley, and perhaps most notable, Jonathan Edwards, most known for his role in the First Great Awakening, bringing Calvin's hellfire theology to America. On July 8th, 1741, he preached his most famous "*Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God*" sermon, greatly influencing the theological formation of American Protestant Christianity. Below is an excerpt from his speech:

> The God that holds you over the pit of hell, much as one holds a spider or some loathsome insect over the fire, abhors you, and is dreadfully provoked. His wrath towards you burns like fire; he looks upon you as worthy of nothing else but to be cast into the fire. He is of purer eyes than to bear you in his sight; you are ten thousand times as abominable in his eyes as the most hateful, venomous serpent is in ours.
>
> It would be dreadful to suffer this fierceness and wrath of Almighty God one moment; but you must suffer it to all eternity. There will be no end to this exquisite, horrible misery. When you look forward, you shall see along forever a boundless duration before you, which will swallow up your thoughts, and amaze your soul. And you will absolutely despair of ever having any deliverance, any end, any mitigation, any rest at all. You will know certainly that you must wear out long ages, millions of millions of ages in wrestling with this Almighty, merciless vengeance. And then, when you have so done, when so many ages have actually been spent by you in this manner, you will know that all is but a point to what remains. So that your punishment will indeed be infinite…

> The world will probably be converted into a great lake or liquid globe of fire, in which the wicked shall be overwhelmed, which will always be in tempest, in which they shall be tossed to and fro, having no rest day and night, vast waves and billows of fire continually rolling over their heads, of which they shall forever be full of a quick sense within and without; their heads, their eyes, their tongues, their hands, their feet, their loins and their vitals, shall forever be full of a flowing, melting fire, fierce enough to melt the very rocks and elements; and also, they shall eternally be full of the most quick and lively sense to feel the torments; not for one minute, not for one day, not for one age, not for two ages, not for a hundred ages, nor for ten thousand millions of ages, one after another, but forever and ever, without any end at all, and never to be delivered. [71]

To no surprise, this Puritan perspective is often criticized as condoning a type of divine sadism—or "cosmic child abuse," as coined by several theologians. Reconciling this view with the biblical portrayal of a loving and merciful God is challenging as it portrays a God who not only allows but also perpetuates eternal suffering, resembling a vindictive despot more than a gracious, loving Father.

The divergent conceptions of hell in Catholic, Orthodox, and Protestant Christianity underscore profound theological differences. Whereas the others include notions of correction, purification, and hope, the Protestant depiction of hellfire as a realm of ceaseless retribution and unrelenting physical, emotional, and psychological torture casts a more disturbing vision of divine justice. This depiction, focusing solely on endless pain and suffering, risks depicting God as a malevolent, abusive entity, contrary to the scriptural declarations of His loving and compassionate nature.

These variances reveal that our interpretation of hell significantly shapes our wider theological understanding of God's essence, His connection with humankind, and our role in this world. In modern times, this has often led to significant theological reevaluation and deconstruction among numerous young Protestants, resulting in either a transition to other denominations or altogether desertion of the faith. As I will later argue, I believe the hellfire doctrine dramatically affects one's mental and emotional health.

Christian Fundamentalism (18th Century-Today)

Denominations such as Evangelical, Baptist, Southern Baptist, Calvary Chapel, Pentecostal, Presbyterian, Methodist, Adventist, Churches of Christ, Plymouth Brethren, Charismatic, Nondenominational, Assemblies of God, Messianic, Church of the Nazarene, EFCA, and other similar modern fundamental and Reformed groups are all derivatives of conservative Protestant Christianity. They are greatly influenced by the Puritan views of Edwards, as well as the theological perspectives of Luther and Calvin, which have their origins in the teachings of Augustine of Hippo. Essentially, they all share a common theological ground with minor variations and adjustments. These denominational traditions are where hellfire preaching gained prominence and popularity, becoming the central element of the Protestant message, particularly in the context of American Christianity.

Of course, whether you agree with it or not, Protestant theology has its reasoning, well-established theological argument, and efforts to substantiate its views in the Bible. I have dedicated the next Part of the book to examining these doctrines.

Hell in Modern Christianity

Here is a brief summary of the most prevalent views on hell in contemporary Christianity, detailing the main advocates and the evolution of each perspective:

Annihilationism (Conditionalism)

Annihilationism asserts that the wicked will ultimately be destroyed or cease to exist rather than suffer eternally. Annihilationism believes that only the saved are granted immortality, while the unsaved face complete and final annihilation.

Some key proponents include early Christian theologian Arnobius (3rd century), as well as John Stott, Edward Fudge, and Clark Pinnock (20th century). Annihilationists argue that the wicked will be utterly destroyed after the final judgment, ensuring that they do not endure eternal, conscious torment. Instead, their punishment is seen as finite, culminating in extinction.

Development: This view gained traction in the modern era, particularly through Edward Fudge's influential book, *"The Fire That Consumes,"* which argued biblically and theologically for annihilationism. John Stott's endorsement also helped bring the perspective into mainstream evangelical discussions.

Today, Annihilationism is popular among Seventh-day Adventists and other evangelical groups seeking a "less abusive" alternative to the hellfire view.

Universal Reconciliation (Universalism)

Universal Reconciliation posits that Jesus' blood covers the sins of all people; thereby, all souls will eventually be reconciled to God and attain salvation. Some Universalist perspectives suggest that salvation of all will occur instantly after death, whereas the majority view is that many will first undergo a purification process in a realm akin to purgatory or hell. Universal Reconciliation highlights Jesus's ultimate victory over sin and death, emphasizing God's love, grace, and mercy.

Key proponents include numerous Church Fathers such as Clement of Alexandria (2nd Century), Origen (2nd Century), and Gregory of Nyssa (c. 4th Century), and modern proponents like Hosea Ballou (18th Century), George MacDonald (19th century), Karl Barth (20th century), and David Bentley Hart (21st century).

These theologians contend that God's love and justice will eventually result in the reconciliation of all souls, guaranteeing that no one is eternally barred from God's presence. They believe that an individual's faith and deeds influence their eternal rewards and roles rather than their salvation.

Development: Origen's early concept of *apokatastasis* suggested eventual restoration for all souls. Later, other Church Fathers, such as Gregory of Nyssa, further defended Universalism. Although some of Origen's views were later condemned, Universal Reconciliation persisted among many theologians and is gaining a new wave of proponents in modern times.

Today, Universal Reconciliation, better known as Universalism, has supporters in different denominations, mainly in the Orthodox Church and non-conservative Protestant denominations, emphasizing a more inclusive understanding of salvation.

Purgatorial View

This Roman Catholic doctrine holds that some people will have to go through an intermediate state in which their souls will undergo purification before entering

heaven. This purification prepares souls to achieve the holiness necessary to enter God's presence.

Some key proponents include Augustine of Hippo (5th century), Thomas Aquinas (13th century), Dante Alighieri (14th century, in literature), and the Catholic church. These theologians view Purgatory as a merciful opportunity for some elected souls to be purified from residual sin before enjoying the beatific vision of God in heaven.

Development: The concept developed in early Christianity and was formally articulated by Catholic theologians, like Thomas Aquinas's *"Summa Theologica,"* which provided a systematic theological framework. Dante's *"Divine Comedy"* popularized the imagery.

Today, Purgatory remains a distinctive doctrine of the Roman Catholic Church, also recognized to varying degrees by some Eastern Orthodox and Anglican traditions.

The Orthodox View (Mystery of Hell)

Eastern Orthodoxy views hell less as a place of ongoing torment punishment ("hellfire") and more as a state of being separated from God's love, with some nuances about potential eventual reconciliation.

Some key proponents include Isaac the Syrian (7th century), Gregory Palamas (14th century), and contemporary figures like Kallistos Ware (20th century). These theologians view hell as a consequence of rejecting God's love, with the potential for eventual reconciliation for all souls.

Development: Orthodox theology has traditionally focused on the transformative and purifying aspects of divine judgment, often viewing hell as a metaphorical state rather than a literal place. The concept of "the River of Fire" by Saint Isaac the Syrian describes hell as an experience of God's presence that is painful for those not in communion with Him. Today, this view is prevalent in Eastern Orthodox theology, emphasizing a more mystical and relational understanding of hell and judgment.

Eternal Conscious Torment (ECT) or Hellfire

This perspective maintains that hell is a realm of perpetual, conscious torment—physical, mental, and emotional—for the unbeliever (e.g., Calvinism, Evangelicalism, Catholicism) and for the believer who has forfeited their salvation (e.g., Arminianism, Pentecostalism, Baptist, Catholicism), nuanced depending on the denomination's specific theology.

Some key proponents include Augustine of Hippo (5th century), Anselm of Canterbury (11th century), Thomas Aquinas (13th century), John Calvin (16th century), Jonathan Edwards (18th century), and, in modern times, figures such as John MacArthur, John Piper, R.C. Sproul, and Wayne Grudem (21st century).

Development: Augustine's works, such as *"The City of God,"* helped solidify this view in Western Christianity. Thomas Aquinas reinforced it in *"Summa Theologica,"* and Jonathan Edwards' fiery sermons during the Great Awakening embedded it in American Evangelicalism.

Today, the concept of Eternal Conscious Torment (Hellfire) is predominantly held by conservative and fundamentalist Protestant denominations, as well as by many Catholics, who see Hellfire as an inevitable result of divine justice. In their doctrine, they maintain that sin is an offense against God's infinite dignity and thus merits perpetual and severe torturous punishment. They hold the belief that those who pass away in disbelief will experience everlasting separation from God and endure unending, conscious, physical, mental, and emotional torment in Hellfire as proper punishment for their earthly sins. Ironically, a particular theological view held by many conservative Protestants suggests that Catholics, despite accepting and believing in Jesus as the Messiah, will still be condemned to eternal damnation due to differing theological beliefs.

The ECT perspective is, to a large extent, consistent with the views of hell commonly held by Islam. The Sunni view of hell, especially, is almost identical to the Eternal Conscious Torment (Hellfire) view in Christianity. Sunni theology also underscores hell as a realm of perpetual firey punishment for the condemned, employing the same depictions found in ECT.

Nuanced Views

- **Metaphorical Fire**

While some Christians (mainly fundamental and conservative Protestants) believe in literal flames in hell, others interpret the fire metaphorically, representing spiritual suffering and separation from God.

Metaphorical Fire Proponents: C.S. Lewis (20th century) and modern theologians across denominations.

These theologians suggest fire should be understood as a metaphor, representing the profound anguish of being separated from God. The metaphorical view has gained acceptance in modern theological discussions, emphasizing the symbolic nature of biblical texts and descriptions.

- **Emergent Views**

Emerging Christian movements and some contemporary theologians question traditional doctrines of hell, especially Eternal Conscious Torment, advocating instead for different, more nuanced, or symbolic interpretations of hell.

Some key proponents include Peter Enns, Andy Stanley, Brian Zahnd, William Paul Young, Brian McLaren, and Rob Bell.

These figures argue for a reinterpretation of the concept of hell that aligns more closely with both contemporary theology and biblical values of justice, compassion, forgiveness, and inclusivity.

- **Mortalism (Soul Sleep)**

Mortalism, also known as Soul Sleep, holds that the soul becomes unconscious at death and remains so until the resurrection and final judgment. Thus, as of

today, most or all souls are not yet in either heaven or hell. This view suggests an intermediate state as a period of unconsciousness awaiting the final resurrection and judgment.

Conclusion

These and other less-known views reflect the diversity of thought within Christianity regarding the afterlife and the fate of the wicked, showcasing a range of interpretations from strict, eternal punishment to ultimate reconciliation with God. The development of these doctrines has been influenced by key theologians and historical contexts, shaping the varied landscape of Christian eschatology today. When compared, the concept of hell in Judaism can be best understood as a nuanced position, somewhat akin to the Universalist and Purgatorial perspectives within Christianity.

Part II

The Theology of Hellfire

Introduction

Endless debates can ensue over the meanings of various biblical words and verses, and later in the book, we will examine the current standing of these arguments. However, grasping the historical concepts and ideas underpinning Hellfire theology can illuminate today's misconceptions about hell. In essence, we should initially strive to comprehend how certain beliefs about Hellfire—some of which are quite bizarre—came to be.

For instance, John MacArthur's protégé, popular Calvinist preacher Paul Washer, claimed:

> The moment when you take your first step through the gates of hell, the only thing you will hear is all of creation standing to its feet and applauding and praising God because God has rid the earth of you. That's how not good you are.[72]
>
> Paul Washer

So much for *"Love does not delight in evil"* (1 Corinthians 13:6). As troubling as this statement may seem, it accurately represents the Augustinian-Calvinist theology, which is supported by biblical and philosophical reasoning derived from prior doctrines. In this section of the book, my aim is to dissect these arguments and scrutinize them from my perspective as a Jewish theologian. The subsequent chapters will, therefore, delve into the doctrines upon which the concept of Hellfire is predicated. However, we will begin by addressing the question: From what did Jesus

die to save us? This question, within theological discussions, is referred to as "Models of Atonement."

Jesus Died to Save Us from What? (Models of Atonement)

When considering hell, everything boils down to one question—why did Jesus have to die? The answer, though, is very complex, and it depends on whom you ask, in what region of the world, and to what year you set your time machine. Many theologians have tried to answer this question, a doctrine known today as ***"Models of Atonement."*** These models, or theories, offer different perspectives on the significance of Jesus' death and its impact on humanity.

Atonement, originally from the term "at one ment," is the medium through which reconciliation between humanity and God is made available. It serves as the bridge, the adhesive, the re-stitching, and the repair of humanity's bond with its Creator. This fundamental concept—the sacrificial death and resurrection of Jesus Christ—has been interpreted in various ways throughout Christian history. This chapter explores the six major historical theories of atonement, each offering distinct perspectives on why Jesus died and the implications of his crucifixion.

Recapitulation Theory of Atonement

St. Irenaeus (130-202 AD), an influential early Christian theologian, developed the recapitulation theory of atonement, which is predominantly embraced by Orthodox denominations. This theory posits that Christ underwent all stages of human life, facing the same challenges as sinners but responding obediently, thereby

counteracting Adam's disobedience. In this framework, Christ acts as a "second Adam" who reenacts humanity's story on our behalf.

The underlying logic of this model draws on the concept of leadership and representation. Just as David stood for all of Israel in his battle against Goliath, so Jesus represented the entirety of humanity. Similarly, as a patriarch embodies and leads his family, or a prime minister embodies his nation, Adam was considered the first patriarch of humankind. His failure led to universal repercussions (Romans 5:12). Christ, by this theory, steps in as the new patriarch and the ultimate King Messiah who redeems Adam's failure by perfectly adhering to God's commands, thus reversing the curse of disobedience.

The scriptural basis for this model includes passages like 1 Corinthians 15:21-22, which articulate that everyone's death came through Adam and everyone's resurrection through Christ:

> For since death came through a man, the resurrection of the dead comes also through a man. For as in Adam all die, so in Christ all will be made alive.
>
> 1 Corinthians 15:21-22

Adam and Eve, despite living in the idyllic conditions of the Garden of Eden and having only one restriction to follow, were deceived by the devil. Contrastingly, Jesus adhered flawlessly to the stringent Law of Moses under the most arduous circumstances imaginable and while opposed by many.

According to the recapitulation model, Jesus not only relived human life stages impeccably but did so as our representative. Therefore, Satan holds no claim over humanity, or at least over those who belong to Christ. Moreover, as stated in Romans 8:34, Jesus intercedes at the right hand of God. 1 John 2:1 refers to Him as our advocate before the Father, and Hebrews 7:25 highlights that He lives continually to intercede for us. Thus, the recapitulation model portrays Christ as both mankind's ultimate representative and its advocate, re-living and redeeming human life for the sake of all who align themselves with Him.

The Ransom Theory (Christus Victor)

The Ransom Theory, also known as Christus Victor, is by far the most influential theory of atonement in Christian theology. It asserts that Christ's death was a ransom paid to liberate humanity from the bondage of Satan. This theory emphasizes Jesus' victory over the forces of evil and highlights the cosmic battle between good and evil.

The Ransom Theory traces its origins to the early Christian Church and was the predominant understanding of atonement for the first thousand years of Christianity. Church Fathers such as Origen (185-254 AD) were instrumental in developing this theory. Origen systematically articulated that humanity, due to Adam's sin, was enslaved to Satan, often referred to as "*the prince of this world.*" To redeem humanity, God offered Jesus as a ransom, which Satan accepted, not realizing that Jesus' divine nature would ultimately lead to his defeat. This understanding was further expanded by theologians like Gregory of Nyssa (335-394 AD).

Several key theological concepts define the Ransom Theory:

1. Enslavement to Satan: Humanity's fall in Genesis 3 resulted in humanity's spiritual captivity under Satan's dominion, necessitating divine intervention.
2. Ransom Payment: Jesus' death is perceived as a ransom for humanity paid to Satan, implying a transactional element where a price is paid for the sake of redemption.
3. Christus Victor: The term "Christ the Victor" highlights Jesus' triumph over the powers of darkness. His resurrection is seen as the ultimate victory, breaking the chains of sin and death, freeing humanity, and restoring cosmic order.

Biblical Foundations

Several key biblical passages support the Ransom Theory:

> For even the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a **ransom** for many.
>
> Mark 10:45

This verse emphasizes the ransom aspect of the sacrificial nature of Jesus' mission.

> For there is one God and one mediator between God and mankind, the man Christ Jesus, who gave himself as a **ransom for all people**.
>
> 1 Timothy 2:5-6

This passage reinforces the concept of Jesus' life as a ransom for all of humanity.

> Since the children have flesh and blood, he too shared in their humanity so that by his death he might break the power of him who holds the power of death—that is, the devil— and free those who all their lives were held in slavery by their fear of death.
>
> Hebrews 2:14-15

This underscores Jesus' role in defeating the devil and liberating humanity.

> When you were dead in your sins and in the uncircumcision of your flesh, God made you alive with Christ. He forgave us all our sins, having canceled the charge of our legal indebtedness, which stood

> against us and condemned us; he has taken it away, nailing it to the cross. And having disarmed the powers and authorities, he made a public spectacle of them, triumphing over them by the cross.
>
> Colossians 2:13-15

This passage vividly depicts Jesus' triumph over the forces of evil.

The Ransom Theory frames the atonement within the context of a cosmic battle between good and evil. Jesus is portrayed as a divine warrior who confronts the powers of darkness, defeats them on our behalf by giving his own life, and liberates humanity from spiritual bondage to Satan. This dramatic narrative resonates with biblical themes of redemption, such as God's deliverance of Israel from Pharaoh.

A helpful analogy for understanding the Ransom Theory is that of a child being lured away by a stranger. Despite parental warnings, the child is tempted by the stranger's offer of candy and is subsequently kidnapped. Similarly, humanity fell for Satan's deception and was spiritually captured. Jesus, acting as the rescuer, offers himself as a ransom to liberate the child from the stranger's grasp.

Scripture declares Jesus came into this world to "*drive out the ruler of this world*" (John 12:31), "*destroy the works of the devil*" (1 John 3:8), "*destroy the one who has the power of death, that is, the devil*" (Hebrews 2:14-15), and ultimately "*put all his enemies under his feet*" (1 Corinthians 15:25). Jesus came to overpower Satan, who holds the world in bondage, and to "*plunder his house*" (Luke 11:21-22). Christ came to end the reign of the cosmic "thief" who had seized the world to "*steal, kill, and destroy*" (John 10:10). Through his death on the cross, Jesus disarmed "*the rulers and authorities*" and made a "*public spectacle of them*" by "*triumphing over them on the cross*" (Colossians 2:15).

In a more nuanced explanation, the triumph over Satan is viewed as a "divine deception" or a "cosmic sting operation." God used Satan's ignorance of sacrificial love and his greedy lust for power against him. As 1 Corinthians 2:8 states, "*None of the rulers of this age understood it, for if they had, they would not have crucified the Lord of glory.*" Satan, in his desire to kill Christ, failed to understand that Christ's mission was to die. God outplayed Satan within the rules of the cosmic game. Satan was overcome not by the martial power of God but by His love.

Illustration

The great late C.S. Lewis provided a vivid illustration of the Ransom Theory in his book *"The Chronicles of Narnia: The Lion, the Witch, and the Wardrobe."* In this story, four children find themselves in the fantasy world of Narnia, where an evil sorceress, the White Witch, has seized control. One of the children, Edmund, conspires with the witch but is eventually rescued by Aslan, the great lion and rightful ruler of Narnia. Aslan offers himself as a sacrifice in place of Edmund, illustrating the concept of a greater being sacrificing himself to defeat evil and restore order—in the name of love.

Calvinists often criticize C.S. Lewis' view of atonement, arguing that "*C.S. Lewis was not an evangelical*[73]" and had "*significant deficiencies*[74]" in his theological views of atonement. This criticism stems from Lewis' adherence to the Ransom Theory of Atonement. Why is this important? Because as I mentioned earlier, everything boils down to this one question. Your atonement theology is really the foundation for all other theological doctrines, including the doctrine of hell. Thus, one's stance on atonement has far-reaching implications for their overall theological framework.

In the Ransom Theory of atonement, Jesus took our place, not so that God could punish him, but so that Satan could kill him. This act was a divine strategy to overcome the devil through his ignorance of sacrificial love. Sacrificial love, the spiritual "magic" that evil was unaware of, proved to be the ultimate power that overcomes evil (still true today...[75]). The Ransom Theory dominated Christian thought until other views, such as Anselm of Canterbury's theory of "Satisfaction," began to challenge it in the late 11th century.

Moral Influence Theory

"Monkey see, monkey do" is the principle that underpins the Moral Influence Theory of Atonement. Imitation is the cornerstone of human learning. This is evident in child-rearing and discipleship, where extensive research has shown that infants and toddlers are exceptional 'copycats,' learning by observing the behaviors of others—

parents, caregivers, and even television.[76] This is also true for adults, who often learn new skills and behaviors by observing and mimicking others. Whether it's in professional settings, social interactions, or personal development, imitation plays a crucial role in how we acquire knowledge and adapt to new situations.

With allusions in several Church Fathers' writings, this theory was systematically articulated later by the French theologian and logician Peter Abelard (1079-1142). Abelard, who also entertained Ransom's substitutionary atonement (not to be confused with Penal Substitution Atonement!), proposed that Christ's death was an act of participation in the suffering of His creation, demonstrating the profound love of God—a love so deep it was willing to die with and for its creation, setting a moral example for humanity to emulate. In his commentary on Romans 3:26, Abelard wrote:

> Nevertheless it seems to us that in this we are justified in the blood of Christ and reconciled to God, that it was through this matchless grace shown to us that his Son received our nature, and in that nature, teaching us both by word and by example, persevered to the death and bound us to himself even more through love, so that when we have been kindled by so great a benefit of divine grace, true charity might fear to endure nothing for his sake.[77]
>
> Peter Abelard

This sacrificial love aims to provoke a moral awakening in sinners, freeing them from the clutches of selfishness.

Consider Mary Magdalene, who devoted her life to the one who saved her from evil; her response was to emulate Christ's grace and love and extend it to others. Similarly, the moral influence theory advocates that God's love and grace should compel followers of Christ to become agents of love and grace themselves. In fact, His love and grace are considered the defining characteristics of Christ's followers. These qualities are central to their faith and guide their actions and interactions with others.

In strained relationships, acts of grace and kindness may mend a broken heart and revive lost connections. Thus, by the grace and kindness shown by God through the cross, human hearts may soften, return to God, and mirror that love towards others. Since Christ managed to win over sinners' hearts with nothing but His sacrificial

love, so should His followers live by the love, kindness, grace, and compassion He demonstrated. This is also where we find Abelard's answer to the question of why Jesus had to die:

> Jesus died as a demonstration of God's love, a demonstration that can change sinners' hearts and minds, turning them back to God.[78]
>
> Peter Abelard

Since God cannot die—cease to exist—even for a single moment, the Moral Influence theory suggests that Jesus's death is more than anything a **demonstration** of sacrificial love rather than God actually dying. Christ's death showcases ultimate love, capable of inspiring even the most hardened individuals. This transformative power of love, as Abelard believed, is far more effective than the fear of punishment.

If someone greater than us—our Creator—demonstrated His love towards us through sacrificial death, how can we not be moved to love others similarly? *"We love because He first loved us"* (1 John 4:19)—We now understand the meaning of love as self-sacrifice and are capable of reproducing it only because God first demonstrated it through the cross of Jesus.

Abelard systematically articulated and propagated the Moral Influence Theory as an alternative to Anslem's Satisfaction Theory.[79] While Anslem rejected the early Ransom theory, Abelard sought to improve it.[80] However, while in Anselm's Satisfaction theory and Calvin's Penal Substitution, Jesus reconciles a wrathful God. Abelard, in contrast, emphasized that it is "*God, who through Jesus Christ reconciled us to Himself*" (2 Corinthians 5:18).

Due to his view on atonement, Abelard was eventually excommunicated by the Catholic synod in Sens, France. His theory of atonement, however, has lived on in various forms throughout the last millennium. Today, the Moral Influence Theory of Atonement is embraced particularly by denominations with a less conservative theological outlook, including non-conservative Protestants and, to some extent, liberal Catholics and Orthodox. This view sets the non-conservative Protestant groups, who generally embrace this theory, against the conservative Protestant groups, who usually favor the Penal Substitution Theory.

Satisfaction Theory of Atonement

Anselm of Canterbury (1033-1109) was an Italian Benedictine monk who lived in feudal Europe. In Anselm's time, most of Europe was governed by a feudal system where commoners owed allegiance to knights who provided protection. The social and justice systems were largely influenced by this feudal hierarchy, with knights and kings employing severe punishments to maintain authority and prevent rebellion. Knights could not forgive transgressions without punishment as it would be seen as a sign of weakness and could incite an uprising against them. Similarly, transgressions against a king were met with even harsher penalties, often execution, to uphold their honor and deter revolt.

Influenced by Augustine of Hippo and this cultural backdrop, Anselm saw sin as an affront to the honor of God, the ultimate sovereign. Anselm proposed that just as a human king cannot overlook an affront to his dignity without imposing a death penalty on those unwilling to surrender, so too God could not forgive sins without restitution. However, Anselm argued that God's required punishment for sin must be far more severe than earthly death penalties, affecting the afterlife. Anselm's conception of God was significantly anthropomorphic.

The Satisfaction Theory of Atonement, articulated by Anselm of Canterbury, rejects the previous Ransom Theory and posits that, instead, Christ redeemed humanity by "making satisfaction" for humankind's disobedience.

In this theory, Christ's suffering and death on the cross are seen as the ultimate act of restoring—satisfying—God's honor and retribution. In this paradigm, Jesus's death is essentially God satisfying Himself for the sake of humanity, allowing for divine justice to be served while reconciling God. This concept of atonement implies that Christ's sacrifice was the payment-through-retaliation necessary to mend the relationship between God and humanity, broken by sin, by paying back the great debt owed to God's honor.

Illustration: Imagine a kingdom where a subject has committed an offense against the king, a misstep so grave that it warrants a death sentence. Instead of allowing the execution to proceed, the king's son, moved by a deep love for the subject, intervenes.

He offers his own life to maintain the king's honor and satisfy the stringent demands of justice. This act of self-sacrifice resolves the dilemma, preserving the king's honor while demonstrating profound mercy and love. However, the perspective of the Father killing the Son presents several moral and theological dilemmas, as it pivots God against Jesus, portraying the Son as merciful and loving, in contrast to the Father, who is depicted as cruel and merciless.

The satisfaction theory is criticized by some for depicting God as incapable of forgiving without exacting revenge. Critics argue that this perspective portrays a merciless system of justice rooted in retribution rather than restoration or transformation.

This view of atonement grew dominant within the Catholic Church, shaping its understanding of how reconciliation between God and humanity is achieved.

Penal Substitution Atonement (PSA)

John Calvin's 16th-century Penal Substitution Theory of Atonement, which emerged during the Protestant Reformation, is built upon Anselm's Satisfaction theory and posits that Christ redeemed humanity by taking on God's punishment for human sin. In contrast with scriptural claims,[81] the PSA is believed to be a punishment and abuse administrated on Jesus by God.

A distinction must be made between the often confused terms 'Substitutionary Atonement' (Christ suffers for us) and 'Penal Substitution' ('PSA,' Calvin's model of atonement whereby God punishes Christ in our place).

PSA is often criticized for being the most violent, merciless, and brutal of all theories of atonement and for being a major latecomer, to which proponents of PSA often point to Eusebius of Caesarea (260-339 AD), who allegedly promoted PSA when writing of Christ bearing the curses due to us:

> Christ transferred to Himself the scourging, the insults, and the dishonor, which were due us, and drew down upon Himself the appointed curse.[82]
>
> Eusebius of Caesarea

However, Eusebius and the Penal Substitution Theory of Atonement have a significant and crucial difference. According to Eusebius, **evil men** inflicted Christ with torture and suffering, not God, as PSA teaches. The Penal Substitution Theory of Atonement (much like Anselm's Satisfaction theory) is crucial for our discussion as it is where hellfire preaching really takes off.

The following quotes by conservative protestants/reformed/evangelicals best describe the Penal Substitution Atonement view.

According to John MacArthur:

> We must remember, however, that sin did not kill Jesus; God did. The suffering servant's death was nothing less than a punishment administered by God for sins others had committed[83]...God put his own Son to death? That is precisely what Scripture teaches.[84]
>
> John MacArthur

Likewise, in his sermon titled "*The Pleasure of God in Bruising the Son*," John Piper, a Reformed (Calvinist) pastor as well, affirms:

> Jesus was not swept away by the wrath of uncontrolled men. He was bruised by his Father.[85]
>
> John Piper

Likewise, Piper wrote in his book:

> The ultimate answer to the question, "Who crucified Jesus?" is: God did. It is a staggering thought. Jesus was his Son. And the suffering was unsurpassed.[86]
>
> John Piper

Wyatt Graham, director of The Gospel Coalition (Calvinism's online hub), wrote:

> Jesus bore divine wrath at the cross for our sake, and so protected us from it. This act implies that God hates humans since he would have poured wrath upon humans. [87]
>
> Wyatt Graham

Trevin Wax, a writer for The Gospel Coalition as well, argues:

> God killed Jesus. I know that might sound harsh, and it is, indeed, hard to wrap your mind around. But it's true. God the Father sacrificed his Son. He killed his Son in order to spare us His righteous wrath. [88]
>
> Trevin Wax

In his sermon, "Jesus sweats blood," Evangelical pastor Mark Driscoll explains:

> See, at the cross of Jesus, there is hatred for Jesus and love for us...on the cross, the wrath of God was poured out on the Son of God. To say it another way, Jesus took the cup on the cross and drank every single drop of the wrath of God, and he endured it. This was physical, emotional, spiritual, mental suffering to a degree that is incomprehensible. [89]
>
> Mark Driscoll

C.J. Mahaney, an evangelical Reformed pastor and former president of Sovereign Grace Ministries, preached:

> Who killed Jesus? The Father. The Father killed the Son….He crushed his son for you! He crushed Him! He bruised him! He punished him! He disfigured him! He crushed him! With all of the righteous wrath that we deserved. That's what the Father did. So great was His love.[90]
>
> C.J. Mahaney

David Platt, evangelical reformed Baptist pastor and former president of IMB, writes:

> Jesus was pulverized under the weight of God's wrath as he stood in our place...At the cross, God showed the full expression of his wrath.[91]
>
> David Platt

Lastly, an excerpt from a devotional in a popular magazine for Evangelical Christian women:

> God tortured His son and Himself to release the bondage and grip of sin on His creation.[92]
>
> Devotional, Living Better Magazine

Penal Substitution Atonement's Logic

In the PSA theory, the term "penal" relates directly to penalty or punishment. Having consequences for transgressions is foundational in any society, and it helps maintain order. For example, under the Law of Moses, a thief might pay back more than what was stolen as both restitution and punishment. Similarly, in modern contexts,

penalties like speeding fines enforce societal rules. But if someone is unable to pay their fine, another might take the penalty on their behalf, exemplifying substitution. This is reflective of Christ's death on the cross, taking the penalty due to sin upon Himself, thereby acting as a substitute.

However, Calvin took this idea a step further by proposing that God's justice required a much more severe penalty to be paid for sin—eternal torture in hell. According to PSA, Jesus Christ bore the full wrath of God and the ultimate penalty of torture and abuse for human sin on the cross. Thus, Calvin's interpretation presents Jesus not only as a sacrificial offering but as the recipient of God's wrath, which some argue diverges significantly from the original Hebrew understanding of atonement.

A distinction has to be made between the Ransom Theory of Atonement (Christ suffers for us) and Penal Substitution (God punished Christ instead of punishing us.) Also, Penal substitution differs from Anselm's Satisfaction theory in that it sees Christ's death not as repaying God for lost honor but rather as paying the penalty (which, according to PSA, includes the idea of hellfire's eternal conscious torment).

While the Catholic church adopted Anselm's satisfaction theory, the Protestant church upheld Calvin's Penal Substitution model. The Catholic church developed the idea of purgatory, while the Protestant church continued to develop the concept of eternal conscious torment further.

Criticism of Penal Substitution Atonement

The Penal Substitution theory is heavily critiqued for various reasons, such as for depicting God's justice as excessively severe and disproportionate—suggesting even minor transgressions merit endless hellfire torture. Critics argue that this perspective fosters a detached, transactional relationship between humanity and God, emphasizing punishment and retribution over a nurturing, parent-like relationship centered on love, reconciliation, and restoration. Other theologians and thinkers raise ethical and theological objections about the nature of divine justice and mercy and the theory's incompatibility with many Bible passages.

Despite its criticism, Penal Substitution remains the central tenet in most Reformed, evangelical, and conservative Protestant denominations, profoundly influencing their theology, view of God's character, understanding of atonement and the nature of

salvation, and ultimately—their view of hellfire as Eternal Conscious Torment, as evident in the preachings of Reformed, evangelical, and conservative Protestant pastors and evangelists.

Since Penal Substitution Atonement is considered the greenhouse of the doctrine of hellfire, I will now offer a quick summary of the main points of criticism by modern-day theologians.

1. Problematic Father-Son Dynamic: Penal Substitution Atonement (PSA) portrays the Father requiring the torture and killing of His Son, suggesting a disturbing dynamic within the Godhead and an alleged temporary split within the Godhead. This depiction conflicts with the message of divine unity and love central to Christianity.

2. Ethical Concerns: PSA involves punishing the innocent to absolve the guilty, which contradicts our innate sense of justice. Punishing a law-abiding citizen for a criminal's actions can be considered unjust.

3. Paradox of Forgiveness: PSA implies forgiveness requires punishment, which contradicts the essence of forgiveness and Jesus' teachings on forgiveness in the New Testament gospels. True forgiveness, as demonstrated throughout Jesus' ministry, involves letting go, not transferring punishment to another. Biblical teachings on forgiveness emphasize grace and mercy without conditioning or demanding for retribution.

4. Overshadowing Love and Resurrection: PSA makes punishment the essence of the Gospel, which can diminish its broader themes, shifting the emphasis from Jesus's teachings about unconditional love, sacrifice, kindness and forgiveness to a transactional and violent view of salvation.

5. Disproportionate Punishment: PSA suggests eternal abusive punishment for temporal sins or lack of faith, which challenges the notion of a just and merciful God. This disproportionality raises ethical concerns about divine justice and compassion.

6. Logic of Trauma and Abuse: The idea of a God demanding torture for atonement seems unethical and can trigger trauma and align with patterns of abusive behavior, leading to a skewed view of God as a punitive figure rather than a loving parent.

7. Endorsement of Violence: PSA necessitates violence for salvation, which contradicts Jesus's teachings of nonviolence and peace, potentially endorsing violence as a divine mandate.

8. Limitation on Divine Love: PSA portrays God as a judge who prioritizes retribution over mercy, obscuring the unconditional nature of divine love and potentially leading to legalism and a cult-like community.

9. Historical and Biblical Discrepancies: PSA is a relatively modern development, diverging from both early Christian understandings of atonement and that of the Hebrew Scriptures. Old Testament sacrifices were about purification, not punishment, and New Testament teachings likewise emphasize reconciliation and restoration.

10. Issue of Fairness: PSA fails to account for human limitations and imperfections. God created humans with finite knowledge and very limited cognitive abilities, making it unfair to impose eternal punishment on finite beings and for temporal sins influenced by these inherent limitations.

11. Fear as Motivation: PSA promotes fear as the primary motivator to believe, conflicting with the biblical message that *"there is no fear in love"* (1 John 4:18) and the portrayal of a loving and compassionate God. Psychologically, fear-driven motivation is detrimental to emotional, mental, and spiritual growth.

12. Pagan Influence: The concept of a wrathful deity demanding the torture and killing of an innocent sacrifice to appease wrath is rooted in deeply ancient pagan practices, not biblical teachings.

I have made a longer, in-depth version available on my website.[93]

Scapegoat Theory of Atonement

A newcomer model of atonement is that of René Girard (1923-2015), a French historian, literary critic, and philosopher of social science, who delved deeply into anthropology, particularly the mechanisms of societal violence and mimetic desire. Mimetic desire is the notion that humans desire objects or statuses primarily because they observe others desiring them. This mimetic process often leads to rivalry and escalating tensions within a society. To prevent a total societal breakdown, communities unconsciously choose a scapegoat, a substitute victim who gets blamed for the crisis even if they are not the actual cause. Focusing collective aggression on this scapegoat provides temporary relief and restoration of societal order. Over time and across cultures, this process often becomes ritualized and encoded in myths

wherein the scapegoat might even be deified. Therefore, the scapegoat Theory of Atonement focuses on the social aspect of the atonement.

However, Girard postulated that the Christian narrative uniquely demystifies this universal mechanism. According to Girard, in Christianity, Jesus is portrayed as the ultimate scapegoat, an innocent victim who bears collective violence but is then vindicated through the resurrection. This New Testament portrayal is crucial, as it reveals the falsehood of the scapegoat mechanism and presents Jesus not as a perpetrator deserving of death but as an innocent victim offering forgiveness. Girard argued that the Gospels expose the scapegoat mechanism for what it is, showing that the victim is innocent and that the violence directed at them is unjust.

Thus, in the Christian understanding, Girard saw a profound critique of humanity's cycles of rivalry and violence. He believed that the death and resurrection of Jesus offer a path toward redemption and atonement that contrasts with traditional theological interpretations. By exposing the victim's innocence and the violence's injustice, the Christian narrative invites believers to break the cycle of mimetic rivalry, strife, hostility, and revenge and embrace forgiveness and reconciliation instead. This revelation challenges societies to move away from violence towards a more compassionate and just way of life, making Girard's model a transformative approach to understanding atonement.

Jewish Model of Atonement

This chapter is titled "Jewish Model of Atonement" to reflect that Judaism's concept of atonement differs from Christian perspectives in that it relies solely on the Old Testament interpretation. Suppose, indeed, Jesus is the Jewish Messiah and humanity's ultimate sacrifice and atonement. In that case, the best way to understand Christ's death is by examining the role of sacrifice and atonement in the Law, which Jesus claimed he came to fulfill. Understanding atonement from the perspective of the Hebrew Scriptures can provide a deeper insight into the biblical concepts of sin, sacrifice, and atonement while highlighting some shortcomings and misconceptions of traditional Christian models of atonement.

Sacrifices in the Hebrew Scriptures

Israel never sacrificed to God to relax His wrath or satisfy His appetite for blood, as taught by the theories of atonement proposed by Calvin and Anselm. Sacrifices were never about Israel killing animals in the hopes that God, upon seeing these corpses, would receive satisfaction and choose not to punish Israel as well (PSA). Israel's sacrifices were also not about restoring God's lost honor (Satisfaction Atonement). In fact, these were the pagans' motivations, not Israel's. Killing and abusing others as a means to avoid punishment is why the pagans worshiped their gods. For Israel, however, the sacrificial system included a profound act of giving thanks, communion, worship, cleansing, purification, and covenant renewal. It was a chance for Israel to

realign herself with God's will and commandments (repentance), expressing devotion and thanksgiving.

The sacrificial system, as outlined in the Old Testament, was multifaceted and symbolic, deeply embedded in Israel's spiritual life. The Torah (Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy) mentions many kinds of sacrifices, but only two directly dealt with the forgiveness of sins: *ASHAM* (Guilt-offering) and *HATA'AT* ("Sin-offering" or "Purification-offering").

The Book of Atonement in a Nutshell

You don't often hear sermons about Leviticus, the third book of the Pentateuch, dedicated to offerings and sacrifices. Atonement is mentioned about fifty times, often in connection to blood. The book of Leviticus opens with a call from God, who apparently has no issue dwelling among a sinful nation. He summons its sinful leader to come and fellowship with Him:

> The Lord called to Moses and spoke to him from the tent of meeting.
>
> Leviticus 1:1

The Day of Atonement is at the heart of the book, which unifies the entire text. Leviticus explores three primary ways God helps Israel, a sinful nation, live in His presence. It details the rituals Israel had to follow, the seven annual feasts, and the role of priests as guides and mediators between God and Israel. The book emphasizes maintaining Israel's purity to prevent defiling the Tabernacle and its surroundings.

The most relevant part of Leviticus to our discussion is about sacrifices, atonement, and offerings—the primary means by which Israel thanked God and sought forgiveness. Sacrifices were crucial for purifying God's dwelling place, and eight chapters focus on keeping Israel pure, as God demanded His dwelling place among Israel be continually cleansed. The Israelites could become impure and defile the Tabernacle through various means, including contact with reproductive fluids, skin diseases, mold or fungus, and touching a dead body. These impurities, associated

with illness, death, and mortality, affect all of creation but have no hold on God, who embodies life itself. Still, it was not allowed in God's dwelling place.

Metaphorically, Israel could be illustrated as a hospital; the Tabernacle was the operating room, the altar was the operating table, and the priests were the surgeons. The closer a person gets to the altar, the more severe their transgression will be if they do not comply with the purity rules. For this reason, the "operating table" is called the "holy of holies" because of its uniqueness. Remember, God is *holy* (Hebrew: unique, different), meaning that the place where he dwells is also sacred. Therefore, much like an operating room, if Israel brings impurity and contaminates that site, it is no longer distinct and unique (holy) from any other place.

The sacrifices in the Law can be divided into four to eight categories, depending on who you ask. These categories can then be further divided into 20-30 secondary types or kinds. However, the sacrifices dealing specifically with sin were in the minority. Before we get to them, let's consider the meaning of the word atonement in Hebrew.

Atonement in the Law

Three main Hebrew words (that sometimes get translated into the same one word in English) form the linguistic basis for the doctrine of atonement in the Hebrew Scriptures:

GAAL [94] (redeem, kinsman);

PADAH (liberate, redeem);

KAPHAR [95] (atone, forgive).

These three words—representing the concept of atonement in the Hebrew Scriptures—are often confused and translated as the same term, even though in Hebrew, their meanings can vary based on the context. The Hebrew Scriptures primarily use these terms in relation to redeeming something or someone. Examples include fulfilling a family obligation to settle a debt, a relative reclaiming family property from another, freeing an individual (animal or slave) by covering their cost, and providing payment as a substitute for one's life or the life of another. Corporal punishment or torment was never part of Israel's sacrificial system.

From the three terms above, the Hebrew verb ***KAPHAR*** (atonement) is perhaps the most relevant to our discussion on atonement. It appears more than a hundred times in the Hebrew Scriptures. *KAPHAR* is also where *YOM KIPPUR* (Day of Atonement) originates from. The word means one of two things. Some scholars believe the verb indicates "to void," "to wipe away," or "to remove." Others believe the meaning is "to cover" or "to hide."

If atonement is understood as the 'erasure of sin,' it implies a complete removal of guilt and a restoration of the sinner to a state of innocence. This view is echoed in passages like Isaiah 44:22, "*I have **blotted out** your transgressions like a cloud,*" and Zechariah 3:4, "*See, I have **taken away** your sin.*"

Conversely, if atonement signifies 'covering sin,' it suggests that while the sin remains, it is hidden from sight, allowing the sinner to avoid its repercussions. This concept is reflected in verses such as Psalm 32:1, "*Blessed is the one whose transgressions are forgiven, whose sins are **covered**,*" and Psalm 85:3, "*You forgave the iniquity of your people and **covered** all their sins.*"

Each of the two explanations paints a different picture of the act of atonement. If atonement means remove/void, then it nullifies the existence of sin and returns the sinner to his previous state. On the other hand, if atonement means to cover/hide, the sin still exists, but its concealment allows the sinner to avoid sanctions. Perhaps we are not meant to choose just one: While the Old Testament sacrifices covered our sins, the New Testament's Sacrifice removed them altogether:

> Look, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!
>
> John 1:29

In this context, John evidently viewed Jesus' atonement as collective ("sin of the world"), rather than personal.

Now, let's discuss the two main sacrifices used to forgive sins.

ASHAM and *HATA'AT* for the Forgiveness of Sins

A lot can be said about sacrifices in Leviticus, but for the sake of our discussion, we will limit our discussion to the two related to sin: *HATA'AT* and *ASHAM*. This discussion might sound technical, but once we understand these two offerings, we can identify where some Christian doctrines may have diverged.

HATA'AT ("Sin" or "Purification" Offering)

HATA'AT is a category of sacrifices that can be further divided (chicken or beef, personal or communal, internal or external, etc.) The Hebrew word HATA'AT confuses scholars because it originates from either of two words that share the same root: '*HET*,' meaning "sin." Or '*HITE*,' meaning "disinfect, cleanse, purify, sterilize." In English, HATA'AT is translated both ways; therefore, English readers will sometimes see "Sin Offering," while other times "Purification Offering," depending on the translation.

Hebrew scholars mostly side with "disinfect, cleanse, purify, sterilize." They argue that the context and primary uses of that offering in the Law make the case for purification. In the times when sin was involved, the Purification Offering's blood was used to clean and purify the altar/sanctuary/tent of meeting and instruments as blood served as a sanitizer or detergent. This is why the HATA'AT's blood was sprinkled inside the tent and on the instruments—much like sanitizing the hospital's operation room and surgical instruments or purifying wounds so they could heal. The purification offering was not about God's wrath being poured on the poor animal or a way for God to relax His own anger. It was about the blood (representing life, see Leviticus 17:11) of the sacrifice being used to cleanse the sins (representing death and sickness) of Israel.

The point of the HATA'AT was not the animal's death as punishment due to God's wrath but rather about its blood being used to purify. Likewise, in the New Testament, Jesus's blood is used to wash bloody robes white and clean (Revelation 7:14; Hebrews

10:10). The only way to understand how bloody robes can be turned white using even more blood is by understanding Jesus's blood to be the HATA'AT. The blood of Jesus does to us what the blood of the HATA'AT did to Israel—it cleanses and purifies us.

ASHAM (Guilt Offering)

The second type of sacrifice is ASHAM. The Hebrew word ASHAM means guilt. A Guilt Offering was basically compensation given due to an offense. Unlike other sacrifices that took care of Israel as a community, the ASHAM was an offering made by an individual only, amending for their transgression. Old Testament professor Rabbi Yonatan Grossman explains that "*guilt offering Law focuses on the financial aspect: an animal with a certain monetary worth is required.*" [96]

The substitutional value is simple—your sins exact a price that needs to be paid, just as you would have to pay a fine for parking in a no-parking area. The guilt offering viewed sin as stealing from God, a breach of trust between God and humans, and therefore required compensation. However, no element of abuse, wrath, or violence was included as part of the ritual.

Why Blood?

In modern times, largely influenced by Hollywood's portrayals, blood is often associated with violence, conflict, warfare, and bloodshed. However, in the Torah, blood held a different significance. *"Life is in the blood"* (Leviticus 17:11). Scientific understanding today acknowledges that life is indeed contained within the blood. When you donate blood, you are essentially giving the gift of life. This is why it makes sense when Jesus tells his followers, *"Whoever drinks my blood has eternal life"* (John 6:54). In the context of ancient Judaism, blood symbolizes not wrath but healing, purification, and life.

Metaphorically speaking, the sacrifices' blood was akin to what alcohol gel, bleach, or detergent is for us today. No physician would be willing to enter the hospital's operation room unless it is sanitized and germ-free. Likewise, it wasn't that God

would punish Israel if they ignored the sacrificial system; rather, it was as if they were saying, "*We don't care for you being here right now, God. We'll manage on our own. Thanks.*" Thus, God's presence was not there to shield Israel when her ruthless enemies came calling (aka God's wrath).

Thus, in the Hebrew Scriptures, sacrifices were not intended to appease an angry God, as if to prevent Him from striking someone down with lightning in anger. Instead, they were designed to foster fellowship with God and secure His blessings and protection. The goal was to ensure that God felt "welcome" and that His "residence"—the Tabernacle—was kept clean and orderly, so to speak. This fundamentally differed from pagan practices, which viewed the gods as capricious beings requiring appeasement through pain, abuse, and death for their sadistic and demonic satisfaction.

A theologian I sincerely appreciate and often recommend is Dr. Tim Mackie, the founder of the famous "The Bible Project" animated videos. In one of his podcasts, when referring to the Fundamentalist/Evangelical view of Atonement (PSA), he said the following:

Many of us have inherited a story about animal sacrifice, and it goes something like this:

"The gods are angry with me and are going to kill me. But maybe if I kill this animal and make sure the gods get their pound of flesh, they'll be appeased and happy. Maybe they won't kill me or send a plague on my family. Sure, it's barbaric, but so are the gods…"

Much of popular Christian belief has simply imported a pagan storyline into Leviticus and the stories about Jesus' death on the cross. The result is a tragic irony. What the Bible is portraying as an expression of God's love gets twisted into something dark. Our version goes like this:

"God is holy and perfect. You are not. Therefore, God is angry at you, and hates you even, so he has to kill you. But because he's merciful, he'll let you bring this animal to him and will have the animal killed

instead of you. Thankfully, Jesus came to be the one who gets killed by God instead of me. Jesus rescues us from God, so now we can go forever to the happy place after we die and not the bad place."

Is this story recognizable to you? If so, you're not alone. The main problem with this story, to be a bit snarky, is the Bible. More specifically, the problem is that this story has enough biblical language in it that it can pass for what the Bible actually says about animal sacrifice and Jesus' death. However, when you step back and allow Leviticus and the New Testament to speak for themselves, you can recognize this story as an imposter.[97]

Tim Mackie

Likewise, Michael S. Heiser (1963 – 2023), a well-known, highly respected American Old Testament scholar and Christian Best-Selling author specializing in Hebrew Bible and Semitic languages wrote extensively on atonement and offered some relevant criticism of the Penal Substitution theory of Atonement:

Did God select and intend the death of Jesus as a penal substitution, or did he just foreknow what would happen to Jesus on earth (not intending that he die) and then, through raising him from the dead, endorse him as a substitution? It seems to me that God foreknew humanity would suffer the loss of immortality (i.e., Eden would fail and with it, everlasting life with God). God knew this meant that death separated him from the humans he loved and wanted in his family forever. Death was a problem that needed solving—for everyone.

This makes the focal point of God's plan the resurrection, not the violent death. In other words, it ultimately wasn't the death of Jesus that brought about redemption for lost humanity. It was the resurrection. Think about the meaning of "redemption" and you'll see the point. To "redeem" something is to "buy it back". In our case,

the death of Christ enables us to come back into relationship with God. It cures the death problem, which is/was brought on by sin (my own view of Rom 5:12 helps here — that we are guilty before God not because of what someone else did [even Adam] but because of what we invariably and inevitably do — we sin).

Christ wasn't God's chance to vent his anger on his Son. It was his chance to defeat death with resurrection and so secure eternal life for all who believe in the work of Jesus on the cross. So does "substitution" really work to describe this? Obviously, you can't have resurrection without a death, and you need a death that is sufficient for all humanity at all times. I think this necessitates the death of the Son (the everlasting-ness of the atonement seems to require it).

Michael S. Heiser

Evidently, the PSA views, criticized by Tim Mackie and Michael Heiser, penetrated Western Christianity through brilliant yet flawed individuals such as Augustine, Anselm, Calvin, Luther, and Edwards, who shaped much of the conservative fundamental doctrines, including that of the atonement (PSA) and hellfire. I do believe this also has to do with their strong antisemitic attitude, which influenced their perspective, leaning away from the Jewish context and the Old Testament writings.

Conclusion

The concepts of torment, torture, and abuse associated with PSA and Hellfire were completely alien to the Israelites within the biblical framework of atonement. Instead, from a Jewish perspective, Jesus' atonement is a cleansing act that removes the stain of sin, restoring transgressors to a state of purity. The Apostle John writes, "*The blood of Jesus, his Son, purifies us from all sin*" (1 John 1:7), echoing the Old Testament's theme of atonement as erasure and purification. Simultaneously, Jesus' atoning work is a covering that offers protection and shields. Paul articulates this in Romans 3:25,

where he describes Jesus as a *"sacrifice of atonement"* (*hilasterion*), a term that can be understood as a covering or expiation.

The multifaceted concept of atonement in the Hebrew Scriptures, possibly encompassing both cleansing and covering, finds its complete expression in Jesus. His life, death, and resurrection provide the ultimate atonement, addressing both the removal and concealment of sin, thus reconciling humanity to God.

The Doctrines Behind the ECT Theology

Augustine of Hippo is likely the first to have systematically formulated the notion that humans, owing to their flaws relative to their Creator, merit eternal punishment in hellfire. This idea was subsequently embraced by Anselm and the Protestant reformers, notably John Calvin. The subsequent chapters will delve into the theological foundations and subtleties of the belief in ECT/hellfire.

The logic behind the doctrine of eternal conscious torment (ECT) in hellfire follows this sequence:

1. **"Original Sin" & "Total Depravity":** Humanity inherits a sinful nature and guilt due to Adam and Eve's disobedience, negating human desire for goodness or acting virtuously, therefore deserving endless torment in hellfire.
2. **God hates sin and cannot even look at sinners, who must be separated from Him and punished eternally:** Sin and sinners are utterly abhorrent to a holy and righteous God, deserving His wrath and eternal punishment. God's holiness means He cannot tolerate sin or be in the presence of sinners. Consequently, sinners must be eternally separated from God and punished in hellfire.

Essentially, the doctrine of Original Sin posits that the status of being a 'sinner condemned to hellfire' is inherited by all people. "*Destination: Hell*" is stamped —metaphorically—on everyone's forehead from birth. The rationale is that being branded as "sinners" from the outset allegedly justifies God in condemning us all to

eternal fire without us having any justification. After all, as John MacArthur puts it, "*God only accepts absolute perfection,*"[98] and may not allow sinners in His presence.

In the subsequent chapters, we will explore the foundations of this belief system from a biblical and theological standpoint.

Original Sin Theology

The doctrine of Original Sin holds that Adam and Eve's transgression in the Garden of Eden left humanity with permanent guilt. [99] This belief suggests that humans inherit a fundamentally flawed or "totally depraved" nature from birth, thus rendering them guilty from the outset. This belief posits that because of Original Sin, all of humanity is, by default, condemned to hellfire.

John Calvin wrote:

> For our nature is not only utterly devoid of goodness, but so prolific in all kinds of evil, that it can never be idle. [100]
>
> John Calvin

This teaching became fundamental in several Christian groups and denominations, including the reformed, fundamentalist, and evangelical theology:

> Because of Adam's sin, we're all guilty and deserve God's eternal punishment. [101]
>
> The Gospel Coalition

Augustine's Interpretation and Its Ethical Implications

Augustine, trying to justify the baptism of infants, suggested that the guilt of Adam is transferred to all humans. According to Dr. Ken Wilson:

> Because infants have no personal sin, Augustine deduced their baptisms for forgiveness of sin must be based upon their inherited guilt (reatus) from Adam's first sin.[102]
>
> Ken Wilson

Augustine's interpretation of Romans 5:12 was influenced by an early faulty Latin translation, which rendered the phrase "*because all sinned*" as "*in whom all sinned,*" implying that all humanity sinned in Adam. This misinterpretation led Augustine to develop the idea of inherited guilt, which became a cornerstone of Catholic and Protestant theology.

Augustine's doctrine has profound ethical implications. It posits that every human being is born guilty and deserving of eternal punishment due to Adam's sin. This view raises several ethical concerns—I will briefly explore four:

1. Collective punishment

The unfairness of collective punishment: Condemning all of humanity for the sin of one individual is fundamentally unjust. It violates the principle of individual responsibility central to moral and legal systems. The Old Testament consistently emphasizes personal responsibility for sin. For instance, Ezekiel 18:20 states, "*The soul who sins shall die. The son shall not suffer for the iniquity of the father, nor the father suffer for the iniquity of the son.*"

Original sin implies that every human being, regardless of their actions, is born deserving of eternal punishment. This view raises difficult questions about the fate of those who cannot consciously sin, such as infants, the unborn, and individuals with severe mental impairments. Including them in the blanket condemnation contradicts the notion of a just and merciful God.

2. Adding on top of God's punishment

Another concern is the injustice of adding the punishment of eternal conscious torment, exacerbating the unfairness. The Genesis text points only to earthly consequences (Genesis 3:16-19), such as physical death due to the Tree of Life becoming no longer available (Genesis 3:22) and physical suffering, such as pains in childbearing, not eternal torture. Augustine's interpretation introduces a new layer—an extreme and morally problematic form of punishment not explicitly supported by the biblical narrative.

3. Disproportional punishment

Another concern is that this unfairness is intensified when considering the fact that human beings—in contrast with their Creator—are inherently limited in their mental and emotional abilities, including limited in wisdom, knowledge, understanding, and capacity for moral decision-making. These limitations contribute to our propensity to sin. Unlike God, who is omniscient and perfect, humans often struggle with discernment. They are susceptible to various influences, both external and internal, such as misinformation, emotional stress, and physical tiredness, that lead to wrong conclusions, bad decisions, and sin.

For instance, naivety and emotionality make us vulnerable to manipulation and temptation, as seen in the case of Genesis 3. Likewise, physical limitations, such as fatigue and illness, affect our brains, behavior, and decision-making. Using this example, if we were created perfectly like God—never tired and containing all possible information in advance— then judging humanity according to perfect

standards would be justified. These factors should serve as a recognition not of condemnation from birth but of our need for grace from God and each other.

4. A logical contradiction

Suppose creation was perfect rather than merely good. How could Adam and Eve have sinned without possessing a sinful nature, which purportedly only manifested after their initial transgression? Moreover, if Adam and Eve were capable of sinning without a sinful nature, why is the doctrine of Original Sin necessary to explain why people sin today?

Human Inclination

What I believe the Bible teaches is not Original Sin but the human inclination toward evil. James 1 succinctly captures this concept: *"Each person is tempted when he is lured and enticed by his own desire. Then desire, when it has conceived, gives birth to sin..."* (James 1:14-15).

We all possess the flesh (Greek: Sarx), which harbors various desires for security, food, water, sleep, sex, and more. These desires are the source of our inclination toward sin. Importantly, these desires themselves are not sinful, as we were created with them. Instead, sin arises when we fail to control these desires in ways that align with God's will. Eve's sin exemplifies this process precisely as described by James: she saw that the fruit was desirable, took it, and ate. Thus, the first sin ever committed mirrors the way we continue to sin today.

In the January 2006 article titled "*What Is the Biblical Evidence for Original Sin?*" on John Piper's website "DesiringGod," the article opens with the claim that "*Psalm 51:5 states that we all come into the world as sinners.*" [103]

Psalm 51 is a penitential psalm expressing deep remorse and seeking forgiveness. King David wrote it after the prophet Nathan confronted him about his adultery with Bathsheba and his orchestration of the death of her husband, Uriah. The psalm is a

heartfelt plea for mercy, cleansing, and renewal from God, emphasizing themes of confession, repentance, and the desire for spiritual restoration.

Poetry, Not Manual

Interpreting Psalm 51:5 as if speaking of Original Sin or Total Depravity is a classic example of Eisegesis. Eisegesis is the process of interpreting a text in a way that introduces one's own presuppositions, agendas, or biases. The word eisegesis literally means "to lead into," which means the interpreter injects his own ideas into the text.

First, it is essential to recognize that this passage is Hebrew poetry rich with bold and imaginative figures of speech. Hebrew poetry often exhibits a freedom that deviates from standard forms of expression. Therefore, extracting statements from poetical literature and using them literally as a basis for doctrinal schemes is a significant error.

A bad translation of Psalm 51:5

When read in context, Psalm 51:5 suggests that David was born into a sinful *environment*, a statement open to various interpretations. In fact, you have to be reading a Calvinistic translation of the Bible even to consider Psalm 51:5 to be about Original Sin or Total Depravity.

For example, the distinction between the NIV (Calvinistic) and KJV (mostly neutral) translations of Psalm 51:5 reflects subtle yet significant differences in how the verse is understood and interpreted, particularly regarding the nature of sin and the human condition at birth.

NIV Translation:

> Surely I was sinful at birth, sinful from the time my mother conceived me.
>
> Psalm 51:5, NIV

This translation suggests that **David was inherently sinful** from birth/conception, suggesting a personal moral state of sinfulness. It reflects a theological perspective that aligns with notions of Original Sin, where every individual is born with a sinful nature. This, of course, aligns with the Augustinian-Calvinist view.

KJV Translation:

> Behold, I was shapen in iniquity; and in sin did my mother conceive me.
>
> Psalm 51:5, KJV

The King James Version offers an entirely different interpretation, focusing on the **environment** or the **circumstances** of David's conception and birth. This can be interpreted to mean that David's birth occurred under sinful circumstances. The phrase "*shapen in iniquity*" suggests that David's formation was influenced by sin, potentially pointing to the sinful acts or the morally corrupt context into which he was born.

The difference largely centers on whether "sinful" is perceived as an inherent quality of David (as suggested by the NIV) or as a descriptor of the environment or circumstances surrounding his conception and birth (as suggested by the KJV). Each translation brings its own interpretative layers to the text, which can influence readers' theological conclusions.

As in the case of most Bible verses, and while the original Hebrew of Psalm 51:5 can be interpreted in several ways, it tends to align more closely with the KJV's translation, emphasizing the circumstances of David's conception and birth rather than inherent sinfulness from birth.

What Sinful Circumstances?

What situation, environment, or circumstances might Psalm 51:5 be referring to regarding David's birth? I will now present the ancient Jewish interpretation of David's birth circumstances, which is largely unknown to most Christians.

David, a rejected outcast

David's strained familial relationships, particularly with his brothers (1 Samuel 17:28) and potentially his father and mother (Psalm 27:10), highlight a complex dynamic within his household. David was an outcast in his own family. His own parents rejected him: "*Though my father and mother forsake me, the LORD will receive me*" (Psalm 27:10).

As the story goes (1 Samuel 16), God sent the prophet Samuel: "*Then he consecrated Jesse and his sons and invited them to the sacrifice.*" To this significant event, Jesse invited all his sons except David, prompting Samuel to ask, "*Are these all the sons you have?*" (verse 11)

King David, a central biblical figure known for his spiritual depth and poetic psalms, has a birth story marked by family rejection and a controversial beginning. These early experiences shaped not only his path to kingship but also his character and spiritual life, emphasizing themes of redemption and divine favor. This helps us understand why David was notably absent from a significant family gathering—a sacrificial ceremony led by the prophet Samuel, who was to anoint one of Jesse's (David's father) sons as the future king. Despite the importance of the occasion, Jesse did not initially call David to attend. Only upon Samuel's insistence did Jesse send for him. This incident underlines David's peculiar position within his family, overlooked and underestimated even during pivotal moments. How humiliating this must have been for David—God sent a prophet to visit, and a ceremony was about to take place, but only he, David, wasn't invited! But why? Why was David an outcast?

Conception in sin

In the New Testament, there are instances where the authors refer to sources, mostly Jewish, that are not part of the Hebrew Bible (or the Christian Old Testament). Three examples are Jude 1:14-15, where Jude refers to a prophecy within the Book of Enoch. Paul, when quoting Aratus's poem "Phainomena" in Acts 17:28.

And when Jesus quotes an unknown Jewish source or tradition in Matthew 5:43. Understanding the historical context surrounding biblical narratives is crucial for accurate interpretation. This context is often enriched by exploring sources outside the canonical texts, such as rabbinic literature, which provides additional insights not explicitly detailed in the Bible.

According to Jewish tradition, particularly a story in the Talmud,[104] Jesse had a relationship that could be akin to that with a concubine, but it was with his own wife under a different guise. The Talmud recounts a complex story about Nitzevet: Jesse, her husband, doubted his lineage due to his descent from Ruth the Moabitess (Ruth 4:17). Consequently, Jesse had left Nitzevet after their seventh son and planned to father children with his Canaanite maidservant. Taking pity on Nitzevet, the maidservant proposed a plan: they would secretly switch places on the wedding night, allowing Nitzevet one more opportunity to be with Jesse. This plan succeeded, reminiscent of Leah and Rachel's deception of Jacob, and Nitzevet became pregnant with David, her eighth son. Despite her apparent pregnancy, Nitzevet didn't disclose the switch to Jesse. As a result, she was scorned as immoral, and her son David was ostracized within his own family.

The familial background and early life of David depict a more complex and nuanced backstory involving his family dynamics and conception, suggesting that Psalm 51:5 may speak more to personal and immediate circumstances rather than about some unrelated anachronistic doctrine that did not come into existence until about 1,400 years later. When considering all data and context, "*Shapen in iniquity*" and "*In sin did my mother conceive me*" most likely refer to the sinful way in which David's parents conceived him, which also explains why he was a reject.

David's early life and conception, which is marked by rejection and sin, paints a picture of a man who rose above his circumstances through divine favor. His journey from a shepherd boy overlooked by his own family to the revered king of Israel exemplifies a narrative of redemption and transformation, not of "total depravity" or "original sin." These insights into David's life offer not only a deeper understanding of his biblical portrayal but also serve as a reminder of the power of redemption.

Jeremiah 17:9

Back in the day, I used to serve at a fundamental baptistic-Calvinistic ministry in Israel. Once, I questioned a Calvinist co-worker and the theology professor at the ministry's college, asking him about the self-sacrificial good deeds committed by Jewish non-Christians around us. He explained that, based on Jeremiah 17:9-10, these acts are fundamentally selfish and stem from wrong motives such as seeking attention and self-honor. I found the conversation rather strange, considering some of the examples I gave were people who sacrificed their own lives to protect those of others. While people can indeed do evil, it doesn't mean they are inherently evil, as the image of God still very much exists within mankind and leads to many good and beautiful results.

Still, Jeremiah 17:9-10 states the following:

> The heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately sick; who can understand it? I the Lord search the heart and test the mind, to give every man according to his ways, according to the fruit of his deeds.
>
> Jeremiah 17:9-10

Reformed fundamentalists, such as R.C. Sproul, interpret this verse to mean all of us are:

> Born in sin, our hearts are "deceitful above all things, and desperately sick" (Jer. 17:9). We do not, apart from Christ, love the truth. We rationalize the irrational and defend the indefensible.[105]
>
> R.C. Sproul

Likewise, John Piper adds:

> All human beings — no exceptions — are born with this kind of fallen, diseased, deceived, self-exalting, God-opposing heart.[106]
>
> John Piper

Jeremiah 17:9-10 from a Jewish perspective

The Hebrew Bible's concept of "the heart" often signifies the seat of human will and intentions rather than an ontological statement about inherent evil. We can't read this verse literally but metaphorically; otherwise, taken literally, "the heart is desperately sick" would mean heart disease. Instead, metaphorically, the heart can be influenced by evil motives. However, the heart can also be changed, as indicated in many other biblical passages that call for a *"circumcised heart"* (Deuteronomy 30:6). These verses, evidently, also speak metaphorically.

The original Hebrew word translated to "deceitful" is *AQOB*, meaning "cunning" or "can't be trusted." It originates from another Hebrew word, *AQAB*, meaning "heel," which implies "following," "tracing," and "tailing." This suggests that our hearts are often inclined to follow our emotions, which can be misguided or deceitful and, therefore, cannot be fully trusted.

While our actions might outwardly seem "good," their underlying motives might not always be as pure. This doesn't mean all actions are always evil; rather, it highlights the difficulty in discerning when a good deed is motivated by genuine goodwill and when it is not. However, God knows the heart's motive for every action it takes: *"The Lord search the heart and test the mind, to give every man according to his ways."* (Jeremiah 17:10). The verse's point isn't to declare our heart as inherently evil but to emphasize its capacity for deception. Our actions, even when they appear good, can originate from impure hypocritical motives (Matthew 6:5). For instance, when money is given to the poor while filming the action for social media recognition. However, God always sees the true intentions of our hearts.

While the passage in Jeremiah underscores the propensity for human hearts to be deceitful, it does not make an unequivocal claim that all humans are inherently evil. Notice that the passage itself implies a degree of moral agency. God is said to "give

every man according to his ways, according to the fruit of his deeds," which suggests that individuals are capable of good and are responsible for their actions and the conditions of their hearts; otherwise, why would the verse suggest giving blessings according to deeds?

Also, Jeremiah spoke in a specific context, at a particular time, and to a specific group. One could argue that Jeremiah was referring to a certain moral condition that the nation of Israel was experiencing at a distinct point in its history. This interpretation gains further credibility, especially when considering other verses where the people of Israel are said to have *"a good heart"* (1 Samuel 12:20, 2 Chronicles 19:9, or 1 Samuel 13:14). Furthermore, interpreting Jeremiah 17:9-10 not as an inclination of the human heart but as a generalizing statement that all humans are inherently evil ignores the broader scriptural context, which includes teachings on free will, repentance, transformation, and the existence of good, even in non-Christians (e.g., Acts 10:2).

To conclude, Jeremiah 17:9-10 speaks of the inclination of the human heart to do evil and why it can't be fully trusted. In Jewish theology, this is called Yetzer Hara. A Hebrew term taken from the Flood story in Genesis 6:5, "for the inclination of the human heart is evil from youth." (Genesis 8:21).

The absence of Original Sin in Old Testament theology

In conclusion, other than the mentioned two verses, taken out of context, a thorough examination of the Old Testament reveals a conspicuous absence of the concept of Augustine's Original Sin. This absence is telling. If Original Sin were such a foundational concept—or a concept at all—one would expect it to be clearly articulated throughout the Hebrew Scriptures, especially in the Law. However, in the Hebrew Bible, Adam is mentioned only twice outside of Genesis: In 1 Chronicles 1:1 as part of a genealogy and in Hosea 6:7, where his transgression is used as an analogy for Israel's covenant violation. There is no mention of inherited guilt from Adam's sin. The story of Adam and Eve in Genesis 3 describes their disobedience and the subsequent consequences, especially the loss of access to the Tree of Life due to their expulsion from the Garden of Eden. However, this narrative does not suggest

that Adam's guilt is transmitted to all humanity, nor does it hint at the doctrine in question.

Romans 5:12

On John Piper's website, "DesiringGod," it states:

> "Sin came into the world through one man, and death through sin, and so death spread to all men because all sinned." (Romans 5:12). The first part describes what happened historically: through one man disobeying God, sin entered what had been a pristine world. The second part helps us see what was happening theologically: all of us sinned. Paul is not just saying that Adam kicked off a trend... No, Paul is saying something more profound and tragic: *By the one man's disobedience the many were made sinners.* (Romans 5:19). By Adam's act, all of us are constituted sinners. His sin made us sinners...This is the doctrine of original sin, and it often gets bad press. [107]
>
> DesiringGod website

Firstly, it may not have been apparent that the website only quoted the first part of Romans 5:19 and omitted the second—more crucial—part.

Secondly, the implication of this verse is significant: if indeed the point of verse 19 is that humanity is condemned beforehand to eternal damnation due to Adam's transgression, then the flipped side of that same coin is that through Christ's obedience, humanity is now deemed righteous:

> For just as through the disobedience of the one man the many were made sinners, **so also through the obedience of the one man the many will be made righteous.**
>
> Romans 5:19

A closer examination of this verse and its context suggests that Paul's intent may not align with the later Augustinian-Calvinist theological interpretations. Paul's discussion of Adam in Romans 5 is part of a larger argument contrasting Adam and Christ. He presents Adam as a type of Christ, using the former's disobedience and the latter's obedience to illustrate the broader narrative of sin vs. redemption. Importantly, Paul does not explicitly state that Adam's guilt is inherited by all humanity. Instead, he emphasizes that death spread to all because all have sinned.

Furthermore, the Greek text of Romans 5:12 can be interpreted in different ways. The phrase "because all sinned" (ἐφ' ᾧ πάντες ἥμαρτον) can be read as "because" or "in that," suggesting either a causal or consequential relationship. This ambiguity has led to various interpretations, none of which unequivocally support the notion of inherited guilt. Peter Enns, a Professor of Biblical Studies, writes:

> Let there be no mistake: the doctrine of the Fall, as it is understood by many (but not all) Christians, is absolutely dependent on this one passage filtered to us through Augustine's understanding of Paul, and remains a view usually championed in the Reformed tradition and middle-of-the-road American Evangelicalism and Fundamentalism. Romans 5:12, translated properly (as in the NRSV and other translations), says: "Therefore, just as sin came into the world through one man, and death came through sin, and so death spread to all because all have sinned." The "one man" is, of course, Adam. And Paul seems to be saying, quite clearly in fact, that death spread because all have sinned. Now what that means exactly needs some clarification, but that isn't the issue here. The issue is that Augustine, working from a poor Latin translation of Romans 5:12, has "in him" where the Greek has "because." You can see the problem. Augustine's reading is that death spread to all because all sinned in him [in Adam]. In other words, death spread to humanity because all humanity was somehow "present" in Adam's act of disobedience. This bad reading of Romans 5:12, rooted in a bad Latin translation of the Greek, has led to the notion that all humans are culpable (guilty) with Adam for what Adam did—all humanity sinned in him. Augustine's reading is what many Christians believe Paul

> actually said, and which is why Augustine's notion of "original sin" is defended with such uncompromising vehemence as the "biblical" teaching. But neither Romans nor Genesis or the Old Testament supports the idea. [108]
>
> Peter Enns

Evidently, we are all part of a faulty world, and so we are also destined to be affected and add our own brokenness into the messy swamp of human sin. The reality of sin is proven by the fact that we live in a dying world and are slowly dying ourselves.

In commenting on Romans 5:12, Christian philosopher and theologian William Lane Craig explains:

> It is in that sense that one man's sin led to condemnation and death for all men: Adam was the floodgate through which sin came into the human race and then spread to all people... [109]
>
> William Lane Craig

A more nuanced reading of Romans 5:12 and related passages suggests that Paul's intent was not to impose inherited guilt but to highlight the universality of sin and the need for global redemption through Christ. The verse emphasizes that death spread to all because all sinned, indicating a focus on the reality of human sinfulness rather than inherited guilt or the "original sin" tradition.

In other words, you are not guilty of Adam and Eve's sins. You are guilty because you sin. Hypothetically, if the world were perfect, everyone in it was perfect, and you were born to perfect parents, there was the potential for you to be perfect. However, the imperfections of your parents and the world affect who you are and your decision-making. Therefore, you, too, are destined to be imperfect and sin, and so will your children and so forth. Like an incurable pandemic, sin entered the world long ago, contaminated anything good and pure, and spread to all people. In this context, our death is actually meant to serve a purpose, ensuring that we do not endure suffering indefinitely.

The "God Can't Stand You" Theology

In an article titled, "Why do I face the consequences of Adam's sin when I did not eat the fruit?" on the popular Reformed website "GotQuestions," the author answers:

> The Bible says, *"Sin entered the world through one man, and death through sin, and in this way death came to all men, because all sinned"* (Romans 5:12). It was through Adam that sin entered the world. When Adam sinned, **he immediately died spiritually—his relationship with God was broken**—and he also began dying physically—his body began the process of growing old and dying. From that point on, every person born has inherited Adam's sin nature and suffered the same consequences of spiritual and physical death. [110]
>
> GotQuestions website

The Augustinian-Calvinist view posits that Adam and Eve experienced "spiritual death"—eternal alienation from God as a result of their sin. However, if you read the above passage carefully, you may have noticed the sudden yet subtle introduction of two ideas or doctrines:

1. "*When Adam sinned, he immediately died spiritually.*"
2. *"His relationship with God was broken."*

According to the author, Adam "died spiritually," and his relationship with God was "broken." In other words, according to the Augustinian-Calvinist view, because Adam and Eve ate the forbidden fruit, you, I, and everyone else is spiritually dead (damned to hellfire even before we took our first breath), and God is too upset with us to have any relationship with us. This is not merely my conclusion but the deductive conclusion and conventional view of those adhering to hellfire theology. For example, according to 'creation.com,' which is recognized as a fundamentalist Evangelical website:

> The Bible is clear: we are all born in sin. Therefore, our default destination due to original sin is hell and not heaven. [111]
>
> creation.com

Did Adam "immediately die spiritually"?

The statement "*immediately die spiritually*" is ambiguous and missing any context. It is often interpreted as Adam becoming 'totally depraved' and destined for eternal damnation in hellfire. Yet, the text does not say a thing to suggest this interpretation; it seems to be a conclusion derived from the Augustinian-Calvinist theological standpoint, specifically the TULIP doctrine. If you were to compare it with the biblical text of Genesis 3, you would find no mention of being "*spiritually dead.*" There are consequences for their sin, but none of which are "spiritual death."

Concerning physical mortality, Adam and Eve once had access to the Tree of Life, which granted them an unparalleled, invaluable, and inequivalent source of vitality. However, once they consumed the fruit of the Tree of Knowledge, God aligned with His earlier warning, *"In the day that you eat of it you shall surely die"* (Genesis 2:17), which He did by revoking their access to the Tree of Life: *"The man has now become like one of us, knowing good and evil. He must not be allowed to reach out his hand and take also from the tree of life and eat, and live forever"* (Genesis 3:22).

So, as Genesis 3:22 (and Revelation 2:7) clearly suggests, *"to live forever"* results from eating from the Tree of Life rather than being an inherent trait. The Tree of Life

becoming no longer available to humanity is the only kind of death the biblical text suggests. Nothing else.

Was Adam's relationship with God broken?

If God cannot even look at sinners, it implies that He cannot be near them. If God is unable to be near sinners, it suggests that He hates them. If this is true, then the argument that God must send all sinners—all of humanity—to hellfire is validated. As the renowned Reformed theologian R.C. Sproul stated:

> We always say the Cliché, "God Hates the sin, but he loves the sinner." That's nonsense! The Bible speaks of Him abhorring us, and that we're loathsome in His sight, and He can't stand to even look at us! [112]
>
> R.C. Sproul

To assess the claims that *"Adam's relationship with God was broken"* and that God "can't stand to even look at us," one must simply compare these statements with the accounts given in the Scriptures. Should it be the case that Adam and Eve's bond with God was severed by their sin, one would anticipate the text to reflect this. Yet, not only does the narrative not suggest such a severance, but it indicates the contrary.

According to the biblical account, Adam and Eve fled in shame. It was not God who "couldn't even look at them." They were the ones who *"hid themselves from the presence of the LORD God,"* as described in Genesis 3:8. There is no suggestion that God could not look at them or that He withdrew His presence. On the contrary, following their sin, God actively sought them out (Genesis 3:9). He approached them and made garments to cover their shame (Genesis 3:21). Would Sproul suggest God did all that with His eyes closed? I beg to differ: God's actions contrast sharply with human tendencies to hate, judge, ostracize, and shame sinners; God, instead, draws near to sinners and provides for their needs, covers their shame, and forgives their sin, demonstrating His commitment to restoration rather than alienation.

Furthermore, Genesis 3:22 reveals that Adam and Eve were banished from **the Garden**, not from **God's presence**. This distinction becomes clear in Genesis 4, where God continues to engage directly with Adam and Eve's family even outside the Garden. This continuity of relationship underscores that expulsion from the Garden did not equate to abandonment by God, affirming that physical separation from a specific place does not sever the Divine connection.

As a flawed human, I cannot earn salvation through my own limited and finite efforts; that's why salvation MUST be a gift of grace freely given by God through Christ's sacrificial death. This, however, does not imply that God hates me for my imperfections and errors. The Augustinian-Calvinist notion that sinners are beyond God's reach, that God despises them, or that He cannot even look at people simply because they are not perfect contradicts both the Old and New Testaments. God's interactions throughout scripture demonstrate His ongoing engagement with imperfect humanity, underscoring His enduring love and universal accessibility of His grace to all from the very beginning.

God may despise sin, but He also knows our mistakes contribute to character development. The key lies in recognizing our faults and striving to improve. My understanding of the Bible leads me to believe that God pays more attention to our efforts to overcome our inclination to evil on earth than to the sins themselves.

Consider David: he made many mistakes and faced numerous corrections. He endured the earthly consequences of his actions, yet he continually sought to amend his behavior, demonstrated genuine remorse, and consistently worshipped God. This reflects a profound spiritual journey, not a sin-free existence.

There's a common misconception that accepting Jesus into your heart and being baptized magically transforms us into sinless beings like Jesus. However, we remain human, and sin persists. Paul himself confessed to being the "worst of sinners" (1 Timothy 1:15), highlighting our ongoing human flaws. The crucial difference is that Jesus covers our sins. Embracing Jesus doesn't make us sinless; it liberates us from the fear of being hated or alienated by God, allowing us to live in grace, not perfection.

Despite being great sinners with significant flaws, Noah, Abraham, Moses, and David maintained very intimate relationships with God. This demonstrates that divine intimacy is not restricted to the sinless. Furthermore, God's love for sinners is so profound that He chose to dwell among an entire nation of sinners, as illustrated

in Leviticus 16:16, where God continuously made His dwelling among Israel, even in their impurity:

> The tent of meeting, which is among them in the midst of their uncleanness.
>
> Leviticus 16:16

This underscores that God does not shy away from sinners, and His presence is not withheld from those who are imperfect, emphasizing His commitment to be with His people despite their flaws.

Jesus taught us to view God as our ultimate Father. What loving parent would hate their children and wish to torture and burn them for their flaws? On the contrary, good and loving parents desire to redeem, teach, repair, discipline, and restore their children, not destroy them.

The overarching theme in both the prophetic writings of the Old Testament and the New Testament is that God, incarnated as a human in Jesus, came to Earth specifically to seek out and extend love to sinners. This divine mission is vividly depicted through Jesus' actions, as He spent much of His time on Earth engaging with sinners, often sharing meals and offering blessings to them. This is highlighted in several biblical passages, such as Matthew 9:10-17, Mark 2:15-22, and Luke 5:29-39, where Jesus is shown not shunning but rather actively seeking the company of those considered impure or unworthy by religious standards, thereby emphasizing God's inclusive love and mercy.

In contrast to an angry, hateful God who hates sinners and wants nothing but to punch us all in the mouth and into damnation, Jesus spoke of God as loving, caring, forgiving, full of compassion, and protective (Matthew 23:37). A Father who's not only able to look at His sinful children but makes an effort to reach out to them, to deliver and redeem them from their own sin.

Isaiah 59:2 and Habakkuk 1:13

Still, those cheering for the Augustinian-Calvinist theology will point to two Old Testament verses:

> Your eyes are too pure to look on evil; you cannot tolerate wrongdoing.
>
> Habakkuk 1:13

> Your iniquities have separated you from your God.
>
> Isaiah 59:2

Concerning Habakkuk, the key to understanding Habakkuk's complaint is found in the Hebrew parallelism of the poetry. "*To look on*" is parallel with "*tolerate*." Habakkuk points to God's holiness and says, "You are too holy to ignore. No way you can accept this evil in your nation." Or "You are too good to ignore the evil being done." This is *a figure of speech* and not a literal claim by Habakkuk that God's physical eyes can't look in the direction of evil people. Otherwise, this will contradict the book of Job, where God seems to be communicating with Satan.

Isaiah 59:2

When taken out of context, "*Your iniquities have separated you from your God*" does sound like God is separated from mankind due to sin. For example, according to Paul Washer:

> God is morally perfect and separated from all evil. It is impossible for Him to take pleasure in sin or remain in fellowship with those who practice unrighteousness.... According to Isaiah 59:2, how does sin affect God's relationship with man? Can God have fellowship with the wicked?[113]
>
> Paul Washer

Another example comes from the popular Calvinist website 'GotQuestions.' The opening statement answering the question "*What are the consequences of sin?*" reads:

> Eternal separation from God: "*But your iniquities have separated you from your God; your sins have hidden His face from you, so that He will not hear.*" (Isaiah 59:2)[114]
>
> GotQuestions

Context, context, context

Isaiah 59:2, however, has nothing to do with "eternal separation from God." This is another classic example of eisegesis and of taking a verse out of context.

First, the status of individual salvation cannot be drawn theologically from the state of affairs between the nation of Israel and God. Israel was a nation of sinners before and after Isaiah, yet it maintained a national relationship with God. Isaiah 59 is a national rebuke, not an individual being scolded by God. Individuals with eternal souls can theoretically be eternally separated from God in hellfire, not nations.

Second, the "*separation*" Isaiah writes about has absolutely nothing to do with eternity but reflects a temporary withdrawal of physical protection and blessings over Israel. According to Deuteronomy, God holds back His earthly blessings and physical protection from Israel when they fail to walk in His ways.

Third, the very existence of these verses proves the exact opposite of "separation," as an active conversation takes place between the God of Israel and Israel. This shows that the "separation" is not a complete cut-off; otherwise, God wouldn't have communicated at all.

Fourth, Isaiah, an Israelite himself, wrote, "*For I am a man of unclean lips, and I live among a people of unclean lips, and my eyes have seen the King, the LORD Almighty*" (Isaiah 6:5). Not only did Isaiah — a sinner — see God, but the fact that God communicated through a prophet who is a sinner himself is a proof against the Calvinistic interpretation of Isaiah 59:2.

The true meaning of Isaiah 59:2

The context of Isaiah 59:2 is that God is answering Israel's inquiry about why His blessings and protection have vanished. Israel has sinned before God, and in response, does God disappear? On the contrary, God is actively pursuing Israel through His prophets, communicating with them, and explaining the consequences of their sins. This has nothing to do with "eternal separation in hellfire." If anything, it points in the opposite direction: the discipline and restoration of a loving Parent.

In chapter 59, Isaiah explains to Israel that their hope for help and protection from evil (previous verse) is denied because they misbehave. Remember, God already warned Israel in Deuteronomy 28 – if you do not behave, God will not protect you from evil. That is the sense in which Israel is "separated" from God. He is unwilling to rescue and protect them from earthly evil (59:1).

Thus, Isaiah 59:2 has nothing to do with an individual's spiritual/eternal condition or hellfire. Isaiah speaks merely about a temporary, physical, and natural consequence for his nation due to their actions. If God were to cut off Israel completely, they would cease to be His chosen nation and disappear long ago. However, God promised Israel, "*The Lord your God goes with you;* ***he will never leave you nor forsake you***" (Deuteronomy 31:6-8).

Consider the Prodigal Son (Luke 15). He departed from his father's safeguard and endured the repercussions. However, this does not imply that his father ceased to be his parent. On the contrary, his father awaited his return daily, watching from outside his estate. It is we who distance ourselves, not God.

But What About God's Holiness?

Psalm 99:5 proclaims, "*He is holy*." Does that mean God can't stand to look at us?

In contemporary language, the term "holy" often conjures images of angelic figures in white robes with halos above their heads, epitomizing purity, innocence, or perfection. Yet, in Biblical Hebrew, "holy" means being "set apart," emphasizing distinction and uniqueness. This uniqueness does not imply that what is not holy is evil. For instance, God sanctified the seventh day as holy, not due to any deficiency in the other days, but to dedicate it to a special purpose. God is also set apart from all other deities for various reasons, but more than anything—because He is the Creator.

Peter Gentry, Professor of Old Testament, examined the usage of the word "holy" in the Hebrew Scriptures and concluded:

> The basic meaning of the word is 'consecrated' or 'devoted.' In the Scripture, it operates within the context of covenant relationships and expresses commitment.[115]
>
> Peter J. Gentry

If God's holiness meant He hated sinners or "*could not bear to look at sinners,*" then it follows that God cannot be in the presence of sinners, thereby condemning them to eternal judgment and separation. But this view is clearly contradicted by the different manifestations of God throughout the scriptures, the promises of the scriptures, and the very manifestation of the Son of God who came to live among sinners. Furthermore, if God is omnipresent, He is always present in the fallen world. The universe continues to exist because the Creator's presence preserves it.

Because God is distinct and unique (holy), the places He inhabits must also be. Just as a surgical room must be sterilized and maintained free of contaminants to be suitable for operations, so too, God's dwelling place in the camp of Israel needed to be cleansed and made holy again after becoming defiled. In biblical times, this

purification involved using the blood of offerings, symbolically serving as a form of spiritual antiseptic.

Unlike the restrictive religious "holiness" that kept religious people at bay, Jesus, who was also holy, did not isolate himself from sinners. Instead, he engaged with them directly—touching, loving, and caring for them. This illustrates that God's holiness does not inhibit His ability to have a relationship with sinners; rather, it highlights His unique love for them, a love so profound that it was the very reason for Him to become one of us. This truth challenges the notion that God despises sinners, cannot bear to look at them, or have to damn them to eternal torture in hellfire due to their inherited finite and limited nature or their imperfection.

But Doesn't God Hate Sinners?

> You hate all who do wrong.
>
> Psalm 5:5

Marco from Reading, Pennsylvania, wrote to ask pastor John Piper: "*Pastor John, what do you make of the saying, 'God loves the sinner, but hates the sin?'*" John Piper's answer included a quotation of Psalm 5:5 as well as the following statement:

> It is just not true to give the impression that God doesn't hate sinners by saying, '*he loves the sinner and hates the sin*.' He does hate sinners.[116]
>
> John Piper

Likewise, pastor Mark Driscoll preached to his congregation the same motif:

> The Bible speaks of God not just hating sin but sinners... Psalm 5:5, "*You,*" speaking of God, "*hate all evildoers.*" God doesn't just hate what you do. He hates who you are![117]
>
> Mark Driscoll

In the same way, Reformed Baptist pastor David Platt wrote:

> Does God hate sinners? Listen closely to Psalm 5:5-6: "*The arrogant cannot stand in your presence; You hate all who do wrong.*"[118]
>
> David Platt

The ECT's logic in quoting Psalm 5:5-6 goes something like this:

1. Those who sin are sinners.
2. Everyone sins.
3. God hates sinners.
4. God must separate Himself from sinners.
5. Therefore, God hates everyone and must condemn all to hellfire.

Practically speaking, fundamentalist preachers believe that every cute newborn, every sweet toddler, and every child playing in your neighborhood's park—are all sinners condemned to hellfire as God hates them.

On the surface, Psalm 5 seems to contradict verses like John 3:16, which states, "*For God so loved the world.*" In "*World,*" John speaks about the people in it, not the waters and soil. John essentially says, "*For God so loved the sinners.*"

So, is there a conflict between Psalm 5 and John 3:16?

Psalm 5:5

Biblical Hebrew has a limited vocabulary, so many Hebrew words carry a broad range of meanings, varying according to context. Moreover, the meanings of words often evolve over time.

To fully grasp the message of Psalm 5:5, it's crucial first to understand its context. Hebraist scholar Mitchell Dahood interprets Psalm 5 as a *"repudiation of false gods when one was accused of idolatry."*[119] In a similar vein, VanGemeren, Professor Emeritus of Old Testament and Semitic Languages, views Psalm 5 as God's self-distinction from other deities, asserting that *"whereas other religions brought together good and evil at the level of the gods, God had revealed that evil exists apart from him."*[120]

Thus, with this context in mind, more accurate than 'God hates everyone' will be to conclude that God hates idol worshippers. Remember, the pagans around ancient Israel would not only steal office pens and lie about how lovely you looked in your new evening dress tonight; they would burn their babies in the fire as a sacrifice for their idols.[121] The pagans were cruel and evil. So, it is they, in this context, that God hates.

But this isn't even the main problem with how Psalm 5:5-6 is being misused.

The Biblical Meaning of "Hate"

Much like "love," the English word "hate" has become heavily loaded with strong emotional connotations in contemporary language. "Hate," often used to express extremely strong emotions, is usually associated with images of violence, wrath, death, and anger. In biblical Hebrew, however, "hate" means something else altogether.

Regrettably, preachers often misinterpret ancient Hebrew (and Greek) terms when reading a translation in their native languages, applying modern perspectives and interpretations. This misinterpretation can occur accidentally, but at times, it might also stem from a desire to support a pre-existing theological agenda.

SANE = To avoid, reject, and ignore

The Hebrew word translated to "hate" is *SANE*. The Hebrew Bible frequently uses *SANE* as a synonym for 'reject,' 'avoid,' 'deny,' or 'ignore.' If you don't trust my Hebrew skills as a native Hebrew speaker, then allow me to point you over to the Ancient Hebrew Lexicon of the Bible, where '*SANE* ' is explained as something one avoids:

> The pictograph is a picture of a thorn, then is a picture of seed. Combined, these mean "thorn seed." The thorn, (the seed of a plant with small sharp points) causes one to turn in directions to avoid them.[122]

Hate as reject: In Romans 9:10-13, Paul clearly uses "hate" in a matter of election. God elected Jacob yet rejected (*SANE*/hated) Esau. *"Esau I have hated"* is not about God wishing for Esau a violent and painful death but about God **rejecting** Esau and electing Jacob instead.

Thus, biblically speaking, to hate someone is to reject or avoid them—to deny your attention, election, intimacy, or blessings from them. If a woman hates her husband, she turns indifferent, pushes him away, avoids him, and leaves him. On the other hand, if she still cares for him — loves him — she will get angry and fight loudly and emotionally. You go to battle over the things you cherish most but avoid associating with those you hate and are apathetic about.

Hate as ignore/avoid: Paul's understanding of "hate" is also why Paul says, *"No one ever **hated** their own body, but they feed and care for their body."* (Ephesians 5:29). We all know people who emotionally hate their body or parts of it. I emotionally hated mine when I was a fat kid with zits on my face. But as we just established, biblical hate is not about emotions or feelings of detestation. Paul was saying that no one ignores their body. We indeed drink water when we are thirsty and don't avoid going to the toilet when our body tells us to (even if emotionally we "hate" ourselves).

The understanding that to 'hate' means to *reject*, *ignore*, or *avoid* is the only way the words of Jesus would make any sense:

> If anyone comes to me and does not **hate** father and mother, wife and children, brothers and sisters—yes, even their own life—such a person cannot be my disciple.
>
> Luke 14:26

Love would not demand that you "hate" (in the modern emotional sense of the word) others or your family because that would contradict Jesus' commandment to love even our enemies. So clearly, to "hate" your family must mean we have to choose him over them, not loathe and despise them.

As a Jew, I had to experience Luke 14:26 when my Jewish mother first found out I believed in Jesus. When she demanded I stop believing and reject Jesus, I had to reject her plea, choosing Christ instead.

In the same way, we should read Psalm 5:5-6. God rejects the evildoers—the idols and those who worship them. God's rejection of idols stems from their influence in leading Israel to commit heinous acts, such as the burning of their children.

To conclude, from a biblical standpoint, when you reject, avoid, or ignore someone, you SANE ("hate") them. Therefore, God may "*hate*" in the sense of withdrawing blessings and protection from people, rejecting their appeals, or avoiding them. However, God loves even the greatest of sinners (1 Timothy 1:15).

Conclusion

God did not create humanity exactly like Himself—all-knowing, all-wise, immortal—but rather as limited and finite beings. In other words, there is a vast gap between God's perfection and infallibility and humanity's fallibility, limited abilities, restricted knowledge, and need for survival. Yet, fundamentalism/ECT insists that God must subject us to eternal torturous punishment because of the very gap between how He is and how He made us. How can that be considered sensible? How is it just and ethical? Clearly, it is not.

Why God Allowed Sin in the First Place?

I'm only human.

Of flesh and blood, I'm made.

Human. Born to make mistakes.

(Human, Song by The Human League, 1986)

Imagine a game where you put someone in an Escape Room, telling them that unless they figure it out, you'll burn the room with them in it. It sounds like a sick game, doesn't it? And yet, religious people tell us that any newborn baby is automatically destined to eternal torture in Hellfire unless they "figure it out."

If the purpose of life is simply to avoid eternal torture in Hellfire, we would have to wonder why the Creator would make such an important truth so hard to find. Why would this Creator hide it from almost everyone, making it concealed and invisible in the world around us? Why would only those born in certain cultures, where a particular religious text is valued, have the advantage of knowing this truth? And why would the fate of humanity depend on people interpreting this text very literally, even though many throughout history have understood these same texts metaphorically or symbolically? It doesn't make sense that such a crucial truth would be so obscure, accessible only to a few. Yet, there lies an even deeper question

beneath it all—if indeed sin condemns us to an eternity in Hellfire, what would a world without sin look like? Can such a world even exist?

King David, for instance, wrote his Psalms praising God for His forgiveness and grace only after he sinned, not before. Learning about forgiveness, grace, and compassion only in theory is quite restrictive. Since these virtues often involve an emotional experience, they must be experienced, too. Therefore, the human experience would be fundamentally lacking, impossible even, without sin being part of the equation. This isn't to encourage sin or to suggest it's good or positive; rather, it's a logical deduction that sin is an inherent part of the human learning experience. Our universe is not some "Plan B" that God devised in response to the events of Genesis 3. Rather, it is the product of a wise and all-knowing God, intentionally designed with purpose and foresight.

Therefore, if the human experience is contingent on the existence of sin—evident by the way God created humanity (not all-knowing, all-understanding, etc.)—then it greatly challenges the notion that human sin must lead humanity to eternal Hellfire. Condemning humans to eternal torture in Hellfire for not being perfect like God is akin to condemning a fish for its inability to climb a tree.

Imperfect People in an Imperfect World

In our quest to comprehend the intricate subtleties of religious texts, we often grapple with abstract concepts that defy easy understanding. One such notion is the distinction between “good” and “perfect,” especially when considered within the realm of divine creation. The debate primarily revolves around the premise that what is created as “good” is not necessarily “perfect.” [123]

Although God is perfect and lacks nothing, He created humans with various physical, mental, and emotional limitations. Humans have finite wisdom, understanding, knowledge, and emotional capacity. These traits may develop as we grow, but they never achieve perfection. Consequently, our inherent limitations often lead to mistakes and wrongful choices, manifesting in what is typically considered sinful.

Even traits like self-centeredness or egotism are not purely evil, as they are, to some extent, necessary for survival and self-preservation. However, they may be viewed as sinful when they harm others or come at their expense.

However, our imperfections serve a profound purpose in the divine blueprint of creation. In this chapter, I would like to explore why an omnipotent and omniscient God would create humanity with such inherent limitations and restrictions.

> *God saw all that he had made, and it was very good.*
>
> Genesis 1:31

In biblical Hebrew, the word *"TOV"* is used in Genesis when God sees creation as "good," which generally means pleasing or beneficial, reflecting a positive quality or desirable state. It does not imply moral perfection but rather that something fulfills its intended purpose or function well. The Hebrew word for "perfect" is *"TAMIM,"* which conveys completeness, wholeness, or blamelessness and is used in different contexts than Genesis' *"TOV."* Besides, if creation had been 'perfect' rather than 'good,' then the presence of an evil entity in the Garden of Eden would not be possible.

Scriptures consistently define creation as “good,” but nowhere do they pronounce it as “perfect.” This distinction forms the basis of a critical conversation surrounding the nature of existence, the meaning of life, and God's perceived role in it.

Consider natural phenomena like earthquakes, volcanoes, and hurricanes. These are intrinsic components of our planetary existence, and while they can cause profound damage, they also contribute to our ecosystem and the vital processes that support life on Earth. For instance, volcanoes create fertile land, while hurricanes can distribute heat around the planet. So, these "bad" events find their place in a “good” creation.

The definition of perfection is God. God’s traits include Omniscience (all-knowing), Omnipresence (ever-present), Omnipotence (all-powerful), and Omnibenevolence (all-loving). If humans were to attain all knowledge conceivable, transcending the realm of “good” and edging towards perfection, we would still fall short. Despite attaining vast knowledge, we wouldn’t necessarily be “perfect” because we still lack the other divine traits. Therefore, we cannot say that Adam and Eve were created

perfect. In fact, they were created finite and limited in many ways that affected their thought process and decision-making.

God's perfection lies in the fact that there is no necessity for any alteration in His Being, Essence, attributes, decrees, or Persons. God and His perfections are one (as suggested by scriptures such as Malachi 3:6, Numbers 23:19, Psalm 102:25-27, 1 Samuel 15:29, Revelation 22:13, and others.) If God's nature were susceptible to change through addition, subtraction, infusion, or any other means, it would signify an imperfect nature. Any form of change, whether for better or worse, implies imperfections in the object subject to change.

In contrast, Adam and Eve were created as finite beings with a capacity for learning and growth. The human ability to learn and grow indicates that they weren't created perfect but good. Here, "good" implies that they were also bestowed with free will. However, when coupled with limited knowledge, free will inevitably lead to mistakes —sins. Hence, while they were created good, the potential for sin was inherent in their nature due to their capacity for choice and limited understanding.

The Meaning and Purpose of Life

Therefore, it is essential to question why some believe that the purpose of life and creation is essentially to evade eternal punishment. An alternative and perhaps more meaningful viewpoint proposes that the purpose of life and creation lies in the journey of learning and evolving in our comprehension and knowledge of our own identity, the nature of God, and, ultimately, the essence of love. This approach brings us to the somewhat paradoxical role of sin.

Love, grace, compassion, and their ilk can only truly be understood and appreciated in the face of sin. Thus, sin is not an anomaly but a crucial part of the learning process that allows us to grasp these profound concepts through real-life experiences. How else would it have been possible for Adam and Eve to understand and experience the full depth and extension of God's love, grace, and forgiveness if it weren't for their sin?

God Has No Plan B

Those following the Augustinian-Calvinist view see Genesis chapter 3 as God's "Plan B" set in motion by human disobedience. However, I would claim it's inaccurate to view Genesis chapter 3 as God's alternative plan. Instead, sin, within this understanding, serves a purpose. Just as we can only appreciate light by experiencing darkness or warmth through the contrast of cold, so too must we encounter evil—sin, to truly understand the goodness of God, His grace, and kindness.

This view illuminates the path towards grasping the deeper notions of love and grace, steering us away from the anxious, unreachable pursuit of perfection and redirecting us towards the more attainable goal of maturity and growth. Perfection will eventually come, but not in this lifetime (Revelation 21-22).

No pain, no gain

'Sin' is closely tied with 'suffering.' Undeniably, sin, with its destructive potential, may cause pain, suffering, and upheaval. It destroys goodness, distorts the harmony of relationships, erodes trust, and often propels us into a spiral of remorse and guilt or taking vengeance. In this sense, sin is indisputably detrimental. Yet, within this harsh reality of sin, we also find an opportunity for creativity, growth, and maturity—*no pain, no gain.*

Humans are not robots. Machines cannot sin; humans can. As counterintuitive as it may seem, sin serves as a catalyst for learning. Each misstep or lapse in judgment, while unfortunate, also brings forth an opportunity to reflect and reassess our choices. Sin provides a harsh but effective mirror, reflecting our fallibility and need for justice as well as grace and forgiveness. It reinforces our human limitations and our constant need for Divine guidance.

In essence, sin helps us mature by instigating introspection and repentance. It can lead us to seek forgiveness, not just from God, but also from those we have wronged. In this process, we can learn to exercise humility, demonstrate empathy, and extend compassion—integral aspects of personal and spiritual growth.

Sin, while often destructive, can also catalyze growth and progress, both individually and societally. For example, on a societal level, recognizing the evil in practices such as slavery or child trafficking has led Western countries to prohibit these actions, reflecting a collective move toward moral improvement. Sin inadvertently pushes societies to redefine ethical standards and embrace more humane practices. On a personal level, navigating through our own mistakes and sins can lead to greater wisdom, creativity, and maturity. These experiences can drive us to develop traits that align more closely with godly virtues as we learn from our missteps and strive to embody better qualities.

In fact, according to clinical Psychologist Jordan Peterson, sin may be the most significant catalyst for growth, wisdom, and creativity:

> There's a famous psychologist named Hans Isaac who was the most highly cited psychologist in the world for a long time. He wrote a great book called "genius", which is a real study of creativity...He found that early traumatic experiences are good predictors of late creativity. Now, we should also say that early traumatic experiences are also great predictors of catastrophic adult lives. But the thing that people don't understand about creativity is that there's no reason to be creative unless you have a problem to solve. If someone dies on you young and you're forced to fend your way in the world and deal with that kind of trauma, you have to put yourself together in a creative manner, and it's no joke. And so, early negative experiences allied with high intelligence and this kind of temperament that we were talking about are one of the things that foster creative production. Parents are misinformed about this sort of thing because they think that if they just do laissez faire things with their children, you know, "*you can do anything you want*", they'll automatically be creative. That's the stupidest thing you could possibly imagine because that isn't how creativity works. Creativity emerges when you put serious constraints on things.[124]
>
> Jordan Peterson

Painful experiences are crucial in shaping our understanding of justice, empathy, mercy, grace, compassion, redemption, and Divine love, deepening our faith and nurturing spiritual maturity. Thus, while sin inevitably causes pain, it paradoxically serves as a catalyst that guides us on our spiritual journey, aiding in our development of wisdom and deeper understanding.

The Divine Intent Behind Human Limitations

Consider this paradox: God is omniscient (all-knowing), which is one thing that makes Him perfect. He made us humans, but He didn't make us perfect. Humans, created by God, are inherently finite with very limited mental understanding and restricted emotional capabilities, often acting based on emotion, which inherently dooms to make mistakes, bad choices, and sin.

In other words, we are imperfect (sinners) because we were born this way. Imagine being punished forever in fire by the one who created you for not being perfect, despite the fact it's how He made you. That's a bit like punishing a fish for not being able to climb trees or killing your children because they couldn't do your taxes right.

Therefore, God's creation of humanity with finite capacities is a deliberate act. In addition to growth, it is also meant to foster interdependence among individuals. If humans possessed perfect wisdom and understanding, held to all possible knowledge, and had a deep emotional capacity, the need for one another would greatly diminish. Relationships are not just social conveniences but are central to God's plan for human existence. They teach us about love, sacrifice, humility, and patience. Through our interactions, we experience growth, not despite our imperfections but because of them. Each person's unique limitations and strengths can complement another's, which fosters a community that thrives on mutual support and understanding.

Moreover, our limitations allow for the expression of free will and the genuine development of character. In a world where a perfect being predetermines every outcome, the concept of choice becomes redundant.[125] Through our flawed decisions and the moral challenges we face, we can truly grow mentally, emotionally, and

spiritually. This growth is often most profound when we recognize our vulnerabilities and depend on God and each other for guidance and strength.

We Learn from (Painful) Experience

God could have "downloaded" all available information into our brains in advance, but instead, He only gave us a few basic instincts with which to begin life. As imperfect creatures, we are meant to learn progressively and through experiences. Sure, sin causes pain and suffering—I experienced plenty of it and added my own mess to the pile—but unless we experience that pain and suffering, our character will never grow. Through sin, our painful life experiences in this world build our character and may prepare us for life in the next world.

Artificial Intelligence cannot feel pain, agony, or sorrow—emotions that are central to the human experience. If we never sinned, we would never understand the need for forgiveness. Without the experience of forgiveness, we couldn't truly grasp the depth of love. This is what sets us apart from Siri and Alexa. Our ability to feel deeply allows us to appreciate forgiveness and grace as more than mere concepts. This experiential understanding is essential, as one cannot truly learn about forgiving love without feeling and experiencing it firsthand. This is reflected in the paradox expressed by Jesus: "*Whoever has been forgiven little loves little.*" (Luke 7:47). The mistakes we make and the forgiveness we receive enrich our understanding of love, grace, compassion, justice, and other divine qualities, deepening our emotional and spiritual growth.

None of us likes to admit it, but at times, we all become tools in the hands of evil. An unfortunate implication of sin is that it destroys everything. But the Bible also promises new bodies and a new earth. This gives us a foundation for forgiving others because we know that no matter how badly someone treated us—even if they killed us—everything will once again be made new (Philippians 3:21; 2nd Corinthians 5:1-10; Revelation 21:1-5).

The hopelessness of sin also leads us to conclude that we need something much stronger than ourselves and greater than anything in the world to bring about redemption. Logically, since we are flawed and limited and sin is such a crucial part of

our life and learning experience, it would be erroneous to associate it with Hellfire and eternal punishment.

Sin may hinder our relationship with God (James 4:3; 1 Peter 3:7), and while some people may cancel us when we fail to meet their moral standards, God does not act this way. Humans often view sin as a severe threat, and rightly so, because it can cause real harm. However, sin poses no threat to God; it cannot harm or diminish Him, which is why sin has never stopped God from making Himself known to sinners. God is not intimidated by sin nor turns His face away from it. If we understand Jesus as our healer, this directly counters the notion that God "*abhors us or finds us loathsome.*" How could a physician who despises their patients, unwilling even to look at them, effectively heal them? Didn't Jesus touch the sick and sinners to heal them? God's approach is one of engagement and restoration, not eternal abuse in fire.

Conclusion

In conclusion, considering that humans were created with inherent limitations rather than perfection, it is unreasonable to judge and condemn humanity by standards of absolute perfection. Therefore, assertions that "*God only accepts absolute perfection*"[126] or the notion that God "*abhors us, we're loathsome in His sight, and He can't stand to even look at us,*"[127] is irrational, and suggesting eternal torture for our intrinsic imperfections is likewise illogical and unethical. These ideas misrepresent God as a cruel and abusive tyrant rather than as a loving Father, undermining the foundational biblical concept of a compassionate and forgiving Creator.

Does a Sin Against an Infinite God Merit Infinite Punishment?

Once upon a time, a naïve couple lived in blissful ignorance, unaware of their own lack of knowledge. Then, a cunning, malevolent figure exploited their innocence, convincing them they could become all-knowing, just like God. Seduced by this idea, they ate from the Tree of Knowledge, which opened their eyes to the vast world of information surrounding them. This act was based on the Serpent's deceptive promise that eating the fruit would grant them complete knowledge. However, while humanity has gained more knowledge than any other known species, it remains a fraction of what can be known.

Imagine the entire range of knowledge as the vast array of fruits and vegetables that exist. In comparison, the knowledge that Adam and Eve—and, by extension, humanity—possess is like a single piece of fruit.

It is not arrogant for God to claim omniscience because He truly knows all. In contrast, when humans claim complete understanding, it only further reflects our inherent limitations.

This gap between our limited knowledge and the boundlessness of what can be known is fertile ground for sin. For instance, even the most astute judge can err disastrously if missing small yet crucial information. Similarly, everyday people make flawed decisions or judge others harshly because they lack a complete picture of circumstances. This propensity to judge, a mere example, illustrates how our limited understanding influences our actions.

Our inherent limitations—lacking complete wisdom, understanding, and knowledge—define our human condition. These constraints mean that we are inherently fallible as individuals and communities. God, in His perfection, embodies

the ideal judge. To approach fairness, a human judge must gather as much wisdom, information, and experience as possible and take adequate time to consider the evidence. However, most human decisions, probably including that of Adam and Eve, are made under time and knowledge constraints, often exacerbated by mental stress, physical conditions, or emotional biases.

In this context of inherent imperfection, Jesus represents the exception. He provides a perfect standard against which we can measure and align our lives. While we lack a detailed instruction manual for every situation, Jesus offers a living example to live by. Emulating Jesus means adopting His life as a model for our own, where His teachings inspire our actions and theological understanding.

Striving to be Christ-like helps us mitigate the effects of sin. Yet, the reality of life's complexities means that even with the best intentions, situations often demand knowledge we don't possess, and decisions must be made in less-than-ideal conditions. This imperfection doesn't just apply to moral dilemmas; it's a pervasive part of the human experience. When someone cries out, *"It's not fair!"* they often highlight this discrepancy between someone's limited perception and the fuller reality.

As Christ-followers, we are called to bridge this gap with grace, recognizing that while we aspire to perfection, it is unattainable in this world. This recognition risks harshly judging ourselves or others. Instead, we should offer understanding and forgiveness. Humans, inherently limited and fallible, need patience and grace from God, each other, and themselves.

Should an Infinite God Infinitely Punish His Finite-Created Humans?

One of the more philosophically sophisticated arguments made by proponents of eternal punishment posits that while we are finite beings, emotional and with minimal understanding, our sins attain an infinite quality because they are committed against an infinite being—God. Thus, infinite punishment is deemed justifiable. This strange rationale, intriguing on faulty philosophical grounds, aligns with a common intuition: the gravity of an offense increases with the dignity of the person offended.

For example, slapping a child is seen as less severe than slapping the king's son. This argument was articulated by the 13th-century Dominican friar Thomas Aquinas in his Summa Theologiae:

> The magnitude of the punishment matches the magnitude of the sin. Now a sin that is against God is infinite; the higher the person against whom it is committed, the graver the sin—it is more criminal to strike a head of state than a private citizen—and God is of infinite greatness. Therefore an infinite punishment is deserved for a sin committed against Him. [128]
>
> Thomas Aquinas

The belief that sin against an infinite God merits infinite punishment is flawed for the following reasons:

1. The argument that sin against an infinite God merits infinite punishment weakens when we consider that God, being infinite, is beyond any harm or diminishment by human sins. God's infiniteness implies that He cannot be truly hurt or damaged by our actions. In this sense, the impact of our actions on God is negligible, making it disproportionate to claim that these finite actions merit infinite consequences. If anything, God's infinite nature suggests He can absorb and endure any offense without the need for extreme retribution—much like a parent absorbing their small child's tantrum without feeling compelled to kill them. This perspective underscores the idea that God's love is big and wide enough to endure everything. In this paradigm, God's justice would focus more on correction and restoration rather than endless, pointless punishment, as He is not threatened or diminished by human wrongdoing. (If anything, God's dignity is more likely injured by the slander of those who profess to worship Him yet impugn His character by teaching Eternal Conscious Torment! Even here, the real damage is done to those who reject God because of this false report.)

2. The logic behind infinite punishment for sins against an infinite being leads to absurd ethical conclusions. For instance, if we follow this reasoning, it would suggest that cursing a prime minister or a pastor is a far worse crime than torturing and killing a pet dog or cursing a layman simply because the prime minister and pastor hold a higher position of authority. This conclusion is ethically bizarre, as it prioritizes offenses against status over tangible harm inflicted on sentient beings. It reveals the flawed nature of the argument, showing that it fails to consider the consequences of actions and the suffering they cause. Instead, it places undue emphasis on the status of the offended party, leading to a distorted and unjust moral framework based on class and status.

3. If one accepts the premise that finite beings can merit infinite punishment, this has disturbing ethical implications for our understanding of justice and morality. It implies that any deviation from moral perfection, no matter how small, deserves the most extreme punishment possible, which leads to an untenable and ethically problematic worldview. This kind of moral absolutism is not only impractical but also unjust, as it ignores the nuances of human experience, intention, and the nature of actions.

4. Humans, being finite creatures, are incapable of committing truly infinite sins. Our lives are limited in time and scope, and so are our actions. If the soul is truly infinite, then killing someone would only be a temporary interruption of their physical existence. To classify our offenses as deserving of endless punishment ignores the fundamental limitations of human existence and capability. Furthermore, suppose every sin is infinitely punishable because it is against an infinite God. In that case, this collapses all distinctions in the severity of sins, making all transgressions —from a woman lying about how her friend's wedding dress looks to ISIS and Hamas raping or killing of children—equally heinous, which contradicts the biblical differentiation of sins (John 19:11).

5. In God's own law, as revealed in the Torah, justice is portrayed as proportional, often following the principle of *lex talionis*—"an eye for an

eye" (Exodus 21:24). This principle of proportional justice does not align with the idea that finite human sins should incur infinite punishment.

Biblical justice, in its most rational form, is based on proportionality —matching the severity of the punishment with the severity of the offense. Finite beings committing finite actions, regardless of the being against whom they are committed, logically deserve finite consequences. To argue that a finite action deserves infinite punishment because the offended party is infinite conflates the nature of the being with the nature of the offense, thereby committing the Category Mistake Fallacy and undermining the principle of proportional justice. In other words, the punishment should be proportionate to the crime, not to the status of the offended party.

Can you imagine a loving father threatening their child, *"If you don't behave perfectly, because I am your father, I will have no other choice but to set you on fire! It's only just!"?* Or, can you imagine a judge handing down a 75-year prison sentence to an impoverished 18-year-old single mother because she stole baby food from a major retailer like Walmart instead of a small grocery store to nourish her hungry child? Clearly, this argument does not hold up logically.

6. The argument hinges on the concept of infinity, but infinity in itself is complex and often misunderstood. Infinity cannot simply be applied to moral actions or consequences in a straightforward manner. Just because God is infinite does not mean that every action against Him carries infinite consequences. For instance, when the nation of Israel sinned against Him, the consequences were always of a finite nature. Infinity, in mathematics and philosophy, is not merely "bigger" or "greater" but represents a different kind of concept altogether, one that is absent from Israel's Law and doesn't deduct for moral actions.

7. Punishment, by its very definition, is temporary and corrective. The very concept of a punishment with an infinite nature is self-contradictory. From a philosophical standpoint, infinite punishment could be seen as purposeless suffering. If punishment is intended to correct, deter, or

rehabilitate, then an infinite punishment would be entirely ineffective in achieving these goals, as it offers no opportunity for learning, growth, or repentance. It becomes mere vengeance, which is not aligned with rational concepts of justice.

Arthur P. Adams (1848-1920), a Methodist minister, wrote regarding the Greek word "kolasis," which was translated as "punishment":

> The purpose of "punishment" is not only the protection of society, and the restraint of the offender, but also his reformation; this latter should be the main purpose of "punishment"; any "punishment" that is not conducive to this end is wholly unjustifiable, it is simply an attempt to overcome one evil with a greater evil; - now to talk about endless "punishment", is nonsense, as much as it would be to talk of endless correction, or endless reforming. You might speak of endless torture, or endless suffering; but endless "punishment" is not a proper collection of terms at all. [129]
>
> Arthur P. Adams

Job

While philosophically compelling to some, this theory finds no support in Scripture. In fact, a similar argument is presented by the "Three Stooges" — Eliphaz, Zophar, and Bildad — in the story of Job and is challenged by Elihu:

> I would like to reply to you [Job] and to your friends with you [Eliphaz, Zophar, and Bildad]. Look up at the heavens and see; gaze at the clouds so high above you. If you sin, how does that affect him? If your sins are many, what does that do to him? … Your wickedness only affects humans like yourself.

Job 35:4-8

Following Elihu's speech, when God eventually speaks to the group, He condemns Eliphaz, Zophar, and Bildad but notably does not rebuke Elihu. This absence of correction suggests that Elihu's perspective, which details the nature of God's justice, was aligned with divine truth. Considering God's silence on Elihu's statements, it seems evident that the idea of infinite punishment lacks scriptural endorsement. This is further affirmed by the explicit divine disapproval of similar views held by Eliphaz, Zophar, and Bildad, making this philosophical argument for eternal damnation scripturally implausible.

In summary, the idea that sin against an infinite God merits infinite punishment is logically inconsistent with the biblical principles of proportional justice, risks portraying God in a negative moral light, misunderstands the concept of infinity, and leads to untenable ethical implications. A more rational approach would be to consider the nature and intent of the actions, the finite capacities of human beings, and the goals of justice, which should include fairness, correction, and the goal of redemption.

Why Only a Temporary Punishment Makes Sense

Consider this scenario: you're driving, distracted for a moment, and tragically, you accidentally run over a baby, resulting in its death. It's a horrifying situation, and it's your fault. Suppose that the baby ends up in an eternal paradise. Would it then make sense for your punishment to be eternal torment in a fiery furnace once you die? Of course not.

This raises a significant point: if our ultimate destinations converge in the same eternal state, even the gravest misfortunes here are temporary. This doesn't negate consequences, but it questions the necessity of *eternal* punishment.

Such a drastic scenario helps illustrate a broader theological debate: If God despises sin but loves the sinner, His justice system should aim to eradicate the (effects of)

sin rather than destroy the sinners. It could be argued that even in the most morally depraved individuals, God's image still exists. Therefore, for God to destroy or forever torture the sinner means He will also destroy or forever torture His own image in them.

What Purpose Could Eternal Torment Serve?

What, then, is the purpose of eternal torment? This question challenges the Augustinian-Calvinist concept of hell as a place of endless torturous punishment. Such retribution is neither corrective nor rehabilitative, offering no opportunity for the damned to change, improve, or seek redemption. Instead, it mirrors the unrelenting fury of immature, human-like vengeance rather than reflecting God's just and merciful character as portrayed in the Bible. The idea of eternal torment seems to conflict with the God described as loving, forgiving, and compassionate—a God whose justice is restorative, not rooted in endless wrath.

Conversely, Jesus's metaphors of individuals being remanded to prison and *"delivered to the torturers,* ***until*** *he should repay everything he owes"* (Matthew 18:34) or *"you shall most certainly not emerge* ***until*** *you repay the very last pittance"* (Matthew 5:26; cf. Luke 12:59) suggest a punishment of temporary nature rather than eternal torment. The language of *"until"* implies a set duration or a point at which the punishment will end once the debt is paid.

Conclusion

The "justice paradigm" advocating for eternal torment in hellfire posits that all sinners, and consequently all humanity, merit perpetual burning. However, this perspective seems fundamentally flawed. Human lives, while fleeting, are followed by an eternal existence; thus, the sins of our temporal lives, having temporary effects, should logically incur temporary punishments. What, then, is the purpose of eternal punishment? Is it merely retributive, serving no purpose other than to inflict sadistic

pain for the sake of God's amusement? How does this reconcile with the concept taught by Israel's prophets of God as a gentle, loving parent who disciplines—not to destroy—but to teach and reform Israel:

> A bruised reed he will not break, and a faintly burning wick he will not quench; he will faithfully bring forth justice.
>
> Isaiah 42:3

Moreover, the idea of eternal torment is at odds with the eschatological promises found in Scripture, such as in Revelation 21:4, where God assures us that death, mourning, crying, and pain will cease. If eternal hellfire exists, how could these promises ever be fulfilled? Would God erase our memories of "unsaved" loved ones to spare us from eternal grief, thereby stripping us of our identities and experiences that have shaped us into who we are? Such a prospect raises disturbing ethical and theological questions about the nature and character of God.

If God's punishment is indeed temporary, it does not diminish His justice but rather proves the principle that *"where sin increased, grace increased all the more."* (Romans 5:20). God's justice is not limited to retribution but is ultimately rooted in His desire for redemption and restoration of all things.

Part III

Hell in the Bible

Introduction

When you hear phrases like "financial meltdown," do you picture Wall Street skyscrapers literally dissolving into puddles? Or consider a "political battlefield" — does it bring to mind politicians wearing armor and dueling with swords? How about the "corporate jungle"? Perhaps you visualize business managers hunting junior employees as if they were wild prey. And the term "media circus" — does it conjure images of journalists dressed as bees and swans, performing outlandishly for attention? Clearly, these scenarios are not meant to be taken literally. Contemporary audiences understand these expressions as figures of speech that employ symbolism and analogy to communicate complex ideas vividly. This was even more true in the context of societies that were mostly illiterate and heavily dependent on illustrations, metaphors, stories, and parables for comprehension.

Imagine you are a basketball player, and your coach sends a message to the team's group chat saying, *"We grilled the Yankees so strong last week I can still smell the smoke and hear the sound of their cry echoing!"* Your brain, knowing the context, understands these are metaphorical and symbolic expressions. But imagine someone in the year 4025 reading your coach's text and interpreting it literally. This is the same fallacy modern readers of the Bible often commit when confusing its different genres.

Cultural and Theological Context

Any student of Judaism knows that Jewish teachers always used literary techniques

like figurative language, metaphors, symbolism, and analogies in their teachings. Jesus and Paul—Jewish rabbis themselves—also utilized these and other literary methods, often overlooked by Western non-Jewish readers. Consider these examples:

Jesus:

1. "*I am the bread of life.*" (John 6:35)—Jesus did not suggest that He was a piece of pastry. Instead, this was a known symbol of spiritual sustenance.
2. "*You are the light of the world.*" (Matthew 5:14)—Jesus did not imply that His followers are candles or light bulbs. Rather, a Jew would understand this as a metaphor for how they can provide guidance, truth, and influence in the world.

Paul:

1. "*You are God's field, God's building.*" (1 Corinthians 3:9)—This symbolizes the growth and community among believers, not a literal claim of them being soil or structures.
2. "*Put on the full armor of God.*" (Ephesians 6:11)—This analogy represents spiritual readiness, suggesting the use of faith-based virtues as armor rather than physical gear made of iron or metal.

These verses clearly demonstrate the use of literary devices to convey deeper meanings and teachings. When ignored, not only can much of the richness and layered significance embedded in these scriptural texts be lost, but it may also lead to superficial, misinformed, or even harmful interpretations that fail to grasp the full spiritual and ethical insights intended by the authors.

This, I believe, is partly due to the intentional historical separation of Jewish elements from Christianity. For example, Emperor Constantine (4th century) actively uprooted Christianity from its Jewish roots in his efforts to establish a distinct, "Jewish-free" identity. Such efforts included the removal of Jewish priests from the church, the promotion of new doctrines and practices, and the insertion of pagan ones, which diminished any Jewish influences and excluded Jewish believers from Christianity early on. *"Let us then have nothing in common with the detestable Jewish crowd..."* [130] declared Constantine.

The First Council of Nicaea, held in 325 AD in Turkey, is perhaps the most renowned in Christian history. This was a pivotal event in early Christianity. However, bishops with Jewish backgrounds were not allowed to join the council.[131] This had notable, long-lasting repercussions for Christian-Jewish relations.

The Council changed the celebration of the Resurrection from the Jewish Feast of First Fruits to Easter in an attempt to disassociate it from Jewish feasts, stating, "*For it is unbecoming beyond measure that on this holiest of festivals, we should follow the customs of the Jews. Henceforth, let us have nothing in common with this odious people.*"[132] It was also decided to replace Passover with Easter and the Saturday Sabbath with a Sunday Sabbath.[133]

The persecution of the Quartodecimans marked the beginning of a dark era. The term "Quartodeciman" is Latin for "fourteeners," referring to Jews who celebrated Passover on the 14th of Nisan. As time went on, performing circumcision was outlawed, with violations punishable by death. Eventually, Jews were prohibited from holding public office or serving as officers in the military.[134] Later, restrictions were put on where the Jewish people could live, with whom they could do business, and where they could travel.[135] It comes as no surprise that Christianity has completely distanced itself—theologically as well—from its Jewish context. This has profoundly influenced Christian theology and the lack of understanding of Jesus and Paul as Jewish teachers, as well as the entire Bible, which was largely authored by Jewish individuals. This historical disconnection solidified and had long-lasting effects on the interpretation of biblical texts. In this part of the book, I hope to undo some of it.

Biblical Context

When you hear the word "hell," what imagery springs to mind? Suppose you are a member of Catholic or Protestant Christianity. In that case, you likely envision an immensely dark realm (Matthew 22:13) dominated by a vast lake of searing fire (Matthew 8:12), where souls are being tortured eternally while their teeth gnash and they cry endless tears 24/7. At a glance, there's a seeming contradiction in such descriptions: how can a place be shrouded in darkness and ablaze with fire simultaneously, given that fire naturally emits light? But you see, Jesus's Jewish

audience wouldn't take these words in their literal sense but understand them as proverbial figures of speech, symbolism, analogies, etc.

Indeed, these descriptions were not intended to be taken literally. Jesus Himself acknowledged, "*I have been speaking figuratively*" (John 16:25), and that He "*speaks to the people in parables*" (Matthew 13:10). This language highlights the use of metaphors to impart deeper spiritual truths, which is ironically juxtaposed against how some modern Christians interpret certain directives.

Consider Jesus' statement in John 6:54: "*Only he who drinks my blood has eternal life.*" Interpreted literally, this statement would suggest that only those who physically consumed Jesus' blood could attain eternal life. Such a literal interpretation not only restricts eternal life to a very few who had that access but also conflicts with Jewish Law, which Jesus said he came to fulfill, not to abolish (Matthew 5:17). Jewish Law explicitly prohibits the consumption of blood, commanding that Israelies "*must not eat the blood of any creature.*" (Leviticus 17:14). This apparent contradiction highlights the importance of recognizing Jesus' uses of metaphors and symbolism, emphasizing the spiritual act of accepting his sacrifice rather than a literal consumption of blood.

Likewise, hardly anyone takes Jesus's warnings to "*gouge out your eye and throw it away*" (Matthew 18:9) or "*cut off your right hand and throw it away*" (Matthew 5:30) literally. This is particularly ironic given Jesus was also referencing "hell" (*Gehenna*) in these same verses, highlighting a selective literalism that points to the importance of careful interpretation when studying biblical scripture.

However, by the time of the first English translations of the New Testament, the hellfire tradition had been so well ingrained in some Church traditions that where the translators saw "*Gehenna.*" This led to many of today's misconceptions about hell.

Biblical Genres

The Bible—a narrative—employs a wide range of literary devices, including metaphors, parables, and allegories, to communicate its messages. These literary devices are seldom meant to be taken literally—contrasting with a textbook or manual—but rather to illustrate deeper spiritual truths and creatively express them.

When Jesus speaks of hell in parables, for instance, he is using already familiar concepts and vivid imagery to convey profound moral and life lessons.

The Augustinian-Calvinist view of hellfire relies heavily on interpreting metaphors, symbolism, hyperbole, parables, allegories, and other similar literary styles not according to their intended genres but rather literally. This approach can lead to a misunderstanding of the original context and meaning of the Biblical texts.

Therefore, in this part of the book, we will delve into what the Bible actually articulates about hell. Given my goal to keep this book concise and your preference for a more manageable read, I have selectively focused on a number of Biblical references related to hell, though not exhaustively. Specifically, I've chosen to highlight those passages most frequently cited by advocates of the Augustinian-Calvinist view of eternal conscious torment (ECT) in Hellfire.

The concept of "Sufficient Sampling" or "Representative Refutation" means that if you have effectively refuted a representative sample (such as 20 verses about hell), you do not need to refute every single verse because the sample is considered sufficient to demonstrate the overall point.[136]

By examining these passages, we aim to uncover the intended message and genre-specific nuances that are often overlooked when interpreted literally. We will consider the historical and cultural contexts, the literary styles employed by the Biblical authors, and some of the fallacies committed in modern interpretations. By examining key passages and understanding their context and literary styles, we can gain a clearer and more nuanced understanding of what the Bible does and doesn't say about hell, encouraging a more thoughtful and informed reading of the Bible.

Hell in the Torah

The Hebrew Scriptures, which chronicle God's relationship with Israel over thousands of years, do not contain a Hebrew term equivalent to the concept of hellfire as understood in later Augustinian-Calvinist theology. Instead, the Old Testament's Hebrew word " *SHEOL*" simply refers to the realm of the dead, akin to a grave. For instance, Genesis 37:34-35:

> Then Jacob tore his clothes, put on sackcloth and mourned for his son many days. All his sons and all his daughters rose up to comfort him, but he refused to be comforted. And he said, "No, I shall go down to **Sheol** to my son, mourning." Thus his father wept for him.
>
> Genesis 37:34-35, ESV

The NIV translated Sheol as "grave":

> I will go down to the **grave** to my son in mourning.
>
> Genesis 37:35, NIV

If we read this verse in other translations, like that of Douay-Rheims Bible, for instance, it will make no sense: *"I will go down to my son into hell, mourning."* Why would Jacob want to go to hell, and why would he think his son is burning in hell? This

is the time to remind ourselves that the word "hell" did not always mean what most understand it as today (eternal conscious torment in fire).

In English bible translations, the Hebrew term *Sheol* is variably translated in English versions of the Old Testament[137] as "grave," "underworld," "pit," "death," and "hell." This variation in translation has led to significant theological confusion regarding the afterlife.

Deuteronomy 32:22

John MacArthur's interpretation of the hellfire doctrine illustrates the confusion that can arise from depending solely on a single translation, particularly when ignoring the context and disregarding the evolving meanings of words over time:

> [Hellfire] is not new. This is what the Bible has said. You can go back to Moses…In Deuteronomy 32:22, it reads this way in the Authorized Version, *"A fire is kindled…says God…in my anger and burns to the lowest part of **hell**."* The 1611 King James version made it clear even that early that the anger of God reached into hell.[138]
>
> John MacArthur

In Hebrew, however, the term "hell" does not appear in the Deuteronomy 32:22 text; rather, the word used is "*Sheol*." Consider the much more literal JPS translation of Deuteronomy 32:22:

> For a fire is kindled in My nostril,
> And burneth unto the depths of the **nether-world**,
> And devoureth the earth with her produce,
> And setteth ablaze the foundations of the mountains.
>
> Deuteronomy 32:22 (JPS)

Taken literally, it would imply that God has a nose from which, during Moses' time, fire erupted to set the mountain foundations ablaze. However, within its context, Deuteronomy 32:22 serves as a metaphor for God's wrath, extending even to the underworld.

The absence of a definitive concept of hellfire in the Old Testament texts partly explains why traditional Jewish views on the afterlife, including notions of punishment, differ markedly from those later developed in Christianity. In Judaism, *Sheol* is more neutrally seen as a place where all deceased souls rest until judgment day rather than a place of torment.

Moses and the Prophets never depicted *Sheol* as a place of torment after death, which reflects the overall focus of the Law of Moses on temporal, not eternal, rewards and punishments. In fact, the Torah and the Prophets always emphasize an immediate consequence of actions within one's lifetime rather than posthumous suffering or reward.

Was Hellfire the Consequence of Breaking the Ten Commandments?

You might be familiar with videos by fundamental Evangelical minister Ray Comfort, which have been widely advertised and amassed roughly half a billion views on social media. He is best known for his "Ten Commandments Interrogation" series. In these videos, Comfort approaches strangers in public and prompts them to confess their sins by asking if they've ever broken the Ten Commandments. His line of questioning includes: *"Have you ever lied?" "Have you ever stolen anything?" "Have you ever lusted after someone?"* Honestly, it's challenging for anyone to answer 'no' to these questions. For instance, calling a bride's unattractive dress 'beautiful' technically makes you a liar. Taking a pen from work and not returning it makes you a thief. Regarding lust, I recall a doctoral class where all attendees were men. The professor asked if there was someone in the class who had never fantasized about lesbians. Despite the embarrassment, no hands were raised. It seems theologians, pastors, ministers—we've all been there. This wasn't a liberal institution. It was Dallas Theological Seminary!

Then, Comfort continues by explaining God's holiness to his interviewees: "*You have to be perfect in God's eyes. Morally perfect!*" Says Comfort.[139] Otherwise, "*if God judges you according to the Ten Commandments,*" you are doomed forever. The punishment is everlasting condemnation "*in the lake of fire,*" concludes Comfort.

So, because you broke the Ten Commandments, God must torture you in fire for eternity. Or, to use the words of another reformed preacher: "*We owed a debt to God because of our sin. And that debt was eternal punishment.*"[140] (Paul Washer)

During an encounter in August 2022, Comfort questioned a young Israeli-Jewish man on the street, "*Have you ever looked at a woman with lust?*"[141] Upon receiving an affirmative response and a smile, Comfort responded that, according to Jesus, this is equivalent to committing adultery and would result in condemnation to hellfire on judgment day. Comfort's claim made no sense to the young Jewish guy, who politely said he believed otherwise.

Let's step back and analyze the reasoning behind Comfort's claim that violating any of the Ten Commandments results in eternal damnation by using one of Comfort's frequently cited commandments:

> You shall not commit adultery.
>
> Exodus 20:14

Once Comfort gets his interviewees to admit that they have previously looked at a woman with lust, he then continues by quoting the following verse:

> I tell you that anyone who looks at a woman lustfully has already committed adultery with her in his heart.
>
> Matthew 5:28

Comfort's reasoning goes something like this: Any transgression of the Ten Commandments, no matter how minor, such as a fleeting lustful glance at a passing woman, warrants harsh and everlasting punishment—eternal torture in hellfire. Essentially, Comfort argues that God endowed you with strong sexual instincts as an integral part of your being. Yet, if you entertain a sexual thought for even a moment

—and it is inevitable that you will—God is left with no option but to subject you to eternal torment in hellfire. The logical next step in this direction is to mandate that women cover themselves with Hijabs to prevent anyone from being inadvertently attracted. While I'm not advocating for permissiveness, this example highlights how religious legalism thrives.

Let's consider applying Comfort's reasoning to everyday life. Imagine living in a country where parking in a no-parking zone could land you a lifetime prison sentence or where a parent is legally permitted to cut off their child's hand for watching pornography. This scenario illustrates a society with extremely severe and unbalanced moral codes, akin to the harshness found in regimes like North Korea or Iran. Yet, this parallels how some Christians interpret Biblical Law, portraying it as even more draconian as eternal torture in the fire for lusting in your mind is much worse than losing your hand (or eye).

The issue is not with Jesus or the Law but with the misinterpretation of Moses and Jesus and with the association of the Law with eternal life or punishment in hellfire.

For the sake of argument, let's hypothesize for a moment that in Matthew 5:28, where Jesus spoke of lustful looks being akin to adultery, he was indeed suggesting a literal, judicial sentence of death, as stated in Leviticus 20:10. Under this interpretation, we must also consider his earlier statements in Matthew 5:21-22, where he allegedly equates an insult (*"fool"*) with risking eternal damnation. Such an interpretation might lead one to believe Jesus frequently threatened his disciples with eternal torture for anything but perfection. However, understanding Jesus in this way would severely distort his message. As a Jewish rabbi, Jesus often taught using parables, metaphors, symbolism, and figurative language to convey deeper spiritual truths rather than acting as a human textbook for escaping hellfire.

So, what was Jesus trying to convey? Every company that has been established began as an idea, a concept in someone's mind. Every gun fired at a person was initiated by a thought in the shooter's mind. All actions are initially conceived in our minds. Adultery begins with harboring the thought. Cursing stems from first feeling anger. Murder is preceded by hatred in one's heart.

To quote Andy Woods, the president of Chafer Theological Seminary:

> Jesus warned you about murder happening in your heart long before physically anything else transpires. Because private thoughts will ultimately lead to public actions. That's why there is so much scripture about us guarding the mind.[142]

What's the Point of the Law?

Misusing the Law

The term "Torah" (or "Law") is among the most perplexing and debated terms in both Judaism and Christianity, mostly due to erroneous translations.[143] "Torah" primarily refers to the Pentateuch, the first five books of the Hebrew Bible. However, the same word is also often used to refer to the laws and commandments within the Pentateuch.

Although there are laws in the Torah, the literary genre of the Torah is not judicial but narrative. It's a story – a story written in one book, "The Book of Moses." Later, the book was divided into five books: Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, and Deuteronomy. The laws/commandments are only a small fraction of the Torah, which is a narrative story. Jewish Bible Professor Simeon Chavel explains:

> The Torah, which contains most of the laws, is not a collection of laws but rather a narrative that tells the history of the Jewish people in their earliest days…Therefore we can view the Torah as a source of laws and even construct a set of laws from it. But this is not adequate grounds to interpret the Torah outside of its literary genre, which is a narrative…The fact that the biblical laws are always found in a literary context and not in a legal context means that the laws are indisputably tied to the means and purposes of the literary context in which they are found…The Torah is, first and foremost, a narrative and not a law book, and it needs to be treated accordingly.[144]

Judaism doesn't consider the Law's commandments to be an instruction manual on "how to get saved from hellfire," but rather as encompassing rites, rituals, customs, morals, and justice, all impacting earthly daily life and carrying immediate consequences. These laws, provided in the context of establishing a new nation, functioned essentially as the constitution of Israel. In a similar vein, American citizens do not regard the U.S. Constitution and laws as a pathway to eternal life. While the Law may have significantly influenced an Israelite's earthly life, it clearly pertained to their existence in this temporal world:

> If you fully obey the LORD your God and carefully follow all his commands I give you today...You will be blessed in the city and blessed in the country. The fruit of your womb will be blessed, and the crops of your land and the young of your livestock–the calves of your herds and the lambs of your flocks. Your basket and your kneading trough will be blessed...The LORD will send a blessing on your barns and on everything you put your hand to. The LORD your God will bless you in the land he is giving you.
>
> Deuteronomy 28:1; 3-5; 8-10

Much like modern law, the Torah sets forth regulations on taxation (Leviticus 27:30; Deuteronomy 14:28), banking (Exodus 22:25; Deuteronomy 23:19), and labor laws (Leviticus 19:13; Deuteronomy 24:14-15), among others. Suppose the Torah were to be given in contemporary times. In that case, it might include mandates such as prohibiting smoking on airplanes or prohibiting pedestrians from crossing the street unless the walking signal light is green (for Israel, I think it's white in the USA). While there are fines and penalties for violating these statutes, they do not pertain to one's eternal fate.

Throughout the extensive history of Israel, none of its prophets, kings, or judges ever linked adherence to the commandments with eternal life or hellfire. It was rather about life's repercussions. Discussions of the afterlife, in terms of obeying the commandments, would have been alien to the people of Israel. Indeed, breaking a commandment incurred punishment, but this was related to their temporal existence,

not the everlasting fate of their souls. While sin did carry penalties, including death for certain transgressions, these were physical, not spiritual/eternal consequences.

For instance, let's look into another one of Comfort's favorite commandments to quote in his videos. The 8th commandment says: "*You shall not steal.*" (Exodus 20:15).

Here in the Middle East, lamb is a favored dish. Imagine a scenario where my neighbor, driven by hunger while I was abroad, steals and eats one of my sheep. Does this mean, as some might suggest following Comfort's logic, that he's destined for eternal torture in hell? Not quite. Exodus 22:1 offers clarity: *"If a man steals an ox or a sheep, and kills it or sells it, he shall repay five oxen for an ox, and four sheep for a sheep."* This scriptural context reveals that God's justice for theft involves restitution, not eternal torture in fire. Thus, instead of facing eternal doom, my neighbor now owes me four sheep, and they better be well-fed and chubby!

To complicate matters, consider a person in the era of Deuteronomy who violates two commandments at once by abducting a woman to engage in sexual relations with her. One might assume that such transgressions must result in eternal damnation in hell. However, the Law offers a pretty straightforward solution:

> If a man meets a virgin who is not betrothed, and seizes her and lies with her, and they are found, then the man who lay with her shall give to the father of the young woman fifty shekels of silver, and she shall be his wife, because he has violated her. He may not divorce her all his days.
>
> Deuteronomy 22:28-29

In such a case, the man must pay a fine to the young woman's father and provide for her for life. It appears one might have to atone for their wrongdoings, possibly for a lifetime. However, this had nothing to do with one's eternal life.

King David is another great example. David committed theft and adultery with Bathsheba and even orchestrated the murder of her husband, Uriah. David also failed to repent or make amends. Only after about a year or so did God, tired of waiting on David, finally send the prophet Nathan to confront David (2 Samuel 12). Still, Nathan made no threat or mentioned David's afterlife. Instead, he declared David's punishment, which did not involve hellfire. Only at this point did David finally repent,

hoping God would spare his child's life. It seems clear that both Nathan and David understood that David's afterlife was not at stake. Notably, God did not even demand David's resignation from his kingship.

Let's look into another commandment. The 5th commandment, *"Honor your father and mother"* (Exodus 20:12), which holds a much more severe punishment. What would happen if you didn't honor your parents? Several chapters later, in the book of Leviticus, we find the most extreme situation: *"For anyone who curses his father or his mother shall surely be put to death"* (Leviticus 20:9). Now the question is, what kind of death is Leviticus referring to? A spiritual one? An eternal torture in the fire, as some believe, or was it something of a different nature? In Deuteronomy 21, we find the answer:

> ...then his father and his mother shall take hold of him and bring him out to the elders of his city at the gate of the place where he lives, and they shall say to the elders of his city, "This our son is stubborn and rebellious; he will not obey our voice; he is a glutton and a drunkard." Then all the men of the city shall stone him to death with stones.
>
> Deuteronomy 21:18-21

In the Bible, while a physical death penalty may have excluded someone from society, it was never linked to a secondary, eternal punishment in the afterlife. As far as the Torah is concerned, our behavior on Earth affects our life on Earth.

Conclusion

Nowhere in the Torah is there a threat that violating a commandment will result in eternal condemnation in hell. The fact that the foundation of the entire Bible, the Pentateuch, says nothing about hell is significant enough to cast serious doubt on the doctrine of eternal hellfire. The Pentateuch, which lays the groundwork for all of biblical theology, is completely silent on the concept of hell as a place of eternal

torment. This absence strongly suggests that the idea of hellfire is not an original part of the biblical message but rather a later development that lacks grounding in the core scriptures of the Jewish and Christian faiths.

I do respect Comfort, Washer, or other fundamentalist preachers' sincerity, earnestness, zeal, and fervor for God. Yet it's crucial to address that their interpretations may distort the character of God and the essence of the Good News. They tend to oversimplify the complexities of sin, divine commandments, and the concept of hell, often reducing them to a simplistic notion like eternal damnation for coveting a neighbor's attractive new convertible. These perspectives not only ignore context but fail to capture the broader, more compassionate teachings found in scripture.

Hell in the Prophets

The Hebrew Prophets also do not contain a Hebrew term equivalent to the concept of hellfire as understood in later Augustine-Calvinist Christian theology. Instead, the Hebrew word " *SHEOL*," which simply refers to the realm of the dead, is variably translated in English versions of the Old Testament as "grave," "underworld," "pit," "death," and "hell." This variation in translation has led to significant theological confusion regarding the afterlife. In this chapter, I will examine the most popular verses used to establish hellfire in the Old Testament's prophets.

Isaiah 5:14

Isaiah's prophetic vision during the First Temple period emphasized moral justice. His prophecies often highlighted the failure of Israel's leaders and people to uphold these values, resulting in severe consequences as depicted in Isaiah 5:14. This focus on justice and the inevitability of divine consequences reflect the larger theme of Isaiah's ministry, which called for repentance and adherence to God's covenantal laws. Chapter 5 contains graphic prophetic warnings delivered by the prophet Isaiah, including a warning of impending judgment due to the moral and social decay in Israel and Judah, urging the people of Israel to repent before it is too late.

Isaiah 5:14 states,

> Therefore **Sheol** has enlarged its appetite and opened its mouth beyond measure; and the nobility of Jerusalem and her multitude will descend, her tumult and he who exults in her.
>
> Isaiah 5:14

While some translations translated *"Therefore **Death** expands its jaws"* (NIV) and *"The **grave** is licking its lips in anticipation"* (NLV), others, like the English Revised Version, translated *"Therefore **hell** hath enlarged her desire."*

As we already covered, Sheol is a Hebrew word used in the Old Testament to describe the realm of the dead, often translated as the grave, having nothing to do with the modern concept of hellfire.

Isaiah 5:14 metaphorically describes the soon-reaching consequences of Israel, where the grave is depicted as expanding to accommodate the numerous who will die if Israel doesn't repent.

In Isaiah 5:1-7, God likens Israel to a vineyard that has failed to produce good fruit despite His care. The following verses (8-23) contain a series of woes against various forms of social injustice and moral decay in Israel. Isaiah uses vivid imagery to depict the grave consequences of these sins. Has Isaiah's prophetic warning come true?

Key Events Following Isaiah's Prophecy:

1. **Assyrian Conquest of Israel (722 BCE)**: The Northern Kingdom of Israel fell to the Assyrian Empire in 722 BCE, only a few decades after Isaiah's prophecies. The Assyrians invaded, leading to the capture and deportation of many Israelites. This event marked a significant loss of life and the displacement of the population.
2. **Sennacherib's Campaign against Judah (701 BCE)**: King Sennacherib of Assyria launched a campaign against the Southern Kingdom of Judah, devastating many cities, including Lachish. Although Jerusalem was

miraculously spared, the campaign caused substantial destruction and loss of life.

3. **Babylonian Exile (586 BCE)**: The ultimate fulfillment of many of Isaiah's prophecies of judgment came with the Babylonian conquest of Judah. In 586 BCE, Jerusalem was finally destroyed, the Temple was burned, and a significant portion of the population was killed or exiled to Babylon. This catastrophic event was a direct consequence of the continued moral and spiritual decline warned about by Isaiah.

To conclude, Isaiah's warnings in Chapter 5 about the dire consequences of Israel's and Judah's sins were realized through several significant historical events, highlighting the accuracy and gravity of Isaiah's prophetic warnings. Isaiah 5:14 uses the metaphor of a grave enlarging its size and readiness to receive many newcomers, depicting the extensive death casualties awaiting Israel. The depiction of *Sheol* underscores the severity of divine consequences in response to persistent injustice and disobedience. However, it was not perceived as related to the notion of everlasting torturous punishment in the afterlife.

Isaiah 66:23-24

Isaiah 66:23-24 is also often cited in discussions about hellfire judgment. However, a closer examination reveals a nuanced understanding that differs from some modern interpretations of eternal hellfire.

> "From one New Moon to another and from one Sabbath to another, all mankind will come and bow down before me," says the Lord. "And they will go out and look on the **dead bodies** of those who rebelled against me; **the worms that eat them will not die, the fire that burns them will not be quenched**, and they will be loathsome to all mankind."
>
> Isaiah 66:23-24

Isaiah 66 explores themes of divine sovereignty, judgment, and restoration, ultimately affirming God's grand vision for humanity. The chapter presents a powerful narrative that juxtaposes God's omnipotence with His expectations of true worship.

Section 1: God's Infinite Dwelling (Verses 1-2): Isaiah opens with a declaration of God's dominion, where the heavens serve as His throne and the earth as His footstool. This imagery underscores God's omnipotence and His desire for genuine and humble worship, seeking those who revere His word rather than grandiose temples.

Section 2: False Worship and Divine Judgement (Verses 3-4): The text criticizes the hypocrisy in religious practices, equating insincere rituals to abhorrent acts. God promises retribution for those who follow their own corrupt inclinations, forewarning of severe consequences.

Section 3: Encouragement for the Faithful (Verses 5-9): This section offers hope and encouragement, using the metaphor of a pain-free birth to symbolize the swift and peaceful emergence of a new era for Jerusalem, urging the faithful to trust in God's promise and timing.

Section 4: Future Glory for Jerusalem (Verses 10-14): Isaiah foretells a time of peace and prosperity for Jerusalem, drawing on the comforting image of a mother soothing her child to illustrate the deep, nurturing love God holds for His people.

Section 5: The Coming Judgement (Verses 15-17): A stark warning of imminent judgment is issued against the pagan nations.

Section 6: Gathering of the Nations and New Creation (Verses 18-24): The chapter concludes with a vision of universal gathering and renewal, contrasting peace with the grim fate of the pagan nations who did not listen and repent.

The imagery of unquenchable fire and undying worms is a potent metaphor often found in biblical texts, particularly used to describe the total and irrevocable destruction of nations. This symbolism, later to be used in the gospels, vividly portrays the aftermath of divine judgment, where the fire that consumes represents an unstoppable force of destruction that cannot be extinguished by human means. Simultaneously, the worms that do not die add a layer of ongoing decay, suggesting a perpetual state of ruin.

It is important to note, however, that Isaiah describes *"dead bodies,"* not "people ceaselessly tortured."

Unquenched fire symbolizes complete consumption—nothing is left salvageable, akin to a landscape devastated by an uncontrolled blaze that leaves only ash and

char in its wake. Meanwhile, the undying worms represent various decomposers, including certain types of worms, maggots, and beetles, who are well-known for their role in consuming decaying flesh. These organisms are critical in the process of decomposition, helping to break down dead organic matter. In this context, *"worms that eat them will not die"* suggests these pagan nations or empires will not rise again.

Malachi 4:1

Malachi 4:1 provides a stark warning about an imminent day of judgment, emphasizing its severity through vivid imagery:

> "Surely the day is coming; it will burn like a furnace. All the arrogant and every evildoer will be stubble, and the day that is coming will set them on fire," says the Lord Almighty. "Not a root or a branch will be left to them."
>
> Malachi 4:1

This imagery not only emphasizes the severity and decisiveness of the impending judgment but also anchors its significance firmly within the reality of post-exilic Israel, where the community grapples with moral and spiritual challenges.

The reference to a "day" that burns like a furnace—and there were many of these "judgment days" in Israel's history—indicates a period of purification and judgment that is imminent and inescapable, yet temporal and for the purpose of purification. This metaphorical language is typical of prophetic literature, where the motif of fire often symbolizes God's purifying Israel's wickedness and the consuming wrath against sin. A few verses earlier, Malachi wrote:

> He will sit as a refiner and purifier of silver; he will purify the Levites and refine them like gold and silver.
>
> Malachi 3:3

The specificity of the judgment against *"all the arrogant and every evildoer,"* in the context of God's relationship with Israel, highlights the comprehensive nature of divine justice, which targets all forms of unrighteousness within the community.

In Malachi's time, the Israelites struggled with disillusionment and spiritual apathy after returning from exile. The prophet's message serves as a stern reminder of the covenant obligations that the Israelites had neglected. The imagery of leaving neither *"root nor branch"* illustrates the total eradication of evil, ensuring that no vestige of corruption or defiance remains to corrupt the community anew.

Historically, its original audience would have understood this prophecy as a call to repentance and reform. It underscores the earthly judgments that God would meet within the community's lifetime rather than a threat of eternal damnation in the afterlife—a concept unfamiliar to the Israelites. The prophetic warning is framed to galvanize the Israelites towards righteousness, contrasting their current complacency with the stark, destructive consequences of continued moral decay.

Thus, Malachi 4:1 serves as a prophetic warning and a promise of an unpleasant yet temporary purification. It reminds us that God's justice is imminent and aimed at cleansing iniquities, thereby restoring the community to a state where it can truly flourish under divine guidance. The verse ultimately reinforces the theme that God's interventions, though often severe, are meant to lead His people back to a path of righteousness, ensuring their long-term communal and spiritual health.

Hence, to interpret Malachi 4:1 as an allusion to eternal torment in hellfire would mean significantly overlooking the context of its composition. Even if one suggests that Malachi's prophecies address both immediate earthly consequences for Israel and the afterlife, it follows that since Israel's judgments were always temporary and aimed at purification, any analogous scenarios in the afterlife inferred from these verses would similarly be for purification's sake rather than eternal.

Daniel 12:1-2

The Book of Daniel, including its apocalyptic visions, reflects the concerns and events of that era, making it one of the later additions to the Hebrew Bible. Daniel 12:1-2

is often cited in discussions about the afterlife and the concept of eternal conscious torment:

> At that time shall arise Michael, the great prince who has charge of your people. And there shall be a time of trouble, such as never has been since there was a nation till that time. But at that time your people shall be delivered, everyone whose name shall be found written in the book. And many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt.
>
> Daniel 12:1-2

However, a closer examination of its context reveals a different understanding. There are a few things to consider regarding these verses:

1. The Book of Daniel is highly figurative, known for its rich use of allegory and symbolic imagery, such as the giant statue made of different materials (gold, silver, bronze, iron, and clay), the four beasts emerging from the sea, and the ram with two horns and a goat with a prominent horn. This context demands that interpretations consider these elements symbolic rather than literal textbook descriptions.
2. ***"Your people"*** refers specifically to Daniel's people, the Israelites. This targeting helps clarify the prophecies' intended audience within the historical and cultural context of the Hebrew people.
3. ***"MANY of them that sleep"*** will awaken, rather than *ALL*, indicates a selective process. This challenges the notion that Daniel speaks universally of last final judgment destinies like heaven or hell. This implies that the "waking up" may involve varied outcomes based on individual lives and actions rather than pointing to a universal or uniform judgment for all.
4. ***"Book"***: There are several references to "books" in the Hebrew Bible. For instance, Psalm 56:8 mentions a memory book: *"You have kept count of my tossings; put my tears in your bottle. Are they not in your book?"*

while Malachi 3:16 speaks about the *"book of remembrance."* These books symbolize records of people's deeds and God's acknowledgment of them.
In Daniel, the *"book"* likely signifies the ledger containing the names of those among the Israelites faithful to God who will be delivered in times of tribulation. Considering that the "end times" began with Jesus' birth, this reference could allude to various events, such as the catastrophes of 70-135 AD, during which Israel's temple was destroyed, and many Jewish individuals were executed and exiled while Jewish believers in Jesus were preserved.

5. Some scholars point to the clear allusions to Genesis 1-2 with terms like *"dust"* (*AFAR*) and *"earth"* (*ADAMAH*) found within this context. In this context, some interpret these as intertextual references to the ongoing conflict between good and evil—symbolized by the seed of the woman and the serpent. According to this interpretation, in the *"day of the Lord"*—not limited to a singular apocalyptic event—there will be divisions within Israel. Some will align with the woman's seed, while others will align with the serpent's seed. These verses are also enriched with celestial imagery that ties back to Moses and the Genesis creation narrative, where heavenly bodies like the sun, moon, and stars symbolize spiritual entities. Those aligned with the seed of the woman are destined to rule in a god-like manner; they will shine brightly, enact justice, and do so eternally in the New Eden or New Jerusalem.

6. *"Everlasting"*: The Semitic term *"OLAM,"* often translated as "everlasting" or "forever," generally signifies a lengthy duration rather than literal infinity, a later philosophical concept that did not exist in biblical times (more on that in a later chapter). In the Torah, *"OLAM"* is frequently used concerning the Law and commandments, though many Christians believe these are no longer applicable. Jeremiah refers to *OLAM* as a 70-year period (Jer 25:9), while Isaiah (32:14) and Jonah (Jonah 2:6) also use it to describe specific time spans.
In Daniel, the juxtaposition of "everlasting [OLAM] life" with "everlasting [OLAM] shame and contempt" raises questions about their duration. Although both terms imply some form of equivalency, this doesn't necessarily pertain to their length. Jewish tradition speaks of two eras:

OLAM HAZEH (this current age/world) and OLAM HABA (the age/world to come). The reference to "OLAM" as pertaining to "the age to come," rather than an indefinite period, suggests that in Daniel 12:2, the terms "life" and "shame and contempt" might both belong to the age to come qualitatively, without necessarily implying a never-ending duration.

7. *"Shame"*: The distinction in Daniel 12 between life and disgrace does not create a strict bifurcation between two states of existence. While 'shame' is contrasted with 'life,' nothing suggests that 'shame' is inherently distinct from life itself. Since those experiencing shame and contempt are alive (or else they wouldn't be able to feel), at least in some sense, those who awaken to shame at the resurrection might be depicted as shocked and surprised, suddenly aware of their misdeeds. Unlike pride, shame arises from the recognition of wrongdoing. Biblically, shame and restoration are compatible, as seen in passages like Ezekiel 16:63, where God forgives those who feel shame. This emotion, shame, symbolizes humility, remorse, and repentance—qualities valued by God. Most of today's religious culture in the West views shame negatively, yet both Judaism and biblical narratives like that of the Prodigal Son illustrate shame's positive role in prompting repentance and reconciliation (Luke 15:17).

In Ezekiel 16:63, shame facilitates atonement and restoration, demonstrating that it can be part of a purification process: *"that you may remember and be confounded, and never open your mouth again because of your shame, when I atone for you for all that you have done, declares the Lord GOD."*

Thus, Daniel 12:2's contrast between life and shame does not imply a clear bifurcation; rather, it suggests that individuals may experience both salvation and shame as part of their spiritual renewal. Therefore, even if taking Daniel 12:2 as speaking of the afterlife, it's possible to understand "shame" and "everlasting" as a period of repentance that does not necessarily equate to perpetual torment.

There is more that can be said, but when considered, these seven points are enough to challenge the simplistic Augustinian-Calvinist interpretation of Daniel 12, highlighting its disregard for the context and meanings of the words involved.

Conclusion

As we have examined, the Torah and the rest of the Old Testament do not articulate a definitive doctrine of hellfire. Rather, proponents of the ECT hellfire theory, in the absence of explicit teaching, extrapolate from a handful of disparate verses to support their perspective, which is not substantiated by the text itself.

We also saw that the penalty for eating from the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil was physical death, manifesting in the expulsion of Adam and Eve from Eden and the loss of access to the Tree of Life (Genesis 2:17; 3:22-24). God warned Adam and Eve, "for in the day that you eat of it you shall surely die" (Genesis 2:17), and on that day, they were banished from the Garden and denied access to the Tree of Life. This punishment is purely physical and immediate, with no indication of eternal torment in the afterlife.

The Hebrew Bible text consistently describes destruction as physical and immediate, affecting both individuals and nations. This is evident in the various divine judgments recorded, such as the flood (Genesis 6-9), the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah (Genesis 19), and the numerous military defeats of Israel's enemies.

If hellfire were a reality, we would expect Moses to mention it explicitly in the extensive laws and warnings given to Israel. The Mosaic Covenant, including the Ten Commandments and over 600 laws, delineates blessings for obedience and curses for disobedience, all within the context of this life (Deuteronomy 28). There is no mention of eternal torment in the afterlife as a consequence.

Furthermore, in Jeremiah 32:35, God harshly condemns the practice of burning people (as a sacrifice to Molech), stating that such an act *"never entered His mind."* This declaration would be contradictory if God intended to subject the majority of humanity to eternal fire, as such an idea would inherently be in His mind.

The Hebrew Scriptures simply do not contain a concept of hellfire as understood in later Christian theology. This absence is significant because it suggests that the idea

of eternal hellfire was not part of ancient Israel's theology. Any doctrine that does not appear in the foundational texts of the Law, the Prophets, and the Writings cannot be considered a core biblical doctrine. This also begs the question—if the doctrine of hellfire did not originate from God, where did it originate from?

Additionally, we observed that the Hebrew word "*Sheol*," often inconsistently translated in English Bibles as "hell," among other words, actually symbolizes the grave (the realm of the dead, the underworld), not a place of eternal torment. The continued translation of *"Sheol"* as "hell" in some modern Bibles perpetuates misunderstandings, suggesting an interpretation of eternal torment that is not present in the original Hebrew text. This mistranslation obscures the original context and intent of the Scriptures, leading to a distorted view of biblical teachings on the afterlife.

As we move into the New Testament, it's essential to recall that when the gospels and letters were composed, the Hebrew Scriptures were the only Bible. Jesus and his Jewish disciples' teachings were rooted in these texts. The subsequent chapters' analysis of New Testament passages will clarify whether the New Testament presents a novel doctrine, that of eternal hellfire, or maintains the themes established in the Old Testament.

Gehenna: Jesus' "Hell"

You very likely heard the claim that "Jesus talked more about hell than He did about heaven." Take, for example, the words of famous Calvinist Pastor John MacArthur:

> Yes, Jesus was a Hellfire preacher… Jesus spoke more about hell than anybody else in the Bible. In fact, He spoke more about hell than everybody else in the Bible combined…. He continually spoke about hell and He warned sinners to escape hell because of its horrible reality.[145]
>
> The gospels and the writers of the New Testament describe hell as a fiery place, and its fire is the fire of torture and torment. It's also described as darkness, outer darkness, like being lost in the most infinite corner of space under horrible torture and pain, a place of weeping, wailing, teeth-grinding agony.[146]
>
> John MacArthur

This statement, however, is incorrect. In fact, Jesus not once spoke of "hell" but spoke of "Gehenna," a term well-known in Judaism.

The term "Gehenna," used by Jesus in the New Testament as a metaphor to describe the condition of suffering and divine consequences, was understood by Jews of the first and second centuries primarily as symbolizing harsh consequences rather than a destination in the afterlife.

In Matthew 23:15, Jesus condemns the religious leaders for making their converts *"twice as much a child of hell"* as themselves. Here, Jesus uses "hell" (*Gehenna*) as a present reality rather than a future destination, suggesting that He viewed *Gehenna* as a condition of moral, spiritual, physical, mental, or emotional corruption occurring in this life. This indicates that Jesus understood *Gehenna* more as an earthly state of separation from God's ways and its consequences, characterized by hypocrisy and spiritual blindness, rather than an eternal place of torment awaiting sinners in the afterlife.

This interpretation aligns with the views of early Jewish and Christian thinkers, including Saint Origen. Origen, a Church Father from the second century, engaged extensively with Jewish scholars and writings, which influenced his understanding of scriptural texts. In his work '*Against Celsus*,' Origen discusses Gehenna, suggesting that Jews who did use it in terms of afterlife reality in his time viewed it more as a temporary process or place intended for purification and correction rather than eternal damnation.

Origin was a prolific writer who wrote roughly 2,000 treatises in multiple branches of theology, including textual criticism, biblical exegesis, hermeneutics, and homiletics. He was one of the most influential and controversial figures in early Christian theology and apologetics. He has been described as *"the greatest genius the early church ever produced."* [147]

Origen wrote extensively about the New Testament gospels and his interactions with Jews, but the most pertinent section is as follows:

> Now as we found that Gehenna was mentioned in the Gospel as a place of punishment, we searched to see whether it is mentioned anywhere in the ancient Scriptures, and especially because the Jews too use the word. And we ascertained that where the valley of the son of Ennom was named in Scripture in the Hebrew, instead of valley, with fundamentally the same meaning, it was termed both the valley of Ennom and also Gehenna. And continuing our researches, we find that what was termed Gehenna, or the valley of Ennom, was included in the lot of the tribe of Benjamin, in which Jerusalem also was situated. And seeking to ascertain what might be the inference from the heavenly Jerusalem belonging to the lot

> of Benjamin and the valley of Ennom, we find a certain confirmation of what is said regarding the place of punishment, **intended for the purification of such souls as are to be purified** by torments, agreeably to the saying: *"The Lord comes like a refiner's fire, and like fullers' soap: and He shall sit as a refiner and purifier of silver and of gold."*
>
> Origen, Against Celsus, VI, 25.

This context is crucial for interpreting New Testament references to Gehenna, as it underscores the idea that early interpretations of this term, even when using it as an afterlife concept, might have leaned towards a temporary, corrective punishment rather than an unending torment.

"Valley of Hinnom" (Gehenna/Géenna)

Gehenna comes from the Hebrew phrase "*GEY HINNOM*," which means the "valley of wailing." It's an actual valley, here in Israel, on the southwest side of Jerusalem (Joshua 15:8).

In that valley, in the gorge known as *Topheth*, worshipers performed child sacrifices in the fire (2 Kings 23:10). This site was dedicated to the god Molech, to whom Israel's kings like Ahaz and Manasseh sacrificed their children (2 Chronicles 28:1-3; 2 Chronicles 33:6). The prophets confronted this evil, saying that God would send enemy nations to conquer Jerusalem, and Israel's leaders would be killed and their dead bodies thrown into that valley to be burned (Jeremiah 7:30-33). The fires that those kings started to consume the innocent would one day turn and consume them. While Israel experienced many purifying fires from God for their sins (e.g., Isaiah 1:25, Isaiah 48:10, Jeremiah 9:7, Malachi 3:2-3, Zechariah 13:9.), the act of burning young children as offerings to pagan idols was the most abhorrent of them all. In ancient Israel, Gehenna was essentially synonymous with shame and disgrace, representing a dark and ignominious chapter in Israel's history that led to significant purifying

judgment. For example, Jeremiah said that this place would become "the valley of slaughter," for in that ditch, the Babylonians would dump the corpses of Israelites:

> So beware, the days are coming, declares the Lord, when people will no longer call this place Topheth or the Valley of Ben Hinnom, but the Valley of Slaughter.
>
> Jeremiah 19:6

In later Jewish literature, such as 1 Enoch, which predates the New Testament, the Valley of Hinnom symbolized Israel's purifying punishments. God frequently punished Israel, but the biblical punishments were always for the sake of purification; otherwise, Israel would have long ceased to exist. God's punishment is real, but it is not akin to Calvin's or Luther's ideas of punishment, explicitly enticing to burn and eliminate the Jewish people once and for all.

Jesus, also a prophet of Israel, used these same images of 'fire' and 'Gehenna' to describe horrible evils and shame and God's response to them. God promised He wouldn't let evil go unchecked (Isaiah 13:11, Nahum 1:3, Proverbs 11:21, Jeremiah 25:31, Ezekiel 18:30, Malachi 4:1). Therefore, the fire of God's justice will ultimately consume all evil and remove it from His beloved nation. Likewise, He will purify His creation once and for all (Revelation 21:1-4; 2 Peter 3:3-9).

This Jewish term symbolizing shame and punishment, Gehenna, occurs 12 times in the New Testament and is translated as "hell," misunderstood by many modern readers as an afterlife torturous destination.

The Valley of Unpleasant Odors

The Kidron Valley, now a national park in Jerusalem, encompasses the Valley of Hinnom, also known as Gehenna, within its borders.[148]

The presence of urban garbage dumps, where city residents would burn waste, is widely recognized, although their exact locations have been unclear and debatable. To ensure you are well-informed of the ongoing heated debate, primarily between

Calvinists and non-Calvinists, regarding Hellfire and whether Hinnom was a garbage dump, consider the following: In 2011, Francis Chan, a Calvinist pastor, authored "*Erasing Hell,*" aiming to disprove the garbage dump theory. Subsequently, in 2015, DL Kennedy penned "*Gehenna Revisited: Rebutting Francis Chan*," which sought to counter Chan's claims.

A recent excavation, however, has confirmed the existence of a substantial city garbage dump in the Kidron area:

> The chance discovery of an Early Roman city dump (1st century CE) in Jerusalem has yielded for the first time ever quantitative data on garbage components that introduce us to the mundane daily life Jerusalemites led and the kind of animals that were featured in their diet. Most of the garbage consists of pottery shards, all common tableware, while prestige objects are entirely absent. Other significant garbage components include numerous fragments of cooking ovens, wall plaster, animal bones and plant remains. Of the pottery vessels, cooking pots are the most abundant type. Most of the refuse turns out to be "household garbage" originating in the domestic areas of the city...[149]

Rabbi David Kimhi (1160–1235), in his commentary on Psalms 27:13, noted that fires were perpetually maintained in the valley of Hinnom to consume the waste and corpses deposited there. Likewise, the Jewish Talmud links the location with fire and smoke (Erovin 19).

As with all city dumps, the poor, including lepers, often scavenged through the garbage. The waste and refuse that accumulated were often incinerated to be disposed of. Since there was always someone throwing their trash in this worms' paradise, the fires never ceased.

Quoting Isaiah 66:24, Jesus reminded his audience that:

> Gehenna, where "the worms that eat them do not die, and the fire is not quenched."

Worms do die; however, the metaphorical notion that they never perish is possibly linked to the abundant, continuous "food" (either corpses, garbage, or both) they consume. This could represent the numerous individuals who perished and were cast into the valley at various times in history, both before and after Christ's time.

The central issue is not whether the Valley of Hinnom served as the city's refuse site or merely as a location for discarding dead bodies (as mentioned in Jeremiah 7:31-32, 9:6-7, 19:11-12, and Isaiah 30:33). The significance lies in its symbolism of Israel's disgraceful past and the dire consequences that followed.

Jesus' summoning of Isaiah 66:24 likely evoked memories in the Jewish consciousness of Isaiah and Jeremiah's descriptions of numerous corpses thrown into the Valley of Hinnom during the Babylonian siege.

Jesus wasn't trying to describe some horrific afterlife cosmic scenario but was referring to a place well-known to Jews. A place symbolizing shame, humiliation, degradation, and divine consequences on Israel when failing to walk in God's ways. It was a way for Jesus to warn the nation of Israel of the upcoming repercussions of their failure to repent and change their ways.

American theologian, Edward William Fudge, explains:

> The term conveyed a sense of total horror and disgust...Gehenna was a place of undying worm and irresistible fire, an abhorrent place where crawling maggots and smoldering heat raced each other to consume the putrefying fare served them each day.[150]

Unfortunately, Jesus' caution to Israel became a reality. The first-century historian Josephus documents that, during the Roman siege of Jerusalem, corpses were thrown over the city walls into the adjacent valleys due to the lack of burial space within the city (Jos. War 5.12.3).

Clearly, to first-century Jews, Gehenna was a tangible location infamous for its disgustingness, repulsiveness, and revulsion. It was emblematic of shame and

humiliation, accompanied by images of fire, refuse, and death. It was the same national warning as before, only this time coming from the Prophet of prophets.

To Be Thrown Into Gehenna (Matthew 5:27-29)

Let's examine Matthew 5:27-29 as a case study:

> You have heard that it was said, "You shall not commit adultery." But I tell you that anyone who looks at a woman lustfully has already committed adultery with her in his heart. If your right eye causes you to stumble, gouge it out and throw it away. It is better for you to lose one part of your body than for your whole body to be thrown into Gehenna.
>
> Matthew 5:27-29

What did Jesus mean when he said that men looking at a woman with lust will end up in Gehenna? Was Jesus really promoting self-mutilation and teaching—as some believe—that looking at a woman lustfully will result in eternal punishment in Hellfire?

It's hard for me to imagine that Jesus, who only a few verses earlier said, "*Do not think that I have come to abolish Law or the Prophets*" (5:17), would contradict both himself and Moses in suggesting eternal Hellfire torment for anyone lusting in their mind, a concept utterly foreign to the Law and to Jews.

Clearly, Rabbi Jesus, a master of using parables, symbolism, and metaphors to convey deeper spiritual truths, was speaking figuratively. Otherwise, if we interpret Jesus' words in Matthew 5:29 about plucking out one's eye literally, we face an ethical and theological contradiction, as it seems unimaginable that Jesus would advocate for self-mutilation.

In his commentary on Matthew, theologian Francis Wright Beare points to the challenges in giving a literal interpretation to these words of Jesus:

> If this [Mt. 5:29-30] is to be taken as a 'demand' of Jesus, then it must be said that he is demanding the impossible, for it is the universal experience that the sexual impulses are uncontrollable.[151]
>
> Francis Wright Beare

It is improbable that Jesus was saying that if you were sexually aroused by looking at another person or fantasizing about them, even momentarily, you'd literally end up tortured in Hellfire forever. Jesus likely had children and teenagers—such as his disciples—in his audience.[152] Was he teaching them to literally dismember body parts, like their eyes, to ensure they would be saved from eternal torture in fire? If so, didn't Jesus know we don't need eyes to imagine and fantasize? People who become blind are still capable of lusting in their minds. Would Jesus actually instruct these young men that they would be eternally punished just for having sexual thoughts? Considering that sexual thoughts are a common human experience, why would God design us with these impulses and then imply eternal torture for entertaining them? How could that be considered just? A literal interpretation of Jesus's hyperbolic metaphors in Matthew 5 is nonsensical and misrepresents God's character, yet it does explain some of the religious legalism observed in the world.

Jesus often used hyperbolic language—a common rhetorical technique in Jewish teachings—to emphasize that evil begins with our thoughts. The use of such vivid metaphors was not to instill a fear of eternal damnation for typical human experiences like sexual thoughts but to stress the ethical life choices expected in his teachings. Lust was merely an example of something much bigger. Recognizing that lust is a common human experience his audience would relate to, Jesus highlighted the need for accountability and the pursuit of a higher moral standard, which Israel often failed to uphold. Jesus, knowing that probably all of his listeners lust in their minds, used it to make a point. Remember, Jesus wasn't speaking to a specific individual. His audience was a "crowd of Jews" (verse 1); he was a Prophet addressing the nation of Israel.

Why Threaten With Gehenna?

Suppose you were judged and condemned by society and, therefore, had to scavenge for leftovers in Gehenna to survive; it meant you got to the lowest point in your life—a place of great shame. You've likely lost everything and become an outcast. When New Testament texts using Gehenna are considered,[153] things become even more apparent. Jesus symbolically uses Gehenna to teach about consequences. Imagine the kind of shame people who lived in or scavenged through Gehenna Valley felt—constant shame and embarrassment. For that reason, missing one eye is better "*than to have two eyes and be thrown into the fire of Gehenna*" (Matthew 18:9). Losing a body part is preferable to scavenging for food amidst Gehenna's trash and flames for the rest of your life.

Now, let's connect the dots—If you were an Israelite caught committing adultery, you would either be stoned or become an outcast of society and find yourself living in shame in a dumpster—Gehenna. New Testament scholar N.T. Wright explains:

> When Jesus was warning his hearers about Gehenna, he was not, as a general rule, telling them that unless they repented in this life, they would burn in the next one. As with God's kingdom, so with its opposite: it is on earth that things matter, not somewhere else.[154]
>
> N.T. Wright

Every act of adultery ever committed started with a lustful thought, but not all lustful thoughts led to adultery. Harboring lustful thoughts might lead to dire consequences, as thoughts can manifest into actions. In a rigid religious society, such as that of second-temple Judaism, certain actions may provoke severe repercussions, stripping you of all you hold dear and casting you out to scavenge in the city's dump—Gehenna—as no one is willing to hire or work with you.

God's Gehenna is Restorative

The ability to control one's thoughts is essential, but there's an even deeper lesson to be learned. It was not God who threw individuals into the Valley of Hinnom; it was the people—a hyper-religious society. While God desires that even sinners live with dignity, be rebuilt, and become self-sufficient, it is religious leaders who often cancel, boycott, degrade, and essentially lead sinners into the Valley of Shame.

In contrast, when God witnesses sinners committing adultery, He does not seek to shame or abandon them. How do I know? Well, because when religious people brought a woman caught in adultery before Christ, suggesting she needed to be severely punished, Jesus did the very opposite of what the religious leaders hoped for. He forgave her: *"Then neither do I condemn you,"* Jesus declared. *"Go now and leave your life of sin."* (John 8:11). She did indeed sin. But Jesus did not condemn her. The religious legalists did. Similarly, while some religious individuals may be quick to condemn others to Hellfire, Jesus chose to show grace instead of passing judgment. He recognized that love is a much more potent force for renewing the human heart and conscience than the threat of Hellfire.

Worms and Maggots

Even when we consider the metaphors used, such as worms, who indeed inhabit garbage dumps and consume decaying matter, we can see God's grace. What is often lacking in modern Western thought is the Jewish context. For example, the Talmud (Shabbat 151b) mentions that maggots are formed for the deceased's benefit, indicating their role in the natural decomposition process. This is seen as a component of the life and death cycle established by God. Such a view acknowledges the presence of worms as an integral part of the natural world and essential in the body's return to the earth: *"…till you return to the ground, for out of it you were taken; for you are dust, and to dust you shall return."* (Genesis 3:19)

Worms and maggots play a vital role in our ecosystem, contributing to the decomposition process and facilitating the recycling of nutrients. Historically, worm (larval) therapy has been very successful in treating wounds.[155][156] However, in the modern era, sulfa drugs, also known as sulfur or brimstone drugs, became the popular method for treating infections in the 1940s. This led to the decline of worm therapy, which the public viewed with distaste. Subsequently, antibiotics became the preferred treatment. This all suggests that the predominantly negative view of these metaphors in the modern Western mindset was, in fact, more intricate and nuanced in ancient Israel. The metaphors of fire, sulfur, and brimstone, which we will explore later, are also included in this complexity.

Even if everything I have said so far is false... Even if Gehenna were to be taken literally as an afterlife cosmic fire chamber that endlessly burns people, this interpretation clashes with biblical prophecies. Jeremiah proclaims that one day Gehenna "*will be holy to the Lord*" (Jeremiah 31:40), while the Psalmist envisions it transformed into a place where *"thirsty hearts journey to appear before God in Zion, the valley of Gehenna will become a place of springs"* (Psalm 84:5-7). These passages suggest a restoration and sanctification of Gehenna, not its perpetuation as a place of eternal torment. How, then, could Gehenna be a literal and unending Hellfire if it is destined to become holy and rejuvenated? These Old Testament prophecies seem to directly contradict the idea of Gehenna as a place of eternal suffering in fire, as conceived by adherents of the ECT Hellfire doctrine.

Conclusion

To conclude, in Jewish thought, Gehenna symbolized the severe consequences of straying from God's path. On a national level, this concept represented the tangible loss of divine blessings and protection. On an individual level, it represented the outcome of sin, especially in an unforgiving religious society. As a result, those who deviated faced vulnerability and adversity, akin to being left to fend for themselves in a desolate wasteland. Jesus used Gehenna both as a reminder and a threat for Israel —Your enemies will consume you, and you will be left to scavenge in the ruins.

Akin to the prophets of Israel before him, Jesus issued a direct warning to Israel: Turn away from your evil ways, or you will once again be consumed by Gehenna's flames, scavenging through the ashes to survive. His admonition to Israel was a tangible threat. This prophecy's fulfillment began 40 years later, starting in 70 AD, after a relentless five-month siege, with the Romans razing Jerusalem and the Second Temple. Rome decimated Jerusalem, killing and reducing the people of Israel to starvation amidst the ruins. According to first-century historian Josephus, over one million people, mostly Jews, were killed during the siege, with many corpses thrown into Gehenna.[157]

"Eternal" Punishment

Justice demands punishment; without it, crimes such as murder and theft would go unchecked, leading to chaos and lawlessness. Retribution is a necessary deterrent to maintain order and protect society.

While the opposite extreme of ECT hellfire are those who do not anticipate any form of punishment in the afterlife, to me, the gravity of certain human actions implies that consequences are unavoidable. It is unknown, and perhaps unknowable, what measures will be taken and against whom. However, suppose we entertain the notion of a period of correction for at least some actions or individuals. In that case, we must then consider the nature of this process, its intent, and its duration. This chapter will primarily focus on the concept of duration.

The Biblical Concept of Time

One of the risks in interpreting an ancient Jewish Middle Eastern text—the Bible—from a Western perspective is the anachronism fallacy, which involves injecting modern ideas into the ancient text. This issue becomes particularly apparent when considering the concept of time. In Western philosophy, eternity is a subject of extensive debate, but the concept, as understood today, essentially does not exist in the Near Eastern biblical context.

The concept of hell as a place of abusive torment with no end has been a cornerstone of a few Christian denominations, including the Baptist, Calvinist,

Fundamental Evangelicalism, Pentecostal, and other conservative Protestant and Catholic groups for centuries. This view has deeply influenced the religious worldview of individuals and churches alike. However, a careful study of the original languages of the Bible—Greek and Hebrew—reveals significant nuances in the terms translated as "eternal" or "everlasting." These terms, when properly understood, challenge the view of hell as an endless state of punishment.

According to the Interpreter's Dictionary of the Bible:

> **Time:** The Old Testament and the New Testament are not acquainted with the conception of eternity as timelessness. The Old Testament has not developed a special term for "eternity." The word *aion* originally meant "vital force," "life," then "age," "lifetime."
>
> The Interpreter's Dictionary of the Bible (vol. IV, p. 641-655)

The 19th-century theologian Charles Ellicott explains:

> ***Everlasting punishment–life eternal*:** The two adjectives represent the same Greek word, *aionios*-it must be admitted that the Greek word which is rendered "eternal" does not, in itself, involve endlessness, but rather, duration, whether through an age or succession of ages, and that it is therefore applied in the New Testament to periods of time that have had both a beginning and ending.
>
> Commentary on the Whole Bible (Matt. 25:46)

In James Hasting's Dictionary of the New Testament, it says:

> ***Eternity***: There is no word either in the Old Testament Hebrew or the New Testament Greek to express the abstract idea of eternity.[158]
>
> James Hasting

In the Encyclopedic Dictionary of the Bible, it is written:

> ***ETERNITY***: The Bible hardly speaks of eternity in the philosophical sense of infinite duration without beginning or end. The Hebrew word *OLAM*, which is used alone (Ps. 61:8; etc.) or with various prepositions (Gen. 3:22; etc.) in contexts where it is traditionally translated as 'forever,' means in itself no more than *"for an indefinitely long period."* Thus *OLAM* does not mean 'from eternity' but 'of old' Gen. 6:4; etc. In the New Testament *aion* is used as the equivalent of *olam.* [159]
>
> Encyclopedic Dictionary of the Bible

Richard Francis Weymouth, Doctor of Literature and a Bible translator, explains:

> **Eternal**: Greek: *"aeonion,"* i.e., *"of the ages."* Etymologically this adjective, like others similarly formed, does not signify *"during,"* but *"belong to"* the aeons or ages. [160]
>
> R. F. Weymouth

Theologian and Professor Herman Oldhausen says:

> The Bible has no expression for endlessness. All the Biblical terms imply or denote long periods. [161]
>
> Herman Oldhausen

Professor Knappe of Halle wrote:

> The Hebrew was destitute of any single word to express endless duration. The pure idea of eternity is not found in any of the ancient languages. [162]

Knappe of Halle

Charles H. Welch, editor of The Berean Expositor:

> Eternity is not a Biblical theme...What we have to learn is that the Bible does not speak of eternity. It is not written to tell us of eternity. Such a consideration is entirely outside the scope of revelation.[163]
>
> Charles H. Welch

G. Campbell Morgan, a British Doctor of Divinity and a conservative pastor who was the president of Cheshunt College in Cambridge wrote:

> Let me say to Bible students that we must be very careful how we use the word 'eternity.' We have fallen into great error in our constant usage of that word. There is no word in the whole Book of God corresponding with our eternal.[164]
>
> Campbell Morgan

OLAM

The Hebrew word *"OLAM"* is crucial in understanding the temporal nature of many biblical concepts, sometimes translated or interpreted as eternal. While "olam" is often translated as "forever" or "eternal" in some English versions of the Bible, a closer examination reveals that it generally means '**an age**' or '**agelong.**' A long duration without necessarily implying an infinite, unending span of time. Incidentally, even in contemporary Hebrew, "*OLAM* imprisonment," or a *life sentence*, spans only 25 years (17 years with good behavior). Not "everlasting."

The term *Olam* is frequently used in the Hebrew Scriptures in contexts that clearly indicate a finite period, further supporting the argument against the concept of eternal hellfire. Below are a few examples.

Jonah 2:6

> To the roots of the mountains I sank down; the earth beneath barred me in forever [*olam*]. But you, LORD my God, brought my life up from the pit.
>
> Jonah 2:6, NIV

In this verse, Jonah describes his experience in the belly of the fish, using the word *"olam"* to convey the seemingly interminable nature of his ordeal. However, we know from the narrative that Jonah was in the fish for three days and three nights (Jonah 1:17). The use of *"olam"* here underscores a period that felt exceedingly long to Jonah but was finite. This example illustrates how *"olam"* can describe an experience that is intense and seemingly endless but ultimately limited in duration.

Isaiah 32:14-15

> Because the palaces will be forsaken, the bustling city will be deserted. The forts and towers will become lairs forever [*olam*], a joy of wild donkeys, a pasture of flocks—Until the Spirit is poured upon us from on high, and the wilderness becomes a fruitful field, and the fruitful field is counted as a forest.
>
> Isaiah 32:14-15, NKJV

In this prophecy, Isaiah uses "*olam*" to describe the desolation of cities and palaces, implying a long period of abandonment. However, this state of desolation is clearly

finite, as it is set to last *"until the Spirit is poured upon us from on high."* The prophecy foresees a time when the wilderness will become a fruitful field, indicating a restoration that ends the "*olam*" of desolation. Here, "*olam*" conveys a significant but temporary period.

Leviticus 24:8

> Every Sabbath day Aaron shall arrange it before the LORD regularly;
> it is from the people of Israel as a covenant forever [*olam*].
>
> Leviticus 24:8, ESV

The context here is the showbread in the Tabernacle, in which the priests are to set out every Sabbath as a part of an "everlasting" (*olam*) covenant. This practice, which no longer takes place, was part of the Mosaic Law, which, according to later prophets (e.g., Jeremiah 31:31-32) and the New Testament (Hebrews 8:7-13), was fulfilled and replaced by the New Covenant through Jesus Christ. Thus, the "forever" was indeed long-lasting but not infinite, ending with the advent of the New Covenant. This demonstrates how "*olam*" refers to a covenantal period that, while enduring, is not eternal.

Ecclesiastes 1:4

> A generation goes and a generation comes, But the earth remains
> forever (*olam*).
>
> Ecclesiastes 1:4, NASB

Solomon's reflection in Ecclesiastes uses *"olam"* to describe the enduring nature of the earth. However, other biblical passages suggest that the current heavens and earth will eventually be replaced by a new creation (2 Peter 3:10-13, Revelation 21:1).

Therefore, *"olam"* in this context highlights the earth's long-lasting stability relative to human generations, but not an eternal unchangeability. This usage reinforces the idea that *"olam"* signifies an extended but finite duration.

Jeremiah 25:9

> "I will summon all the peoples of the north and my servant Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon," declares the LORD, "and I will bring them against this land and its inhabitants and against all the surrounding nations. I will completely destroy them and make them an object of horror and scorn, and an everlasting [*olam*] ruin.
>
> Jeremiah 25:9, NIV

In this passage, Jeremiah uses *"olam"* to describe the desolation that will come upon the land and the servitude of the king of Babylon. Here, *"olam"* refers to a period of seventy years, demonstrating once again that "olam" signifies a significant but finite period. This prophecy further illustrates that *"olam"* does not inherently mean an unending duration, as the desolation and servitude in chapter 25 are explicitly limited to seventy years.

Daniel 7:18

> But the holy ones of the Most High shall receive the kingdom and possess the kingdom forever [*olam*]—forever [*olam*] and ever [*olam*].
>
> Daniel 7:18, NRSV

Daniel's vision describes the saints' possession of the kingdom as *"for olam—for olam and olam,"* using the Aramaic equivalent of 'olam' **three** consequent times. In

contemporary understanding, this phrase might be translated as *'for an age, and another age, and another age,'* or *'for all ages,'* suggesting a continuation through multiple distinct periods. The repetition of 'olam' thrice, rather than a singular instance, could imply a progression or extension that goes 'on and on and on,' hyperbolically describing eternity. This stylistic choice might have been used to emphasize the concept of continuity beyond a typical duration, indicating a perpetual succession of ages that collectively approach the idea of eternity. This could possibly be the sole instance in the Scriptures where the concept of eternity is referenced.

Conclusion

The Hebrew word "*olam*," sometimes mistakenly translated as "forever," "everlasting," or "eternal," more accurately denotes an age or a long, yet finite, period. The various biblical examples illustrate that "*olam*" encompasses durations that are significant and enduring but ultimately limited. Recognizing this nuance is essential for accurately interpreting biblical texts and understanding the nature of divine promises and judgments. This understanding is particularly relevant in the discussion of hell, where the term "eternal" may have been traditionally misapplied, obscuring the true nature of God's judgment, justice, and mercy.

Aion and Aionios

The Greek words "*AION*" (αἰών) or "*AIONIOS*" (αἰώνιος) translate the Hebrew word "*olam*." They are used in the Septuagint (Greek translation of the Old Testament) for '*olam*' and New Testament writings. *"Aion"* means "age," referring to a specific period with a beginning and an end. *"Aionios,"* derived from *"aion,"* describes something pertaining to an age.

Strong's Concordance explains:

aión: a space of time, an age
Definition: a space of time, an age
Usage: an age, a cycle (of time), especially of the present age as contrasted with the future age, and of one of a series of ages stretching to infinity.

Strong's 165

HELPS Word-Studies explains:

aiŏn (see also the cognate adjective, 166 /aiōnios, "age-long") – properly, an age (era, "time-span"), characterized by a specific quality (type of existence).

HELPS, 165

Importantly, much like 'olam,' these words do not inherently mean "without end" or "eternal" in the sense of unending time. For example, Romans 16:25-26 states:

> Now to him who is able to establish you in accordance with my gospel, the message I proclaim about Jesus Christ, in keeping with the revelation of the mystery hidden for long ages [aionios] past, but now revealed and made known...
>
> Romans 16:25-26, NIV

The term "aionios" refers to a secret kept for ages, not eternally.

This does not mean aion-aionios can never mean "time with no end," but it would be the exception and is limited by context. Much like with Daniel 7:18, Ephesians 3:21 seems to indicate eternity by the repetitive *"all generations, forever and ever"*:

> To him be glory in the church and in Christ Jesus throughout all generations, forever and ever. Amen.
>
> Ephesians 3:21, NIV

This doxology expresses "aion" in a plural form, often translated as "forever and ever" but literally meaning "to the ages of the ages." This phrasing might suggest a succession of ages or periods, each with its start and end but extending into a horizon beyond human comprehension. This stylistic choice might have been used to emphasize the concept of continuity beyond a typical duration, indicating a perpetual succession of ages that collectively approach the idea of eternity.

Misinterpretations and Translation Bias

The terms *aion* and *aionios* have historically been subject to various interpretations and biases in translation, often reflecting the theological predispositions of translators rather than the intrinsic meaning of the words. This issue is not just a matter of linguistic accuracy but also influences theological beliefs and how we view God's character.

Early translations of the Bible, including the Septuagint and the Latin Vulgate, had to grapple with how to represent Hebrew and Greek concepts of time and duration. Due to Roman philosophical influences on the concept of eternity, translators' choices have echoed through centuries in various Christian doctrines. For example, Jerome's Latin Vulgate (4th-century Latin translation of the Bible initiated by the Roman Catholic church) often used the Latin word *"aeternum"* to translate aionios, a choice that implied an unending state. This has significantly shaped Western Christian thought, where "eternal" is understood as everlasting.

For this and other reasons, scholars have debated the interpretation of words like "aion" and "aionios" as "eternal" in many English translations. Some translations, such as Young's Literal Translation and the Concordant Literal Translation, choose terms like "age-during" or "eon" to more accurately reflect the original meanings. These

choices highlight the variability in understanding these key terms and suggest that eternal punishment is not an inherent concept in the original texts.

Augustine of Hippo

The interpretation of *aion* and *aionios* has been heavily influenced by Platonic and later Neoplatonic thought, which viewed time as a degraded form of eternity. This philosophical overlay added a layer of infinity to the term that was not necessarily present in its original context.

Augustine of Hippo, widely known to be influenced by Neoplatonism,[165] argued that because God is eternal, any attribute of God, including punishments or rewards, must also be eternal in the sense of being timeless and unending.

Influenced by Neoplatonism, Augustine's argument that God's eternal nature necessitates eternal punishment commits the Fallacy of Equivocation by conflating God's timeless existence with the finite nature of human sins, leading to the mistaken conclusion that finite actions deserve infinite punishment. This reasoning undermines the principles of justice and proportionality and misrepresents God's nature as infinitely vengeful rather than just and merciful. Additionally, Augustine's argument commits the fallacy of False Analogy by assuming that because God's attributes, like love and justice, are eternal, their expression must also be eternal in the same way. This overlooks the finite and temporal nature of human life and the principle of proportional justice.

Augustine argued that because "aionios" was used for both *life* and *punishment* in Matthew 25:46, both must be eternal. However, this interpretation fails to recognize that the duration of "aionios" is contingent upon the subject it modifies. For instance, "aionios" life refers to the life of the age to come, while "aionios" punishment refers to corrective measures within a defined period.

Augustine's views were far from being universally accepted. The Eastern Orthodox Church, for example, rejected Augustine's new interpretation and continued to retain a more nuanced view of time, the afterlife, and punishment, often focusing on the transformative and purifying aspects of divine judgment. This divergence illustrates

that Augustine's doctrine of eternal punishment was not a settled matter even in the early centuries of Christianity.

During the Middle Ages, the doctrine of eternal hellfire became more entrenched, partly due to the works of influential theologians like Thomas Aquinas, who systematized Catholic theology. The medieval church used the fear of eternal damnation as a tool for moral manipulation and herd control, emphasizing the horrors of hellfire in sermons and art.

The Protestant Reformation brought renewed scrutiny to many established doctrines, including the nature of hell. Reformers like Martin Luther and John Calvin challenged the Catholic church's use of fear and the sale of indulgences as a means to manipulate the faithful. However, they did not reform the Catholic view on hellfire.

In modern times, several translations and scholars have recognized the need to correct the mistranslations of *"aionios"* and *"olam."* For instance, in Young's Literal Translation, Robert Young consistently translated *"aionios"* as *"age-during"* to reflect its true meaning. Likewise, the Rotherham text also chose *"age-abiding"* for *"aionios,"* aligning with the context of the original texts, and Concordant Literal Translation renders *"aionios"* as *"eonian,"* emphasizing its association with ages rather than eternity.

Aïdios

In Koine Greek, the term that most closely implies "forever" or "eternal" in the sense of endless duration is "ἀΐδιος" (aïdios). This term is possibly used to describe something that is truly everlasting and without end (as opposed to *"aionios"*). For instance:

> For since the creation of the world God's invisible qualities—his *eternal* [*aïdios*] power and divine nature—have been clearly seen, being understood from what has been made, so that people are without excuse.
>
> Romans 1:20. NIV

Also:

> And the angels who did not keep their positions of authority but abandoned their proper dwelling—these he has kept in darkness, bound with *everlasting* (*aïdios*) chains for judgment on the great Day.
>
> Jude 1:6, NIV

As evident, while *"aion"* and *"aionios"* refer to a long, indefinite period of time, *"aïdios"* is used less frequently in the New Testament but carries a more explicit connotation of possibly endless duration. If the authors of the New Testament had intended to convey that hell was eternal, they likely would have used the term *"aïdios,"* which they did not.

Kolasis

The other word in question in *"Eternal **punishment**"* is the word "kolasis," translated as "punishment." The Greek word "κολασις" (*kolasis*) carries a profound significance that has often been overlooked in translations of biblical texts. Originally, "kolasis" was used in the context of chastisement and correction, and even in horticulture, it refers to the pruning of plants. In this sense, pruning involves cutting off certain parts of a plant to correct its growth, ensuring that the plant remains healthy and productive. This punitive process may be viewed as a corrective punishment, not with the intent of being wholly destructive, as in "to torture and kill," but rather with the aim of providing chastisement and discipline.

For instance, the works of the philosopher Plato often reference "kolasis" in discussions about justice and moral education.[166] In his dialogues, Plato suggests that true punishment (*kolasis*) aims to reform the offender, thereby restoring them to a state of moral and social health. Rather than mere retribution, this perspective aligns closely with the original horticultural meaning of the term, emphasizing correction and rehabilitation, which is impossible if the punishment is endless.

Likewise, in "*Gorgias*," Plato discusses the concept of punishment and justice, highlighting that punishment (*kolasis*) should be remedial.[167] He contrasts it with retribution (τιμωρια), which is punishment for the sake of satisfying the anger or desire for vengeance of the one who punishes. Likewise, Aristotle[168] distinguishes between different types of punishment, noting that "*kolasis*" is administered for the sake of the one who is being punished, to correct their behavior, as opposed to punitive actions taken for the sake of retribution or deterrence.

In other words, *kolasis* was perceived as a form of punishment that was both temporary and corrective.

If we take "*kolasis*" to mean corrective punishment, the implication is that the kolasis punishment described in the New Testament is intended to bring about correction and, ultimately, restoration. This understanding aligns with the broader biblical themes of redemption and reconciliation. By viewing divine punishment as corrective, we gain a deeper appreciation for the nature of God's justice and mercy, which aims not at mere retribution but at ultimate restoration. For instance, in 1 John 4:18, *Kolasis* implies correction and improvement, not unending torment:

> There is no fear in love; but perfect love casts out fear, because fear involves ***kolasis***. But he who fears has not been made perfect in love.
>
> 1 John 4:18, NKJV

Therefore, instead of "eternal punishment," it could be argued that Jesus' words might be better translated as "an age of corrective punishment."

Conclusion

Augustine's interpretation of *"aionios"* as eternal set a precedent that influenced Western Christianity—primarily Catholic and Protestant—for centuries. However, his lack of proficiency in Greek led to significant misunderstandings perpetuated in later theological developments.

Unfortunately, many popular English translations render "*kolasin aionion*" as *"eternal punishment."* However, literal translations such as Young's "The Concordant," Weymouth, or Yale's "The New Testament: A Translation" render these words "*an age-long chastisement*" or "*the discipline of that age.*"

Consistency in translation is crucial for accurately conveying the meaning of biblical texts. Variations in translating *aion* and *aionios* across different Bible passages have led to inconsistencies in how readers understand the concept of time in scripture. The translation of *aionios* as "forever" in one context and "age-lasting" in another can confuse readers and lead to contradictory interpretations of scripture, affecting theological conclusions about the nature and duration of divine judgment.

The Sheep and Goats (Matthew 25:31-46)

In Matthew 25, Jesus presents three parables: The Parable of the Ten Virgins (verses 1-13), The Parable of the Bags of Gold (verses 14-28), and the one we focus on today, The Parable of the Sheep and the Goats (verses 31-46). Some, Augustine himself included, interpret a section of this parable (verses 41-46) as evidence allegedly supporting the Augustinian-Calvinist Hellfire. Let's read the entire parable:

When the Son of Man comes in his glory, and all the angels with him, he will sit on his glorious throne. All the nations will be gathered before him, and he will separate the people one from another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the goats. He will put the sheep on his right and the goats on his left. Then the King will say to those on his right, "Come, you who are blessed by my Father; take your inheritance, the kingdom prepared for you since the creation of the world. For I was hungry and you gave me something to eat, I was thirsty and you gave me something to drink, I was a stranger and you invited me in, I needed clothes and you clothed me, I was sick and you looked after me, I was in prison and you came to visit me."

Then the righteous will answer him, "Lord, when did we see you hungry and feed you, or thirsty and give you something to drink? When did we see you a stranger and invite you in, or needing clothes and clothe you? When did we see you sick or in prison and go to visit you?"

The King will reply, "Truly I tell you, whatever you did for one of the least of these brothers and sisters of mine, you did for me."

Then he will say to those on his left, "Depart from me, you who are cursed, into the *aiōnion [age-long]* fire prepared for the devil and his angels. For I was hungry and you gave me nothing to eat, I was thirsty and you gave me nothing to drink, I was a stranger and you did not invite me in, I needed clothes and you did not clothe me, I was sick and in prison and you did not look after me." They also will answer, "Lord, when did we see you hungry or thirsty or a stranger or needing clothes or sick or in prison, and did not help you?"

> He will reply, "Truly I tell you, whatever you did not do for one of the least of these, you did not do for me." Then they will go away to aiōnion punishment, but the righteous to aiōnion life.

Firstly, it's important to recognize that this, like the preceding two, is a parable, not a historiographical account of events.

Secondly, it is significant that Jesus' warnings are not aimed at those with flawed Soteriology or Christology or at those completely devoid of faith in him. Instead, Jesus cautions those who show indifference to society's marginalized, impoverished, and needy individuals. Furthermore, the initial audience and critique of the parable were directed not at the secular, non-believing society, but rather at the religious community.

Thirdly, verse 32 states that *"the nations will be gathered before him."* Nations cannot "burn in hell," but they can collapse and be consumed by enemies in an "everlasting fire," similar to empires that were permanently destroyed. Historically,

the downfall of nations that neglected their poor and needy often foreshadowed their eventual destruction.

According to Abbott's An Analytical Study of Words:

> Matthew 25:31-46 concerns the judgment of NATIONS, not individuals. It is to be distinguished from other judgments mentioned in Scripture. [169]

Fourthly, the text lacks a redemptive quality. There is no apparent indication of post-mortem salvation within the entire context of the parable. If it were about salvation from hell, it would suggest that salvation comes not through faith—which is never mentioned in the text—but through deeds, such as visiting prisons and clothing the homeless. This presents a dilemma for proponents of the Augustinian-Calvinist concept of eternal damnation. If the text indeed refers to torment in hellfire, it appears to be contingent not on faith but on actions, a concept at odds with the Reformed doctrine of *sola fide* ("by faith alone").

The Sheep and the Goats

As everyone over here in the Middle East can testify, sheep are way cuter (and tastier) than goats. However, these are not the primary distinctions between the two. The key to understanding this parable and who the goats are lies in, of course, the Hebrew Scriptures. Ezekiel 34 similarly employs the sheep and goats metaphor:

> Son of man, prophesy against the shepherds of Israel; prophesy and say to them: "This is what the Sovereign Lord says: Woe to you shepherds of Israel who only take care of yourselves! Should not shepherds take care of the flock?"...As for you, my flock, this is what the Sovereign Lord says: "I will judge between one sheep and another, and between rams and goats."

Ezekiel 34:2, 17

Ezekiel's parable is not a contrast between believers ascending to heaven and seculars descending into hellfire but rather a critique of Israel's leadership and their poor stewardship.

Similarly, Zechariah 10:3 underscores the theme of selfishness represented by the shepherds/goats (the mention of 'goats' is oddly missing from the popular NIV and ESV):

> Mine anger was kindled against the shepherds, and I punished the goats: for the LORD of hosts hath visited his flock the house of Judah, and hath made them as his goodly horse in the battle.
>
> Zechariah 10:3, KJV

Like the prophets who preceded him, Jesus' parables of judgment target Israel and its religious leaders. This aligns with the role of Hebrew prophets, who held Israel's leadership accountable for their stewardship of the flock entrusted to them, especially regarding the poor, widows, and orphans.

In the same vein, only two chapters earlier (Matthew 23), Jesus sharply reproaches the leadership of Israel, using the same language of "woes" that Ezekiel employs to denounce those who neglect their duty to the flock.

His original audience clearly understood the target of Jesus' parables as a criticism being directed at Israel's religious leaders:

> When the chief priests and the Pharisees heard Jesus' parables, they understood that he was speaking about them.
>
> Matthew 21:45

Conversely, interpreting these parables as addressing unbelievers vs. believers (In what? Jesus hadn't even died yet) rather than critiquing the leadership's treatment of the poor and needy misrepresents their broader context. Jesus, the ultimate prophet

of Israel, judged the house of Israel, particularly its leadership. This insight is further reinforced by Jesus's other parables.

Matthew 21 further supports this interpretation:

> Therefore I say to you, the kingdom of God will be taken away from you and given to a people producing its fruit…When the chief priests and the Pharisees heard Jesus' parables, they knew he was talking about them.
>
> Matthew 21:43,45

Indeed, Jesus entrusted the keys to the Kingdom to his Jewish followers, effectively transferring God's presence from man-made Jewish sects to one made by Jesus himself. Acts 2:42-47 illustrates that the first church consisted predominantly of Israeli Jews. This counters the notion of Replacement Theology; God did not replace Israel with the Gentiles but instead created a new Jewish denomination into which Gentiles were later integrated (Acts 15, Romans 11).

In summary, a shepherd does not torture his goats with fire or kill them when they are annoying; rather, he disciplines them. Goats may symbolize wicked leadership, bad nations, or both—subject to individual interpretation—destined to endure disciplinary punishment.

Verse 46 in earlier Bible translations:

The topic of "eternal punishment" (kolasin aionion) was addressed in another chapter; however, consider how Matthew 25:46 has been rendered in previous Bible translations.

The New Covenant by Dr. J.W. Hanson, 1884:

> And these shall go away into onian chastisement, and the just into onian life.

Young's Literal Translation of the Holy Bible, 1898:

> And these shall go away to punishment age-during, but the righteous to life age-during.

The Holy Bible in Modern English, 1903:

> And these He will dismiss into a long correction, but the well-doers to an enduring life.

The People's New Covenant, 1925:

> And these will depart into age-continuing correction, but the righteous, into age-continuing life.

The New Testament, a Translation, 1938:

> And these will go away into eonian correction, but the righteous into eonian life.

Rotherham Emphasized Bible, 1959:

> And these shall go away into age-abiding correction, But the righteous into age-abiding life.

The Restoration of Original Sacred Name Bible, 1976:

> And these shall go away into age-abiding correction, but the righteous into age-abiding life.

The New Testament, A New Translation, 1980:

> Then they will begin to serve a new period of suffering, but God's faithful will enter upon their heavenly life.

With more than 900 translations of the Bible in English, it's always beneficial to explore multiple versions to gain a broader understanding. For more insights on Bible hermeneutics, consider exploring my book: "*Read Like a Jew: 8 Rules of Basic Bible Interpretation for the Christian.*"

Outer Darkness, Weeping and Gnashing of Teeth

Indeed, when these metaphors are taken literally and out of context, their imagery might appear quite terrifying, akin to a vivid depiction of the Augustinian-Calvinist hellfire:

> But the subjects of the kingdom will be thrown outside, into the darkness, where there will be **weeping and gnashing of teeth**.
>
> Matthew 8:12

> They will throw them into the blazing furnace, where there will be **weeping and gnashing of teeth**.
>
> Matthew 13:42

> Then the king told the attendants, "Tie him hand and foot, and throw him outside, into the darkness, where there will be **weeping and gnashing of teeth**."
>
> Matthew 22:13

Many Christians envision Hellfire as a place where millions perpetually weep and gnash their teeth day and night forever and ever. I hope they will have sufficient hydration to replenish their bodily fluids and that their teeth, which would otherwise

require monthly replacement, will be silicone or steel. I also hope they have some decent dentists there.

Jokes aside, we must not take these metaphors literally. Otherwise, in Matthew 22:13, *"outer darkness"* is referred to as the place of weeping and gnashing of teeth, while in Matthew 13:50, Jesus calls that same place *"a furnace of fire."* Again, if we interpret these passages literally, we have a contradiction because fire produces light in contrast with complete darkness.

According to the Physics Department at the University of Illinois:

> We usually keep the name "flame" for something that's burning and giving off light. If we use the word that way, there can't be a black flame, since "black" means that no visible light is coming from it. [170]

Let's continue to take the literal line of thinking further. If we look at the context of Matthew 13, we see that it actually rejects ECT in hellfire and supports annihilation: *"Just as the weeds are gathered and burned with fire, so will it be at the end of the age."* (verse 40). When a weed is burned, it leaves nothing. Again, if taken literally, this contradicts the idea of eternal torment and supports the view of annihilation.

However, suppose I wasn't convincing enough. In that same chapter, Matthew 13, it is also mentioned that *"Jesus spoke all these things to the crowds in parables. He did not say anything to them without using a parable."* (Matthew 13:34). Thus, it might be wise to take Matthew's advice and interpret these as metaphors.

Wise people, especially rabbis, often speak using metaphors and parables. It is the uninformed who misunderstand and take their words literally:

> This is why I speak to them in parables: Though seeing, they do not see; though hearing, they do not hear or understand.
>
> Matthew 13:13

The uninformed were, ironically, the most religious people on the planet. Nevertheless, the ensuing question is, what exactly do these metaphors represent—not to us but to the original Jewish hearers?

Gnashing of Teeth

By now, you might not be surprised to hear that the phrase "gnashing of teeth" already appears in the Hebrew Scriptures in contexts beyond pain or abuse, often symbolizing envy, anguish, despair, or frustration.

Psalm 35:16 says, *"With godless mockery they gnashed their teeth at me."* Here, the gnashing of teeth is depicted as an expression of animosity and derision from King David's enemies. The enemies are portrayed as mocking him while gnashing their teeth. This usage emphasizes the extreme disdain and viciousness of the mockers, possibly stemming from feelings of great jealousy towards the king.

Psalm 37:12 says, *"The wicked plot against the righteous and gnash their teeth at them."* In these verses, the wicked are depicted gnashing their teeth at the righteous as they conspire against them. Here, the gnashing of teeth seems to symbolize envy and jealousy.

Psalm 112:10 contrasts the righteous and the wicked: *"The wicked man will see and be vexed, he will gnash his teeth and waste away; the desire of the wicked will perish."* In this verse, gnashing of teeth symbolizes the frustration and helpless rage of the wicked, again possibly stemming from jealousy as they witness the success and blessedness of the righteous. They are consumed by envy, leading them to gnash their teeth.

In all these instances, "gnashing of teeth" is associated with strong negative emotions, possibly envy, jealousy, and frustration. It reflects intense mental and emotional responses rather than physical pain. These contexts provide a richer understanding of the term when it appears in the New Testament, particularly in describing the fate of the wicked in eschatological judgments. Rather than indicating eternal torment in fire, it suggests a state of profound emotional and psychological distress that possibly resembles the feelings of envy, jealousy, or regret.

Likewise, in Acts 7:54, some of the *"members of the Sanhedrin"* were frustrated by what Stephen had said and "*gnashed their teeth at him."*

In conclusion, the biblical term "gnashing of teeth" appears to be unrelated to physical suffering or torment but rather symbolizes intense emotions like envy,

jealousy, regret, or frustration. Perhaps "gnashing of teeth" can be best understood as the ancient version of FOMO:

> Fear of missing out (FOMO) is the feeling of apprehension that one is either not in the know about or missing out on information, events, experiences, or life decisions that could make one's life better.
>
> "Fear of missing out (FOMO)", Wikipedia

Have you ever been offered an early opportunity to invest in Bitcoin, only to scoff at the idea and later realize you missed out on becoming a millionaire? That regret, symbolized by the gnashing of teeth, is what we call FOMO, or the Fear of Missing Out. The emotional sting comes from recognizing what you could have achieved had you made different decisions in the past.

This is not about people trembling because they are whipped endlessly in hellfire. Rather, it's about the regret—by Christians too—over the rewards and honor they could have secured had they chosen differently in life.

In biblical terms, this concept possibly refers to individuals who missed their opportunity to accumulate significant rewards in God's kingdom. In this life, you have a unique opportunity to gather rewards and treasures that will await you in the world to come. You can spend your money on a luxury boat, but you can also "invest" in your spiritual future by, for instance, feeding the poor, building wells for the less fortunate, or supporting a struggling, cheeky Bible scholar in Israel. This spiritual investment is likely to yield far greater returns in your eternal future:

> Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moths and vermin destroy, and where thieves break in and steal. But store up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where moths and vermin do not destroy, and where thieves do not break in and steal. For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.
>
> Matthew 6:19-21

When you give to the needy, do not let your left hand know what your right hand is doing, so that your giving may be in secret. Then your Father, who sees what is done in secret, will reward you.

Matthew 6:3-4

Jesus answered, "If you want to be perfect, go, sell your possessions and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven."

Matthew 19:21

Look, I am coming soon! My reward is with me, and I will give to each person according to what they have done.

Revelation 22:12

Consider also: Matthew 5:12, 6:1-4, 6:19-21, 10:42, 18:4, 19:21, 20:26-28, 25:21 25:34-40; Mark 9:41, 10:29-30; Luke 6:22-23, 12:33-34, 18:22; Revelation 22:12.

One day, the stingy, mean, unkind, uncaring, unempathetic, and arrogant will gnash their teeth in regret. In contrast, those who are lovingly sacrificial, kind, generous, caring, empathetic, and understanding will inherit all the blessings the Kingdom has to offer. Yes, it's that simple![171]

It is my personal belief that in the future Kingdom, much like in our worldly ones, there will be a variety of roles and hierarchical positions. It is, after all, God's Kingdom, not a communist country. Many Christians will have had the opportunity to secure—not their salvation from hellfire—but an elevated status in this forthcoming Kingdom through acts of sacrifices, generosity, and kindness. When they eventually recognize that their malevolent and self-centered deeds have relegated them to the lowest echelon in the impending Kingdom, they will gnash their teeth in remorse. This anguish will be so profound that it will, metaphorically, sear their hearts like an unquenchable flame, for there will be no further chances to ascend the ranks. Spiritually, this is the ultimate Fear of Missing Out.

Outer Darkness

In the Old Testament, the term "darkness" has multiple meanings depending on the context. It can signify despair, ignorance, or the state of being excluded from God's protection and blessings. For instance, the Torah parallels lack of prosperity and misfortune with darkness:

> And you shall grope at noonday, as a blind man gropes in darkness; you shall not prosper in your ways; you shall be only oppressed and plundered continually, and no one shall save you.
>
> Deuteronomy 28:29

In the New Testament, the term *"outer darkness"* metaphorically represents exclusion. It is depicted as an exclusion from a vibrant banquet or celebration. Envision an ancient town in first-century Israel where, at night, darkness envelops all but one place—a radiant banquet hall in the center of the town square. In ancient times, much like today, banquets and celebrations were celebrated at night, often offering the only source of light in the area.

Being outside a kingdom at night during those ancient days meant complete darkness, as there were no modern light sources or electricity. Thus, being in the *"outer darkness"* symbolized being excluded from the joyful, light-filled celebration. This state is described as one of "weeping and gnashing of teeth," indicating profound frustration, perhaps stemming from the regret of those left out of the party. This image bears a resemblance to the contemporary expression "being kept in the dark." Missing out on a party, however, does not mean that you will be tortured in fire forever. It simply means you were not considered worthy to be invited to the banquet.

Conclusion

The images discussed, like that of gnashing of teeth or outer darkness, convey the emotional and spiritual distress associated with being excluded from the most significant celebration imaginable. It is akin to the feelings of isolation and desolation one might experience when not invited to an important social gathering while feeling they deserve to partake.

If the link between celebrations and darkness seems unclear, reflect on the employment of these metaphors in Jesus' parable:

> Then he said to his servants, "The wedding banquet is ready, but those I invited did not deserve to come. So go to the street corners and invite to the banquet anyone you find." So the servants went out into the streets and gathered all the people they could find, the bad as well as the good, and the wedding hall was filled with guests. “But when the king came in to see the guests, he noticed a man there who was not wearing wedding clothes. He asked, "How did you get in here without wedding clothes, friend?" The man was speechless. Then the king told the attendants, "Tie him hand and foot, and throw him outside, into the darkness, where there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth. For many are invited, but few are chosen.”
>
> Matthew 22:8-14

An invitation is extended to all, but only the deserving—represented by wedding garments—will be found worthy to dine and dance in the grand festivity. In Middle Eastern tradition, such celebratory imagery is not associated with hellfire but rather signifies esteemed roles, honor, dignity, glory, tribute, rank, and social standing. These signify those who will be found worthy. This doesn't mean others won't possess eternal life and partake in the everlasting dominion of Jesus Christ on earth and across the cosmos. Yet, they will forgo the initial coronation festivity marking the

establishment of His throne on earth. Not being invited to a celebration does not imply one will be subjected to eternal torment. It simply means they were not found worthy of this kind of blessing: *"Blessed is the one who will eat at the feast in the kingdom of God."* (Luke 14:15)

Lazarus and the Rich Man (Luke 16)

Jesus, having just concluded The Parable of the Shrewd Manager (verses 1-13) with the statement that *"You cannot serve God and wealth,"* proceeded to exemplify godly stewardship with yet another parable:

> There was a rich man who was dressed in purple and fine linen and lived in luxury every day. At his gate was laid a beggar named Lazarus, covered with sores and longing to eat what fell from the rich man's table. Even the dogs came and licked his sores. The time came when the beggar died and the angels carried him to Abraham's *KOLPON* [bosom]. The rich man also died and was buried. In Hades, where he was in *BASANOS* [touchstone, testing], he looked up and saw Abraham far away, with Lazarus by his *KOLPON* [bosom]. So he called to him, *"Father Abraham, have pity on me and send Lazarus to dip the tip of his finger in water and cool my tongue, because I am in agony in this fire."* But Abraham replied, *"Son, remember that in your lifetime you received your good things, while Lazarus received bad things, but now he is comforted here and you are in agony. And besides all this, between us and you a great chasm has been set in place, so that those who want to go from here to you cannot, nor can anyone cross over from there to us."* He answered, *"Then I beg you, father, send Lazarus to my family, for I have five brothers. Let him warn them, so that they will not also come to this place of BASANOS* [touchstone, testing]." Abraham replied, *"They have Moses and the Prophets; let*

> *them listen to them." "No, father Abraham,"* he said, *"but if someone from the dead goes to them, they will repent."* He said to him, *"If they do not listen to Moses and the Prophets, they will not be convinced even if someone rises from the dead."*
>
> Luke 16:19-31

In the Bible, the term "Abraham's Bosom" (sometimes translated as "Abraham's side") is a unique expression found only once. In Jewish tradition, however, "Abraham's Bosom" is a well-known metaphor (e.g., Apocalypse of Zephaniah 11:1-2; Kiddushin 72b; Genesis Rabba 67), not regarded as a literal place or as a historical account of events but a metaphor for being in a state of peace and blessing.

Nothing in the parable speaks about the quality of faith of the characters involved. In fact, this parable isn't about faith at all. The Rich Man, representing the Pharisees, is religious, as he calls Abraham "father," who in return calls him "son." On the other hand, Lazarus clearly represents the poor and marginalized, those who suffer in this life but are ultimately vindicated, as Jesus' earlier Beatitudes promise. The Rich Man symbolizes those—often religious—who live in luxury and neglect the needs of others, losing rewards in the afterlife.

What If It's Not a Parable?

The Augustine-Calvinist interpretation is compelled to view this narrative as a factual historical record due to the literal understanding of the imagery of heat and fire ("hellfire"). However, this interpretation involves a selective literal approach to the narrative, treating certain elements as figurative while others as literal descriptions. For example, John MacArthur asserts that the poor man is in Heaven, suggesting he views the term 'Abraham's Bosom' as a metaphor:

> "…Abraham's bosom. That's kind of an Old Testament reference to a place of comfort, a place of peace where Abraham is and Abraham, of course, was a true believer…So this would be heaven." [172]

John MacArthur

False. The phrase Abraham's Bosom does not appear in the Old Testament. Yet, notice how John MacArthur says, *"That's **kind of** an Old Testament reference."* That was an interesting choice of words, *"Kind of."* How about *not at all* an Old Testament reference? Additionally, John MacArthur added a theological layer by saying, *"Abraham, of course, was a true believer…So this would be heaven."*

By interpreting it that way, MacArthur shifted the parable's focus from a critique of the love of money (verse 14) to the question of who is a true believer. In his view, Lazarus was a "true believer," while the Rich Man was not. However, the parable's original intent is not to define true belief, as it doesn't even address faith. This is evident also through Jesus' choice of the "Rich Man" over the "True Believer." In fact, Christ had just shared The Parable of the Shrewd Manager (verses 1-12) about the unjust steward who had mishandled his master's money. This second parable was told to illustrate further what proper stewardship is. Jesus did not abruptly switch from one genre to another; he did not go from telling a parable to narrating a historical event.

"Bosom" means a person's chest area. If we interpret this parable literally instead, then did Lazarus literally sit on Abraham's chest? There wouldn't be room to breathe, let alone stretch one's arms. Clearly, Christ is using symbolism. John MacArthur's interpretation that equates Abraham's bosom with heaven highlights a tendency among some preachers to selectively interpret this parable metaphorically where it fits their theological narratives about hellfire. However, Abraham's Bosom, a term unique to this parable and Jewish tradition and not found elsewhere in scripture, complicates literal interpretations, suggesting a symbolic reading was intended.

Interpreted literally, the parable appears to say that heaven and hell are separated by merely a short walk, with inhabitants of both sides able to communicate—a notion at odds with other beliefs positing hell as a distant, inaccessible realm below and heaven as an elevated sanctuary above. Instead, the parable should be considered as metaphorically highlighting the consequences of ignoring divine commandments —represented metaphorically by the impassable chasm between the Rich Man and Lazarus. This chasm underscores the finality of one's earthly actions and their implications for the afterlife, yet it remains a vehicle for moral teaching rather than a doctrinal statement on the geography of the afterlife. The *"great chasm* (or *gulf*)"

referred to the Jordan Rift Valley, symbolizing the division between Gentile lands and the Holy Land of promise, which Jews recognized as a symbol of salvation (divine blessing and protection).

A few chapters earlier, Jesus, possibly concerned that his words might be interpreted literally, clarified, "I speak in parables" (Luke 8:10). Nevertheless, some persist in interpreting these parables as literal historical events to align with their theological views.

Lazarus-Eleazar

Jesus's use of a real name in parables is not typical. For this reason, advocates of ECT in Hellfire often suggest that when real names are used, they ground the story in reality and, therefore, are not parables but actual historical events. This, however, represents a misconception of the function and significance of names in Judaism.

In contrast with non-Hebrew names, Hebrew names always carry a meaning. Hebrew names are often descriptive and reflect characteristics, divine attributes, or significant events associated with the individual. For instance, "Isaac" means "he will laugh," referencing Sarah's laughter upon learning she would bear a child in her old age. Similarly, "Samuel" means "heard by God," reflecting Hannah's prayer for a son. This tradition underscores the significance and intentionality behind Hebrew naming in Israel's culture, which is less common in most other naming traditions.

Lazarus, the Greek form of the Hebrew name "Eleazar," was already assigned in the Old Testament. In Hebrew, "Eleazar" means "God's Help." For a Jewish audience, this name—as with all other Hebrew names—bears allegorical significance and theological implications, suggesting Divine aid and fortitude, aligning with the parable's theme.

The expression *"desiring to be fed with the crumbs which fell from the rich man's table"* commonly identified Gentiles, as seen in Matthew 15:22–28. Similarly, the term *"laid at his gate"* echoes the typical Jewish reference to a Gentile convert known as a "Proselyte of the Gate," who embraced Jewish ethics, rejected pagan beliefs, and adhered to certain Jewish rituals yet did not undergo circumcision or baptism. However, they were often viewed as "second class" in religious terms.

The use of Lazarus-Eleazar and Abraham in the parable reminds the Jewish audience of Eleazar of Damascus, Abraham's chief steward mentioned in Genesis 15:2-3. Eleazar, also a Gentile steward, was initially the heir to Abraham's estate until Isaac was born. Despite this, Eleazar faithfully executed Abraham's wishes, even at the cost of his own inheritance. This disinheritance is symbolically captured in the parable, where Lazarus-Eleazar, representing Eleazar, is depicted as a "beggar" who has nothing of earthly value. The connection between Abraham and Eleazar adds depth to Jesus's parable, highlighting previous themes of stewardship.

The employment of a specific name to evoke Jewish tradition, something Jewish rabbis often do, suggests that Lazarus-Eleazar is the focus of the parable rather than the fictional setting. This technique highlights the importance of the character and the underlying message, drawing from familiar traditions and teachings to convey a deeper meaning and ongoing themes. In this parable, likely the concept that *"Some who are last will be first, and some who are first will be last."* (Luke 13:30), according to their life decisions.

The Rich Man

On the other hand, the Rich Man, unnamed, donned purple linen, a fabric traditionally associated with royalty, nobility, and affluence due to the costly nature of the purple dye in those days. This signified wealth and elevated status. The "Rich Man" remains unnamed because the parable is meant to elevate Lazarus-Eleazar.

The Rich Man was portrayed as an actual son of Abraham, with Christ having him call Abraham "father" (Luke 16:24) and Abraham acknowledging him as "son" (verse 25). In Judaism, this sonship implied that the Rich Man was a legal possessor of Abraham's inheritance, not necessarily a literal son, enjoying all the physical blessings promised to Abraham's seed. He wore purple, symbolizing kingship, and linen, representing priesthood—indicating the rich religious and royal heritage of Israel, specifically Judah, which assumed possession of both the kingdom and priesthood, embodying the promises given to Abraham. Essentially, beneath the surface, this served as Jesus's critique of Israel's religious and affluent leadership (e.g., verse 14).

Though the Rich Man was given Abraham's blessings, he was shown to be unfaithful. In contrast, Lazarus (Eleazar, the faithful steward) was now in Abraham's bosom, received into the "everlasting habitations" (verse 9). In a sense, this parable can be seen as Jesus' sarcastic answer to the Pharisees' declaration, *"We are Abraham's descendants"* (John 8:33) and *"Abraham is our father"* (John 8:39). This theme emerges early in Luke's gospel, where John the Baptist proclaims, *"do not begin to say to yourselves, 'We have Abraham as our father.'"* (Luke 3:8)

Fire, a symbol of the Rich Man's punishment, does not signify the duration of his punishment. Rather, "fire" carries profound symbolism of purification in Judaism and the Hebrew Scriptures, which will be the subject of a subsequent chapter.

BASANOS

The Greek word "*BASANOS*" is often translated as "*place of torment*" (NIV), "*horrible place*" (CEV), and "*place of pain*" (GNT), depending on the English translation. However, 'HELPS Word-Studies' defines '*BASANOS*' as follows:

> **Basanos:** a touchstone (a dark stone used in testing metals), hence examination by torture.
> **Cognate:** 931 básanos – originally, a black, silicon-based stone used as "a touchstone" to test the purity of precious metals (like silver and gold). See 928 (basanízō).
> In the papyri, basanos also means, "touchstone," "test" (so P Oxy I. 58.25, ad 288). 931 (basanois) was "originally (from oriental origin) a touchstone; a 'Lydian stone' used for testing gold because pure gold rubbed on it left a peculiar mark. Then it was used for examination by torture. Sickness was often regarded as 'torture' " (WP, 1, 37).
>
> HELPS Word-studies; 931 BASANOS

In essence, '*basanos*' signifies not gratuitous vengeful torture but rather a form that purifies precious metals, thereby cleansing them—a punishment of temporary and corrective nature rather than sadistic neverending torment.

Conclusion

The Lazarus of the parable is identified as Eleazar, Abraham's steward (Genesis 15:2), a Gentile from Damascus who "ate the crumbs." Despite being disinherited and becoming a beggar, Eleazar remained a faithful steward to Abraham and God. Upon his death, he received Abraham's inheritance in "everlasting habitations." The Rich Man in the parable is possibly Judah, representing Israel's religious aristocracy, who had five literal brothers and was a son of Abraham, unlike Eleazar. Judah also possessed kingship (symbolized by purple) and priesthood (symbolized by linen). However, Judah was not the true steward of Abrahamic blessings. Despite having the "oracles of God" (the Old Testament), Israel did not respond to their own Messiah.

The parable, set against the socio-religious backdrop of the Pharisees' love for money (Luke 16:13), serves as a critique of materialism and a call to ethical living according to Moses and the prophets, who often stressed God's mandate of taking care of the poor and needy (Exodus 22:22-23, Leviticus 19:9-10, Deuteronomy 14:28-29, 15:7, Isaiah 58:7, Proverbs 19:17, 22:9, Psalm 82:3-4, Zechariah 7:9-10, Jeremiah 22:16). The irony of the names in the parable is striking – religious wealth is personified by the "Rich Man," while the poor, needy and outcasts are given a more personal touch with a surname, epitomized by the remarkable Hebrew name "God Helps"!

The narrative does not attempt to develop a "hellfire" doctrine but to challenge the false yet prevailing notion of wealth as a sign of divine favor on religious people, subverting it to critique those who neglect justice and mercy. Jesus' engagement with Pharisaic hypocrisy does not endorse their views but utilizes traditionally familiar concepts in Judaism to challenge their practices and beliefs.

Thus, interpreting this parable should consider its role within Luke's broader narrative, its Jewish context, and Jesus' ministry, focusing on its ethical teachings and its use as a tool for spiritual reflection rather than a literal description of people

being forever tortured in fire in the afterlife. This approach aligns with the broader scriptural context where parables function as illustrative tools rather than doctrinal textbook treatises.

"Unquenchable Fire" (Matthew 3:10-12)

When the Western mind encounters the word "fire," it often conjures images of witches being burned at the stake, nuclear bombs, or Dante's depictions of individuals tormented by flames, which has significantly influenced Western Christian theology. However, in the Bible, Judaism, and other ancient civilizations, fire, though potentially painful, primarily symbolized purification.

In ancient agricultural societies, including those in the Near East, fire was sometimes used to clear fields of stubble and weeds after the harvest. This practice helped prepare the soil for the next planting season and could also control pests and diseases.

According to HELPS Word-Studies, the Bible use of "fire":

> **4442 pýr – fire:** In Scripture, fire is often used figuratively – like with the "fire of God" which transforms all it touches into light and likeness with itself.
>
> God's Spirit, like a holy fire, enlightens and purifies so that believers can share more and more in His likeness. Indeed the fire of God brings the uninterrupted privilege of being transformed which happens by experiencing faith from Him.

Fire in the Hebrew Scriptures and Jewish Thought

In the Hebrew Bible (E.g., Isaiah 1:25, Isaiah 48:10, Jeremiah 9:7, Malachi 3:2-3, Zechariah 13:9.), fire is never depicted as a symbol of eternal torture in Hellfire. Still, it does represent many other significant concepts, particularly purification. One notable instance is the ritual of burning the Red Heifer described in Numbers 19:1-10. In this ritual, a completely red heifer without blemish is slaughtered and burned entirely with fire. The resulting ashes are then used to create water for ceremonial cleansing.

Similarly, Numbers 31:23 details the purification process for items taken from non-Jews. The passage indicates that items are required to undergo purification by being subjected to fire. This process underscores the symbolic use of fire in purification rituals.

In Malachi 3:2-3, the passage uses fire as a metaphor for Israel's purification, similar to how a refiner uses fire to purify metals:

> But who can endure the day of his coming? Who can stand when he appears? For he will be like a refiner's fire or a launderer's soap. He will sit as a refiner and purifier of silver; he will purify the Levites and refine them like gold and silver.
>
> Malachi 3:2-3

In Jewish thought (e.g., Avoda Zara 75b), fire often symbolizes a process of purification and refinement. It is used to cleanse impurities and sanctify both objects and individuals. This is evident in various rituals and symbolic acts described in the Torah, where fire removes impurities and makes something pure and holy.

In the Hebrew Bible and Jewish tradition, fire also signifies God's presence, divine judgment, and transformative power. For instance, the burning bush encountered by Moses (Exodus 3:2) symbolizes God's holy presence, while the fire on Mount Sinai

represents divine revelation and covenant (Exodus 19:18). These instances illustrate the multifaceted symbolism of fire in biblical and Jewish thought, emphasizing purification, sanctity, and divine interaction with humanity. However, the Hebrew Scriptures never use "fire" in reference to an ongoing torture in hell.

Jesus, also a prophet of Israel, used these same familiar images of 'fire' to metaphorically describe God's response to the horrible evils in our world. He won't let them go unchecked. The fire of God's justice will one day consume evil and purify His beloved children once and for all (2 Peter 3:3-9; Revelation 21:1-4).

Matthew 3:10-12

In contrast with the Hebrew Bible and Jewish thought, the Augustinian-Calvinist perspective frequently employs the symbol of fire in a literal sense to endorse their belief in the perpetual torment of Hellfire. John the Baptist's words in Matthew 3:10-12, for instance, are commonly cited in this context:

> And even now the ax is laid to the root of the trees. Therefore every tree which does not bear good fruit is cut down and thrown into the fire. I indeed baptize you with water unto repentance, but He who is coming after me is mightier than I, whose sandals I am not worthy to carry. He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit and fire. His winnowing fan is in His hand, and He will thoroughly clean out His threshing floor, and gather His wheat into the barn; but He will burn up the chaff with unquenchable fire.
>
> Matthew 3:10-12

Jewish parables are deeply rooted in the agricultural context, resonating with a society whose daily life and economy were intricately tied to farming. This background is crucial for interpreting parables about master-servant relationships, wheat and chaff, and other agricultural metaphors. In Matthew 3:10-12, John the

Baptist employs these familiar agricultural images to convey his message of Israel's looming judgment.

In context, John the Baptist is speaking about impending judgment on Israel if it fails to repent. In Matthew 3:7-8, John warns the religious leaders that wrath (which, in Old Testament terms, often meant the violent conquest of Israel by its enemies) is coming upon the nation. However, Israel could escape it if it bore fruits worthy of repentance. When John speaks of the axe being laid at the root of the tree, he is saying that Israel's judgment is imminent.

Wheat and Chaff

Then, John goes on to speak about Jesus. The imagery of wheat and chaff is particularly telling. In agriculture, wheat grows as a single plant with both grain and chaff. The process of winnowing and threshing involves separating the valuable grain from the worthless chaff. This metaphor suggests that within each individual, there is a mixture of good and bad. The good (wheat) is preserved, while the bad (chaff) is destroyed.

When John uses the image of the wheat and the chaff, he describes the common practice of farmers gathering the harvest on their threshing floor, where the wheat is separated from the chaff with a winnowing fork. This tool was a cross between a rake and a shovel so that large scoops of grain could be tossed into the air while also creating a bit of a breeze. The heavier grain would fall back to the ground, while the lighter chaff would get blown off to one side, where it would pile up against a low wall of the threshing floor. Once the wheat and chaff had been separated in this way, the grain would be taken away for storage, while the useless chaff would be set on fire. Since chaff is light and insubstantial, it's not even usable as fuel as it burns very quickly, leaving almost no ash behind and very little evidence that it ever existed. If we are to take John's illustration as speaking of Hellfire, then we once again end up with a case for final annihilation, not eternal torture.

In the metaphor of wheat and chaff, the wheat could be seen as representing the good within us, intertwined with chaff—undesirable elements like sin and imperfections. This imagery aligns with Paul's teachings about the unworthy parts of

ourselves being refined through fire, *"if it is burned up, the builder will suffer loss but yet will be saved—even though only as one escaping through the flames"* (1 Corinthians 3:15), highlighting a purification process where our sins and flawed nature are eradicated, leaving only what is pure, even if the only good left is God's image.

This process is not about inflicting torment on individuals, a concept often oversimplified in teachings as a dichotomy of the saved and the damned, but rather a process of purification. This idea resonates with the core Christian doctrine of transformation, which calls believers to partake in the divine nature (2 Peter 1:4) by casting off the old self for a renewed existence in Christ. This metamorphosis entails separating the spiritual wheat from the fleshly chaff, retaining the soul's intrinsic worth while eliminating sinful traits.

The act of winnowing and threshing, integral to this metaphor, could symbolize the meticulous separation of one's virtues (the wheat) from one's vices (the chaff), which can be seen in Christ's admonition in Luke 22:31, where Simon Peter is told that Satan has desired to sift him as wheat—testing his faith and character. Likewise, Paul's epistles to the Galatians (2:20) and Colossians (3:9-10) echo this sentiment, illustrating how Christians should manifest their faith by adopting the new self, constantly rejuvenated to mirror the image of God.

Ultimately, the imagery highlights not eternal damnation in Hellfire but rather spiritual cleansing and purification, accentuating the transformative path of faith we are invited to embark upon. This process is immensely beneficial in realizing the blessings that God intends for us in this life. However, those who fail to repent will face their sins' dire and ruinous outcomes. This is the warning John delivers to the leaders and the entire nation of Israel. John employs the metaphor of fire to denote this destruction. In other words, John is warning: If you won't repent—remove your chaff—God will do it for you!

Burning of Chaff and Unquenchable Fire

When John says that the "trees will be thrown into the fire" (Matt 3:10), he is not literally talking about actual plants punished in Hellfire but is using the imagery of cutting down a tree, which then gets burned. Many trees are cut down and then used

to make planks of wood for building and construction. The trees of the lowest quality are, however, harvested and utilized as fuel for cooking and heating.

John states that those who won't repent will be symbolically cut down and burned. This signifies their worthlessness, as they will not be of any significant use when judgment arrives, representing their misdeeds.

The term *"baptism by the Holy Spirit and fire"* mentioned in Matthew 3:11 is similarly interpreted. The Holy Spirit and the fire are not at odds but complement each other. Baptism, meaning "immersion," suggests that just as metals are purified when immersed in fire, so too is this a metaphor for cleansing. The passage indicating Jesus will administer this baptism by fire does not imply Jesus will literally stand in hell with a massive flamethrower, burning people forever, but rather alludes to the symbolic purification of Israel.

Fire naturally dies out slowly. In contrast, unquenchable fire, unlike quenchable fire that must be maintained, suggests it will not stop until it fully completes its task. It burns all it is meant to burn and fully consumes everything fed into it. Chaff does not burn eternally; it burns quickly and then is gone. Thus, describing this fire as unquenchable indicates it burns hot and fast until there is nothing left to burn: *"For everyone will be salted with fire."* (Mark 9:49)

Gregory of Nyssa's beliefs may indeed reflect this view:

> God has one goal...some straightway even in this life purified from evil; others healed hereafter through fire for the appropriate length of time. [173]

Eusebius, in his Ecclesiastical History, [174] writes about a Christian named Julian who was burned to death for being a Christian. Eusebius describes this fire as being an immense fire. The Greek words he uses are *puri asbestō*, exactly the same words used by John in Matthew 3:12. Eusebius goes on to use the exact same term to describe how other Christian martyrs were killed. Clearly, when Eusebius used this phrase, he was certainly not saying that these Christian martyrs went to Hellfire. The bodies of these Christians were reduced to ash in the fire, not sent to everlasting torment.

Conclusion

Matthew 3:10-12, when understood in its historical and cultural context, along with the agricultural metaphors used by Jesus, points towards a punishment of purification and transformation rather than eternal conscious torment. The fire mentioned symbolizes refining and cleansing, which is necessary for sanctification. This interpretation aligns with the broader biblical narrative of redemption and restoration rather than unending torture.

Similar to 1 Corinthians 3:12-15, where works are tested by fire, the "chaff" represents the sinful, unworthy parts of ourselves. This metaphorical fire purifies by burning away sin and impurities, leaving only what is good and valuable. The core message of Christianity revolves around transformation—becoming “partakers of the Divine Nature” (2 Peter 1:4). This involves shedding the old nature and embracing the new nature, as emphasized in Galatians 2:20 and Colossians 3:9-10. The imagery of winnowing and threshing, along with the "unquenchable fire," can be understood as a process of refinement, separating what is usable (e.g., our souls, God's image, good deeds, and faith) from what is not (sin and falsehood).

Aren't we "Born Again" to Avoid Hellfire?

Evangelicals, commonly self-identified as "Born-again Evangelicals," generally interpret "born again" as a profound experience of repentance and faith in Jesus's sacrifice for sins. This experience is often specific, memorable, and pivotal to their personal testimony. These experiences, usually emotionally charged, can look like reciting a "salvation prayer" from a pamphlet in order to escape eternal damnation by "inviting" Jesus into one's heart or undergoing an emotionally intense "born again" experience, such as speaking in tongues in the case of pentecostal and charismatic groups.

Finding a comprehensive definition is challenging; however, the following statement serves as a good example of the Evangelical concept of being "born again":

> Being born again means starting over as a new creation in Christ. It's a personal and spiritual renewal, where your sins are forgiven and your heart is transformed by the Holy Spirit. In John 3:3, Jesus said to Nicodemus, *"Truly, truly, I say to you, unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God."* [175]

The term "born again," however, could not have originally referred to accepting Jesus's death for one's sins to escape hellfire when it was first used in John 3:3, as Jesus had not yet died, nor was his death foreseen at that time. If anything, Jesus' disciples expected Him to lead a revolt against the Romans and establish His reign (Luke 24:21). This suggests that initially, the phrase "born again" held a completely

different meaning. Therefore, to assert that "to be born again" means "to avoid hellfire by accepting Jesus's death for one's sins" would constitute an anachronism fallacy, as it retroactively applies a concept or event (Jesus' death and its theological interpretation) to a period before it actually happened or was comprehended in such a manner.

To Be Born Again

> Very truly I tell you, no one can see the kingdom of God unless they are born again.
>
> John 3:3

So, what did Jesus mean by the term 'born again'?
To answer, we must consider two terms:

1. “Born Again”

2. “See [or ‘enter’] the Kingdom of God.”

1 Peter 1:23 states, ***“For you have been born again, not of perishable seed, but of imperishable, through the living and enduring word [logos] of God.”*** Here, Peter addressed an audience during a period when the New Testament, as we know it today, did not yet exist. At that time, only the "Old Testament" had been canonized. Thus, the question is, what was the "word" Peter spoke of?

Some Christians today view the Bible as God's word. However, John’s Gospel begins by identifying Jesus—not the Bible—as the “word” (logos) of God. This influenced early Christian thought to see Jesus’ life, ministry, and teaching as the ultimate expression of God’s word. Therefore, the “word of God” likely refers to Jesus's ministry, life, and teachings, particularly his parables and Sermon on the Mount, which were initially passed down orally.

In this context, to be born again is to educate oneself with Jesus’s teachings, values, and instructions and adjust oneself's life, attitude, and actions accordingly. This isn’t

a one-time mystical-emotional experience or a line one recites from a pamphlet but a lifelong mental journey of becoming Christ-like, including aiding the sick, helping the poor, embracing the outcast, loving enemies, forgiving trespassers, loving sacrificially, growing in empathy and compassion, becoming kinder, etc. This journey must begin with an initial realization of who our loving God is and what He truly desires from us through His word—Jesus Christ—leading to a lifelong pursuit.

Now, is "born again" supposed to lead us into paradise and away from eternal fiery torture?

The Kingdom of God

Some Christians view the "*Kingdom of God*" as a mystical afterlife paradise. However, this idea also diverges from Jesus's teachings.

In Matthew 4:17 and Mark 1:15, Jesus mentions that "*the kingdom of God has come near.*" Luke 17:21 states, "*The kingdom of God is within you,*" and Matthew 12:28 and Luke 11:20 assert, "*The kingdom of God has come upon you.*"

"*Near,*" "*within you,*" and "*upon you*" make the Kingdom of God very different from a heavenly destination far away in the afterlife.

In Matthew 5:3, Jesus said, "*Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the **kingdom of heaven**.*" and in Matthew 6:33: "*Seek first his **kingdom** and his righteousness, and all these things will be given to you as well.*" In Luke 8:1, we read that "*Jesus traveled about from one town and village to another, proclaiming the good news of the **kingdom of God**.*" He also sent out His disciples, in Luke 9:2, "*to proclaim the **kingdom of God** and to heal the sick.*"

Clearly, the "Kingdom of God" Jesus was referring to at the time was a present reality – a spiritual mindset, lifestyle, and attitude to life —here and now. This is, in fact, a very Jewish view known as *TIKKUN OLAM*. The Hebrew phrase *Tikkun Olam* means "world repair." In Jewish circles, Tikkun Olam has become synonymous with social action and the pursuit of justice, especially for the poor and needy.

To summarize, Jesus wasn't a 21st-century evangelical pastor from the West preaching you must go through a mystical-emotional experience that will—once you die—help you escape Hellfire. Instead, the parables of Jesus, a Jewish rabbi, were

concerned with the present. According to Rabbi Jesus, to “be born again” and “see/enter the kingdom of God” (John 3:3) means stepping into a living reality that represents Jesus' teachings and values:

> The kingdom of God is…righteousness, peace, and joy in the Holy Spirit.
>
> Romans 14:17

My book, *"The Kingdom of Yeshua: Christ's Timeless Wisdom to Revive Your Spiritual Life,"* offers an in-depth exploration of the concepts of "being born again" and "seeing/entering the kingdom of God" and what living in that kingdom looks like.

"Away from me, you evildoers!"

There are two kinds of "Christianity." One is a religion that, on paper, intellectually adheres to all the correct theological recipes and doctrines about Jesus' Lordship and Divinity. The other is a way of life—represented by *the kingdom of heaven*—embodied by Christ-like individuals who live out the values Jesus taught and demonstrated. These values include loving-kindness, empathy, justice, compassion, extending grace, forgiveness, humility, and selflessness. While the former is frequently motivated by a desire for political power and concentrates on theoretical religious formulas, the latter embodies a transformative way of living that mirrors the heart and character of Jesus through an individual's worldview, values, actions, and relationships.

With that in mind, let's read one of the most frequently quoted portions from Jesus's Sermon on the Mount:

> Not everyone who says to me, "Lord, Lord," will enter the kingdom of heaven, but only the one who does the will of my Father who is in heaven. Many will say to me on that day, "Lord, Lord, did we not prophesy in your name and in your name drive out demons and in your name perform many miracles?" Then I will tell them plainly, "I never knew you. Away from me, you evildoers!"
>
> Matthew 7:21-23

"Lord, Lord"

Many people intellectually affirm sound theology and acknowledge Jesus as their "Lord." This title, especially when used for Jesus, is a mark of respect and signifies deity. Let's use an extreme yet relevant example. The Ku Klux Klan has historically portrayed itself as a Christian organization, using Christian symbols and rhetoric to justify its ideology and actions. Most of its leaders identified as Christians, including preachers and ministers.[176] For instance, William Joseph Simmons, a Methodist preacher, was involved in the founding of the second Ku Klux Klan in 1915.[177] Other preachers and ministers like him contributed to the Klan's efforts to present itself as a defender of Protestant Christian values despite the organization's actions and beliefs being fundamentally opposed to Jesus's teachings.

Many individuals, today and throughout history, are intellectually submitted to the Lordship of Jesus, as evidenced by the way Jesus describes their enthusiastic proclamation, *"Lord, Lord."* They appear to be aligned in their understanding of who Christ is and seem fully committed to religious conduct. They probably attend church every Sunday and are actively involved in commendable "good works;" they preach, teach, prophesy, perform exorcisms, and even exhibit supernatural signs (Matthew 7:22). This resembles the same attitude Paul spoke of:

> If I have the gift of prophecy and can fathom all mysteries and all knowledge, and if I have a faith that can move mountains, but do not have love, I am nothing.
>
> 1 Corinthians 13:2

"Many Will Say To Me"

Moreover, they are not a mere handful but *"many"* in number, highlighting that this form of religious self-deception is not a rare phenomenon but rather widespread—the "wide road" of religion. Consider the irony: Many televangelists boast about the miracles they have performed in Jesus's name, and many pastors and theologians take pride in prophesying and teaching in Jesus's name (verse 22), yet Jesus disapproves of their ministry and points out that they are *evildoers*. The root of their lawlessness is not found in women donning colorful shorts and dancing with long-haired men to blaring music; it lies elsewhere entirely.

Recall what Jesus taught his crowd in his Sermon on the Mountain: humility, meekness, righteousness, mercy, peacemaking, compassion, forgiveness, and loving-kindness. These teachings encapsulate "doing the will of the Father," which they crucially did not practice. Their lack of this practice hindered them from entering the kingdom of God.

"Enter the Kingdom"

In Jesus's time, societal divisions were stark. The wealthy often resided within the safety and prosperity of kingdom walls, while those outside lived in relative poverty and vulnerability. Metaphorically speaking, real estate within the walls is always highly sought after. This societal setup is an analogy for the spiritual kingdom, suggesting that, spiritually and metaphorically speaking, some might end up in conditions akin to those less fortunate living outside the kingdom walls, essentially losing their privileged status, struggling, and perhaps in shame.

Entering the kingdom, therefore, symbolically signifies gaining a status of respect and honor for being close to God. Yet, not every Christian will automatically receive a privileged position in this kingdom; only those Jesus said he "knows."

"I Never Knew You!"

In Judaism, to "know" someone means to have a close, intimate relationship with and support what they stand for. Being an admired pastor and teacher with millions of followers on social media, leading a Bible College or renowned evangelistic ministry, or pastoring a church doesn't guarantee that Jesus "acknowledges" you or, in other words, approves of your ministry. Merely proclaiming, *"I was 'born again' 20 years ago,"* or boasting about numerical accomplishments in Christian ministry does not ensure special recognition from Jesus or attest to having a genuine intimacy with God. By "intimacy," I'm not speaking of mystical charismatic experiences but about knowledge—of God and His will—that translates to fruit; *"Ye shall know them by their fruits."* (verse 16). Do they exhibit the fruit of love—such as being kind, gracious, compassionate, and forgiving even towards their adversaries? Or is their fruit limited to religious legalism, condescension, and residing in a religious ivory tower? Are the individuals under their leadership spiritually flourishing and emotionally thriving, or are they experiencing depression, stubbornness, and anxiety?

The teachings of Jesus underscore the crucial element of spiritual life: it's not about religious piety and outward performance but about the essential transformation of one's heart to align with God's will and its expanding ability to love and bless others truly. Merely performing religious acts or proclaiming Jesus's name is not enough to gain respect and honor that would secure a place in His Kingdom. Jesus's caution is not regarding salvation from hellfire—which is not at all implied in the context—but rather about the rewards and responsibilities that await those who act according to God's will.

Conclusion

If Jesus' teachings indicated that "many" would be rejected concerning their salvation from hellfire, it could seem that a significant number of Christians might be at risk

of eternal damnation. This interpretation could seem at odds with Paul's teachings, which indicate that *"all are justified freely by his grace,"* (Romans 3:24) not merely a select few, since salvation is a free *"gift of God not by works, so that no one can boast."* (Ephesians 2:8-9).

In this context, however, being 'known' by Jesus, 'seeing,' or 'entering' the Kingdom serve as metaphors not for escaping hellfire but for being in close communion with God, a reward for the manner in which we live our lives. Unlike salvation, the rewards, treasures, honor, and respect are to be earned through *"doing the will of my Father who is in heaven."* (Matthew 7:21).

Assuming Jesus's declaration that *"many"* have it wrong in his name is true, don't be surprised to find *many* churchgoers, ministers, seminary students, theologians, and pastors in that category.

"Narrow Gates" That Lead Where?

Matthew 7:13–29 concludes the Sermon on the Mount, where Jesus discusses the choices that lead to a blessed and prosperous life when living a life of righteousness. He emphasizes the importance of not only hearing His words but also acting on them, likening those who do to a wise man who built his house on the rock and, therefore, can stand through life's trials. In Matthew 7:13-14 Jesus stresses:

> Enter through the narrow gate. For wide is the gate and broad is the road that leads to destruction, and many enter through it. But small is the gate and narrow the road that leads to life, and only a few find it.
>
> Matthew 7:13-14

Augustinian-Calvinist preachers often interpret these verses out of context, suggesting that Jesus was implicitly threatening people with hellfire. For instance, in his sermon, *"The Way to Heaven: Matthew 7:13–29."* John MacArthur preached:

> Jesus Himself warned that many will deceive themselves into thinking they're going to heaven when they're really on the path to hell.[178]...The word destruction here simply refers to ultimate, eternal judgment in hell, everlasting torment.[179]

However, the context of Matthew 7:13-14 within the Sermon on the Mount does not suggest in any way that *"broad"* and *"destruction"* refer to eternal torture in hellfire, nor that *"narrow"* and *"life"* indicate heaven for those who accept Jesus as their crucified Savior. When Jesus declared, *"I am the gate"* (John 10:9), it would not have been understood as Him stating, "Believe that I died for your sins." The people who heard Jesus speak were not yet aware of his impending crucifixion and the theological implications of accepting his sacrifice for their sins. Therefore, interpreting Yeshua's metaphors in this way seems improbable and misaligned with the original message. This modern Western interpretation is not only anachronistic but also overlooks the historical and cultural context in which Jesus' original audience understood his teachings.

Narrow Is the Road

In this often taken-out-of-context verse, rabbi Jesus employs the metaphor of two paths (or ways), well-known imagery that echoes a common theme in both the Hebrew Scriptures (e.g., Deuteronomy 30:19, Proverbs 4:18-19, Psalm 1:6, Psalm 118:19-20) and in Jewish wisdom literature (e.g., Berakhot 28b:6, Pirkei Avot 2:1), contrasting the path of righteousness that brings blessings and prosperity with the path of wickedness leading to destructive consequences in life. This aligns with the Jewish concept of *'Derech Hashem'* (God's Way), where following God's law is viewed as a narrow path that demands dedication and, at times, sacrifice—but leads to great blessings!

Small Is the Gate

The imagery of gates in the context of ancient kingdoms, particularly as used in biblical texts, is rich in symbolic meaning (e.g., Isaiah 60:11, Jeremiah 7:2, Psalm 24:7, Nehemiah 3:1, Proverbs 8:34). For instance, gates could symbolize a righteous way of living that brings blessings and prosperity:

> Open the gates that the righteous nation may enter, the nation that keeps faith.
>
> Isaiah 26:2

To better understand the symbolism of gates, it's helpful to consider the roles gates played in ancient times. Ancient kingdoms were typically fortified with walls, and gates were crucial entry and exit points. Most people would enter through the wide gate. It was easier to pass through and could accommodate larger groups of people and carriages with goods or large animals. It was used for regular, everyday traffic, like a modern highway.

In contrast, a narrow gate was smaller, more exclusive, and harder to find. It was often controlled or guarded and led quicker into the most private parts where the king would reside. Only privileged ones could enter it. It was much less used and represented an exclusive status and a personal, intimate relationship with the king.

The "wide gate" and the "narrow gate" are metaphorically used to represent two different paths in life. Jesus contrasts the wide gate, symbolizing most people (remember, people were religious back then; secularism did not exist), with the narrow gate, symbolizing the more exclusive remnant.

The narrow road/gate symbolizes the closeness and intimacy with God that those who walk in righteousness experience, not an escape from an eternal cosmic fire chamber—a concept that was utterly foreign to the young Jewish disciples and hearers. The narrow road/gate represents the challenging but fulfilling path of living a righteous, godly life.

The narrow gate also symbolizes a difficult, seldom-traveled path demanding diligence, discipline, ethical fortitude, and spiritual dedication. Within the framework of ancient realms, this metaphor may be interpreted as a representation of decisions and their repercussions. The broader gate, bustling with trade, might signify the common pursuit of power and riches. It was also the place where religious leaders convened, epitomizing the quest for prestige and communal endorsement. Conversely, the narrow gate might represent a life embodying the principles of Jesus' teachings, as illustrated in his parables and the Sermon on the Mount.

Destruction

The Wide Gate symbolizes the easy, popular path that aligns with societal norms, including indulging in worldly pleasures, obstructing justice for self-gain, or following the common religious worldviews, which ultimately diverts from true spiritual fulfillment and leads to destruction. "Destruction," much like "gates" and "roads," was a metaphor implemented by Jesus to describe a life wasted, not an attempt to threaten us with an eternal cosmic holocaust.

I had a Jewish friend in high school who was fond of gambling and gradually became addicted to sports betting. He was frequently cautioned that this path could lead to his life's destruction—not in the afterlife, but in his earthly future. Sadly, he lost everything and faced real ruin. On the other hand, I had another Jewish friend whose life was devastated by drug addiction. His life was literally a hell he could not escape. It is pointless to threaten people with addiction to hell; they are already there and can teach us what it feels like. He recognized the need for change but couldn't do anything about it. One day, a Christian in recovery offered him a helping hand, and he embarked on a journey to overcome his addiction by following "the narrow way." He triumphed, finding a new lease on life. Now, he runs a thriving business and has a wonderful family.

For the sake of argument, if we entertain the Augustinian-Calvinist perspective, we face a contradiction since most Protestants believe salvation or justification comes through faith alone. However, if Jesus's words ("only a few find it") were about avoiding eternal torture in hellfire, it would indicate he was promoting a salvation that requires work. Hard work. Yet, if salvation is truly a free gift of grace, these verses may be interpreted as referring to the immediate consequences of our choices and actions in this life.

Destruction transcends the mere physical realm; its reach extends into the spiritual and emotional aspects of life. I have observed numerous individuals, both from my Jewish and Christian circles, who have been ensnared by an excessive devotion to religious formalities. This adherence to strict legalism often breeds a host of negative traits. Initially, it may start with a rigid adherence to rituals and rules, but gradually,

this can lead to deeper psychological impacts. These individuals become increasingly anxious, struggling with the fear of not meeting high religious standards. They often turn unkind, their compassion overshadowed by judgment and criticism of those who do not adhere as strictly to religious norms. Ultimately, this path can lead to profound sadness and depression, as the joy that faith is supposed to bring gets lost in the relentless pursuit of religious perfection. This transformation is a poignant reminder of the destructive power of misapplied religious fervor, affecting the mind and spirit just as profoundly as physical forces can ravage the body.

Conclusion

The contrast between the wide and narrow gates and roads in ancient parables symbolizes life decisions, ethical courses, and spiritual passages that influence our daily existence. The wide gate symbolizes the effortless, common route many select, whereas the narrow gate represents the arduous, seldom-trodden path that leads to genuine satisfaction in accordance with the principles of God's Kingdom.

Jesus likely employs kingdom imagery to distinguish between earthly and spiritual accomplishments. Choosing the narrow gate might not yield immediate worldly acclaim, but it fosters a more intimate, profound connection with God and a more lasting form of esteem and honor—one that aligns with the divine will and timeless spiritual tenets. In essence, Jesus's teachings advocate for deliberate choices concerning the direction of one's life. He encourages his disciples to deliberately select their course, fully conscious of the consequences of their decisions in both this existence and in the afterlife.

The "Gates of Hell" (Matthew 16:18)

In Matthew 16, Jesus finally introduces the concept of his death and resurrection to his disciples. In verse 18, Jesus declares something that confused many:

> And I tell you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church, and the gates of Hades will not overcome it.
>
> Matthew 16:18

This statement, often misinterpreted to imply the fires of hellfire, actually speaks to the resurrection and the defeat of death. Understanding the historical and cultural context and examining the language used reveal a profound promise of victory over death rather than a reference to eternal conscious torment in hellfire.

Hades, sometimes confusingly translated to the English "hell," is actually the Greek word equivalent of Sheol, representing the underworld or the realm of the dead (the grave). In the New Testament, Hades similarly denotes the unseen place where souls go after death, awaiting resurrection. Like Sheol, Hades is not inherently a place of torment or bliss but a temporary holding place for the dead.

Rock? Church?

Let's go a few verses back for context. In Matthew 16:13, Jesus asks His disciples what

they have heard from others about His identity: *"Who do people say the Son of Man is?"* (Matthew 16:13). The disciples respond with various opinions they have heard. Then, Jesus asks them directly: *"But what about you? Who do you say I am?"* (Matthew 16:15). Simon Peter answers, *"You are the Messiah, the Son of the living God"* (Matthew 16:16). Jesus replies,

> Blessed are you, Simon son of Jonah, for this was not revealed to you by flesh and blood, but by my Father in heaven. And I tell you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church, and the gates of Hades will not overcome it.
>
> Matthew 16:17-18

Some interpret the phrase *"this rock"* as referring to Peter himself. However, the context from the previous verses indicates that "this rock" refers to the recognition of Jesus as *"the Messiah, the Son of the living God"* (Matthew 16:16). In other words, the church will be built—theologically—on the core and fundamental acknowledgment that Jesus is the Messiah!

In Greek, the word for Peter is "Πέτρος" *(Petros)*, which means a small stone. In contrast, the word for rock is "πέτρα" *(petra)*, which means a large rock or bedrock. The word "Petros" is masculine, while "petra" is feminine. This play on words indicates that Peter *(Petros)* is given a symbolic nickname, but the foundation *(petra)* of the Christian church is Jesus.

Peter himself, in his later letter, describes the cornerstone and the rock not as himself but as Jesus:

> To you who believe, this stone is precious. But to those who do not believe, "The stone the builders rejected has become the cornerstone," and "A stone that causes people to stumble and a rock that makes them fall."
>
> 1 Peter 2:7-8

Similarly, Paul writes in his first letter to the Corinthians: *"The rock was Christ"* (1 Corinthians 10:4). In his letter to the Ephesians, Paul also states: *"Christ Jesus himself as the chief cornerstone."* (Ephesians 2:20).

Thus, the acknowledgment of the Son of God—not Peter—is the rock, the spiritual cornerstone of the Church.

Considering the use of all these previous metaphors, interpreting "the gates of Hades" in Matthew 16:18 as referring to a literal fight against hellfire is not feasible. The imagery of gates fighting against a building is nonsensical. Instead, the gates of Hades, understood in the context of ancient Jewish and Old Testament writings, symbolize the power of death (the grave). Jesus is proclaiming that the power of death will not overcome His church. This is a promise of resurrection and future perseverance of Jesus's ministry/Church rather than a reference to hellfire or eternal conscious torment. The Church, built on the recognition of Jesus as the Messiah, will ultimately triumph, liberating those held captive, much like an army breaking through the gates of a walled city to free its inhabitants.

The Gates of Death

Taken literally, the idea of gates fighting against a building is absurd. A gate is a defensive structure, not an offensive weapon. The imagery of the "gates of Hades" suggests something that confines or restrains, as if keeping the dead from leaving. In the context of Jesus' promise, the gates symbolize the obstacles of death and the grave. This interpretation aligns with their usage in the Hebrew Scriptures, where they are referred to as "the gates of death" (Job 17:16, Psalm 9:13, Isaiah 38:10).

The gates of death—like the gates of a cemetery—are a metaphor for the grave, not for a place of eternal hellfire torture.

Jesus' statement in Matthew 16:18 is a proclamation of His impending victory over death. By saying that the gates of Hades will not overcome His church, He assures that death—perhaps persecution—will not prevail against him, his ministry, and his disciples. This aligns with the broader biblical narrative of resurrection and eternal life:

> I am the Living One; I was dead, and now look, I am alive for ever and ever! And I hold the keys of death and Hades.
>
> Revelation 1:18

> Death has been swallowed up in victory. Where, O death, is your victory? Where, O death, is your sting?
>
> 1 Corinthians 15:54-55

These verses reinforce the idea that Jesus' mission was to conquer and defeat death—not hellfire—once and for all, thus inverting the Genesis 3 consequence of death.

Additionally, if the gates of Hades are meant to keep souls confined, Jesus' statement that they will not overcome his church implies liberation, not further confinement. The Church's role would be to break these gates and free the captives, aligning more with the concept of resurrection and liberation from death.

Conclusion

Matthew 16:18's reference to the "gates of Hades" is best understood as a metaphor for death and the grave, not a place of eternal fiery punishment. Jesus promised that his church would prevail over death, highlighting his mission to conquer death and lay a path into eternal life that no gate can block. This interpretation aligns with the broader biblical narrative of redemption and avoids the logical inconsistencies of a strictly literal interpretation. Thus, the "gates of Hades" now signify Jesus' triumph over death, ultimately assuring resurrection and victory over evil.

Fear Whom?

This chapter will explore two verses frequently cited by proponents of the Augustinian-Calvinist doctrine of hellfire. The first verse, from the Old Testament, is Proverbs 1:7, which states, *"The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge."* The second verse, unrelated to the first, is from the New Testament, Luke 12:5, which is also referenced in Matthew 10:28: *"Fear him who can destroy both soul and body in hell."*

Old Testament Fear

Have you ever ascended to the summit of the Eiffel Tower or stood at the prow of a boat amidst the vast ocean? Maybe you've perched on the edge of a mountain cliff or lain under a star-studded sky in the desert. If you have, you might remember the deep sense of awe, reverence, and sheer wonder that enveloped you. Undoubtedly, even the most courageous adventurer standing at the edge of an Olympic springboard would be hard-pressed to keep their heart from trembling. All of these feelings could be best described as *YIR'AH*.

While some English translations choose the English word "fear" to translate *YIR'AH*, other translations use "Awe,"[180] "Respect,"[181] and "Reverence."[182]

Moses was overcome with *YIR'AH* when he pleaded with God to witness His glory (Exodus 33). Similarly, the Israelites were steeped in *YIR'AH* when Moses descended from Mount Sinai with a shining face (Exodus 34).

In short, *YIR'AH* most often relates to experiencing something that surpasses one's abilities and comprehension.

To the modern eye, the concept of "fearing God" may initially appear to imply being scared, terrified, or afraid of God, but this isn't the biblical meaning. Being scared of someone doesn't entail knowledge. Instead, *YIR'AH* of God encapsulates a sense of awe, respect, and reverence toward God's majesty. You only want to study something —or someone—thoughtfully when you are in awe of them.

YIR'AH is an acknowledgment of God's sovereignty over all things, being all-powerful, etc. In the Old Testament, a Hebrew root with multiple meanings—Y-R-A —conveys different ideas depending on the context. *YARE* & *YIR'AH* are examples of Hebrew words derived from this root, meaning reverence, respect, or awe. In Genesis 22:12, it is used to describe Abraham's respect and trust in God:

> "Do not lay a hand on the boy," he said. "Do not do anything to him. Now I know that you *YIR'AH* God, because you have not withheld from me your son, your only son."
>
> Genesis 22:12

Proverbs 1:7

In Proverbs 1:7, *YIR'AH* is used to describe wisdom and knowledge:

> The fear of (*YIRAT*) the LORD is the beginning of knowledge; but fools despise wisdom and instruction.
>
> Proverbs 1:7

In this Proverb, the contrast of knowledge is despising wisdom and instruction, while the contrast of *YIR'AH* is a foolish person. If *YIR'AH* were about being scared-terrified, then the opposite would not be a foolish person who despises wisdom but

fearlessness. In this context, having *YIR'AH* —or being impressed with God—is the opposite of a fool: someone who rejects wisdom and instruction.

For illustration's sake, imagine a master craftsman and an apprentice. The apprentice must approach the master with respect and a willingness to learn, recognizing the master's expertise and authority. If the apprentice despises the master's instruction, they are unlikely to gain the skills and knowledge needed to become a craftsman themselves. *YIR'AH*, in this case, represents the apprentice's awe and respect for the master, which is essential for true learning. In contrast, a fool is like an apprentice who rejects the master's wisdom, thereby missing the opportunity to grow and develop.

Scared \ Terrified in the Bible

The Hebrew words in the Hebrew Scriptures that describe what we in modern language consider "fear" are *EIMAH* (terror) and *PACHAD* (scare). These are when you are afraid for your life, fearing someone will want to hurt you or kill you. However, the words used in Proverbs 1:7 and 9:10 are different, meaning "awe" or "reverence." In other words, wisdom begins with awe and respect for God, not with fearing he'll kill you…

In the New Testament, when Paul delivered his sermon in the synagogue at Antioch, he addressed two distinct groups: *"Men of Israel and* ***you who fear God****, listen"* (Acts 13:16). "God-fearers" is a known phrase meant to describe Gentiles who demonstrated deep respect and reverence for the God of Israel. In the Book of Acts, *"God-fearing Gentiles"* (Acts 13:26) refers to Gentiles (non-Jews) who were attracted to Judaism and its teachings but had not fully converted to Judaism.

Paul didn't refer in his sermon to people who were scared-terrified of the God of Israel. On the contrary, they were drawn to Him because they were in awe and respected Him. They admired the God of Israel's power, justice, and goodness. Their "fear" was not one that repels but one that attracts and motivates obedience, encourages humility and fosters a more profound, respectful relationship with God.

New Testament Fear

Luke 12:5 (Matthew 10:28)

> Meanwhile, when a crowd of many thousands had gathered, so that they were trampling on one another, Jesus began to speak first to his disciples, saying: **“Be on your guard against the yeast of the Pharisees, which is hypocrisy.** 2 There is nothing concealed that will not be disclosed, or hidden that will not be made known. 3 What you have said in the dark will be heard in the daylight, and what you have whispered in the ear in the inner rooms will be proclaimed from the roofs.” 4 “I tell you, my friends, do not be afraid of those who kill the body and after that can do no more. 5 But I will show you whom you should fear: **Fear him who, after your body has been killed, has authority to throw you into hell [Gehenna].** Yes, I tell you, **fear him**. 6 Are not five sparrows sold for two pennies? Yet not one of them is forgotten by God. 7 Indeed, the very hairs of your head are all numbered. **Don’t be afraid**; you are worth more than many sparrows.
>
> Luke 12:1-7

If you've been around the hell discussion long enough, you may have heard some advocates of the Augusinian-Calvinist hellfire explain that it's not really God who will send you to hellfire or torture you forever but Satan and his demons or that God doesn't cast anyone to hell because we send ourselves there. However, these same people also often cite Luke 12, contradictingly arguing for the necessity to fear God, who allegedly may throw you into the fire to consume your flesh forever for misdeeds. Luke 12:5, along with Matthew 10:28, has been a subject of intense debate among devout Christians. Some English Bible translations reflect that view well:

> But I will warn you whom to fear: fear the **One** who, after **He** has killed, has the power to throw that person into hell; yes, I tell you, fear **Him**!
>
> NASB

Notice that "One," "Him," and "He" are capitalized, indicating the translator's theological belief that these words speak of God. The NLV takes it a step further, explicitly using the word "God":

> But I'll tell you whom to fear. Fear **God**, who has the power to kill and then throw you into hell. Yes, he's the one to fear.
>
> NLV

However, many other translations have refrained from interpreting the verse, instead adhering to the original Greek text. For instance:

> But I will forewarn you whom ye shall fear: Fear **him**, which after he hath killed hath power to cast into hell; yea, I say unto you, Fear **him**.
>
> KJV

> But I will warn you whom ye shall fear: Fear **him**, who after he hath killed hath power to cast into hell; yea, I say unto you, Fear **him**.
>
> ASV

> But I will show you whom you should fear: Fear **him** who, after your body has been killed, has authority to throw you into hell. Yes, I tell you, fear **him**.
>
> NIV

The meaning of the Greek word *τὸν (ton)* means "to/he/the" (definite article). As you can see, some translations have decided to translate the word "τὸν" in Luke 12:5 as God, while most others have kept it neutral.

The word *μετά (meta)* in verse 5, often translated as "after," can also be translated as "also" or "not only." In that case, the audience is to fear X, who can destroy not only their body but also their soul.

Context

Understanding any verse in the Bible necessitates considering its context. Luke 12 is embedded within a broader dialogue where Jesus discusses matters of the heart. In this segment, the focus is on being wise (12:1) while not being fearful (12:4,7).

The verse in question is part of a passage where Jesus exhorts his followers not to fear their persecutors. Subsequently, Jesus reassures his disciples not to live in fear (12:6-7), emphasizing God's care for them. It seems illogical and contradictory to suggest that Jesus, having devoted this teaching to the theme of not being afraid, would simultaneously instill cosmic fear in his young Jewish disciples. In verses 22-32, Jesus reiterates again his teaching not to fear, emphasizing God's care for them.

Ignoring Luke 12's context has led to confusing and contradictory statements, such as the one expressed by R.C. Sproul in his commentary: *"On the one hand, we should fear Him. On the other hand, we should not fear."* [183]

What if Jesus Did Speak of God?

For the sake of argument, let's assume Jesus was speaking not of Satan or some human authority like a priest, judge, or Roman officials—as some theologians believe—but of God. How, then, can we understand Luke 12:1-7?

Luke 12 begins with Jesus's warning against the *"leaven of the Pharisees, which is hypocrisy."* (12:1). Here, Jesus is warning against the sin of religious hypocrisy. Hypocrisy involves living a double life. On the outside, you exhibit a façade of righteousness and judge others according to religious standards you yourself don't live up to, but behind closed doors, you are filled with evil. That's why Jesus called the

Pharisees *"whitewashed tombs, which look beautiful on the outside but on the inside are full of the bones of the dead and everything unclean"* (Matthew 23:27).

In Judaism, shame is regarded as equally detrimental as death, if not more so (Bava Metzia 59a). Given that Gehenna-hell was an actual geographical location historically associated with shame and still repletes with repulsive waste incinerated in fire and worms-consuming remnants—also symbolizing profound shame—it can be construed as a cautionary tale that God might expose religious hypocrisy, potentially leading individuals to a life of shame.

Long story short, you may be able to fool people but not God, who can and will expose your hypocrisy if you fail to repent. And when He does, society may turn you into an outcast. This is precisely the warning Jesus gives in verse 2:

> There is nothing concealed that will not be disclosed, or hidden that will not be made known. What you have said in the dark will be heard in the daylight, and what you have whispered in the ear in the inner rooms will be proclaimed from the roofs.
>
> Luke 12:2-3

In summary, Luke 12 can be seen as a caution against the sin of hypocrisy, which has the potential to ruin one's soul and lead to being an outcast. Sin's influence extends beyond mere physical death; it can corrupt the soul.

At the national level, this was precisely Israel's fate. The religious leaders of Israel failed to turn away from their hypocrisy, resulting in the devastation of Jerusalem and the temple, followed by exile. Consequently, numerous Jews faced poverty and homelessness, forced to forage for sustenance, enduring what could be described as a literal hell.

Destroy the Soul?

Matthew 10:28 echoes the message of Jesus found in Luke 12, almost verbatim, stating:

> And do not fear those who kill the body but cannot kill the soul. Rather fear him who can **destroy [*apollumi*]** both soul and body in hell [Gehenna].
>
> Matthew 10:28 (ESV)

Here, the Greek word for "destroy" is *"apollumi,"* which, according to Strong's Concordance, means *"to destroy, destroy utterly."*[184] Suppose we follow a literal interpretation of this verse and interpret it as speaking of Hellfire. In that case, the implication is not that of eternal conscious torment but rather the complete cessation of existence—both physical and spiritual annihilation. This stands in contrast to the notion of Eternal Conscious Torment, which suggests ongoing, unending suffering.

Alternative Interpretations

Some scholars suggest that verse 5 refers not to God but to the reality of evil or the social consequences of one's actions. This interpretation aligns with the broader moral and spiritual vigilance theme in Luke's Gospel. Other scholars suggest that the verse speaks of Satan. For instance, N.T. Wright argues:

> Some have seen "the one who can cast into Gehenna" as YHWH; but this is unrealistic. Jesus did not perceive Israel's God as a kindly liberal godfather who would never hurt a fly, let alone send anyone to Gehenna. But again and again—not least in the very next verse of this paragraph—Israel's God is portrayed as the creator and sustainer, one who can be lovingly trusted in all circumstances, not one who waits with a large stick to beat anyone who steps out of line. Rather, here we have a redefinition of the battle in terms of the identification of the real enemy. The one who can kill the body is the imagined enemy, Rome. Who, then, is the real enemy? Surely not Israel's own God. The real enemy is the accuser, the satan.[185]

N.T. Wright

Another possible interpretation suggests this verse speaks of people in authority, those who can both order the killing of your body, put your memory to shame or turn you into an outcast scavenging for leftovers in the Valley of Hinnom just to survive another day. Regardless of the interpretation you feel most comfortable with, it's very unlikely that Jesus alluded to the Augustinian-Calvinist concept of Hellfire.

Fear and Trembling?

Another loved verse by fundamentalists is Philippians 2:12:

> Therefore, my dear friends, as you have always obeyed—not only in my presence, but now much more in my absence—continue to work out your salvation with **fear and trembling**.
>
> Philippians 2:12, NIV

John Bertram Phillips, most noted for his The New Testament in Modern English, wrote:

> I had for some time been worried about the expression "fear and trembling." It did not seem likely to me that Paul in writing to the Philippians could have meant literally that they were to work out their salvation in a condition of anxiety and nervousness. We all know that fear destroys love and spoils relationships, and a great deal of the New Testament is taken up with getting rid of the old ideas of fear and substituting the new ideas of love and trust. I realized that the Greek word translated 'fear' can equally well mean 'reverence' or 'awe' or even 'respect,' but I was bothered about the 'trembling.' Surely the same Spirit who inspired Paul to write to

Timothy that 'God has not given us the spirit of fear; but of power and of love and of a sound mind' could not also have meant us to live our entire lives in a state of nervous terror.... When Paul wrote to the Corinthians and reported that Titus had been encouraged and refreshed by their reception of him, he then went on to say that the Corinthian Christians received him with 'fear and trembling'! (2 Cor. 7:15) Now, this makes no sense unless it is a purely conventional verbal form implying proper respect. [186]

Hell in Book of Acts

If Hellfire were real and thus most central to humanity and Jesus' mission, one might expect primary apostles like Peter and Paul to have emphasized it in their teachings. The Book of Acts, which details the founding of the Christian Church and the spread of its message throughout the Roman Empire, would logically be filled with references to hell. Surprisingly, hell is never mentioned in Acts—not even once. This absence suggests that the apostles never considered the concept a critical element of their Gospel message.

The various books of the Bible are intended to deliver distinct messages. The Book of Acts, for instance, focuses heavily on the dissemination of the gospel, as demonstrated by its documentation of the gospel being preached approximately 25 times!

- Acts 2:14-41 - Peter's sermon at Pentecost
- Acts 3:11-26 - Peter's sermon at Solomon's Colonnade
- Acts 4:8-12 - Peter before the Sanhedrin
- Acts 5:29-32 - Peter and the apostles before the Sanhedrin
- Acts 7:1-53 - Stephen's speech before the Sanhedrin
- Acts 8:4-8 - Philip in Samaria
- Acts 8:26-40 - Philip and the Ethiopian eunuch
- Acts 9:20-22 - Saul (Paul) in Damascus
- Acts 10:34-43 - Peter at Cornelius' house

- Acts 13:16-41 - Paul in Pisidian Antioch
- Acts 14:1-7 - Paul and Barnabas in Iconium
- Acts 14:8-18 - Paul and Barnabas in Lystra
- Acts 16:13-15 - Paul in Philippi with Lydia
- Acts 16:25-34 - Paul and Silas with the Philippian jailer
- Acts 17:2-4 - Paul in Thessalonica
- Acts 17:10-12 - Paul in Berea
- Acts 17:22-31 - Paul in Athens at the Areopagus
- Acts 18:4-11 - Paul in Corinth
- Acts 19:8-10 - Paul in Ephesus
- Acts 20:17-38 - Paul's farewell to the Ephesian elders
- Acts 22:1-21 - Paul's defense in Jerusalem
- Acts 24:10-21 - Paul before Felix
- Acts 26:1-29 - Paul before King Agrippa
- Acts 28:23-31 - Paul in Rome

These references illustrate the widespread and varied contexts in which the early apostles shared the gospel, emphasizing its central role in the Book of Acts.

Paul, known as *"the apostle to the Gentiles"* (Romans 11:13), clearly believed that the Gospel should be proclaimed *"to the Jew first"* (Romans 1:16). This belief was evident in his practice of first seeking out the local synagogue to preach the Gospel in every Gentile city he visited (E.g., Acts 9:20, 13:5, 13:14, 14:1, 17:1-2, 18:4).

The Book of Acts documents many occasions where the apostles shared the gospel with both Jews and Gentiles. Notably, they never use the concept of hellfire as a tool for persuasion or mention it at all. For example, Peter's sermon at Pentecost in Acts 2 focuses on the resurrection of Jesus and the fulfillment of prophecy, urging for the adoption of the Christian message. Similarly, in Acts 17, Paul *"reasoned in the synagogue with both Jews and God-fearing Greeks, as well as in the marketplace day by day with those who happened to be there."* Paul's public speech at the Areopagus

likewise emphasizes the nature of God, the need for repentance from pagan idols, and the resurrection of the dead, yet makes no mention of hellfire.

Walter Balfour, an 18th-century theologian, wrote:

> If Gehenna means a place of endless misery for the wicked, it is a fact that the apostles never preached it, either to Jews or Gentiles. The history of the Acts of the apostles, contains an account of their preaching for thirty years, but not once is the subject of hell or Gehenna torments, mentioned by them. They were commanded to preach the gospel to every creature, and they did so, but to no creature under heaven, did they ever preach this [hellfire] doctrine. No living being did they ever threaten with such a punishment. They addressed the worst of characters, but to none of them did they ever say, "How can ye escape the damnation of hell?" They did threaten men sometimes with punishment, but never with eternal punishment in hell.[187]

The central themes in the apostolic message are the resurrection of Jesus, the fulfillment of Old Testament prophecies, the call to repentance from pagan idols, the forgiveness of sins, and the promise of eternal life. The focus is on the individual and social transformative power of Jesus' resurrection and the establishment of God's kingdom on earth. For instance, in Acts 10, Peter preaches to Cornelius, a non-religious Roman Gentile centurion, and his household about Jesus' life, death, and resurrection, being Lord of all, and even mentioning forgiveness of sins through faith in Jesus, without any reference to hell.

The nonexistence of hellfire in apostolic preaching suggests that the early Christians preached a gospel different from the one that was later formed by Augustine, Calvin, and other thinkers. Instead, their original Gospel message centered on the hope and renewal found in Jesus Christ for individuals and communities alike. This is evident in passages such as Acts 13:38-39, where Paul speaks about justification through Jesus, contrasting it with the inability of the Law of Moses to justify. However, there were no threats or any mention of hellfire.

Understanding the historical and cultural context of the New Testament helps explain why hell was nonexistent in apostolic preaching. The concept of hell as a place of eternal torment evolved much later, over centuries, influenced by various cultural and theological developments. In the first-century Jewish context, the primary concerns were adherence to the Law, the coming of the Messiah, and the resurrection of the dead. The apostles addressed these concerns by presenting Jesus as the fulfillment of the Law and the prophets and by emphasizing the hope of resurrection, never mentioning hell in their preaching.

A Different Gospel?

The absence of hellfire in the apostolic message raises significant theological questions. If hellfire were indeed a central tenet of the Christian faith, why did the apostles, who laid the foundation of the early Church, not emphasize it or even mention it in their foundational evangelistic preaching in the Book of Acts? This omission strongly suggests that the core message of the gospel is not centered around the fear of eternal torment but rather on the promise of life, renewal, and the fulfillment of God's promises through Christ.

If the concept of hellfire is not rooted in the teachings of Jesus or His apostles, then its origin must be questioned. It is likely a product of human imagination, developed over time to instill fear as a means of control. Worse still, it may be a tool of deception introduced by Satan to distort the true nature of God, shifting the focus from God's love and mercy to a fear-driven view of the Creator. In this light, the absence of hellfire in the early Christian message challenges us to reevaluate its validity as a doctrine of the Christian faith.

Conclusion

The Book of Acts provides a compelling insight into the early Christian message. The apostles, in their efforts to spread the gospel, did not rely on the concept

of hellfire to persuade their audience. Instead, they emphasized the resurrection, forgiveness of sins, repentance from idol worship, and the fulfillment of God's promises. This absence of hell in their preaching suggests that the early Christian message was fundamentally different from some modern versions, focusing on hope, transformation, and the realization of God's kingdom rather than fear of eternal torture. This understanding challenges contemporary interpretations and invites a re-examination of what truly lies at the heart of the gospel.

Racing for What?

The Apostle Paul, once a Jewish Pharisee of the strictest order (Acts 26:5), was certainly familiar with the concept of an afterlife. Unlike the Sadducees (a sect of Jews active in Judea during the Second Temple period), the Pharisees believed in the resurrection of the dead. Paul is considered by many to be the Bible's most prolific and scholarly writer, with nearly half of the New Testament credited to him. However, Paul, despite dedicating thousands of words to teaching theological doctrine, did not once systematically address the concept of hellfire. It would seem that an eternal place of relentless torment would merit a dedicated portion, if not several, by such an apostle. Rather, there are only a few instances where Paul allegedly alluded to or hinted at the concept of hell, at least in the view of some preachers. Let's examine his letter to the Corinthians first.

1 Corinthians 9:24-27

> Do you not know that in a race all the runners run, but only one receives the prize? So run that you may obtain it. Every athlete exercises self-control in all things. They do it to receive a perishable wreath, but we an imperishable.
>
> 1 Corinthians 9:24

According to Calvinist preacher Tim Conway, *"What Paul is saying in these verses is this: Eternal life hangs on the way we run the race!"*[188] Likewise, according to John Piper, *"Eternal life hangs on the way we run and the way we fight."*[189]

Evidently, some may overstretch Paul's use of this analogy by reading a hellfire threat into his message. This approach risks several problematic and even bizarre outcomes.

For instance, if Paul were speaking of being saved from hellfire, it would imply he advocates for salvation based on strenuous effort rather than grace. Salvation, according to Ephesians 2:8-9, is a free gift from God through faith in Jesus Christ, not a prize earned through human effort. You work hard and compete for prizes, respect, honor, etc., not for freely given gifts, which is what salvation is. Interpreting Paul's analogy as a warning of hellfire may cause unnecessary anxiety and promote legalism, suggesting that one's salvation is contingent upon one's performance rather than God's grace. Additionally, a literal interpretation might imply that Paul believes salvation is reserved for a single individual, as he says, *"All the runners run, but **only one** receives the prize."*

Paul's True Message

Indeed, there is much to gain and lose in the Christian journey, yet it has nothing to do with hellfire. Paul's analogy is meant to encourage believers to pursue their Christian walk with the same dedication and discipline as an athlete training for a race. The focus is on striving for spiritual growth and living a life that honors God. The "prize" Paul speaks of is not to be rescued from hellfire and eternal torture but the rewards and honor that come from a life of faithful service and perseverance. Or, if using Jesus' words, *"Whoever practices and teaches these commands will be called great in the kingdom of heaven."* (Matthew 5:19).

Unfortunately, many Christians seem more concerned with securing a golden ticket into heaven and avoiding an alleged eternal cosmic toaster than actually living out their calling. If we truly love God and understand His love for us, we wouldn't be so obsessed with saving our own skins from Him. Instead, we'd focus on growing the

kingdom—not through fear tactics terrorizing people's souls, but by reflecting the love of God—not the sadomasochistic Augustinian-Calvinist god some conjured up.

Paul's emphasis on self-control and discipline reflects the importance of living out one's faith in a tangible way. However, this does not mean that eternal life is contingent upon human effort. Instead, Paul encourages believers to fully engage in their spiritual journey, aiming for the rewards that come from a life well-lived in accordance with God's will. This echoes the earlier teaching of Paul from a few chapters before: *"The one who plants and the one who waters have one purpose, and each will be rewarded according to their own labor."* (1 Corinthians 3:8). Just as running, racing, and receiving prizes are rewarded for effort, so are planting, watering, and earning wages. Thus, it is about the reward for one's work, not about avoiding neverending torture.

Racing for the "Crown of Life"

Modern cultures rarely use crowns; when they do, they're typically reserved for royalty. However, the term "crown" in the original text is "*Stephanos*," which also means "reward" or "laurel wreath." In ancient Greek Olympics, the Stephanos were given to the victors of athletic competitions.

Scripture mentions several different crowns (rewards). For instance, the *Everlasting Crown*, the *Crown for the One who Wins Souls*, the *Crown of Righteousness*, the *Crown of Glory*, and the *Crown of Life*.[190]

Thus, much like modern Olympic medals, each crown represented a reward for specific acts of service or excellence in God's Kingdom. It seems these crowns will be rewarded to believers at Christ's Judgment Seat. Hence, these crowns are not synonymous with escaping hellfire or receiving eternal life but are additional rewards for Christians who fulfill certain tasks and exhibit particular behaviors.

As an example, let's take the Crown of Life (not to be confused with "eternal life"), mentioned in James 1:12 and Revelation 2:10. This crown represents a special reward for those who persevere, especially through trials and persecutions. Revelation 2:10 reads, *"Be faithful until death, and I will give you the crown of life."* Jesus promises

special honor to those who remain steadfast in their faith despite severe persecution or death due to their faith in him.

Conclusion

In conclusion, by employing the metaphor of a race, Paul vividly illustrates that the Christian journey requires sustained effort, self-control, and a focus on the eternal rewards that God promises to those who diligently follow Him. This perspective shifts the focus from a fear-based motivation to one of striving for greatness in God's Kingdom. Interpreting passages such as 1 Corinthians 9:24-27 as hinting at a warning of hellfire is a misreading that leads to incorrect theological assumptions with unfortunate implications on mental and emotional health. Paul's message is about the importance of dedication and discipline in the Christian life, encouraging believers to strive for spiritual rewards. Salvation remains a gift of grace, not a prize earned through human effort. Therefore, it is essential to understand Paul's analogy in its proper context, recognizing the metaphorical language used to inspire believers to live faithfully and purposefully.

Everlasting Destruction (2 Thessalonians 1:8-9)

2 Thessalonians 1:8-9 is often cited by proponents of Eternal Conscious Torment (ECT) as a key passage supporting the doctrine of hellfire. However, a careful analysis of the text within its context and its numerous intertextual allusions reveals that Paul is not teaching about eternal torture in fire. Let's explore why this is the case.

> This will happen when the Lord Jesus is revealed from heaven in blazing fire with his powerful angels. He will punish those who do not know God and do not obey the gospel of our Lord Jesus. They will be punished with everlasting destruction and shut out from the presence of the Lord and from the glory of his might.
>
> 2 Thessalonians 1:7-9

At first glance, taken literally, *"punished with everlasting destruction"* appears, once again, to support the final annihilation view, not an ongoing torment in fire. However, a deeper analysis suggests a different interpretation. While we have covered some of these phrases before, I will offer a quick analysis in this chapter.

Paul's words in these verses are rich with allusions to other parts of Scripture. For instance, the imagery of Jesus being *"revealed from heaven with His mighty angels"* (2 Thessalonians 1:7) echoes similar imagery used by Jesus in Matthew 13:36-43 and Matthew 25:31-46. Both of these passages refer to the destruction of nations and

communities that ignore God's ways and neglect the needy, not to eternal torment in fire.

Additionally, when Paul writes about *"the presence of the Lord and the glory of His power,"* he likely has texts such as Isaiah 2:19-21 and Isaiah 66:15-16, 24 in view. Isaiah 2:19-21 describes people hiding from the terror of the Lord and the splendor of His majesty when He rises to shake the earth. Isaiah 66:15-16 speaks of the Lord coming in fire to execute judgment. Both passages emphasize God's judgment and the complete destruction of the wickedness from the earth, but not eternal conscious torment in the afterlife.

The phrase *"from the presence of the Lord"* is key to understanding Paul's point. The Greek term for "presence" (*prosōpou*) literally means "face." This was a specific idiom referring to the honor and majesty of God. Therefore, the destruction mentioned is linked to the violation of God's honor rather than a physical separation from His presence.

In biblical times, honor and shame were paramount cultural values. To be in the presence of the Lord (before His face) meant to be in a state of honor and approval. Conversely, to be removed from His presence signified disgrace and dishonor. Thus, Paul is talking about the consequences of dishonoring God, which leads to earthly ruin, the absence of blessings and protection, and loss of honor, not eternal fiery torment.

Temporal Consequences, Not Eternal Torment

In verse 7, Paul suggests that the judgment he speaks of will not occur in another dimension after death. Rather, *"This will happen when the Lord Jesus is revealed from heaven."*

Paul uses three key phrases: *"repay with tribulation," "vengeance with flaming fire,"* and *"punished with everlasting destruction."* All these phrases describe immediate consequences rather than eternal punishment in the afterlife.

1. **Repay with Tribulation:** The Greek word for tribulation (thlipsis) refers to temporal calamity or trouble in this life, not eternal suffering. It implies the immediate hardships and distress faced by those who oppose God's ways.

2. **Vengeance with Flaming Fire:** The concept of vengeance is parallel to the idea of repayment. The flaming fire represents the immediate destructive consequences of sin in this life. As seen throughout Scripture, fire often symbolizes God's purifying judgment, not eternal torment (e.g., Malachi 3:2-3, Hebrews 12:29).

3. **Punished with Everlasting Destruction:** The word "punishment" (*dikēn tisousin*) is better translated as "pay the penalty." This penalty refers to the natural outcomes of sin. The term "everlasting destruction" (*olethron aiōnon*) signifies irreversible ruin in this life. Like a car totaled in an accident or a vessel shattered on the floor, the destruction is complete and cannot be undone, but it does not imply ongoing torment in the afterlife. If it does speak of the afterlife, it would advocate for annihilation.

Paul previously used the same word translated as "destruction" in 1 Corinthians 5:5:

> Hand this man over to Satan for the **destruction** of the flesh, so that his spirit may be saved on the day of the Lord.
>
> 1 Corinthians 5:5

Clearly, "destruction" for Paul indicated physical ruin in the earthly life rather than a fiery torment of the soul in the afterlife.

Figurative Language and Cultural Context

The Bible often uses fire as a symbol of God's judgment and purification. For example, Malachi 3:2-3 describes God as a refiner's fire, and Hebrews 12:29 calls God "a consuming fire." These metaphors illustrate God's purifying judgment rather than literal flames of torment.

When Paul writes about "flaming fire," he uses imagery that his readers would associate with divine judgment and purification, not eternal conscious torment in the afterlife. The destruction is both final and complete, manifesting in this life and reducing the plans and ambitions of the wicked to naught.

Paul's language aligns with other biblical passages that speak of God's judgment bringing complete and irreversible destruction. For example, Sodom and Gomorrah

were destroyed by fire as a judgment from God (Genesis 19:24-25). Jude 1:7 refers to this event as *"punishment of eternal fire,"* but Sodom and Gomorrah are not still burning today. The fire represents the complete destruction of a culture, empire, plan, or individual and the irreversible judgment they experienced.

Similarly, Paul's reference to "everlasting destruction" should be understood as a complete and final ruin of the wicked's plans and ambitions, not as an ongoing torment in fire in the afterlife. The judgment leads to a state where their actions have no lasting significance or impact.

Conclusion

In verse 4, Paul boasts *"about your perseverance and faith in all the persecutions and trials you are enduring."* Paul intended to boost the morale of the Thessalonians, often suffering from persecution, assuring them not with a remote idea intended for a distant future but with the conviction that their current trials would eventually be overcome and a promise that the persecutions would ultimately fail.

Therefore, 2 Thessalonians 1:8-9, when examined in context and understood with its intertextual references, does not teach eternal conscious torment in Hellfire. Instead, Paul speaks about the temporal and irreversible consequences of rejecting God's honor and the persecution of His children. The destruction is complete and final but occurs in this life, leading to the eventual ruin of the plans and goals of those who oppose God.

Tartarus (2 Peter 2:4-6)

The passage of 2 Peter 2:4-6 is ambiguous and subject to much debate, with a range of opinions and interpretations. Proponents of Eternal Conscious Torment (ECT) frequently cite it as supporting evidence for the concept of hellfire. However, this interpretation has significant challenges, as the text within its context and intertextual allusions reveal a different understanding. Let's explore why Peter is not teaching about eternal torture in Hellfire.

2 Peter 2:4-6 states:

> For if God did not spare angels when they sinned, but cast them into hell [**tartaroó**] and committed them to pits of darkness, held for judgment; and did not spare the ancient world, but protected Noah, a preacher of righteousness, with seven others, when He brought a flood upon the world of the ungodly; and if He condemned the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah to destruction by reducing them to ashes, having made them an example of what is coming for the ungodly…
>
> 2 Peter 2:4-6

Tartarus is used metaphorically to describe the gloomy, dark place where rebellious angels are held, awaiting judgment. Tartarus appears in the Septuagint translation of Job (40:20 and 41:24) and in Hellenistic Jewish literature, such as the Greek text of the ancient Book of Enoch. In Enoch, God places the archangel Uriel "*in charge of*

the world and of Tartarus" (20:2), where Tartarus is understood as the prison for 200 fallen angels.[191]

Does "Tartarus" Refer to Hellfire?

The word "Tartarus" appears only once in the New Testament, in 2 Peter 2:4, where Peter describes God's action of casting the angels who sinned into Tartarus and delivering them in chains of darkness while they await judgment. To understand Peter's words, it is crucial to identify the symbolism of Tartarus and the event to which Peter refers.

In Greek mythology, Tartarus is both a primordial deity and a place. As a place, it is a dungeon for the Titans, the second generation of primordial deities defeated by the Olympian gods. Some humans, like King Sisyphus and King Tantalus, were also believed to be sent to Tartarus for severe crimes.

When Peter references Tartarus, he does not endorse Greek mythology but uses familiar cultural concepts to make a point. Just as Christians today might use cultural references without endorsing their underlying ideologies, Peter uses Tartarus to illustrate the severe consequences of the angels' rebellion without supporting the mythological details.

Peter's reference to angels bound in chains of darkness could point to two different biblical events:

1. **The Angelic Rebellion:** Some believe Peter refers to the angelic rebellion described in Isaiah 14:12-21 and Ezekiel 28:1-19.
2. **The Sons of God in Genesis 6:** Others think Peter refers to the events of Genesis 6:1-4, where the sons of God had children with the daughters of men, resulting in the Nephilim. This view is supported by 1 Peter 3:19-20 and Jude 6, which speak of spirits in prison and angels bound for their sins in Noah's days, which Peter mentioned as well.

However, both views face a possible challenge. If all the sinful angels were bound in Tartarus, how could Jesus encounter evil spirits during His ministry, and how could

Satan still be active (1 Peter 5:8)? Unless, of course, the imagery in 2 Peter 2:4 is symbolic rather than literal.

Symbolic Chains of Darkness

If the imagery in 2 Peter 2:4 is symbolic, it may refer to the fear and anticipation of judgment that immobilizes the rebellious angels. Wisdom of Solomon 17:17 describes the ninth plague of darkness in Egypt as a "chain of darkness," which is symbolic rather than literal.

Peter's description of angels bound in chains of darkness suggests they are constrained by the knowledge of impending judgment rather than physical chains. This symbolic interpretation aligns with the biblical theme of God's judgment bringing chaos and disorder back into submission.

Even if one insists on a literal interpretation, it is crucial to note that Peter's description does not include humans being sent to Tartarus. Scripture does not teach that humans will suffer in Tartarus. Therefore, Tartarus cannot be equated with the concept of hellfire as a place of eternal torment for humans.

Conclusion

2 Peter 2:4-6 does not teach about hellfire or eternal conscious torment. The dark abyss symbolizes chaos and disorder, not a place of eternal suffering. Tartarus, whether understood literally or symbolically, refers to the judgment of rebellious angels, not humans. Therefore, the notion that 2 Peter 2:4-6 supports the concept of hellfire is unfounded.

By examining the context, intertextual allusions, and symbolic language, it becomes clear that Peter is emphasizing the severe consequences of rebellion against God, not describing a place of eternal torment. This understanding aligns with the broader biblical narrative of God's judgment and the ultimate restoration of order in His creation.

Jude

The Epistle of Jude, which was written to warn of the destructive concourses of false doctrines, is often cited by the Augustinian-Calvinist Eternal Conscious Torment proponents as supporting the concept of hellfire. For instance, in John MacArthur's commentary on Jude verse 23, he claims the fire is *"the fire of hell."*[192]

However, a closer examination of the text, context, and the use of figurative language reveals that Jude is not teaching about endless torture in hellfire but rather warning against the immediate and destructive consequences of following false teachers. Let's explore this in detail.

> Now I want to remind you, though you know everything once and for all, that the Lord, after saving a people out of the land of Egypt, subsequently destroyed those who did not believe. And angels who did not keep their own domain but abandoned their proper dwelling place, these He has kept in eternal restraints under darkness for the judgment of the great day, just as Sodom and Gomorrah and the cities around them, since they in the same way as these angels indulged in sexual perversion and went after strange flesh, are exhibited as an example in undergoing the punishment of eternal fire...
> ...And have mercy on some, who are doubting; save others, snatching them out of the fire; and on some have mercy with fear, hating even the garment polluted by the flesh.
>
> Jude 1:5-7, 22-23

Jude 1:7 - Eternal Fire and Sodom and Gomorrah

Jude 1:7 states, *"Sodom and Gomorrah…are exhibited as an example in undergoing the punishment of eternal fire."* Are Sodom and Gomorrah still burning today? No. How, then, can Jude say they underwent a punishment of eternal fire? Because it's figurative language.

In this context, "eternal fire" represents the complete and irreversible destruction that befell these cities. It does not imply that the physical fire is still burning. As we previously covered, the term "eternal" here is used to describe the totality and finality of the judgment. The **consequences** of the destruction were permanent, but the fire itself was not.

Interestingly, in Matthew's gospel, Jesus uses the same Greek words translated as "eternal fire" (Matthew 18:8). Jesus says, *"And if your hand or your foot causes you to sin, cut it off and throw it away. It is better for you to enter life crippled or lame than with two hands or two feet to be thrown into the eternal fire."* Most would agree that Jesus was speaking figuratively when He talked about cutting off a hand or foot. Therefore, it only makes sense that Jesus also spoke figuratively about "eternal fire" in the same way Jude did.

The broader biblical context supports this figurative interpretation. As we previously covered, the Bible often uses fire as a symbol of God's judgment and purification, not necessarily as a literal description of eternal torment. For instance, Malachi 3:2-3 describes God as a refiner's fire, purifying the Levites. Similarly, Hebrews 12:29 calls God "a consuming fire," which speaks to His purifying and judging nature, not to literal flames.

Strange Flesh

Sodom and Gomorrah are often associated with homosexuality. However, "Strange Flesh" refers to the desire for human flesh by angels, as depicted in the story

of Sodom, signifying a forbidden yearning between an angel and a human rather than sexual acts between humans. Hermeneutically, 'strange flesh' is never linked to homosexuality in Scripture. The term 'strange' is incompatible with homosexuality, which occurs within the same gender, race, and species and is not 'foreign.' The primary sin of Sodom and Gomorrah was not idolatry or homosexuality, as these were common in many cities. Instead, it was the intent to interact with visiting angels. In Genesis 6, angels sought human flesh; in Sodom, humans sought the 'strange' flesh of angels. This is why Sodom is associated with angels in the New Testament and why it was punished so severely. This distinction is crucial for the context of the angel's "eternal restraints," preventing them from once again interacting with humans.

Jude speaks of angels in the context of false teachers to illustrate the severity of rebellion against God. Just as the rebellious angels were judged and punished, false teachers will also face judgment for leading others astray. The connection underscores the consequences of abandoning God's truth.

Jude's references to fire and eternal fire are metaphorical, highlighting the destructive consequences of false teachings and immoral behavior. These passages warn of immediate, permanent, earthly destruction rather than eternal torture. The figurative use of language is consistent with the broader biblical context, emphasizing God's judgment and purification rather than eternal torment. Therefore, Jude does not teach about hellfire but about the serious, immediate consequences of straying from the truth.

Jude 1:23 - Snatching from the Fire

With that context in mind, in Jude 1:23, we read, *"Save others by snatching them out of the fire."* If this were speaking of an individual's salvation from hellfire, then it would place the responsibility on people, not God, to save from hellfire, which contradicts the central message of the Bible about salvation being solely a work of God.

Here, *"saving"* means rescuing people from the destructive consequences of following false teachers (Jude 1:4, 11). The phrase *"snatching them out of the fire"* is metaphorical, suggesting the act of rescuing individuals from a dangerous or perilous situation—namely, the **false doctrines** that threaten their faith and spiritual well-

being. This metaphor indicates that the people being "saved" are in a hazardous state that could lead to severe negative consequences in their earthly lives. They are not being saved from an afterlife situation but from an immediate effect on their lives —false teachings that will devastate their lives. In a way, this also represents the purpose of the book.

For example, consider a loved one being misled by harmful teachings and consequently joining a cult that could ruin their life. You can rescue that friend from the grips of the cult, much like pulling someone out of a fire.

A modern example of this could be the prosperity gospel, where individuals lose their life savings to charlatans promising financial blessings in exchange for donations. This "fire" is not about eternal damnation but false teachings' immediate, destructive impact.

The Book of Life

Revelation is a book steeped in symbolism and metaphor, written in the apocalyptic genre. It features descriptions of beasts, dragons, flying horses, and other imagery that first-century readers would not have interpreted literally. The apocalyptic genre is characterized by vivid imagery and symbolic language meant to convey deeper spiritual truths rather than literal descriptions.

Revelation 3:5: Being Blotted Out of the Book of Life

> He who overcomes shall be clothed in white garments, and I will not blot out his name from the Book of Life; but I will confess his name before My Father and before His angels.
>
> Revelation 3:5

This verse has caused much anxiety among Christians, as it appears to imply that Jesus might blot out names already written in the Book of Life, suggesting a loss of eternal life and torture in hellfire. This statement is made to the church in Sardis, indicating that those who overcome will be clothed in white garments, and their names will not be blotted out of the Book of Life.

What is the Book of Life?

In the Hebrew Scriptures, the "Book of the Living" lists those presently alive on the earth, whether righteous or wicked (Exod. 32:32-33; Deut. 29:20; Ps. 69:28; Isa. 4:3).

The Book of Life/Living is mentioned in the Bible in three ways:

1. **The Book of the Living:** Psalm 69:28.
2. **The Book of Life:** Philippians 4:3; Revelation 3:5; 20:12, 15.
3. **The Lamb's Book of Life:** Revelation 13:8; 21:27.

Whether discussing the Book of Life or the Lamb's Book of Life, the fundamental point remains that those whose names are written in these books are alive. Different interpretations exist about whether these are two separate books or one single book with varying functions. One interpretation suggests the Book of Life lists everyone who is alive, while the Lamb's Book of Life lists those who will receive great honor. Another interpretation is that there is only one Book of Life.

In John's time, many towns, including Sardis, had citizenship rosters listing the names of their citizens. When a person died, their name was removed from the roster. Additionally, if a person committed severe crimes and brought great shame upon the town, they might also be removed from the roster.

A critical point is that Scripture does teach about names being blotted out of the Book of Life, but this does not refer to losing eternal life. To be an overcomer, one must faithfully love, serve, and honor Jesus throughout their life.

The promise to never remove an overcomer's name from the Book of Life symbolizes a tribute of great honor and respect. It indicates that those who faithfully serve Him will receive special recognition. However, this does not mean that those who fail to overcome will be tortured in hellfire or lose their eternal life.

Likewise, Sardis boasted of her trade in woolen goods and dyed fabrics. In ancient times, *"white garments"* connoted honor, festivity, and victory. White robes (or garments) symbolize respect, honor, and tribute.

Litotes in Revelation 3:5

Since Jesus taught that eternal life can never be lost (John 3:15-18; 4:10-14; 5:24; 6:35-40; 10:28-29; 11:25-26; et al.), it is best to understand the words, *"and I will not blot out his name from the Book of Life"* (3:5), as a figure of speech called a litotes. Litotes is an understatement in which a positive affirmation is expressed by negating the opposite. For example, saying, "I will not stop loving my wife as long as she makes me ice cream," does not mean I will stop loving her if she does not make ice cream. It emphasizes my love for her, with the ice cream being an added delight.

Similarly, when Jesus says He will not blot out the names of those who overcome from the Book of Life, He uses an image the recipients are already familiar with to emphasize the special honor and blessings for those who remain faithful. This does not imply that those who fail to overcome will be tortured in fire forever.

In conclusion, not having one's name acknowledged is simply to forfeit the Master's "Well done" (cf. Matt. 25:21, 23; Luke 19:17, 19).

The Lake of Fire, Sulfur and Smoke (Revelation)

Very little in the book of Revelation could be interpreted literally. While it is crucial to read and study the book thoroughly, appreciating its language, imagery, and themes, it is equally important to recognize the book's genre and that almost every element in Revelation is steeped in references to Hebrew Scriptures, first-century culture, and Roman politics. For instance, Revelation tells of a massive red dragon with seven heads, a beast rising from the sea, having ten horns and seven heads, locusts with human faces, four colorful flying horses, and two witnesses with fire coming out of their mouths burning up their enemies. Interpreting these images literally may result in bizarre conclusions. Similarly, we ought to view depictions such as a lake of fire and sulfur not necessarily as tangible or actual locations but the way the original recipients understood them—as metaphors.

Lake of Fire = The Dead Sea

During the First-Temple period, what we now know as 'the Dead Sea' or 'the Sea of Salt' was sometimes called the Lake of Fire,[193] or the Fiery Lake.[194] This historical context is vital for understanding the symbolic meanings behind Revelation's "lake of fire and sulfur" imagery.

For thousands of years, up to the first century, the Dead Sea was known for its regular eruptions that discharged tar, pitch, bitumen, asphaltites, smoke, sulfur, and

flames. Consequently, the Greeks named it "Lake Asphaltites" due to these fiery, asphalt-spewing occurrences.[195]

Philo said that the valley of the Dead Sea was filled with fires, which were very difficult to extinguish, and that many of these fires had been smoking and burning for a very long time.[196]

The first-century geographer Strabo named the valley *"a land of fires"* because there were frequent boiling outbursts of fire in the region, and the entire area smelled of sulfur and brimstone.[197]

It is common to witness individuals from all over the world, afflicted with various skin conditions, flocking to the Dead Sea, the lowest point on Earth's surface. They are attracted by its waters, rich in minerals such as sulfur and renowned for their healing and purifying qualities. Submerging in the Dead Sea's waters may feel like dipping in fire, as it can often be intensely painful, especially if the water enters your eyes or if you have a skin condition or even a tiny cut. However, it also has remarkable healing properties that are worth the pain.[198]

In Judaism, the lake was traditionally viewed as a place where sinful objects could be cast away. According to the Talmud, *"Any vessels that had on them the image of the sun, or of the moon, or of a dragon, 'let them cast them into the salt sea.'"*[199] Similar to Christianity, Judaism associates baptism in the Mikvah (pool of water) with the purification from sin. It is believed that a Jew *"...immerse in the Mikvah...[it] helps him to do Teshuva and purify himself from his sins."* [200]

In Jewish thought, water is often associated with purification. The ritual bath of Mikvah is a prime example of how immersion in water symbolizes spiritual cleansing in Judaism. Connecting the dots, we can argue that since the Dead Sea is a pool of salty water, it can serve as a metaphor for purification by painful baptism, where sin and impurity are left behind in the symbolic "dead" waters.

Revelation 20:10

> The Devil who deceived them was thrown into the lake of fire and sulfur, where the beast and the false prophet are also. They will be tormented day and night forever and ever.

Revelation 20:10

Some Bible translations depict the Lake of Fire as the most terrifying place imaginable—a realm of eternal torture in fire.

No one in ancient Israel would have imagined a lake like Lake Michigan, which is about 22,400 sq mi in size. Rather, the largest lake in Israel is called, quite amusingly, the Sea of Galilee, which is about 64 sq mi. Therefore, the Lake of Fire should not be understood as an enormous lava lake encompassing billions of individuals in it. If anything, it's more likely the Apostle John refers not to a lake at all but a small pool of molten metal akin to a crucible.

The Greek term "*limné*," translated as "lake," can refer to a pond of any size, suggesting a small pool of molten metal akin to what one would find in a refiner's crucible rather than an expansive lake of lava.

Undoubtedly, for a Jew, the mention of fire and sulfur evokes the biblical imagery of Sodom and Gomorrah: *"Then the Lord rained on Sodom and Gomorrah* ***sulfur*** *and* ***fire*** *from the Lord out of heaven."* (Genesis 19:24). However, consider the future hope presented in Ezekiel in light of the events of Genesis 19:

> When I bring back their captives, the captives of Sodom and her daughters, and the captives of Samaria and her daughters, then I will also bring back the captives of your captivity among them.
>
> Ezekiel 16:53-55

Evidently, Ezekiel perceived the final outcomes of God's judgment on Sodom in a very positive light.

In ancient times, fire and sulfur symbolized the gold refining process, essentially a crucible of molten gold with sulfur added to remove impurities. Sulfur, or brimstone, has been used in metal refining since ancient times.[201] One significant use of sulfur in ancient metal refining involved its ability to convert unwanted metals into sulfides. These sulfides would then react and smoke, allowing the purer metals, such as gold, to settle at the bottom of the crucible. This method was effective in removing impurities from the metal, enhancing its purity and value.[202]

This fact is also evident in biblical texts such as Revelation 3:18, where Christ advises, *"I counsel you to buy from me gold refined by fire,"* using the imagery of gold refined in fire while admonishing the church in Laodicea.

In modern times, sulfur's role in industrial processes remains vital. For instance, sulfur is a key component in the production of sulfuric acid, which is crucial for numerous industrial applications, including fertilizer production, petroleum refining, and chemical manufacturing. The United States Mint and other modern facilities continue to utilize sulfur in these processes to ensure the purity of metals used in coin production and other applications. Sulfer also has other uses, including medical treatment for certain skin diseases (a popular method for treating infections up until the 1940s), insecticides and fungicides, glass production, and other kinds of refinements.[203]

In ancient perceptions, fire and sulfur, though painful, were considered positive and beneficial elements, rather than the Middle Ages' view of them as symbols of sadistic punishment and eternal tomentous abuse.

The word "torment" in scriptures is translated from the Greek *basanizó*, which originally referred to a touchstone—a black, silicon-based stone used to test the purity of precious metals. Thus, the term should be understood not as torture but as a (perhaps very unpleasant) process of testing purity and refinement.

Further, the Greek words translated as *"forever and ever"* are sometimes also translated—and perhaps better rendered as—*"in the ages of ages,"* indicating a future period of time, not the modern philosophical concept of "eternity," one which is absent from the Bible, as we previously established.

Revelation 14:10-11

Revelation 14:10-11 reads:

> They, too, will drink the wine of God's fury, which has been poured full strength into the cup of his wrath. They will be tormented with burning sulfur in the presence of the holy angels and of the Lamb.

> And the smoke of their torment will rise for ever and ever. There will be no rest day or night for those who worship the beast and its image, or for anyone who receives the mark of its name.
>
> Revelation 14:10-11

Revelation 14:10 notes that the torment received by certain people occurs *"in the presence of the holy angels and in the presence of the Lamb"* (Jesus). This raises an intriguing question: Does the presence of Jesus and the angels, possibly symbolic of the church's spirits as suggested in Revelation 1:20, mean that the tormented are only suffering when in their presence? It seems unlikely that heavenly entertainment would include sadistically witnessing the suffering and burning of others, as this contradicts the idea of restful peace described in Revelation 14:13.

Instead, it seems that John is indicating that the torment experienced by these individuals is linked to their allegiance to the beast and its image. The presence of Jesus and his righteous assembly becomes a source of agony for them because it confronts their actions and beliefs. This idea is supported by Revelation 11:10, where the preaching and mere presence of the two witnesses tormented those opposed to their message. The torment, then, appears to be metaphorical—an internal conflict and spiritual anguish experienced by those confronted with the righteousness and truth of Jesus.

Then, the description of smoke rising forever and ever is a vivid metaphor emphasizing the finality and completeness of God's judgment. A smoked sacrifice means that the sacrificed animal will not stand up and run again.

Revelation serves as a warning against idolatry and rebellion and stresses God's justice but does not necessarily imply unending suffering in the afterlife. The focus is on the lasting consequences of rejecting God's ways rather than perpetual afterlife torment.

Revelation 20:14

> Then Death and Hades were cast into the lake of fire. This is the second death.
>
> Revelation 20:14

If the Lake of Fire were a place of eternal torment, it would be illogical and nonsensical to cast abstract concepts (Death and Hades) into it. The fact that intangible, abstract concepts or powers such as Death and Hadēs are cast into the Lake of Fire strongly indicates that the Lake of Fire itself is also an intangible, abstract concept. Metaphorically, the Lake of Fire—or God's purifying judgment—overcomes even death and the Grave. In other words, death and Hades are destroyed—there is no more death. This more closely aligns with the notion of a benevolent God.

The second death signifies the ultimate defeat of death itself, aligning with 1 Corinthians 15:26, where death is described as the last enemy to be destroyed. The term "second death" indicates the finality of this destruction. The context suggests a symbolic representation of the complete eradication of death rather than a cosmic ongoing process of abuse and torture.

The casting of Death and Hades into the lake of fire symbolizes the end of their power and influence. It represents the culmination of God's redemptive plan, where death is swallowed up in victory (1 Corinthians 15:54). The second death is not about eternal suffering but about the ultimate triumph of the God of Life (Genesis 2:7, Job 33:4, Acts 17:25, John 1:3-4, Psalm 36:9) and the eradication-through-transformation of everything that opposes Him. The *second death* is where death dies.

Yes, God is the God of Justice and the Lord of Hosts (1 Samuel 1:3), but He is also rich in mercy (Ephesians 2:4) and Mighty to Save (Zephaniah 3:17). Human kings and generals kill and destroy, but the God of Israel also restores and resurrects. Death is not the end. Death, too, will be cast into the purifying Lake of Fire and Sulfur.

Revelation 21:8

> But as for the cowardly, the faithless, the detestable, as for murderers, the sexually immoral, sorcerers, idolaters, and all liars, their portion will be in the lake that burns with fire and sulfur, which is the second death.

Revelation 21:8 again mentions the lake that burns with fire and sulfur, calling it the second death. Death represents finality, marking the end or conclusion rather than an unending ordeal. The inclusion of fire and sulfur reinforces the idea of purification. The list of sins mentioned (cowardice, faithlessness, etc.) are behaviors that lead to destruction and chaos in life. This is not to suggest that cowards will be tortured forever. The second death symbolizes the final eradication of these destructive behaviors through purification. The focus is on the ultimate defeat of sin, not eternal torment. The use of "death" emphasizes the end or termination of these negative influences, aligning with the broader biblical narrative of renewal and restoration. The use of "death" (end, concluded, ceased) rather than perpetual suffering indicates an end to the destructive influence of these behaviors. Remember the promise from just four verses earlier:

> He will wipe every tear from their eyes. There will be no more death or mourning or crying or pain, for the old order of things has passed away.
>
> Revelation 21:4

The only way to completely eliminate mourning and crying is either to erase and flash everyone's memories (Men in Black) so they don't remember their loved ones or to reconcile everything and everyone, which is only something truly omnipotent (all-powerful) and omnibenevolent (all-loving) God can accomplish. Therefore, the

second death is portrayed as a necessary step in the divine process of eradicating evil and purifying creation. The lake of fire serves as a divine crucible, purging sin and restoring holiness. This interpretation aligns with the biblical theme of God's judgment being restorative rather than merely punitive.

Satan, Saved?!

Deciding the fate of Satan is definitely not in my pay grade. However, many theologians and Church Fathers' views on Satan's salvation present a fascinating and controversial aspect of early Church theology. For example, Gregory of Nyssa, a saint in Eastern Orthodoxy, Catholicism, Oriental Orthodoxy, Anglicanism, and Lutheranism, is noted for his belief in all-inclusive salvation, a doctrine known as *apokatastasis* (literally translates to "restoration" or "reconstitution," implying a return to an original or proper condition). This concept suggests that all of creation, including Satan, will ultimately be restored and reconciled to the almighty God.

Gregory of Nyssa argued that since God is the ultimate source of all good and is infinitely loving and just, the ultimate purpose of God's punishments must be corrective rather than purely punitive. He believed that the process of purification would eventually lead to the repentance and redemption of all beings, including the Devil. This perspective stems from his understanding of divine justice and love, which he saw as incompatible with the idea of endless, purposeless torture.

This view was rooted in Gregory's interpretation of scripture and his reflections on the nature of God and evil. He saw the fire of divine judgment not as a literal fire of eternal torment but as a purifying fire meant to cleanse and transform. Therefore, even Satan, the embodiment of evil, would not be exempt from this ultimate purification and restoration.

There's much to debate and scrutinize. You might reject the idea that Satan can be redeemed, or perhaps you question his very existence. You might contest the idea that hell is essential for purification or dispute Gregory's interpretation of the Ransom Theory of Atonement, which influenced Christianity for a millennium. Yet, Gregory's theories stem from a fundamental belief about God: that He is not only just but also

loving, kind, good, forgiving, compassionate, and gracious—even to sinners (Matthew 5:45).

Gregory argued that God created humanity not out of necessity but from a place of overflowing love, and His motives for wanting to restore His creation are similarly driven.

Embracing the concept of all-inclusive reconciliation held by some of the Church Fathers is challenging, and to be honest, from an emotional standpoint, as a Jewish individual reflecting on the atrocities committed by individuals like Hitler against our people, it's not easy for me to comprehend this concept. Yet, I recognize God is much more gracious and loving than I will ever be! Therefore, reflecting on Gregory's perspectives can be valuable and much better reflects God's character than the concept of eternal torment in Hellfire, which seems at odds with the notion of a loving, kind, benevolent, forgiving, compassionate, and gracious God.

Conclusion

The original audience would have most likely understood fire, sulfur, brimstone, smoke, and imagery of torment (testing of metals) as metaphors for purification, corrective judgment, and eradicating evil, not eternal conscious torment in Hellfire. Additionally, the cultural context of the early Christians, who were familiar with Jewish apocalyptic literature, would have led them to interpret these symbols in line with themes of divine justice, discipline, restoration, and renewal.

In summary, the lake of fire and sulfur appears to indicate a metaphorical refiner's crucible with sulfur, tested for purity. The process is one of refinement, not eternal torment. It embodies divine judgment, potentially letting wrongdoers feel the pain they inflicted while ultimately being saved—even if *"as one escaping through the flames"*—reflecting the principle that mercy prevails over judgment: *"Where sin increased, grace increased all the more"* (Romans 5:20).

Conclusion

If you aim to educate and warn your child about the dangers of hard drugs, it's logical to do so well in advance rather than during or after they've started using. Similarly, if the concept of Hellfire is as crucial as believed—impacting everyone's eternity—one would expect it to be clearly and prominently communicated from the earliest stages of the biblical text.

However, when we examine the progression of how Hellfire is discussed in biblical texts, there's a notable absence in the places where it might be most expected. This absence raises questions about the clarity and priority given to the concept in the scriptures.

Initially, God warns Adam and Eve only of mortality—no mention of eternal torture of some kind, just a life of toil followed by death. Then, throughout the entire Torah, there is not a single warning of eternal Hellfire.

Concurrently, surrounding pagan cultures have rich mythologies featuring fiery underworlds for the wicked, yet these ideas are not reflected in early Jewish theology or anywhere in the Old Testament.

More Questions Than Answers

The biblical trajectory suggests a much later evolution of the concept rather than a clear, divinely mandated truth. This raises critical questions about the origins

and emphasis of Hellfire in Christian doctrine—was it divinely revealed or humanly embellished over time?

We have explored the most frequently cited Bible verses purported to support the concept of eternal torment in Hellfire, and upon careful examination, it becomes clear that none of these scriptures definitively teach that Hell is a place of perpetual abuse and torture.

The Sermon on the Mount contains the first significant cluster of references to Gehenna (Matthew 5:22, 29, 30). But if the idea of eternal Hellfire doesn't appear in the Old Testament, how could Jesus teach the Jewish people about an afterlife of torment in a place they had never been warned about in their own scriptures? And if he was introducing this concept for the first time, why did he speak of it so casually yet ambiguously, as though His listeners were already familiar with it? But in fact, the historical understanding of Gehenna among the Jews was not that of a place of everlasting torture in the afterlife but rather a location associated with shame, filth, divine consequences, and the worst forms of idol worship.

The Augustinian-Calvinist view of Hellfire as a place of eternal torment is arguably the most critical doctrine for one's life. Even if some doctrines are gradually unveiled throughout scripture, it seems very improbable that this fundamental and essential doctrine would be hidden and unknown for thousands of years.

Furthermore, if Hellfire were real, how is it possible that the Apostles, especially Paul—who God commissioned to preach the full counsel of the gospel (Acts 20:27)—not once preached "turn or burn" nor dedicated his theological teachings to exploring that doctrine? The Book of Acts, which meticulously details the early Church's efforts to spread the gospel, would surely emphasize the dangers of Hellfire if it were central to the Christian Good News.

In the science of hermeneutics, proper Bible interpretation must be based on the clear and straightforward scriptures. Thus, instead of taking Jewish metaphors and ambiguous verses and interpreting them through the wrong genre and out of context, we should give precedence to the scriptures that clearly articulate God's ultimate plan for humanity's redemption.

Focus On What Scriptures Made Clear

Paul's writings in Romans 5 boldly declare that Christ's victory is far greater than Adam's transgression. Suppose Paul believed in eternal Hellfire for the majority of humanity. How could he confidently write:

> For no one is cast off by the Lord forever. Though he brings grief, he will show compassion, so great is his unfailing love.
>
> Lamentations 3:31-32

> Consequently, just as one trespass resulted in **condemnation for all people**, so also one righteous act resulted in **justification and life for all people.**
>
> Romans 5:18-19

All means all. Paul echoes this sentiment in 1 Corinthians, stating,

> For as in Adam **all die**, so in Christ **all will be made alive**.
>
> 1 Corinthians 15:22

This is not merely a Pauline theology. In John's gospel, it is written:

> Jesus did not come to judge the world but to save it.
>
> John 12:47

And in John's first letter:

> If anybody does sin, we have an advocate with the Father—Jesus Christ, the Righteous One. **He is the atoning sacrifice for our sins, and not only for ours but also for the sins of the whole world.**
>
> 1 John 2:1-2

Such verses suggest a much more inclusive scope of Christ's redemption rather than a narrow escape from eternal torment for only an elect few. Additionally, Paul asserts that,

> We have put our hope in the living God, who is the **Savior of all people**, and especially of those who believe.
>
> 1 Timothy 4:10

If Hellfire were an imminent threat to the majority of people, wouldn't Paul's message be more about escaping that fate than declaring Christ's all-encompassing salvation?

Similarly, in Revelation 21:5, we are reminded of the hope in God's renewal of all things:

> And he that sat upon the throne said, "Behold, I make **all things** new."
>
> Revelation 21:5

Not few. Not some. Not even many. All things.

This is further supported by Colossians, which speaks of God's intention...

> To reconcile to himself **all things**, whether on earth or in heaven, making peace by the blood of his cross.
>
> Colossians 1:20

The ultimate goal of God's plan, according to Philippians, is that:

> At the name of Jesus **every knee** should bow, in heaven and on earth and under the earth
>
> Philippians 2:10

Likewise, in 1 Timothy, Paul emphasizes that:

> God our Savior...wants **all people** to be saved and to come to a knowledge of the truth.
>
> 1 Timothy 2:3

This aligns with Jesus' mission statement in John 12:47, *"Jesus did not come to judge the world but to save it."* The most crucial question, then, is whether the God who *wants all people to be saved* is indeed wise enough to bring His good will to fruition.

The grand narrative of redemption reaches its climax in the preachings of Acts, where it is stated that:

> *Heaven must receive him until the time comes for God to **restore everything**, as he promised long ago through his holy prophets.*
>
> Acts 3:21

Everything encompasses all living things, not just trees, dirt, and water. The scope of this restoration is as broad as the promise of Psalm 22:

> All the ends of the earth shall remember and turn to the Lord, and **all the families** of the nations shall worship before you.
>
> Psalm 22:27

In conclusion, we ought to suspect doctrines only seen in the Bible through a late blurry interpretive lens and focus on what the Scriptures made clear.

The scriptural evidence leans heavily towards a message of correction and restoration rather than physical, emotional, and mental sadistic torment that never stops. The verses often cited to support Hellfire do not withstand scrutiny when placed in their proper context. Perhaps it is time Christianity reconsiders the Augustine-Calvinist theology, Hellfire included, and embraces a more scripturally faithful understanding of God's ultimate plan for humanity. Yes, the God of Israel is a God of Justice and the Lord of Hosts (1 Samuel 1:3), but He is also rich in mercy (Ephesians 2:4) and Mighty to Save (Zephaniah 3:17). He is the God who restores and resurrects.

Part IV

Hell: An Alternative View

Introduction

We are logical beings created in the image of a logical God. Theology—Theos (God) and Logos (reasoning, understanding, etc.) in Greek—is a logical understanding of God or faith-related doctrine. Therefore, like any other doctrine, I believe the concept of hell—whatever that may be—must also make sense to a healthy human mind.

Jews make great lawyers, meaning we can be "too logical," a polite way of saying some, myself included, come across as intellectual yet emotionally detached. I'll be honest—religious legalism had a lot to do with that. But since 2022, I've made it a top priority for myself to work intensely on my emotional intelligence, striving to balance both heart and mind. Through this journey, I've realized something crucial: the doctrine of Hellfire not only fails the test of logic but also deeply contradicts anything we know about Love.

As Jews, the Hebrew Scriptures form the bedrock of our faith and worldview, guiding our understanding of God, morality, and life's purpose. These sacred texts are not only a historical record of our people but also a living source of wisdom and instruction, shaping our theology, identity, and how we interact with the world. They provide the framework for the Jews' beliefs and practices, influencing every aspect of our lives.

Old Testament theology depicts a world riddled with suffering, injustice, confusion, and death, but it also offers the hope that God's reign will eventually restore creation and rectify all wrongs. This hope is embodied in the prophetic anticipation of a Messiah who would bring about this divine restoration.

Transitioning to the New Testament, we encounter Jesus, proclaimed as the Savior of the World. Here, a seemingly new concept emerges—eternal conscious torment. According to this narrative, humanity now confronts the potential of eternal torture in Hellfire unless it figures out spiritual beliefs correctly. Apparently, not merely recognizing Jesus suffices; individuals must also embrace the correct theological doctrines and exhibit their best behavior. However, the ultimate verification of their destination will only be revealed after death.

Despite the suffering, injustice, confusion, and death already inherent in human existence, this new Hellfire teaching is supposedly meant to offer humanity comfort and peace. Today, Hellfire has become the central message of the gospel in Western Christianity. Ironically, none of the prophets in the Old Testament spoke of such a fate, yet Jesus's arrival supposedly brings this "new revelation" that claims to be the ultimate glad tidings of great joy: the avoidance of eternal torment in Hellfire, a fate that, in this view, the majority of people will inevitably fail to avoid.

This radical shift from the Old Testament's hope of restoration to the New Testament's terror of eternal torturous punishment raises significant theological questions. How could the long-awaited Messiah, who was expected to bring healing and renewal, instead introduce a doctrine that only generates further fear, anxiety, and strife? The dissonance between the Hebrew Scripture's vision of God's redemptive plan and this supposed new doctrine of eternal torment casts doubt on the legitimacy and consistency of such a revelation within the broader narrative of Scripture.

Despite what some religious voices claim, emotions are not weaknesses to be shunned; rather, they are the language of our souls, reflecting our deepest connections to God, others, and ourselves. Emotions are divine gifts woven into the fabric of our being, designed to guide us, protect us, and ultimately enrich our lives in ways that pure logic alone cannot achieve. To dismiss emotions as irrelevant or unworthy is to ignore a crucial aspect of our humanity—an aspect that God Himself endowed us with. When we embrace our emotions alongside our logic, we allow for a more holistic understanding of the world around us. We see with greater clarity, not just through the cold lens of reason but also through the warm glow of empathy, compassion, and kindness.

I believe this dual approach is particularly vital when examining complex man-made doctrines. By integrating both heart and mind, we can better discern the truth, ensuring that our beliefs are logically sound and resonate deeply with the core of our

being, aligning ourselves more closely with the divine intention behind the emotions we were given, using them as a powerful tool to navigate the spiritual journey that shapes our lives.

No Fear In Love (1 John 4:18)

This is a short testimony I came across on YouTube from a woman who grew up in what seems a conservative, fundamental Christian home:

> When I was 6 or 7, I burned my hand and it was excruciating. My mother took the opportunity to say, *"Imagine if that feeling was all over your entire body? That's what hell is like FOREVER; it never stops, and that's why you don't want to sin."*
> That was absolutely terrifying to me. I never forgot that lesson. Fear is a very effective tool to make people comply. [204]

Fear, an ineffective motivator for genuine heart change and spiritual growth, is intended to restrain evil actions and people. The concept of eternal Hellfire as a motivation for faith has long been a cornerstone of the Augustinian-Calvinist message. However, this idea warrants careful scrutiny because it fundamentally contradicts the essence of God's nature as portrayed in Scripture. Love, not fear, should be the foundation of our relationship with God; as John clearly states, *"There is no fear in love. But perfect love drives out fear, because fear has to do with punishment. The one who fears is not made perfect in love."* (1 John 4:18). A faith rooted in existential dread, particularly that of eternal punishment, distorts our understanding of God and leads to unhealthy spiritual, emotional, and relational consequences.

Hellfire as Motivator

The Gospel is a message of love, not fear. Jesus summarized the Law and the Prophets with the command to love God with all our hearts, souls, and minds and love our neighbors as ourselves (Matthew 22:37-40). This is the essence of the true ancient Christian faith—a faith that is not driven by fear but by love.

Love and existential dread are mutually exclusive in the context of a healthy relationship. The Hebrew word for "faith" is also the word for "trust." The idea that God would use the threat of endless torture in Hellfire as a means to compel us to trust Him is fundamentally flawed—a truly loving parent cannot threaten their child's life with fire and demand that they love them in return to avoid it. Likewise, if our faith in God is rooted in fear, then it is not truly trusting. You cannot genuinely trust someone you also fear will harm you at the slightest misstep. A faith built on fear of Hellfire is inherently unstable, prone to collapse under its own weight. Existential dread breeds suspicion and anxiety, not the peace and security that trust in God offers:

> Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you and learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For my yoke is easy and my burden is light.
>
> Matthew 11:28-30

Fearing eternal torture in a cosmic fire chamber does not bring rest, gentleness, or lightness. In fact, it produces the exact opposite—it's fear that burdens us and wears us down. This type of fear is not considered a "healthy fear."

A Loving Father, Not a Sadistic Tyrant

Imagine someone causing you a ceaseless, excruciatingly painful, and abusive form of physical, mental, and emotional torture. As you beg for them to stop, they ignore you and continue. They even seem to receive some form of satisfaction from it. This is essentially the definition of sadism.

Sadism is typically defined as deriving some sort of pleasure or satisfaction from inflicting pain, suffering, or humiliation on others. When considering the concept of eternal punishment or torture—such as the Augustinian-Calvinist doctrine of Hellfire—the infliction of endless suffering without hope of relief or redemption aligns closely with the definition of sadism. A cosmic form of sadism.

Why are kindness, love, grace, empathy, peace, forgiveness, and patience considered godly characteristics? Because they manifest God's love in tangible ways.

Kindness involves loving others, whether they are sinners or not. Love encompasses offering forgiveness despite ignorance or immaturity. Justice aims for correction and rehabilitation rather than revenge or abuse.

This raises significant philosophical, theological, and moral questions. The notion of a deity who enforces eternal, unending punishment can be problematic, as it conflicts with the attributes of mercy, justice, and love that the Bible often ascribes to God.

Given God's qualities, why would one believe that God would eternally torture and abuse sinners both physically, mentally, and emotionally? Surely, if these benevolent attributes truly reflect God's nature, He would be far kinder and more loving than a high school bully, transcending any act of cruelty with compassion and mercy. God is the greatest suitor, able to eventually persuade all of mankind and have us all fall in love with Him.

God wouldn't continue what Hitler, ISIS, and Hamas had started. He's not like them. God is not some intimidating, zealous ex-boyfriend who says, *"If you don't love me back, I'll kill you!"* We'll never convince the world that the God of Christ is their loving Father in heaven with the sadistic, cruel, merciless Hellfire doctrine because not only is it false but also because it portrays Him as a narcissistic, sadistic psychopath tyrant.

The idea that a God of infinite intellect, wisdom, justice, love, and power would not only fail to save but also condemn beings with limited rationality and heightened emotions—traits stemming from their creation—to eternal torment or allow them to damn themselves due to misunderstanding, delusion, pain, fear, and anger, seems more characteristic of a pagan deity than the God revealed through Jesus. The Augustinian-Calvinist concept of Hellfire, perhaps the most horrific notion ever conceived by religious imagination, presents an irrational and spiritually damaging portrayal of existence.

According to New Testament scholar and theologian N.T. Wright:

> The vision of God that people have is distorted, and so many people are actually put off the gospel—they just say, *"No, that sounds like a bullying God. If there is a God, he can't really be like that."* When some people talk about the gospel, you'd think that John 3:16 said: *"God so hated the world that he killed his only Son."* Sometimes people say: *"That picture is important—wrath and sin and hell and all the rest of it, and it's because God loves us."* But simply adding the word "love" onto the end of that story can actually be even worse. It is like what abusers do when they say, *"I love you so much"*—it's hideous. [205]

As a Jew, I am certain that the Jewish community would never accept and adopt this version of a Hitler-like "Jesus," who perpetually burns in fire 99% of all Jews.

The Psychological Effects of Fear of Hellfire

A healthy parent-child relationship is based on love, security, and trust, not fear of being tortured or killed. When a child fears that any mistake might result in severe or eternal punishment, it warps their understanding of love and justice. Similarly, when believers are taught to be fear-driven, it distorts their understanding of God's love and justice, leading to a religious faith that is more about self-preservation than genuine love for God and others.

A common attribute in most, if not all, pagan religions is the threat of eternal torture. Fear-based faith often leads to hypocrisy because it prioritizes strict adherence to rules over the underlying principles and virtues these rules aim to foster. This can lead to behaviors where individuals conform externally to the regulations while their internal attitudes and actions may not align with the spiritual and moral essence those laws are supposed to embody.

Furthermore, focusing on external conformity can create a culture of judgment and comparison, where the emphasis shifts from personal spiritual growth to monitoring others' adherence to the rules—religious judgmentalism. This environment can encourage people to hide their true selves and failings, leading to a disparity between public righteousness and private behavior, which is the essence of hypocrisy.

Belief in Hellfire often leads to stress, anxiety, and other mental health issues because it creates a pervasive and constant existential fear. This fear can manifest in several ways that are detrimental to an individual's mental and emotional well-being:

1. **Perpetual Fear and Anxiety:** The belief that any mistake or sin could result in eternal torment creates an overwhelming sense of dread. This can lead to chronic anxiety, as individuals may fear they are never good enough or constantly at risk of divine retribution. The uncertainty about whether they are "saved" or have met the necessary conditions to avoid eternal Hellfire often causes significant mental distress.
2. **Guilt and Shame:** When an individual's understanding of God and the gospel is centered around sinfulness and imperfection, it can result in overwhelming feelings of guilt and shame. Individuals might feel trapped in a cycle of sin and repentance, never feeling fully forgiven or free from the threat of punishment as they are unable to reach perfection. This can erode self-esteem and contribute to feelings of worthlessness or despair.
3. **Disruption of Relationships:** The fear of Hellfire can distort one's view of relationships, both with God and with others. If individuals believe that love is contingent on perfect behavior or that they must constantly earn God's favor to avoid Hellfire, it can lead to strained relationships, both spiritually and socially. They may become judgmental of others or isolate themselves out of fear of being influenced by "sinful" behavior, leading to loneliness and social anxiety.

4. **Development of Mental Health Disorders:** Over time, the constant fear of eternal punishment can contribute to the development of mental health disorders, such as depression, generalized anxiety disorder, or scrupulosity (a form of obsessive-compulsive disorder focused on religious or moral issues). The relentless focus on avoiding Hellfire can overshadow other aspects of life, leading to a diminished ability to experience joy, peace, or a sense of purpose.
5. **Fear of Death:** Belief in Hellfire can exacerbate the fear of death, as individuals may be terrified of what awaits them in the afterlife. This fear can become paralyzing, making it difficult for individuals to live fully in the present or to find comfort in their faith.

I believe the doctrine of eternal Hellfire could explain the reason why, sometimes, the more religious someone is, the more detached they are from their emotions—it's a coping mechanism.

In summary, a fear-based faith is not only theologically unsound but also psychologically damaging. It creates an environment where believers are more concerned with avoiding punishment than with truly loving God and others. In contrast, a faith rooted in love leads to spiritual growth, healthy relationships, and a deeper understanding of God's true nature:

> For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power and of love and of a sound mind.
>
> 2 Timothy 1:7

The Origin of Fear-Based Religion

If it is true that *"there is no fear in love"* (1 John 4:18) and *"God has not given us a spirit of fear"* (2 Timothy 1:7), then it prompts the question: who introduced the daunting doctrine of Hellfire into religion?

When considering the possibility of a figure such as the Devil, it becomes plausible that the idea of eternal Hellfire might be one of his most cunning deceptions and schemes against the people of God. The Devil, as a being with immense experience and knowledge of the human soul, would understand that fear-based belief fundamentally distorts our identity as individuals and society, overshadows humanity's relationship with God, and ultimately pushes humanity away from the God of Israel. By promoting the idea that God demands nothing but absolute perfection and that any failure may result in eternal torment in Hellfire, the Devil succeeds in painting God in a distorted way once again (as he did in Genesis 3:4), this time as a tyrannical figure rather than a loving Father. Cunningly, he does this from within the church, effectively acting as a theological Trojan Horse.

This theological distortion results in a legalistic view of faith and life, where fearful adherents concentrate on evading punishment instead of fostering loving relationships with God and fellow beings. Twisted theologies have the tendency to affect how people view themselves and others, often leading to a community that is rigid, judgmental, and lacking in grace. Our wise Messiah once instructed us to test teachers by their fruit. If the fruit of pastors and preachers is that many of their followers slowly become cynic, unkind, judgmental, and angry—emulating the characteristics they attribute to their deity—it may indicate their beliefs' true nature and source.

Remember, the ultimate goal of any theological deception is to keep believers and unbelievers from experiencing the fullness of God's love and from spreading that love to others. One way, perhaps the primary way Satan is instilling fear in Christians is by making them think that God's justice demands torturing them forever. By promoting this fear-based belief, Satan achieves several goals.

For instance, when believers operate out of fear, it influences their behavior and interactions with others. Fear breeds insecurity, judgment, and a performance-based mentality. This can lead to a legalistic approach to faith and life, where the emphasis is on following rules, self-comparison with others, and avoiding punishment rather than genuine love, kindness, and compassion. This fosters a rigid, unforgiving community—aka 'religion.'

Moreover, a fear-based relationship with God can skew the Christian's perception of all relationships. If we believe that we must earn, maintain, or preserve God's love or else be eternally tortured, we may start to believe that all love must be

earned, leading to dysfunctional relationships characterized by anxiety, control, and conditional acceptance.

In contrast, when believers understand God's love and grace, it transforms their lives. They become secure in their identity as beloved children of God, which fosters genuine love and compassion towards others—even enemies and sinners—because they see God not as a harsh tyrant but as a loving, forgiving Father whom they seek to emulate. This, in turn, shapes their worldview to be more hopeful, kind, and forgiving.

Thus, Satan's tactic of promoting fear-based religiosity is ultimately a strategy to keep humanity from experiencing the fullness of God's love and from spreading it onwards.

I am aware that there are stories and videos online of people who dreamt or allegedly had a supernatural vision of Hellfire and are now preaching it. I'm not sure what—or who—is behind their dreams or "visions," but I tend to believe it's an expression of their subconscious fears. I also know that Satan is very active in the supernatural dimension and that the purpose of demons is not to reveal the truth but to confuse, scare, and frighten us. They'll do whatever it takes so we live in fear, including lying and pretending. Thus, I would take these "dreams and visions" of Hellfire with a large grain of salt.

Throughout biblical accounts, Satan, the chief of demons, is consistently depicted as employing lies and distortion to confuse, scare, cause fear, mislead humanity, and oppose God's truth. His tactics with Adam and Eve and his attempts to distort the Scriptures with Jesus illustrate his deceptive nature:

> For there is no truth in him. When he lies, he speaks his native language, for he is a liar and the father of lies.
>
> John 8:44

Satan isn't lurking to startle you from the shadows beneath your bed. His methods are far more profound. Remember, Satan's titles, such as *"the tempter," "father of lies,"* and *"the accuser,"* underscore his fundamental role as a deceiver. Given that his ultimate goal is to oppose God, his words and those of his minions can never be trusted. Being the accuser, deceiver, and liar, he would definitely want to make us all believe God wants to burn us forever.

In a comic sense, Satan is like the malevolent older sibling who frightens the younger ones by hissing in their ears, *"You must hide, for if Father comes and discovers this, he will surely kill you!"* So we hide in fear. We hide "among the trees of the garden" (Genesis 3:8), and we hide behind our self-righteousness, traditions, and religiosity from the One who seeks to cover us and forgive our sins.

The danger in believing anything coming from a demonic source, be it through a seance, a vision, a dream, or any other method, lies in their expertise in deception, honed over millennia. But it doesn't conclude with the supernatural. Evil also manifests in the ability to transform narratives and appearances within human culture, disguising itself one day as a devout religious figure and the next as a militant atheist. Additionally, demons' profound understanding of theology and human psychology and their use of sophisticated strategies far exceed human comprehension, making the ability to discern truth a challenging skill to master.

But Wouldn't People "Backslide" Without Fear?

The argument that Christians would "backslide" into committing terrible acts without the looming threat of eternal torture in fire is not only a bleak view of God but also deeply flawed logically. If such a threat is the only thing keeping someone from wrongdoing, it raises serious questions about the authenticity and depth of their faith. True faith should be motivated by love, compassion, and a desire to do good, not by fear of punishment.

If the only thing stopping you from doing evil to others is the threat of eternal conscious torment, then you're simply a malevolent person on a leash.

Looking at the example of my Jewish friends, both secular and religious, it's clear that moral and ethical behavior does not require the fear of eternal damnation. They live according to a strong moral code and values, often sacrificing for the sake of complete strangers without the looming threat of eternal fire. This suggests that morality and ethics can be deeply rooted in values other than existential fear.

The fear-based approach to faith also undermines the very essence of God's desire for a relationship with His people. Fear can lead to compliance but does not foster heart change, growth, love, trust, or genuine devotion. The God of the

Hebrew Scriptures consistently calls His people to love Him and to love one another, grounding their actions in love rather than in existential fear. True faith is not about avoiding punishment; it's about cultivating love, compassion, and righteousness, as exemplified in the teachings and life of Jesus Christ.

Biblical Justice

As humans, we have the tendency to be overly judgmental due to a combination of psychological, religious, and social factors. However, the ability to quickly assess situations and people was always crucial for survival and social cohesion. Psychologically, judgment helps simplify the complexity of human behavior and social interactions, providing a sense of control and predictability. Socially, cultural and religious norms and values shape our perceptions of what is acceptable or desirable, leading us to judge those who deviate from these standards. Personal insecurities and the desire to elevate one's social status also strongly drive judgmental behavior, as comparing ourselves to others can affirm our values or sense of self-worth.

A truly competent judge diligently gathers and scrutinizes all relevant data and evidence, listens attentively to diverse perspectives, and poses critical questions. This thorough process requires considerable time and effort to ensure fair and just decision-making. Despite this, we often judge each other harshly and unjustly, relying on gossip, incomplete information, and prejudice. This hasty judgment lacks the rigorous methods necessary for fairness, leading to injustice in our interactions and society. In contrast, divine justice prioritizes restorative justice over retributive justice. If it were not so, our very existence would be in question.

Therefore, one of humanity's major challenges is that we tend to be overly judgmental and often lack the skills to judge justly or with compassion. Our judgments are frequently based on partial data, such as gossip and one-sided perspectives. Simultaneously, religion often judges harshly, believing it has a God-given mandate to condemn and ostracize those who fail to uphold its moral standards

and traditions. This approach often leads to significant misunderstandings and social discord.

Biblical Justice

> Mercy and truth are met together; righteousness and peace have kissed each other.
>
> Psalm 85:10

The Augustinian-Calvinist view of justice is often synonymous with retribution. This perspective, deeply ingrained in Christian consciousness, equates justice with the dispensation of punishment, where the scales are balanced by penalizing the wrongdoer. However, this view of justice differs markedly from the concept of justice in Ancient Near Eastern (ANE) societies, especially the one reflected in the biblical narrative and Judaism. In these societies, justice was less about retribution and more about restoring order, peace, and, most importantly, reconciliation.

Ancient Near Eastern (ANE) Justice

Consider the biblical injunction to *"love your neighbor as yourself,"* a principle that echoes throughout the scriptures. This commandment encapsulates the essence of ANE justice—it's about harmonious coexistence and the prevention of harm to others. Of course, punishment can be severe in extreme cases, but generally speaking, when harm does occur, the goal isn't to exact punishment for its own sake but to mend the breach and restore peace and harmony.

Take, for example, the biblical approach to premarital sex. In the Old Testament law, the "punishment" for premarital sex was not a corporal or a public display of repentance but rather a marriage, provided the couple was willing and able. The Law seems to prioritize the stability of the relationship and the rehabilitation of the individuals involved rather than mere retribution.

Thus, the biblical concept of justice is not about vengeance but about reconciliation and restoration. It's about correcting wrongs in a way that repairs society, not about inflicting pain for the sake of divine sadistic satisfaction. Biblical justice is motivated by love and compassion, not vindictiveness.

Justice in Judaism

In Judaism, justice, or *"TZEDEK,"* is a foundational concept deeply woven into the fabric of Jewish law, ethics, and theology. It is the opposite of a legalistic black-and-white approach and a divine imperative that seeks to reflect the very character of God. Jewish tradition teaches that God's throne is built on two pillars: *DIN* (judgment) and *RACHAMIM* (mercy). These two attributes are seen as complementary forces that guide the divine approach to justice, ensuring that it is both fair and compassionate.

The Hebrew Bible emphasizes justice as a key component of righteousness. In Deuteronomy 16:20, the Torah commands, *"Justice, justice shall you pursue,"* a verse that underscores the importance of fairness and equity in all aspects of life. Many Jewish scholars interpret the repetition of the word "justice" as a call to not only seek justice but to do so justly, with integrity and righteousness. However, Jewish justice is not rigid or harsh. It is tempered by mercy and compassion, reflecting the belief that while justice is necessary, it must be balanced with understanding and forgiveness.

The Jewish legal system, as codified in the Talmud, also reflects this balance between judgment and mercy. For example, the Sanhedrin, the ancient Jewish court, was extremely cautious in cases involving capital punishment. The Mishnah (Makkot 1:10) states that a Sanhedrin that executed one person in seven years was considered bloodthirsty, highlighting the value placed on life and the reluctance to impose the ultimate penalty. This cautious approach stems from the belief that while justice must be served, it should not be pursued without consideration of the potential for repentance and transformation, akin to God's character.

Furthermore, the prophetic tradition in Judaism emphasizes that true justice involves care for the vulnerable and marginalized. The prophets often condemned Israel for not upholding justice for the poor, widows, orphans, and strangers, frequently leaving them with no choice but to resort to criminality.

The prophet Micah summarizes the essence of biblical ethical teaching with the words: *"He has told you, O mortal, what is good; and what does the Lord require of you but to do justice, and to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God?"* (Micah 6:8). This captures the harmonious relationship between justice, mercy, and compassion, which are essential in the pursuit of a just society. By pursuing justice with compassion, Israelites were called to create a society that is not only fair but also caring and inclusive, embodying the divine ideals of righteousness and compassion.

Who Determines Justice?

In a courtroom, it is the judge, often called by the title "Justice," who determines the just outcome. Similarly, God is not subject to any external rules and is the ultimate arbiter—He creates the rules. This isn't just about God's ability to punish sin; it's about His sovereign choice to either punish or forgive. If human judges possess this discretion, why wouldn't God, with infinitely greater authority and wisdom, have the same latitude?

The Unjust Nature of Eternal Hellfire

According to God's law, justice is to be proportional—you can't burn someone for lying and cheating, but they have to pay a fine (Leviticus 6:2-5). The principle of *"an eye for an eye"* (Exodus 21:24) was meant to ensure that punishment fits the crime, preventing excessive retribution and overreaction. Eternal Hellfire, however, represents an infinitely disproportionate punishment for finite human sins. The notion of endless torment for the mistakes of a limited lifespan contradicts the very concept of justice as portrayed in the Torah. If God's justice is truly just, it cannot condone the idea of eternal suffering as a consequence of the sins of a single lifetime. Such a punishment not only violates the principle of proportionality in God's own Law but also distorts the image of God into that of a sadistic tyrant rather than a loving, corrective Father.

Consider, for example, the Old Testament law that limits a maximum of 40 lashes as punishment, even for severe crimes (Deuteronomy 25:3). In a society where it was common for slaves to be beaten to death, laws were enacted to prevent the degradation of an individual beyond what was deemed just. If God's Law is so careful to limit and prevent excessive punishment in earthly matters, how much more so would this apply to eternal matters? The idea of eternal Hellfire, therefore, seems not only disproportionate but contrary to the very laws, values, and character of God as revealed in the Bible.

The Compassionate Nature of God's Justice

> Mercy triumphs over judgment.
>
> James 2:13

Imagine a little girl named Leah. Leah is seven years old, in first grade, and fully capable of making her own decisions. In the morning, she disobeyed her mom, and on the way to school, upset and emotional, Leah said something very unkind to her mom that hurt her feelings. Although Leah saw she had hurt her mom's feelings, Leah refused to apologize.

That day, a terrorist attack took place in the school, and 7-year-old Leah was murdered without ever repenting for her behavior. If it was up to you, would you sentence this child to eternal torture? Assuming your answer is *"Of course not!"* then let me ask you – who is more gracious and compassionate, you or God?

The Bible portrays God's justice as fundamentally compassionate and merciful (Exodus 34:6-7, Psalm 103:8-14). These attributes seem at odds with the concept of the Augustinian-Calvinist eternal Hellfire, particularly as such punishment serves no corrective or rehabilitative purpose.

Much like the Hebrew Scriptures, the New Testament instances of punishment often aim to restore or correct rather than to inflict endless suffering. For example, in 1

Corinthians 5:5, the purpose of handing someone over to Satan is *"so that his spirit may be saved on the day of the Lord."*

Jesus' parables, such as the Prodigal Son (Luke 15:11-32) and the Unforgiving Servant (Matthew 18:21-35), emphasize God's readiness to forgive and the transformative power of mercy. These stories highlight the temporary nature of separation from God and the ultimate goal of reconciliation and restoration.

Our Struggle Is Not Against Flesh and Blood

Sure, we are more intelligent than cats and dogs, but we are still very much finite and limited in our mental capacity and understanding of ourselves, life, truth, and God. In contrast with our Creator, we are not all-knowing, all-understanding, etc. Satan knows that, and he successfully blinds people's eyes to God's truth from both outside the Church and within it. He also corrupts and vilifies what is good and moral, demonstrating a deliberate strategy to lead humankind astray. This is not to say we, humans, have no responsibility or liability. Still, Satan has been around far longer than you and me, and I believe that God's justice considers our susceptibility to confusion by Satan, who is a master of deceit.

From my own experience, many—perhaps most—people don't reject Christ per se, but rather a distorted religious image of him. This often stems from two primary sources: harmful doctrines that have infiltrated the church through malevolent forces and traumatic experiences inflicted by religious individuals and organizations, frequently rooted in those harmful doctrines.

It's important to remember that Satan himself—if we consider him to be an actual figure, such as a fallen angel—used Scripture to try to tempt and deceive Jesus. If the Devil found it advantageous to manipulate Scripture in his encounter with Christ, it stands to reason he continues to use the Bible to mislead and deceive Christians. Often, Satan convinces Christians that they are being "biblical" when, in reality, they selectively use verses—typically out of context—to support their own agendas and preconceived notions. This deception leads them to believe they are preaching the gospel while, in fact, they are driving people away from it. This, I believe, God's justice also takes into consideration.

Given this, it's plausible that many who need "saving" are already within the church, needing to be rescued from misguided beliefs about a cruel, merciless, hateful God. These beliefs are perpetuated by Christians who, though well-intentioned, mistakenly think they are adhering to biblical principles. As a result, these deceptive doctrines push people further away from God. In this case, who is to blame for their unbelief? Obviously, faith is far more complex than a simple binary choice.

Paul reminds us in Ephesians 6:12 that *"our struggle is not against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the powers of this dark world and against the spiritual forces of evil,"* indicating that the origins of sin and evil extend beyond human actions to include evil spiritual forces. This implies that God does not attribute the entirety of sin to humanity alone, acknowledging that spiritual influences significantly contribute to leading people astray. Paul's recognition emphasizes that the struggle against sin is a combined spiritual and human endeavor, necessitating divine assistance over mere punishment.

Satan's capacity to obscure God's truth and to taint what is good and moral forms part of a calculated strategy to lead humans astray. While this doesn't relieve humanity of our responsibility (and why many people "live in hell"), it does recognize Satan as a liar and deceiver, intent on confusing us, eroding our trust in God, and guiding us onto destructive paths. Moreover, many reject not the true God of Israel but a distorted, frightening religious image of god created by corrupt doctrines encountered in the Church—doctrines introduced by no less than malevolent spiritual evil forces. Nonetheless, I am convinced that, in the end, God's grace will prevail over Satan's lies, as well as our limited human understanding, confusion, and error.

Rejecting 'Jesus' vs. Rejecting 'jesus'

Before World War II, my Jewish grandmother Charlotte faced considerable persecution from local Christians in Eastern Europe who acted in the name of Christ. Then, during the Holocaust, she was captured by the Nazis and subjected to intense abuse and torture. At one point, they tied her up and forcibly removed her fingernails. As she screamed, the Nazi soldiers justified their actions to her by accusing her of

killing Christ. Nazi soldiers frequently rationalized their evil actions toward Jewish individuals by citing well-known Christian figures, including Martin Luther.[206]

Then, during Christmas, she and other Jews in the concentration camps would hear Nazi soldiers, accompanied by their families, joyfully singing Christmas carols on their way to church. These were the very soldiers who tortured and attempted to kill her, but she was only wounded, feigned death, and managed to escape and join the partisans. Her experiences under the guise of Jesus' name led her to reject with great passion what she perceived as 'Christianity' until her final day.

My point is this: Is God now continuing what Hitler began, burning Jews like my grandma in fiery flames of Hellfire for eternity because she couldn't come to believe in a false and antisemitic "Jesus" exhibited to her by Protestant European Christians? Or is God's justice more understanding than that of the Nazis?

Schadenfreude

As a descendant of a family of Holocaust survivors, I very much acknowledge that people who live in a cruel, painful, and abusive world often derive comfort and a sense of justice from the belief that those who have wronged them will face eternal punishment in the afterlife. For instance, consider a mother whose 5-year-old daughter was murdered. She has no means to confront the perpetrator or seek justice for her daughter, and the only solace she might find is in the idea that God will one day bring justice and that the perpetrator will suffer eternal torment in Hellfire. Thus, removing the concept of Hellfire can feel like taking away the comforting assurance and sense of revenge or satisfaction that the person who caused immense pain will face eternal punishment.

However, this is an emotional argument rather than a theological one. While it is painful to challenge and uproot such long-held and comforting ideas, it's essential to recognize the underlying emotion—Schadenfreude, known as deriving pleasure from the suffering of others. In God's kingdom, Schadenfreude is not acceptable: *"Do not gloat when your enemy falls; when they stumble, do not let your heart rejoice"* (Proverbs 24:17).

In taking pleasure or comfort in the suffering of others, we risk becoming the very thing we despise—those who revel in cruelty and suffering.

Furthermore, no form of punishment, however long, can resurrect a lost loved one. Consider a theoretical scenario where your child committed a murder. Will subjecting them to a thousand years of torture and then executing them bring back the victim? Clearly, the answer is no. Punishment itself is not the ultimate goal; rather, it serves as a means to an end, which ideally is repentance and rehabilitation. True justice seeks the reformation of the offender and the hope of eventual reconciliation.

In Jewish law, there is an emphasis on rehabilitating even the most serious criminals rather than merely executing them. Likewise, in most Western countries today, prisons often strive to provide inmates with opportunities for education, therapy, and skill-building, aiming to reintegrate them into society as reformed individuals. This approach is rooted in a belief in second chances and the potential for transformation, recognizing the humanity of even those who have committed grave offenses. If human institutions, with all their imperfections, can extend such grace and compassion, how much more should we expect from God, who is infinitely more loving and merciful? It stands to reason that if hell exists, it would align more closely with the concept of rehabilitation—a place of correction and transformation—rather than a place of eternal, unending, sadistic torture. God's judgment should be seen not as an end but as a means to ultimate restoration. The ultimate redemption in this framework is the belief that God will one day resurrect and fully restore all things:

> He will wipe every tear from their eyes. There will be no more death or mourning or crying or pain, for the old order of things has passed away. He who was seated on the throne said, "I am making everything new!"
>
> Revelation 21:4-5

Therefore, no trauma on earth lasts forever, regardless of its intensity. Our pain and suffering are fleeting when viewed against the backdrop of eternity. God's promises provide hope far surpassing the desire for revenge through another's suffering, reminding us that God's grand design is one of healing and renewal, aiming to

"reconcile to himself all things, whether things on earth or things in heaven" (Colossians 1:20).

Not only will our pain be erased, but so too will the pain of others, including those who have wronged us. This is the challenging essence of forgiveness and grace, which I understand is emotionally taxing, as I have also grappled with it. But consider this: If God commands us to love our enemies (Matthew 5:44), wouldn't He demonstrate this command to an even greater degree by also loving His enemies? And let us not forget that *"love does no harm to a neighbor."* (Romans 13:10). Instead, *"love is kind and keeps no record of wrongs."* (1 Corinthians 13:4-5).

Ultimately, being gifted with eternal life does not mean wrongdoers will be rewarded, esteemed, or privileged. Some may enter heaven without the highest honors, and even the humblest position, such as "cleaning the Kingdom's streets," is considered a privilege—particularly for those who have committed grave sins. But this is the essence of mercy and grace—receiving good when it's not deserved. Matthew 5:45 reminds us that God *"causes His sun to rise on the evil and the good, and sends rain on the righteous and the unrighteous."* I suspect this principle is not just temporal but extends into eternity.

Please do not misinterpret this as a dismissal of justice or belittling of sin. God isn't a radical pacifist, a powerless dude without any real authority who overlooks sin. He will bring justice, and I personally believe that sinners will experience a grievous process in hell, but even there, they will eventually encounter God's mercy, coming out purified. Hell, in this view, serves as a place of correction and purification rather than eternal torture. God's justice is aimed at healing, not endless suffering. Otherwise, God would be no different from a vengeful torturer who delights in pain or schadenfreude, which is far from the loving and restorative nature of the God of Israel.

What About Hitler?!

A common counter-argument I often hear goes like this: "Are you saying that Hitler, who murdered six million Jews, isn't burning forever in Hellfire right now?!"

Using an exception as a counterargument to refute a general claim is known as the "Overgeneralization Fallacy." This fallacy occurs when someone takes a rare or unusual case and presents it as a common scenario, thereby attempting to discredit a broader, more general argument. It involves drawing a conclusion based on insufficient evidence or on an isolated example that doesn't represent the typical situation. This fallacy overlooks the fact that exceptions don't necessarily disprove a general trend or rule.

I'm not Hitler's judge, and while from an emotional standpoint, as a Jew, I would undoubtedly be delighted at the notion of Hitler facing eternal punishment in Hellfire, my emotional justice is not God's.

But consider the great irony in the objection: The fundamentalist ECT view posits that the six million "unsaved Jews" killed by Hitler—some of my own family members included—are burning right there in Hellfire alongside Hitler and the Nazis. This begs the following ethical question: If it was up to you, would you prefer Hitler and the six million Jews he killed to suffer for eternity, or would you prefer all of them to go through a purifying process and eventually get saved?

Likewise, if God predestined billions for eternal torment in fire, as Calvinistic theology holds, then even Hitler, who gassed "only" several million people, might be considered merciful by comparison.

By the way, let's not forget—Hitler wasn't born with an inherent hatred for Jews. No one is born a hater; such animosity is developed over time. Hitler's virulent antisemitism was not an original idea of his; it was cultivated in an environment steeped in nearly 1,900 years of Christian antisemitism. This was the prevailing attitude within much of Christianity as Hitler was growing up. Hitler wasn't born in a non-Christian country such as Singapore, Nepal, Madagascar, Peru, or Suriname but in Christian Europe, a region deeply influenced by Protestant theology. Research has clearly shown the connection between Hitler's hatred for Jews and the antisemitic teachings that had long been embedded in Christian Europe.[207] Hitler was not an isolated anomaly; he was the culmination of centuries of Christian antisemitism. He grew up with the Bible and openly admired Martin Luther, frequently quoting him.

Similar to Hitler, the responsibility for grave sins cannot be attributed to a single person; such individuals are often the culmination of familial, historical, and cultural forces that have developed over centuries.

As previously stated, determining the destiny of the Devil is beyond my authority. Since I perceive very little distinction between the Devil and figures like Hitler, Stalin, Pol Pot, or Mao Zedong, I would also assert that deciding their fate is not within my remit. Instead, I much rather focus on the many non-Christians I know and love and rely on what the Scriptures say clearly about God's will for them (e.g., 1 Timothy 4:10; Romans 5:18; 1 John 2:1-2; 1 Corinthians 15:22; Colossians 1:20; Philippians 2:10; 1 Timothy 2:3-6; Acts 3:21; Psalm 22:27), which is far more comforting than accepting the grim and unsettling notion that the billions these three murderers butchered now suffer in eternal flames with them.

Conclusion

Hellfire's justice portrays God as vengeful and excessively punitive rather than just and merciful, contradicting His nature as described throughout Scripture. For example, Psalm 145:9 says, *"The Lord is good to all; he has compassion on all he has made."* Likewise, Ezekiel 33:11 says, *"Say to them, 'As surely as I live, declares the Sovereign LORD, I take no pleasure in the death of the wicked, but rather that they turn from their ways and live."*

In the New Testament, the crucifixion of our Savior stands as the ultimate representation of human cruelty. Yet, Jesus responded not with anger or vengeance but with a profound plea for forgiveness:

> Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they are doing.
>
> Luke 23:34

This prayer reveals the depth of Jesus' compassion, demonstrating that even in His most tremendous suffering, His heart was inclined toward mercy. It wasn't just a passing request but a deep, divine expression of His desire to pardon even those who caused Him harm.

God, who shares this forgiving nature, undoubtedly takes Jesus' plea seriously. To reject such a heartfelt prayer would contradict God's very character. Therefore, Jesus'

request serves as a powerful reminder of the boundless nature of God's grace, and it challenges us to approach forgiveness in the same way—recognizing that even the most grievous offenses are not beyond divine mercy.

Hellfire's Justice

In contrast with the biblical portrayal of justice, which harmonizes retribution with mercy, the Augustinian-Calvinist view asserts that God's justice demands a rigid, eternal punishment for any sin. When I say rigid, I mean melting your skin in flames of fire forever and ever, a doctrine that always struck me, a Jewish person, as dubious. While human wrath is often cruel and merciless and intended to be destructive, "God's wrath," a biblical term describing God's chastisement of Israel, was always measured and temporary and meant to be corrective and constructive.

The Augustinian-Calvinist view, however, is based on the belief that divine justice always demands severe punishment—Hellfire—for even the smallest of sins:

> His holiness is so pure that he cannot forgive without punishing. [208]
>
> Stan Mast, Calvinist preacher

> Why God punishes sin...The primary reason is that God's righteousness demands it so that he might be glorified in the universe that he has created. [209]
>
> Wayne Grudem, Reformed theologian

> He cannot merely forgive or remit sin without punishing it... Sin left unpunished would leave God's economy out of order. [210]
>
> Millard Erickson, Reformed theologian

The above quotes are philosophical arguments rather than biblical ones. Indeed, when we compare them with the New Testament teachings about freely extending forgiveness—such as Matthew 6:14, 18:21-22; Luke 6:37, 7:46-48; Ephesians 4:32; and Colossians 3:13—it becomes clear that the Augustinian-Calvinist view does not hold up theologically. These and other Bible passages emphasize the free nature of forgiveness and mercy, contrasting with the interpretation offered by Mast, Grudem, Erickson, and other Calvinists.

This prompts the inquiry: Is the narrative that God cannot forgive sin without meting out punishment sourced from the Bible, or is it a replication of the philosophical stance posited by thinkers such as Augustine, Aquinas, Anselm, and Calvin?

Not only is their argument philosophical, but if to complicate matters even further —as these individuals believe Jesus is fully God, a question arises: Since God cannot die without ceasing to be God, how can Jesus's death for only three days be considered a punishment at all? To solve this, they must conclude that something other than just the physical death of Jesus took place—that God the Father killed God the Son.

For instance, Reformed-baptist pastor, author, and member of the Calvinist hub "The Gospel Coalition," Thabiti Anyabwile, explains:

> Spiritual wrath from the Father occurs deep down in the very godhead itself…something was torn in the very fabric of the relationship between Father and Son…the ancient, eternal fellowship between Father and Son was broken as divine wrath rained down like a million Soddoms and Gomorrah's.[211]
>
> Thabiti Anyabwile

Likewise, former president of the Southern Baptist Convention, Pastor James Merritt, explains that:

> Because of our sin, Jesus experienced total separation, complete isolation, and resolute condemnation from God.[212]

James Merritt

Similarly, Reformed Pastor Mark Driscoll taught:

> That eternal, unbroken communion and union between the Father and Son was momentarily severed.[213]
>
> Mark Driscoll

This 'cosmic suicide'[214] theory depicts God as being angry with Himself, punishing Himself, and hating Himself to the extent of killing and expelling Himself from the Trinity. From the perspective of traditional Christianity, this is considered outright blasphemy and heresy as it claims that the Trinity temporarily turned into a “Binity” of two-in-one. It also portrays the triune God as suffering from a split personality or bipolar disorder.

These concepts are fervently disseminated through sermons, literature, videos, and digital platforms, influencing many millions in America and across the globe under the guise of Fundamentalist Christianity, yet in reality, even the Church Fathers would deem these views heretical.

As you must have realized by now, a significant portion of Augustinian-Calvinist theology is grounded in—arguably flawed—philosophical reasoning and human-crafted doctrines deeply influenced by pagan ideas rather than in the Scriptures. Evidently, the concept of "Sola Scriptura" is, for the most part, a placebo. In fact, the myriad Christian groups and denominations, numbering around 40,000, are all deeply entrenched in traditions and man-made doctrines influenced by extrabiblical sources.

In this specific case, the argument is that God’s inability to forgive without punishment stems from a commitment to justice. Justice, of all things, is their argument for why our loving Father must boil us in lava for a billion years!

If God is our Father and we are His children, then allegorically, it's as though they are telling us: *"Brothers, Dad can't forgive us unless he takes out his belt and whips us for twelve hours straight. Only then might he consider forgiving us."*

Or, as Erickson puts it,

> We must ask, is sin really serious if God can forgive without requiring some form of penalty or punishment?
>
> Millard Erickson, "Christian Theology," 838.

Oy vey!

The essence of forgiveness is recognizing the gravity of the offense ***and*** choosing mercy over retribution. Jesus taught the principle of radical forgiveness, instructing us to forgive others *"seventy times seven times"* (Matthew 18:21-22), emphasizing that forgiveness should be extended without any prior act of retaliation. Claiming that forgiven sins are not serious sins runs counter to our Rabbis' teachings.

Forgiveness is a profound act that acknowledges the seriousness of sin while choosing to extend grace. To assert otherwise is to misunderstand the very nature of forgiveness as revealed in Scripture. To forgive someone doesn't mean you first have to hurt them. Instead, forgiveness entails a cost to you while the other party is set free—for free.

For the sake of illustration, say we had a fight, and I offended you, but you chose to forgive me; it means I am set free—for free—while you absorbed the emotional cost. Or, if using the Parable of the Prodigal Son, forgiveness costs the father a significant portion of his wealth and emotional pain. He absorbs the loss to himself without ever punishing his son. That's the nature of forgiveness.

The God Who Is Reluctant to Save

Two primary online platforms for contemporary Calvinism are "The Gospel Coalition" and "Got Questions." On the latter, an article advocates for the Calvinist doctrine of "Unconditional Election," which posits that God has predestined only a select few for heaven and the majority for eternal punishment in Hellfire. In the article, I came across the following argument:

> God elects people to salvation by His own sovereign choice...God, before the foundation of the world, chose to make certain individuals the objects of His unmerited favor or special grace...God elects someone to salvation not because of something worthy God finds in that individual but because of His inscrutable, mysterious will. He makes the choice as to who will be saved for His own reasons...**The question we really should ask is not why God chooses only some for salvation but why He would choose any at all.**
>
> Got Questions, "Unconditional election - is it biblical?"

Firstly, God's will is not "inscrutable" nor "mysterious." In fact, His will regarding salvation is very clear: God *"wants all people to be saved and to come to a knowledge of the truth.* (1 Timothy 2:4).

Secondly, In my short book, *"Free Will and Christianity: You or God—Who's Really Buying This Book?"* I devoted considerable time to refuting Calvinism's concept of "Unconditional Election." However, I would like to touch on one aspect only: *"Why would He choose [to save] any at all?"*

The answer is simple, and it's because *"He is mighty to save."* (Zephaniah 3:17). But I suppose everything hinges on one's preconceived theological perspective. For me, it's not at all surprising that God extends His grace to all humanity, considering His loving nature. God, aware before the world's creation that all humans, except Jesus, would sin, chose to create us nonetheless. This act demonstrates His deep love for us despite our imperfections. This enduring love suggests that God is inherently disposed to bless all people, not just a select few.

To imply that it's a "wonder" that God extends His grace to anyone suggests that His natural inclination is not to bless but to punish. This view fundamentally misunderstands God's character, reducing Him to a pagan-like god who reluctantly shows mercy only out of obligation. But Scripture reveals a different picture—God delights in showing mercy (Micah 7:18) and is not willing that any should perish but that all should come to repentance (2 Peter 3:9).

Imagine, as a parent, if your children sin. You don't hate them—you hate the sin because it harms them and others. You correct and punish them—temporarily—not out of spite but out of love, wanting the best for them. Similarly, God doesn't despise humanity; He hates sin because it harms us. God's ultimate desire is to eliminate sin, not the sinner.

The Augustinian-Calvinist view, however, portrays a god who is fundamentally at odds with the compassionate, loving nature of the God revealed in Scripture. It is as if he thinks to himself: *"Since they regard me as merciful, I must extend a small measure of favor. I'm not inclined to do so because I despise them, but upholding their perception of me as merciful seems necessary. Otherwise, I might get bad publicity."*

God's grace isn't about reluctantly extending favor; it reflects His nature to love and bless all people, good and bad alike (Matthew 5:45), regardless of perceived worthiness. In Jesus, we see God's loving-kindness, proving we are worthy in His eyes and testifying to His infinite love for all creation.

God's Wrath and Vengeance

By now, you might be wondering: *"If not on Jesus, then where is God's wrath and judgment poured? Are we not compromising something about God's justice here?"* I hear you. I mean, I also shout *"penalty!!!"* at the TV screen when the opposing team has a foul on the striker, hoping that the referee will make a fair and just decision. And biblically speaking, did God not declare that while He is *"slow to anger"* (Exodus 34:6), He also *"visits the iniquity of the fathers on the children and the children's children, to the third and the fourth generation"* (Exodus 34:7)? In opposite with popular "hyper-grace" theories, I am not suggesting God is soft on sin.

However, wrath is not about vengeance and hatred. For instance, when we consider the plagues of Egypt (which are somewhat parallel to those in Revelation), we usually imagine a Marvel Studios-style vengeance. However, God's wrath poured in the plagues of Egypt was first and foremost to bring about repentance. It's easy to focus on the children of Israel in the Passover story, but let's not forget the *"multitudes of Egyptians"* (Exodus 12:38) joining Israel by faith while abandoning their false idols to follow the God of Israel. The plagues were what brought them into "saving faith." The wrath of God was a call for change. When you consider the great judgment and tribulation, think not of mere retribution but of mercy, a call for a harvest to believe.

Biblical Wrath

Understanding the cultural context in which biblical texts were written offers insights

into how ancient audiences might have interpreted references to "God's wrath." This perception could relate to their experiences with natural disasters, societal upheavals, or other events they believed were divinely orchestrated.

God's wrath involves allowing individuals to face the consequences of their sinful actions (Romans 1:24). For Old Testament Israel, God's wrath entailed losing God's protection each time they sought protection from other deities (idol worshiping). Consequently, when pagan adversaries attacked, Israel experienced what they perceived as "wrath."

It's pivotal to note that God's wrath shouldn't be equated with the emotional anger often displayed by angry, resentful, unforgiving, immature humans. Instead, it can be metaphorically understood as the natural outcomes of deviating from God's intended path or the cosmic order He established. In Jesus' parable, we can see this "wrath" coming from the father of the Prodigal Son by allowing his son to suffer—and learn from—the consequences of his decisions.

When we encounter passages in the Old Testament that speak of God's wrath,[215] it is important to remember that this wrath is directed at Israel when they turn to worship other gods. However, this wrath is not expressed through direct, catastrophic actions from God, such as lightning strikes or lava raining from the skies. Instead, God's wrath is often manifested indirectly by His withdrawal of protection. It usually appears in the form of cruel pagan nations who rush in to attack, kill, and destroy Israel while God remains passive, allowing these horrors to occur without intervening.

Thus, as a general rule, the wrath of God in the Old Testament is seen when God allows wicked pagans to overcome Israel without coming to their defense. This aligns with God's promises of blessings and curses to Israel in the Law (Deuteronomy 28:15-68). It was as if God were saying, *"You don't want Me? Fine, Israel. Let's see how well the other gods will treat, protect, and care for you."* One of the primary afflictions Israel faced was being subjugated by pagans, who, in return, forced them to worship their gods. There always was a connection between God's wrath and Israel's worship of foreign idols—gods who demanded their worshipers to burn their children in fire.

> The Lord disciplines those he loves.
>
> Hebrews 12:6

Unlike human anger, God's wrath was not capricious or vengeful but purposeful and redemptive. The purpose of God's judgment is not to destroy but to purify and refine. God's discipline is a manifestation of His love, intended to bring about growth and maturity in our lives.

Biblical Vengeance

People often judge others harshly, which usually stems from a desire to feel better about themselves, driven by various psychological and social factors. By highlighting others' perceived flaws, individuals elevate their self-perception and maintain a sense of superiority. Harsh judgment can also serve as a defense mechanism, helping cope with insecurities or self-doubt.

However, when we contemplate the concept of God's vengeance, it is easy for our minds to drift towards sensationalized images of destruction and chaos, as depicted in Hollywood apocalyptical movies with excessive bloodshed. This portrayal can create a misleading illusion that taking revenge and inflicting pain upon others is somehow an inherently godly act. However, it is important to challenge this perception and recognize that the true essence of divinity often lies in empathy, understanding, and forgiveness. In Romans 12:19, the Apostle Paul reminds us that God is the one responsible for exacting revenge, and therefore, we should refrain from seeking it ourselves:

> Do not take revenge, my dear friends, but leave room for God's wrath, for it is written: "It is mine to avenge; I will repay," says the Lord.

Paul teaches that God's vengeance is expressed through His wrath. But what purpose does God's wrath serve in regard to revenge? Isaiah 1:24-26 sheds light on this matter:

> Therefore the Lord, the Lord Almighty, the Mighty One of Israel, declares: "Ah! I will vent my wrath on my foes and avenge myself on my enemies. I will turn my hand against you; I will thoroughly purge away your dross and remove all your impurities. I will restore your leaders as in days of old, your rulers as at the beginning. Afterward, you will be called the City of Righteousness, the Faithful City."
>
> Isaiah 1:24-26

When God executes vengeance and unleashes His wrath, as seen in His judgments against the nation of Israel, His aim was not to crush, annihilate, or devastate but rather to discipline and purify evil. God's wrath and vengeance intend to guide people on the right path, not condemn them forever. While human revenge is often fuelled by emotional rage, divine vengeance aims to restore the transgressor. This is why we should resist the urge to seek revenge ourselves and instead trust God to handle it.

Indeed, God's ultimate purpose in bringing transgressions to light is not to encourage others to exact wrathful judgment upon the guilty but rather to inspire us to contribute to their healing and wholeness through His grace. As Christ-followers, we are called to reflect the love and mercy of our Heavenly Father. In situations where we feel wronged or hurt, it is essential to remember that God's wisdom and justice far surpass our own. By relinquishing our desire for revenge, we open ourselves to the transformative power of God's grace and allow His healing to work in our lives and the lives of those who have caused us pain. If we retaliate, they will retaliate back in an endless circle of revenge. If we don't, God can activate His justice.

God's judgment, when understood through the lens of mercy, is a transformative force that combines justice with compassion. Divine Mercy offers hope, redemption, and forgiveness, allowing us to learn from our mistakes and grow spiritually. By viewing God's judgment as an opportunity for spiritual growth, we can better appreciate the nurturing aspect of divine judgment and strive to become more compassionate and spiritually attuned individuals. God's judgment is not about hurting you but about exposing the truth so the issue can be treated and you can be healed. The purpose of God's judgment is to correct people, not to condemn them. (Isaiah 1:24-26)

As you journey through life, remember that God's vengeance serves a much higher purpose than human revenge – one of purification and redemption. Trust in his divine plan and embrace the transformative power of his grace to bring healing, wholeness, and hope to even the most broken individuals.

Conclusion

"Human wrath" is often cruel and merciless, intended to be destructive, whereas "God's wrath," a biblical term describing God's disciplinary measures of Israel, was always measured and temporary, intended to be corrective and constructive. Wrath denotes God's deep commitment to justice, righteousness, and the welfare of His creation. It embodies the divine reaction that aims to rectify unjust or oppressive human behaviors, striving to reinstate harmony and prosperity in God's creation.

What's Life's Meaning?

According to the Augustinian-Calvinist view, without the threat of eternal torment, there's nothing left for Jesus to save us from. I believe this reasoning actually diminishes the significance of sin, death, injustice, and suffering in the world, reducing the Gospel—and the meaning of life—to a mere Escape Room experience rather than a profound journey of cosmic transformation.

If eternal torment is the ultimate threat and avoiding it is life's goal, then the Gospel's primary concern is no longer the suffering and brokenness of people in the here and now. Belief in this distorted version of the Gospel leads to a religion obsessed with securing a seat as far as possible from Hellfire rather than about engaging with the world's real issues. In the Augustinian-Calvinist view, death becomes merely a gateway to a spiritual existence, and Jesus' mission is reduced to rescuing souls from his angry Father rather than conquering death and bringing about resurrection and renewal (now and forever).

In the ECT Hellfire view, Jesus' death and resurrection are misinterpreted and mostly irrelevant to our current lives on Earth. In the ECT view, Jesus *"tasted death for everyone"* (Hebrew 2:9) becomes Jesus experiencing Hellfire. In the ECT view, Christ's mission is understood not primarily as a victory over death but as a means to pacify His furious Father.

What if, instead, Jesus came into the world to overcome suffering and death, thereby initiating the renewal of all things? What if Christ's bodily resurrection was the precursor to an all-inclusive resurrection, symbolizing the rebirth of all creation? What if God's goal has always been what the prophets declared: the coming of His kingdom, the renewal of creation, and the restoration of all things? We participate

in His Kingdom not by escaping a speculative afterlife fire chamber but by liberating the captive, opening blind eyes, freeing the oppressed, healing the sick, binding up the broken-hearted, feeding the hungry, casting out demons, clothing the poor, extending a hand to the outcast, and preaching good news to all mankind. This is the true essence of the Gospel: a call to join in the restoration of creation—Tikkun Olam—not merely figuring out a way to avoid eternal torment.

What God Really Wants?

A truly loving parent does not demand strict perfection from his children but rather desires their hearts. Which would you prefer as a motivation for your children: to always show perfect obedience or to love you genuinely, even when they fail?

A truly loving parent never demands absolute perfection—as psychopaths do—but always extends compassion and understanding and encourages growth, change, and learning from mistakes. Their discipline is temporary, restorative, and redemptive, not torturous and abusive.

In a religious worldview that revolves around cosmic punishment and a demand for perfection, it is easy to overlook the profound potential within humanity's brokenness. From a true Christian perspective, the life journey of broken, sinful people holds a unique and powerful narrative that puts God's character in a completely different light than the 'cosmic abuser' religion often tries to sell us.

The Bible contains numerous examples of God using sinners, including King David, who committed adultery and murder; Peter, who denied Christ during the crucifixion; and Paul the Apostle, who was once a persecutor of Christians. Rahab, a prostitute in Jericho, and Mary Magdalene, often depicted as a prostitute as well, are also notable examples. Samson's life was marked by personal failings and sins, as well as the epic and groundbreaking story of the Prodigal Son. These and many other biblical examples illustrate the true narrative of the Bible—the redemptive power of God, who acknowledges our shortcomings and does not shy away from us because of them. This makes the Bible a story of God's love, grace, and the transformative power of second chances.

God's Love Expressed in Our Brokenness

If sin had never existed, then brokenness would not exist either. Therefore, the foundation of understanding our broken and sinful state begins with recognizing the depth of God's love. The Bible is replete with examples of God's unwavering love for humanity despite our flaws and failures. In Romans 5:8, we read, *"But God demonstrates his own love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us."* This profound truth reveals that God's reaction to sin was not punishment and destruction and that God's love is not contingent but is extended to us in our most broken state, recognizing that love is the strongest initiator and greatest producer of change and growth.

God's love is not a distant, abstract concept but an intimate and transformative force. It is a love that meets us in our brokenness and offers healing and restoration. In Psalm 34:18, we are reminded, *"The Lord is close to the brokenhearted and saves those who are crushed in spirit."* God's nearness to the brokenhearted is a testament to His desire to lift us up, not in spite of our brokenness but because of it.

One of the most compelling aspects of the Christian faith is the belief in a God of second chances. Throughout the Bible, we encounter individuals who, despite their failures, were given opportunities to start anew. These stories are not just historical accounts; they are living testimonies of God's grace. They illustrate that failure doesn't have the final word and that God's purposes can still be fulfilled through our lives, no matter how broken we may feel. In Lamentations 3:22-23, we find hope in these words: *"Because of the Lord's great love we are not consumed, for his compassions never fail. They are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."* Each new day brings with it a clean page and the possibility of a fresh start, an opportunity for God to work through our brokenness.

Grace: God's Catalyst for Transformation

Grace is the cornerstone of the Christian faith, but you can't experience grace unless you are broken. *"It is not the healthy who need a doctor, but the sick."* (Luke 5:31). Therefore, grace is particularly potent in the lives of broken individuals—sinners. Grace is not merely unmerited favor; it is the empowering presence of God that enables us to become what He has created us to be. The Apostle Paul, who referred to himself as the *"chief of sinners"* (1 Timothy 1:15), experienced this grace firsthand. Despite his murderous past of persecuting Christ's first followers, Paul's encounter with Jesus transformed him into one of the most influential figures in human history.

In 2 Corinthians 12:9, Paul recounts God's words to him: *"My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness."* This paradoxical statement reveals a profound truth: our imperfections and brokenness are the very spaces where God's power and grace can operate most mightily. It is in our vulnerability that His strength is most evident, and it is through our brokenness that His grace can shine most brightly. However, without sin in His creation, there would be no brokenness in the world.

Sin and brokenness, while painful, are opportunities for God to work in us. The process of purification may be uncomfortable, but it is necessary for our transformation. Malachi 3:3 uses the metaphor of a refiner's fire that purifies. Just as precious metals are purified through intense heat, so too are we refined through the trials and tribulations we face.

The Strength of the Broken

Broken people often develop qualities that those who have never experienced deep pain may lack. Empathy, resilience, and humility are forged in the fires of brokenness. These qualities are not just desirable; they are essential for true growth. In 2 Corinthians 1:3-4, Paul writes, *"Praise be to the God and Father of our Lord Jesus*

Christ, the Father of compassion and the God of all comfort, who comforts us in all our troubles so that we can comfort those in any trouble with the comfort we ourselves receive from God." Our brokenness equips us to be vessels of God's comfort and grace to others.

Furthermore, brokenness fosters a dependence on God that is crucial for spiritual growth. In our weakest moments, where all we have left is faith, we have no choice but to learn to rely on God's strength. This dependency cultivates a deeper relationship with God and a more profound understanding of His character. As we, in our brokenness, lean into His strength, we find that we can accomplish far more than we ever could on our own back when we delusionally thought we were grazing perfection.

Life's Meaning Redefined

Through their experiences, broken people often have a clearer understanding of what truly matters. They develop greater empathy and appreciation for life, recognizing that life is not about accumulating accolades but about being faithful stewards of the grace they have received. Their brokenness becomes a platform for God's glory, as their weakness makes His strength known. Therefore, life's meaning is found in a life that trusts and honors God by reflecting His loving-kindness and grace to others who need it. The world often measures success by external achievements—medals, wealth, status, and power. However, from a truly Christian viewpoint, true success is gauged by our journey of faith and our alignment with the image of Christ, which is reflected in how we love others.

Conclusion

For those who feel judged, broken, or defeated, remember that your journey is far from over. No matter how deeply you believe you've messed up, God's redemptive love has the power to transform your life. While I may not know the extent of your

failures, I am certain they do not define you. God has no intention of condemning you to eternal punishment! Instead, restoration and healing await you in God's loving embrace. You can't change the past; let your past mistakes serve not as chains that weigh you down but as learning opportunities for God's purpose to shine through you. In your brokenness, God sees the potential for growth, purification, and a profound spiritual renewal that surpasses human and religious understanding. Embrace your brokenness and use your faith to lean into God's grace, for it is in these moments that your true potential is revealed. Your life can become a living testament to the biblical narrative of restoration by a God who loves you unconditionally, offers endless second chances, and empowers you to rise above your past. Remember, in the hands of our loving Creator, you are never discarded. Instead, you are lifted higher, radiating the brilliance of His transformative love. You are not alone, and your story of redemption can inspire hope and strength in others who are—or will be—also on their path to healing.

Every Knee, Every Tongue

Humanity often seems like mere pawns in a cosmic struggle between God and Satan, with both sides vying for human allegiance. In this scenario, given God's omnipotence and omniscience, His will is destined to prevail, as affirmed by the scriptures. [216] God operates on a plane far beyond human understanding. While individuals may face consequences for their sins, possibly undergoing corrective punishment, the idea that the vast majority of humanity will suffer eternal torment is hard to reconcile. Such a concept undercuts the omnipotent and omniscient image of the God of Israel, who is all-knowing, all-powerful, and *"mighty to save"* (Zephaniah 3:17), suggesting instead that He is unable to achieve His ultimate will that all will be saved.

"Did God really say?" (Genesis 3:1)

Free will is a core aspect of the divine-human relationship, and God does not coerce love; rather, He aims to demonstrate His trustworthiness and goodness. True love must prove itself genuine and worthy, not imposed. The Serpent's deception in the Garden of Eden hinged on casting doubt about God's trustworthiness, framing the cosmic battle as a matter of human perception. The real question is: Who will humans ultimately bow before, God or the Serpent?

Consider a hypothetical where God and Satan are competing for the love and trust of ten people. If God is truly as wise and powerful as He claims, would the outcome

be 6:4 or even 8:2 in God's favor? No, the only acceptable outcome for an all-powerful God would be 10:0. For God to fully triumph, He must win over every single heart, which aligns with the prophecy that, ultimately, every tongue will confess before Him.

Is Yahweh Really the Strongest and Wisest of All?

Your short life, whether it lasts 20, 50, or 120 years, gives you just enough time for a brief glimpse, a quick peek into this cosmic warfare. For most people, it's difficult to make sense of life, not recognizing the spiritual reality behind it. But what if you could see it all—from beginning to end—from God's perspective? Sure, now we see only dimly and know in part, but one day, we shall see face-to-face and know fully (1 Corinthians 13:12). That day, *"the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the LORD as the waters cover the sea."* (Habakkuk 2:14) Then the truth will become evident to us all.

Scripture affirms God's omnipotence, stating that God does whatever pleases Him (Psalm 115:3; cf. Isaiah 55:11 and Jeremiah 32:17). Nothing is too difficult for Him (Genesis 18:14), and His word is never devoid of power (Isaiah 55:11).

God is considered omniscient, which means He possesses all possible information, knowing everything there is to know about everything, crowning Him as the cosmic Grandmaster. Scripture frequently highlights the universality of God's knowledge (Psalm 147:5; John 21:17; Hebrews 4:12-13; 1 John 3:20). It also mentions that God is aware of detailed events on earth, including those in the future (1 Samuel 10:2; 1 Kings 13:1-4; 2 Kings 8:12; Psalm 139:4; Acts 2:23; Acts 4:27-28).

In the days of the Old Testament, God often invited Israel to test Him and observe His works (e.g., Malachi 3:10; Isaiah 7:11; Isaiah 43:10)—to test and see what? His power, wisdom, and goodness. We, His finite, limited, and "infantile" creations, are able to critically examine whether God truly embodies the pinnacle of wisdom, power, love, and goodness. If this is the case, and if God is indeed our loving Father, then we can trust Him, reversing the initial decision made in Genesis 3.

If God is the strongest and wisest, this suggests that He is not only superior in strength and wisdom to all other deities or beings but also that He possesses these

attributes to the utmost degree. God's omnipotence (all-powerful) and omniscience (all-knowing) affirm that He is the ultimate embodiment of strength and wisdom. These qualities imply that His power and knowledge are limitless; He can do anything possible and knows everything that can be known. Furthermore, He can bring about any outcome He desires without compromising anyone's free will. This conception of God reflects the classical theistic view that God's abilities and insights are absolute and unmatched, surpassing all imaginable levels of strength and wisdom. In other words, being the wisest and strongest is, in part, what makes Him God.

These attributes of God are central to understanding His nature, capabilities, and intentions. The pivotal question is: Can God really bring His will to fruition? According to 1 Timothy 2:4, His will is clear: *"He wants all people to be saved and to come to a knowledge of the truth."* But can He actually do it? Is Yahweh really wise and strong enough to make His will triumph over the enemy's? Or maybe 1 Timothy 2:4 is merely wishful thinking?

Well, it seems clear that Paul took the idea quite literally, frequently repeating it in his epistles. For example:

> At the name of Jesus **every** knee should bow, in heaven and on earth and under the earth and every tongue acknowledge that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.
>
> Philippians 2:10

Not a few knees, not some, not even most, but every knee shall bow.

1 Timothy 2:4

Much like a loving parent who wants the very best for all their children, God's loving will is made clear in the scriptures. Let's go back to 1 Timothy 2:4:

God our Savior, who **wants all people** to be saved and to come to a knowledge of the truth.

1 Timothy 2:4, NIV

God our Savior, who **wants everyone** to be saved and to understand the truth.

1 Timothy 2:4, NLV

God our Savior, who **desires all people** to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth.

1 Timothy 2:4, ESV

God our Savior, Who **will have all men** to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth.

1 Timothy 2:4, KJV

No matter what Bible translation you own—God wants/desires all and everyone to be saved. Even without the Bible, this is the only logical conclusion if we believe God is both good and loving. The debate is not over His will but whether He is wise and powerful enough to accomplish His will.

Accordingly, 1 Timothy 2:4 offers a profound basis for testing and comparing the coherence of God's divine attributes, especially his power and wisdom, with His actions and the outcomes of His will. If God truly possesses omniscience (being the wisest), omnipotence (being the strongest), and omnibenevolence (being the most loving), and if His will is indeed for humanity—all of it—to be saved, as it is written in 1 Timothy 2:4, then logically, the eventual complete reconciliation of all souls—through their own free will—becomes not only a possibility but a necessity.

Therefore, 1 Timothy 2:4 presents a significant challenge for the Augustinian-Calvinist adherents, having no other choice but to admit to the existence of

something stronger than God's will (to save everyone). Take, for instance, the theological acrobatics of John Piper's views:

> God wills that all be saved, but in another sense, he does not will that all be saved... Everybody has to face this, not just certain groups. Everyone who believes, as all Christians do, in the wisdom and power and goodness of God would say that the answer is that some other will — or some other desire or commitment of God — takes precedence over the desire for all to be saved.[217]
>
> John Piper

In other words, for the honorable Calvinist Piper to be consistent with his theology, he must believe that God's will is not the ultimate one. But with all due respect to John Piper, the Bible is clear that God wants ALL to be saved. Therefore, the two questions left are—how and when? This is the climax of the biblical narrative, and the day the prophets longed for: The day God's will *"to be put into effect when the times reach their fulfillment—to bring unity to* ***all things in heaven and on earth*** *under Christ."* (Ephesians 1:10)

Logically, any scenario other than the total reconciliation of all things, whether it involves the salvation of only 1% or even as much as 99% of humanity, suggests that God could be wiser and stronger than He is. Indeed, if He cannot persuade His creation of His goodness, wisdom, and power, managing to save only a few, then He would be perceived as an impotent god. In that case, it might be argued that there are potentially other, stronger, and wiser deities out there we should consider. The real theological puzzle, therefore, is whether anything can thwart God's will. Suppose there is something (free will, human stupidity, our mental capacity, etc.) or someone (Satan, society, etc.) that can discard, stop, or negate the will of God even by one inch. In that case, we might need to consider if there is a stronger and wiser deity elsewhere.

I know my argument can be confusing to some. If so, my argument can be summarized deductively in the following way:

1. God is the utmost culmination of wisdom and power and is all good and loving.
2. God's will for all to be saved (1 Timothy 2:4) is because He is good and loving.
3. God's totality in power and wisdom means His ultimate will to save all must eventually come to fruition.

Therefore, the premise and promise that *"every knee shall bow, and every tongue shall confess"* cannot be discarded. The fulfillment of God's will to save everyone is essential; otherwise, it would imply that His will can be thwarted, diminishing His status from that of the supreme deity to merely another god.

Individualistic vs. Collective God

The concept of God desiring the salvation of all has become somewhat sidelined in the modern Western Church, where salvation is predominantly seen through an individualistic lens. This reflects a broader cultural shift toward egocentrism, contrasting sharply with the collective mindset of ancient societies, especially that of the Jewish people. In those earlier societies, salvation was often understood as a communal endeavor involving and benefiting the entire group. However, today's focus on personal salvation highlights this change, emphasizing individualism at the expense of a more collective approach. This shift changes how salvation is perceived and reflects a larger societal movement towards individualism, moving away from the communal and interconnected understanding of human existence that characterizes many ancient and biblical cultures, Judaism included.

Thus, if we observe any outcome where some individuals are eternally condemned or remain in perpetual separation from God, it would pose a significant theological dilemma. Such a scenario would imply a limitation on at least one of God's attributes: either He is limited in power (unable to save all), in wisdom (can't figure out how to convince all), or in goodness (He does not truly care to save all).

Therefore, the totality of salvation emerges not from a naive and hopeful interpretation of scriptural promises but as a critical litmus test for the consistency and reliability of our understanding of God's nature. If God's ultimate victory involves the complete restoration and reconciliation of everything, it confirms His unchallengeable sovereignty and demonstrates His attributes conclusively. This outcome would align perfectly with the scriptural declarations of His will and the prophetic visions of every knee bowing and every tongue confessing in recognition of His Lordship, reflecting a cosmos wholly restored to its intended harmony and divine order.

In conclusion, if God wills that eventually all come to the knowledge of Christ and be saved, as stated in 1 Timothy 2:3-6, then it stands to reason that His wisdom and power will extend to the realization of this all-inclusive salvation. Yet, it is not for us to know exactly how or when.

God's Cosmic Scope of Salvation

In the narrative of Christian theology, Satan represents the principal adversary, actively working to lead humanity away from God by trying to convince us He can't be trusted. Yet, if we accept that God's attributes surpass any of His creations, including Satan, then the Devil's power to deceive and corrupt is ultimately temporary and inferior to God's power to save and restore:

> "As surely as I live," says the Lord, "every knee will bow before me;
> every tongue will acknowledge God."
>
> Romans 14:11-12

To suggest that anything can ultimately interfere with God's promises would imply that someone or something possesses the ability to thwart God's ultimate plan, even in part, thereby imposing a limitation on God's endless omnipotence and omniscience.

"As surely as I live" underscores the certainty and authority of God's declarations. By invoking His own life, God is not only confirming the surety of His promise but also connecting His eternal, unending existence to the inevitability of His plans coming to fruition. This phrase emphasizes the unchangeable nature of God's promises based on His eternal existence and sovereign power. It's a declaration of God's omnipotence and His sovereignty over all things.

In the context of God's desire for all to be saved and Satan's attempts to lead humanity astray, we find reassurance that God's purposes will indeed prevail despite Satan's obvious yet temporary influence. Since Satan isn't fighting God over land but over souls, his primary tactic in opposing God is to distort the human understanding of God and His love. By altering how we perceive and practice love, Satan aims to undermine the very essence of God's character and His commandments, which are rooted in love. This deception leads people away from true divine love—selfless and sacrificial—and towards an understanding of a self-centered, transactional, conditional, and fear-based version of God and His love that has little to do with the biblical definition.

However, God's grand plan for salvation and restoration of all things is sure and will be fulfilled because it is grounded in His loving, unchanging, unconditional, and eternal nature. Until then, we are called to live, walk, and see by faith, not by sight, *"until the time comes for God to restore everything, as he promised long ago through his holy prophets."* (Acts 3:21)

Every Knee Will Bow!

The outcome mentioned in the verse, where *"every knee will bow before me; every tongue will acknowledge God,"* points to a future reality where God's supremacy is universally recognized and accepted. This aligns with the idea that God's power to save and restore is far superior to any deception or corruption Satan might introduce.

Romans 14:11 suggests nothing new but simply recaptures what God *"promised long ago through his holy prophets."* For instance, in Isaiah 45:23 it is written:

> By myself I have sworn, my mouth has uttered in all integrity a word that will not be revoked: Before me **every knee will bow; by me every tongue will swear.**
>
> Isaiah 45:23

Paul and Isaiah vividly illustrate a future in which not few, not some, not even many, but a future where every knee bows and every tongue confesses that Jesus Christ is Lord, underscoring a universal acknowledgment of God's sovereignty and goodness. This imagery is declarative, indicating a state of complete and total submission to God's divine authority across all creation. But what does submission mean? Why will everyone bow their knees, and what will every tongue confess/swear?

Bowing knees

In the ancient world, bowing one's knees was a gesture of profound respect and allegiance, typically reserved for deities and kings. In Daniel 3:16-18, three Jewish men refuse to bow to King Nebuchadnezzar, believing such honor should be reserved for God alone. To the Hebrew mind, therefore, the phrase *"every knee will bow"* signifies a freely chosen act of worship. True worship expresses love and respect, not fear (1 John 4:18).

Confessing tongues

In Hebrew, the word "*TISHABA*," describing the action of the confessing tongue in Isaiah 45:23, means "shall take an oath" or "to swear." Publicly confessing with one's tongue is a way to affirm allegiance and reverence. When a king goes to war, his subjects are expected to pledge their allegiance to him, even to the extent of sacrificing their lives for their sovereign. This act of swearing loyalty signifies a profound commitment and devotion based on admiration.

In this context, bowing knees and confessing/swearing tongues do not suggest the notion of humiliation, punishment, or degradation but rather a surrendering out of adoration and respect. These verses do not imply God will humiliate and degrade all people. Instead, to say it simply, it suggests all of mankind will fall in love with God, which will be evident by words (swearing tongues) and actions (bowing knees). This suggests a future where all creation, willingly through divine persuasion, recognizes, believes, and accepts Christ's lordship.

Allow me to sum up with a simple deductive argument:

Premise 1: God is *"the mighty one who saves."* (Zeph. 3:17)

Premise 2: God loves the world: *"For God so loved the world"* (John 3:16)

Premise 3: His love means He wants to save all: *"God our savior; Who will have all men to be saved."* (1 Tim. 2:3)

Premise 4: God's *"love never fails."* (1 Cor. 13:8)

Premise 5: God's will always comes to fruition: *"No purpose of yours can be thwarted."* (Job 42:2); *"Him who works all things according to the counsel of his will."* (Eph. 1:11)

Conclusion: EVERY knee will bow, and EVERY tongue will confess.

Otherwise, if only a few are saved, one might question Christ's death's purpose. If Jesus' sacrifice did indeed overcome death and hell, yet hell prevails in the end, redeeming only a minority and leaving the majority to suffer eternally, what victory does that represent? If death retains the final word, it would imply that Jesus' death was futile and mostly without reason.

Anything other than an overwhelming, complete, and total victory, and the Christian God fails to fit the very philosophical definition of an omnibenevolent God who is also omnipotent, omniscient, and omnipresent.

The idea that a God of infinite intellect, wisdom, justice, love, and power would not only fail to save but also condemn beings with limited rationality and heightened emotions—traits stemming from their creation—to eternal torment or allow them to damn themselves due to misunderstanding, delusion, pain, fear, anger, etc. seems more characteristic of a pagan deity than the loving Father revealed through Jesus. The concept of Hellfire, perhaps the most horrific notion ever conceived by religious imagination, presents an irrational and spiritually damaging portrayal of God.

As an Ashkenazi Jew, I am deeply aware of the long history of abuse and torment my people have endured, often facing attempts at extermination. Naturally, I long

for justice and, admittedly, even revenge. However, I also recognize that God's will transcends human desires for vengeance. He wishes for all to come to Him, including the greatest sinners of all. If God can one day lead even those who have committed heinous acts to change their minds, repent, and willingly believe, He would truly demonstrate Himself as the greatest, wisest, and most loving being of all—truly worthy of our eternal awe, worship, and admiration.

The concept of complete reconciliation, therefore, is not merely a naive outlook but a logical extension of the nature of God as described in the Bible. It asserts that the cosmic spiritual war between God and Satan will culminate in God's absolute victory, characterized not just by the defeat of evil but by the restoration of all things:

> And through him to reconcile to himself **all things**, whether on earth or in heaven, making peace by the blood of his cross.
>
> Colossians 1:20

This view posits that any temporary victories by Satan are just that—temporary—serving ultimately to manifest God's glory and the depths of His redemptive power and mercy. This doesn't mean people won't suffer consequences, penalties, or loss of rewards. Justice often entails corrective punishments and loss, but the nature of these penalties is fundamentally corrective rather than destructive.

Conclusion

The purpose of life is redefined as a learning experience of divine transformation aimed at rehabilitation and spiritual growth rather than mere retribution or the never-ending infliction of suffering for its own sadistic sake. God is a loving Father, not a sadistic psychopath. Good parents do not abuse their children for their imperfections, ignorance, stubbornness, or misunderstandings. The ultimate purpose of God's punishment and correction is not to abandon the soul to eternal suffering but rather to cleanse and purify it of the flaws and sins that once caused

estrangement from God, preparing it for an eventual reunion and reconciling all unto Himself:

> If anybody does sin, we have an advocate with the Father—Jesus Christ, the Righteous One. He is the atoning sacrifice for our sins, **and not only for ours but also for the sins of the whole world.**
>
> 1 John 2:1-2

Hell should be considered a process akin to a refining fire that purifies rather than destroys, emphasizing transformation and redemption over endless suffering. Such an understanding offers a more hopeful and merciful vision of eternity, framing it within the larger narrative of God's eternal plan for humanity's salvation and ultimate good, which best aligns with a coherent theological framework that upholds God's attributes of omnipotence, omniscience, and omnibenevolence. It assures that God's desire for all to be saved will be fulfilled, thereby affirming His ultimate sovereignty and providing a powerful rebuttal to the notion of any permanent victory for Satan:

> All the ends of the earth shall remember and turn to the Lord, and all the families of the nations shall worship before you.
>
> Psalm 22:27

Amen.

A Final Word

It is likely for a valid reason—see Isaiah 55:8— that the Bible does not provide a single, explicit, systematic doctrine on hell. Traditions about hell often stem from isolated metaphors and parables, frequently interpreted outside their intended genre and context. Contrastingly, Jesus himself declared that he *"did not come to judge the world, but to save the world"* (John 12:47). If Jesus refrained from condemnation, by what right do we presume to condemn others? And why is that? Is it because they don't adhere to the exact same religious theories and formulas as we do? Because they are not yet perfected? Because they do not yet realize what God, through Christ, has done for them? The Bible's ambiguity suggests that we are not meant to obsess over the concept of hell nor to judge others' eternal destinies (Romans 14:4). In fact, when we do so, we risk *"taking the name of the LORD our God in vain"* (Exodus 20:7).

I wish to leave you with an action point. We must not remain passive and let the gospel be diminished to merely decoding the right theoretical formula to escape a sadistic, neverending torment in a cosmic inferno. Denominations centering the Gospel around or obsessing over the doctrine of hell as a realm of eternal cruel punishment shift focus away from the core message of the Gospel, which we ought to uphold. The message of Christ was about embracing God's love, mercy, and grace and paying them forward. Rather than getting bogged down in theological debates over the afterlife, we should focus on embodying and radiating God's love in a world riddled with brokenness and despair. God's love is not a formula for escaping torture; it's a call to action, inviting us to participate in healing and restoration. The Gospel, at its core, is about transformation—of hearts, lives, and communities—through the

love and grace of God, as revealed in our Messiah Yeshua (Hebrew for Jesus, which also means "salvation").

I have a small favor to ask before you close this book (or turn off your e-reader). I've dedicated significant time and effort to creating this book, but I anticipate that some fervent Calvinists may intentionally give my book a low rating. Therefore, if you have found enjoyment and education in the book, please consider expressing your appreciation by sparing a few seconds to rate it on Amazon or Goodreads. If you also have two minutes to spare, leaving a short review would also mean the world to me as an author! I make it a point to read every review. If you want to go the extra mile and help, then feel free to post about the book on social media or even get a copy or two for friends!

Lastly, on the next page, you will find a list of my other books.

Thank you so much for your attention and consideration.

Dr. Eitan Bar

Also by Eitan Bar

Several other books on various spiritual topics are available on my Amazon page. You are welcome to check them out! Some of them are:

- **The "Gospel" of Divine Abuse**: Redeeming the Gospel from Gruesome Popular Preaching of an Abusive and Violent God.
- **God as Father**: Unveiling God's Love for Sinners, Outcasts, Legalists, and Jerks Through the Prodigal Son.
- **The Kingdom of Yeshua**: Christ's Timeless Wisdom to Revive Your Spiritual Life.
- **The Theology of Love**: Christianity's Most Underrated Doctrine.
- **Read Like a Jew**: 8 Rules of Basic Bible Interpretation for the Christian.
- **Lost in Translation**: 15 Hebrew Words to Transform Your Christian Faith.
- **Why Don't Jews Believe in Jesus**: A Jewish-Christian Unfolds the Great Mystery.
- **Refuting Rabbinic Objections to Christianity** & Messianic Prophecies.
- **The Christian's Handbook to Logical Fallacies:** Quick and Easy Guide to Spot Bad Reasoning and Flawed Arguments.

- **Christian and Divorced**: What the Bible REALLY Says About Divorce & Remarriage.
- **Free Will and Christianity**: You or God—Who's Really Buying This Book?
- **Left Behind Deconstructed**: Why I Left Pre-Tribulation Rapture Behind.

Also, many articles are available on my website:
www.eitan.bar

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3. Cheree Hayes, *Does a "Most-Accurate" Bible Translation Exist?* Jan 13, 2023. BibleProject.
4. The complete book provides numerous examples directly from renowned Calvinists.
5. I invite you to check out my book, "***The Christian's Handbook to Logical Fallacies: An Easy-to-Understand Guide for Identifying Poor Reasoning and Flawed Arguments.***"
6. It is commonly stated that where there are two Jews, there will be at least three opinions. This reflects the tradition among Jewish Torah students and scholars to not simply accept the initial idea presented to them, to continually question established notions, and to engage in debate with others who have opposing views. Likewise, I encourage you to familiarize yourself with various points of view.
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